Your Majesty

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fingered and blowed at the same time, sex all night, Puppy Phainon (Honkai: Star Rail), Phainon's parents are alive but are rarely mentioned, Dry Orgasm, Dry Humping

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by Loving_Healer

Summary

Every few years, Okhema Kingdom holds a grand royal ball, inviting various neighboring kingdoms to attend and enjoy the sights that Okhema has to offer. This year, however, Kremnos Kingdom, which has had its borders mysteriously closed for many, many years, suddenly confirmed its attendance in Okhema. And, of course, Aglaea assigns Phainon to be their guard during the duration of their stay.

Little did Phainon know that this would be the most difficult assignment he would ever have.

Notes

I do want to make a note that this story was written before Cerydra and Hysilens were ever in the story (whatever version of HSR that is). I definitely would've included them + Cyrene if I knew more about them, so please excuse their absence!

I also know this work is super long, so if you guys want the chapter numbers where... certain things happen, if you know what I mean:

2, 4, 5, 6, Epilogue 1 :)

Itinerary Day 1: Arrival

“*Me?!*”

“Yes, you. Is there anyone else that I could be speaking to in this room?”

“Are you sure, Miss Aglaea?”

Aglaea only chuckled, leaning back in her golden chair and propping an elbow on the armrest. “I am entrusting this to you, Phainon. Do not fail me now.”

Phainon, who was standing across her desk, fidgeted in place. Although he has been summoned many times into this room, he would still never become accustomed to its grandeur. Aglaea was the ruler of Okhema, after all. How could he not be intimidated? “It just sounds like a tall order for a normal guardsman like me, Miss Aglaea. I would just think it would be better to entrust this task to someone more worthy.”

“There is no one more worthy in my eyes than you, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.” Aglaea leaned forward in her chair, narrowing her eyes. “The ruler of Kremnos will be arriving today, and I want you to accompany him around Okhema. If we want the military might of their kingdom on our side, you will do well to accommodate the Kremnoans’ requests.”

Phainon paused with wandering eyes, absorbing the information that was just presented to him. “I… do not mean to be so forward, Miss Aglaea, but are you sure this task must be done by me? I am just a lowly guardsman from a lowly town out in the countryside that only serves to grow crops for the kingdom. I don't believe this task should fall into my hands. If anything, I believe someone of noble blood should be accompanying the ruler of Kremnos. Maybe your adoptive daughter, Cifera?”

“I have a keen eye for things,” Aglaea began, “And from what I have learned of their ruler, you are the best fit to escort them around our kingdom. And anyway, as Cifera is not my daughter of blood, you and she

would be the same. Do well to win over their ruler. I am trusting you as I always have, Phainon."

Phainon could only bow before leaving the room, shutting the heavy metal door behind him with a deep sigh. As much as he tried to convince Aglaea, it was to no avail. It wasn't as if he had absolutely zero confidence in himself; he just thought it would be rude to allow someone of no noble birth to accompany a figure of noble birth. What was Aglaea thinking? And, what would the Kremnoans think if he were the one to come out and greet them?

Aglaea had provided him with the exact time the Kremnoans were arriving and where their lodgings would be within Marmoreal Palace. It was Phainon's duty to lead them around, ensure they were comfortable with their stay, and accommodate any requests that they may have while staying in Okhema.

Every couple of years, Okhema holds a grand ball, inviting various kingdoms to attend. It was a way for Okhema to gather with other political leaders and forge or strengthen current alliances. And every year, Kremnos has always politely declined those invitations. This year, however, Kremnos suddenly confirmed its attendance, and Aglaea has been scrambling to do her very best to impress the Kremnoans.

One of the more curious things was why the Kremnoans had decided to attend this year; it may be due to the fact that Kremnos had welcomed a new king a few years ago and has now decided to make a public appearance outside of their own kingdom. No one outside of Kremnos knew what this king looked like or what they were like in general, other than that their military might and prowess rivaled even previous generations of kings.

The festivities in Okhema would only last a week, but Phainon was currently preparing to have his head severed from his neck during this week escorting the Kremnoans. If their new leader was truly as fearsome as described in rumors, Phainon wasn't going to make it out of this week alive. Surely, the man was going to be large, burly, covered in scars, and with an intimidating aura, right? He probably had a look in his eyes that would make Phainon immediately fall to his knees. There were even rumors that

the current king killed the previous king with his own hands. If he were able to accomplish such a feat, what would stop him from also slaying some lowly soldier in Okhema?

Wait. Phainon faltered in his steps in the middle of whatever hallway he was currently in, on his way to the guards' quarters adjacent to the palace. What were the Kremnoans' values of etiquette and manners? How should he even greet them? For as long as he has been a soldier for Okhema, he has never once conversed with a Kremnoan.

Kremnoans were described as bloodthirsty, foolhardy, and one-track minded. They were barbaric, bold, and greatly determined. If the general Kremnoan was described as such, he couldn't even begin to imagine their king–a king who had slain even his own father. If he greeted them incorrectly and in a non-Kremnoan fashion, would his head immediately roll from his shoulders? Phainon had actually originally wanted to request leave a few years ago to go training in Kremnos, but when news of the King's death due to his son's hands had flooded the continent, that request immediately ceased. Surely, Aglaea had a better fit than Phainon to escort them around? Unless Aglaea actually viewed Phainon to be just like a Kremnoan and thought they would get along best? What had Aglaea learned about the current Kremnoan ruler that she had deemed Phainon to be the best fit as their guard?

Heaving another sigh, Phainon willed his feet to continue on to his quarters outside the palace. He had to prepare himself before greeting a king, after all–a king who was rumored to be the strongest in the entire continent of Amphoreus. It was why Aglaea was so intent on forging an alliance with the Kremnoans. With the Kremnoans on their side, almost nothing could breach Okhema's borders.

Phainon grimaced to himself. The more he thought about it, the less he thought he would make it out of this week unscathed. Not only was this one of the most important political alliances for Okhema, but Aglaea just had to send some country boy to escort their king. Aglaea had always been intelligent and cunning, and it was why Phainon had always looked up to her as the ruler of Okhema. But, surely her head was not working properly today when she decided to assign Phainon this task? Although Aglaea

trusted in him a lot more than the average Okheman soldier, and Phainon had done his very earnest to see all of her assignments through, Phainon had no faith he would return with good results this time.

Sunlight streamed into his face, rousing him from his own deprecating thoughts. He hadn't even realized that he made it to the entrance of Marmoreal Palace, and the palace guards had already opened the grand doors for him to exit. Nodding in their direction in thanks, Phainon stepped outside to begin preparations for the Kremnoans' arrival. He didn't have long until they arrived, but he would do as best as he could.

In summary, Phainon had quite the morning. He had returned to his quarters and tidied himself up; he couldn't greet the Kremnoans with a disheveled appearance, after all. After a quick breakfast in the downtown market, he had returned to the palace to ensure their room arrangements were in order and that nothing was missing from the rooms. He instructed the maids to draw baths for when they arrive so that they would still be warm by the time they settled into their rooms. He visited the kitchen to review what dishes they were preparing for their stay and even had them accommodate any special food requests that they had included on their acceptance letter– one of which was pomegranate juice mixed with goat's milk. What a strange concoction, but Phainon couldn't knock it without trying it. Maybe it was a special Kremnoan delicacy. Phainon filed the beverage into the back of his mind to bring up later if he needed to keep the conversation flowing with them.

After running around Marmoreal Palace for hours, Phainon eventually collapsed onto a nearby bench in an unused drawing room in the palace. The Kremnoans would eventually be brought to this drawing room as it was the closest one to their temporary quarters; Phainon was just reviewing the area and ensuring nothing was out of place before bringing them in here once they arrived. Everything had to be meticulous, spotless, and perfect, so that Aglaea had no excuse if Phainon died at the hands of the Kremnoan king this week. Glancing down at his clothes, which was the common garb of a normal soldier and now disheveled again after running around the palace the entire morning, Phainon did his best to straighten and tidy his attire one last time before they arrived.

Although Aglaea had prepared for him special guard attire for fancy occasions in case he would ever guard high-profile figures, Phainon thought to save it for the ball instead. Wait, did Aglaea prepare that outfit just for this moment? Phainon had never had to accompany high-profile noble figures until now, yet that was the only reason Aglaea had given him that garb many moons ago.

Well, she had also given him the garb as her own way of promoting him, as the Council of Elders in Okhema always vetoed Aglaea's proposals for a “round table,”–a gathering of Okhema's best soldiers that would closely adhere and follow Aglaea's orders. Aglaea and the Council of Elders were always clashing heads in Okheman government, unfortunately, as the Council of Elders, who oversaw different government and political policies within Okhema, despised the way Aglaea ruled the kingdom. They feared that Aglaea would truly gain even more power if she had her own round table–one that would rival the Council of Elders. The only reason why Aglaea had not been overrun by their rule was because the priests of Janusopolis were backing her, and there was no kingdom that didn't follow the words of the priests–except for maybe the Grove of Epiphany, who valued intelligence and logic above all else. Phainon knew Aglaea was scheming in her own way to combat the Council of Elders, and he knew he would be called upon whenever those plans were ready.

It was approaching the middle of Action Hour which was when they had signalled their arrival. Phainon had done the best he could to scrub off any debris or wrinkles he could catch in his clothes. With another deep sigh escaping his body, Phainon prepared himself for the worst as he shut the drawing room doors behind him to find the entrance of the palace.

Marmoreal Palace was in utter chaos–as it always was around the time of festivities. Grand, high-profile guests traveled from all across Amphoreus to attend the festivities, and it was the palace staff who had to deal with them and accommodate as many of their ridiculous requests as possible. Members of Janusopolis, the Grove of Epiphany, and Styxia always came for the festivities, but now the entire palace was erupting over the fact that Kremnos was actually joining this year. The palace staff already knew how to handle the other three kingdoms but was unsure how Kremnos would

come into play. Phainon couldn't blame them at all–he was already counting down his days, after all. And it was Phainon who had to deal the most with the Kremnoans as their personal guard during their stay.

Phainon passed a multitude of rushing attendants as he made his way to the palace entrance–so many that he had begun to lose count of how many things he had to catch out of their arms as they dashed past him like mad in the corridors. The maids and butlers carried a wide assortment in their arms such as towels, books, ingredients, bedsheets, decorations, and many more things as they prepared for everyone's arrival.

Phainon was attending to Kremnos; he wondered who was attending to the other kingdoms that were arriving? He hadn't had time at all today to converse with anyone except for Aglaea this morning and the guard from even earlier who had interrupted his morning exercise to inform him that Aglaea was looking for him.

Reaching the grand garden that made up the entrance of Marmoreal Palace, there were only a few moments left until the Kremnoans would arrive. Heart pounding and hands sweating under the bright sunlight in anticipation for their arrival, Phainon decided to distract himself from his anxiousness by conversing with the other attendants waiting for the Kremnoans outside as well.

“Phainon!” One of the maids greeted him as he approached her. “I heard you were tasked with accompanying the Kremnoan ambassadors.”

Phainon nodded in confirmation. “Miss Aglaea informed me this morning. Truly a surprise to begin the day.”

“Miss Aglaea has never been wrong–if she tasked you with handling them, then you are surely our best bet.”

“Maybe it is because you are strong?” A nearby butler chimed in. “I've heard the Kremnoans value strength above all else. As our strongest warrior in Okhema, surely they would value your company over any other guard here.”

Phainon laughed lightly. It seemed no one knew anything about the Kremnoans outside of rumors. “I don't think I can compare to their king.”

“Nonsense, Phainon!” A range of voices burst at him. “Everyone knows how strong you are!”

The people began chatting about Phainon's heroic deeds ever since he joined the ranks of Okhema's soldiers many, many years ago. Frankly, Phainon didn't think he deserved all this praise. He was only completing what was tasked to him. There was nothing particularly special about that. There was nothing particularly special about *him*. He was just an average, Okheman citizen, who left his small hometown behind to become strong and help as many people as possible.

Among the chattering of all the servants came the sound of carriages being pulled into the garden. Everyone's conversations completely ceased as they scrambled back to their originally assigned positions to await the Kremnoan ambassadors. Phainon stepped up the stairs leading to the grandiose doors of Marmoreal Palace to watch as the first carriage pulled into place. The only sounds he could hear now were the faint rustling of the plants in the garden and his own pounding heartbeat. He would be one of the first people outside of Kremnos to ever witness their new king.

One of the Okheman attendants pulled open the door of the carriage, but Phainon was too far to see who had stepped out of the carriage. Traditionally speaking, royalty is often seated in the last carriage for protection purposes, so he didn't expect the King to be in the first carriage anyway. That was Phainon's initial thought, until the individual in the carriage was fully soaked in the sunlight.

With how elaborately dressed the first man to emerge was, Phainon could only assume that was the King himself. With glistening gold armor adorning his forearms and hands along with matching gold greaves, this man basically radiated the color of a gleaming, golden sun. With how soft and malleable the metal gold actually was, Phainon could easily tell this armor was only meant for royalty to be used as attire rather than actual protective gear. It was a way to portray both strength on the battlefield and

noble blood, and only the King or others of the noble family would wear golden armor.

An equally gold necklace adorned with blue gemstones lay across his bare chest, and a large golden belt lay across his hips. The only other color this man seemed to wear was a bright crimson, with a heavy, velvet cloak draped over one shoulder and lined with gold accents. Golden clasps kept the cloak on his shoulder, with a grand golden brooch sitting on one side; Phainon could only assume it marked the noble family of Kremnos. A single, gold pauldron was strapped to one shoulder and a matching golden band adorned his bare bicep, with golden hair falling down his shoulders. Phainon was too far to assess the man's face, but what really shocked him were the bright red lines running across his body wherever he could see skin.

Phainon squinted, unsure if he was seeing correctly or if the sunlight really was just that bright. Why was he half-naked? The only thing on his torso was a single sash that indicated royalty draped diagonally across his body, but it didn't look like he wore an actual shirt. He wasn't sure if the sunlight was just playing tricks on his sight. But, what was most interesting was that this man did not wear a crown despite being king. Although Aglaea was the ruler of Okhema, she was not technically a queen, as much of the government was also run by the Council of Elders. Kremnos, on the other hand, truly held a monarchy, yet no crown adorned this man's head. But, with all the golden armor and jewelry, Phainon didn't think anyone else stepping out of subsequent carriages would be the King.

And, he was right. One by one, as all the carriages lined up and doors were opened by attendants, no one that stepped out was dressed nearly as extravagantly as the first man. Not only was he the first one to appear, but he was also half-naked and wore no crown. Phainon was adding these mental notes into his head about Kremnoans, hoping he wouldn't offend him in the future with any accidentally offensive remarks. He needed to know as much about them as possible to appease them during their stay and to keep his head.

While he watched the attendants greet the Kremnoan ambassadors down below, Phainon straightened his back, preparing to greet the Kremnoans

himself. The butlers and maids scrambled around down below to take their luggages and coats as the new guests made their way up the stairs.

With a smile, Phainon greeted them as he finally came face to face with the man they called King. Contrary to his prior expectations, their king was absolutely, objectively beautiful. He was expecting a rugged, scarred man, but the King in front of him was completely unblemished with soft plump lips, a sharp jawline, and the most intimidatingingly gorgeous eyes. To one side of his hair, the front pieces were gathered together in a braid, ending in a golden cuff that held the braid together, yet the rest of his hair was untamed. He resembled a graceful, but wild, lion. That was the best way Phainon could describe his man's features. One could clearly tell this man was born of royal blood with the way he carried himself with such poise and elegance, yet confidence, intimidation, and strength.

“It is a pleasure to meet you.” Phainon smiled at this intimidatingly gorgeous man in front of him as his attendants stopped a little ways behind him. He still couldn't believe how objectively good-looking the King was. “My name is Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, and I will be your guard in Okhema during your stay.”

The King assessed him with eyes blatantly scanning his person. While being evaluated under keen, golden eyes, Phainon also noticed that the King did not wear a sword or any type of blade on his body. What did this king fight with without a single weapon on his person?

“Phainon,” the King repeated his name and, *woah*, the King's voice was deep. It was deep, but his voice was smooth, matching his elegantly intimidating aura. “I assume that you are Okhema's best warrior if they are sending you to accompany my side.”

That really *was why Aglaea assigned Phainon to the Kremnoans?!*

Phainon couldn't help perspiring under the King's intense gaze. But, with a slightly restrained smile, Phainon managed to respond, “I wouldn't possibly be your match, Your Majesty.”

The King hummed, assessing Phainon's build once more. “Do you take on sparring partners?”

“Pardon?”

“I asked if you train your swings against a person or a dummy, seeing as you have a sword strapped to your side.”

“*Ah*.” Phainon's hand instinctively reached for his greatsword. It was his most prized possession, Dawnmaker. He had gotten it forged by one of Okhema's greatest blacksmiths after a few years of working with Aglaea. “I would like to have a sparring partner; unfortunately, there is never a soul who would like to spar against me.”

Phainon's eyes couldn't help dropping to his lips when the King smirked at his response. Raising a chin at Phainon, the King said, “Show me to your training grounds. Let us fight.”

“*Pardon?!*” Phainon blinked blankly at the King, forgetting that he was supposed to be treating him like royalty.

“Is that all you ever say, Phainon?” the King chuckled, crossing his arms across his broad chest. “You said you wanted a sparring partner. Then, let us spar.”

Phainon was flabbergasted. After a long and arduous journey of travelling to a foreign country that they have never visited before, the first thing the King wanted to do was *fight?*

“I.. Well…” Phainon wasn't even sure how to respond. Firstly, the maids were already preparing their rooms to rest as they were speaking. Secondly, how would it be possible for someone as lowly as Phainon to exchange blows with a king? And thirdly, what if the King actually got injured?

Wait, maybe Phainon already failed their test, and he was being brought to the training grounds so they can spill his blood in a more private area?!

With a sheepish smile, Phainon could only say, “I am not sure if it is proper for me to exchange blows with you, Your Majesty.”

The King furrowed his eyebrows. “Not proper?”

“I am… I am just a common guard, Your Majesty. It wouldn't be proper to exchange blows with me. If you would like, I can call a knight of noble birth to–”

“What nonsense are you spouting?” the King scoffed. “Clearly, if there was a knight stronger than you, they would have sent them to accompany me instead. If they decided to send you, then there is no other warrior as strong as you within these borders.”

Phainon hesitated, unsure what the proper response was next. It wasn't as if he could just throw hands with the King of Kremnos, right? He couldn't even begin to imagine the Council of Elders walking in on him getting absolutely pummeled by the visiting king.

“I apologize, Your Majesty.” Phainon could only bow his head. “I am not sure if I am allowed.”

“Even if it is the request of the Kremnoan king?”

Phainon paused, his body growing rigid. Aglaea did task him with accommodating any and all requests that they had while they were here. Would fighting the King fall under that assignment? Phainon's head was a giant, jumbled mess, contemplating whether he should really throw it down against their king or not. It wasn't as if Phainon would *actually* win against the King, but it wasn't as if Phainon could just agree and say, “Sure, let's fight!”

He heard a sigh above him, as Phainon was still mid-bow. “We, Kremnoans, do not believe in anything such as noble birth or noble standing. Even if we are run by a king, the only importance that we hold is that strength is power. It does not matter to me whether you are a king or whether you are from a small, unknown town. What matters is how well you can wield your weapon and how well you can best your opponents.”

“I see.” Phainon stood himself back upright after his words, determination brimming off his eyes. There was no other excuse Phainon could use to deter this battle. If the Kremnoan king wanted to fight, then Phainon was going to give him one. “Then, you would like to spar with me?”

With his smirk returning to his lips, it almost seemed as if the King's eyes began to brightly glow. “Let us fight, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

The King had one of his attendants take his velvet cloak and sash, revealing more of his bare torso to Phainon's eyes. Phainon, with wandering eyes, forcefully tore his gaze away and informed a nearby maid that they still had time to prepare their rooms. The maid rushed off in a hurry to relay the news.

He led them to the training grounds and completely skipped the drawing room and their temporary quarters. This wasn't exactly what Phainon had in mind for their arrival, but he had to do what was best to accommodate them, right? Though, Phainon did his best to give them a tour of the areas around them that they passed on the way to the training grounds.

There were training grounds within Marmoreal Palace, which was where Phainon usually completed his training. Most soldiers used the training grounds near their quarters, but it was much smaller and more crowded. Aglaea had granted him and a few others special permission to use the royal palace's training grounds. Those few others were most likely escorting the other ambassadors from the different kingdoms that were visiting Okhema for the festivities.

Pushing open the doors to the vast training grounds, Phainon and the Kremnoans stepped back outside. It was a completely open training ground, with wooden weapons organised in one corner, and practice dummies and targets in another corner. The training grounds were completely customizable so that whoever was training could tailor to their own needs. Phainon was usually the only one who could be found here, as the others never trained as much as Phainon did, so the training grounds were almost always tailored to him.

He spared a glance at the King, who was nodding and taking in the sights. It seemed the training grounds were to his taste, much to Phainon's relief. He wasn't sure what kind of training grounds they had in Kremnos, where all they did was battle according to the rumors, but he was glad the King was at least satisfied with where he was brought to.

Phainon gently leaned Dawnmaker against the wall near the wooden sparring swords, grabbing one of the spare swords and approaching the center of the training grounds. the King followed soon after, with his attendants watching from the sidelines. Phainon had never had such a large audience before while training, and he was getting a little nervous over their peering eyes. The King, on the other hand, seemed more interested in the sparring partner in front of him.

“Are you ready, Your Majesty?” Phainon was rolling his shoulders and loosening up the tension in his body. He was so nervous over meeting the Kremnoans the entire first half of the day, but so far, the King was treating him with nothing but kindness. He was expecting the Kremnoan king to be brute and brash with all the rumors surrounding him, but he was pleasantly surprised that he was proven otherwise. It definitely helped relieve much of the tension in Phainon's body.

Narrowing his eyes at Phainon, the King flexed his wrist, and Phainon’s gaze immediately dropped to his hands at the action. Wait, did the Kremnoan king fight with his *hands?!* Was the King *actually* going to throw hands at him?! Was that why Phainon couldn't find a single weapon on his person?

“Mydeimos is my name.” The King's voice interrupted his thoughts. “No need for formalities.”

Okay, the tension immediately returned to Phainon's body. He wanted Phainon to address him by first name? Sure, he did that with Aglaea quite often, but he still added a “Miss” to the front of her name as a form of respect. And, he also knew and worked with Aglaea frequently. Calling an actual monarch that he had just met by his first name just didn't sit well with Phainon–someone who had a humble upbringing.

“I'm… afraid I cannot do that, Your Majesty.” Phainon breathed a laugh, readying his stance. Hopefully, the King didn't take too much offense.

Raising an eyebrow, the King also assumed a battle stance. He muttered under his breath, “Okhemans and their unnecessary formalities,” before declaring with a booming voice, “Then, if I win, call me Mydeimos.”

Phainon's eyes widened in response. But before he could respond back, the King rushed him, throwing a fist upward in an uppercut and aiming for his abdomen. Phainon could barely pull his feet backwards as he felt the wind brush against his tunic. If he had thrown his sword up to block the blow, it would have shattered into a million wood pieces.

Stumbling to catch his feet, Phainon barely had time to breathe when another fist came his way. Bracing his sword, he swung to his right, effectively blocking the blow, before jabbing straight into the King's shoulder. Although he did manage to mark the King, he wasn't sure how he was possibly going to win this. The King's defenses were quite strong, and he didn't see anywhere he could pierce through, even with his half-naked body.

The King smirked–possibly from the thrill of the battle or possibly from being scratched. Barely brushing a hand against his shoulder as if a speck of dust had landed on him, he lunged again, aiming for Phainon's shoulder as if seeking revenge. Phainon quickly brought the sword up to his shoulder, but the breath was knocked out of him when the King's other hand landed against his exposed shoulder.

Phainon gritted his teeth, slicing upwards when the King had approached him one more time in an attempt to follow up. His shoulder was throbbing, but it didn't matter if he could still stand. His sword had barely brushed the chin of the King, rushing through his golden and red hair. Tossing the hilt in his grasp, he turned his blade sideways to aim straight for his neck, but his wrist was caught by the King's own grasp.

The two were caught in a standstill, their eyes narrowed at each other and panting for breath. Adrenaline was pumping through Phainon's body–he had never felt such a rush in battle in a long time. It had been a while since

he had ever sparred against an actual human rather than the monsters that occasionally showed up at Okhema's borders, and it was exciting. No, even more than that; it was exhilarating. His heart was pounding, blood was pumping through his veins, and he couldn't wipe the smile off his face as he stared at the man in front of him, completely forgetting how different their social statuses were. At that moment, they were bound by nothing but their own skills on the battlefield.

"Impressive."

Phainon had barely registered those words before he threw his head back, dodging another fist. Seriously, why did it feel like this man had three hands? Ripping his hand from the tight grasp around his wrist, he tried to slice again, only to be effectively blocked by the King's golden vambrace. Phainon decided to aim lower, aiming for his side that wasn't blocked, but the King sidestepped as he attempted another slash.

He took advantage of this dodge, pushing forward and advancing toward him. This entire time, he had been playing on the defense, but now he was able to turn the tide. Phainon leaped forward, slashing a large arc downward and creating a wall of space between him in the King, before quickly stepping forward and swinging sideways, landing a hit on the man's chest. He faintly heard a laugh, but he wasn't sure if it was coming from him or the man he was sparring against. Continuing his advances with large swings, he aimed at the man's shoulders, waist, and arms, and all were continually blocked by the man's gauntlets.

With how wide his swings were, Phainon had managed to back the King into the wall and not let him escape, realizing that he may actually stand a chance to win this fight. Should he win this fight? Against a king? A slight hesitation from that thought left Phainon vulnerable, and before he could decide, he ended up tumbling to the floor.

His entire body ached as he pushed himself up, dust and debris flying through the air from when he had flown straight into the ground. Through the dust clouds, he could barely make out the King, who looked less than pleased that he had won.

“You,” the King growled, chest heaving from the fight, “You let me win that. Stand up. Again.”

Phainon quickly scurried to his feet as the King approached him. It didn’t help that his whole body throbbed from sliding into the floor, but it didn’t look like the King was going to back down anytime soon, especially since he despised the victory that Phainon had given him.

The Kremnoan attendants watched as Phainon and their king swung at each other for the remainder of the day, counting twenty battles and each individual winning exactly ten. It wasn’t until a maid had found Phainon after much effort and informed him that dinner was ready did they finally stop sparring, much to the attendants’ relief. Once their king got absorbed with a good opponent, it was nearly impossible to rip the man away.

However, they all agreed that it was quite a sight to behold, seeing how an ordinary soldier of Okhema was equally matched with their king. It was a battle like any other to the Kremnoans, as they all had watched the entire battle from beginning to end with sparkling eyes.

Phainon breathed a sigh as he dipped into his bath. The bath that he used was shared by all the soldiers, but no one was there as it had become so late in the night. He had no idea how time had passed so fast while sparring with the King, but the sensations of the battle and the rushing of adrenaline were still fresh in his mind. It was a feeling that he would never forget, and he spent the rest of his bath relaying the entire twenty sparring sessions in his mind. Not necessarily to lament over actions he should have done, but he was simply admiring their entire exchange.

Dressed back in the soldier’s uniform, it was time to pick up the Kremnoan guests from the dinner table. Phainon had a quick bite to eat before his bath, as it was rude to dine with royalty without a proper, explicit invitation. He had merely dropped them off in the dining room before quickly fleeing, explaining that he would return after their meal was complete. He didn’t hear what the Kremnoans had to say about that, but knowing the King, if he had opinions, he would hear them upon his return.

And, Phainon was completely correct. Upon entering the dining room again and laying eyes upon the Kremnoans, the King did not look pleased. In fact, much to Phainon's panic, the King looked *extremely* angry.

"Yes, Your Majesty?" Phainon hesitantly approached the table, standing across from the King's fury, who sent a sharp glare in his direction. The butlers and maids had quickly escaped the room the moment Phainon had entered, leaving the entire aftermath to him. "Did you not find the food palatable?"

"Why did you leave?"

Phainon blinked at him. "Pardon?"

The King leaned back into his chair, the fire only growing in his eyes. "HKS, how do I make you call me by name? You seemed to be treating me as an equal during our sparring sessions, so why can you not do that here?"

Phainon was speechless. He wasn't exactly sure what to say. And, he had no idea what the King had just called him. Sure, Phainon agreed that he was sparring with the King just as if he were another soldier during the heat of battle, but they weren't on the training grounds anymore. They were back inside the palace–a foreign king being accompanied by the country's soldier. He was just one of many soldiers. Should he apologize? It didn't look like the King would want an apology.

"In Okhema…it is quite rude for a commoner to be on equal standing as the nobility," Phainon explained. "I apologize if that made you uncomfortable in any way."

The King narrowed his eyes. "Even someone with skills as fine as yours?"

He laughed lightly. "One's birthplace is never forgotten in Okhema's borders. It is stuck to our name like glue."

The King clicked his tongue. "Aedes Elysiae… How annoying. You would thrive so much better in Kremnos." He pushed himself up, and the

attendants next to him followed suit. “Phainon, as I am a Kremnoan, you will do well to follow Kremnoan traditions rather than your own.”

Phainon nodded. It felt almost like he was being reprimanded like a child.

“Next time,” the King’s voice cut through his thoughts, “call me Mydeimos. And, join us when we are eating. You are more than just skilled–you are the most worthy opponent that I have ever enjoyed the opportunity of facing in years. You more than deserve my company, and I would like to meet again with the man I had sparred with earlier today. Because the man in front of me right now is different from the man I faced in the training grounds.”

Phainon quickly scanned the attendants’ expressions to gauge what they were feeling about the King’s orders, but they didn’t seem the least surprised at all. Kremnoan traditions truly felt like whiplash to Phainon.

With a laugh, Phainon nodded once again, his shoulders relaxing. He hadn’t even realized how tensed he was before. “Of course, Mydeimos. As you wish.”

A smile graced the King’s lips at his words, and Phainon swore his heart pounded at the sight of it. Truly, he was the most objectively beautiful person that he had ever laid eyes on. The number of concubines this man had was probably in the hundreds. It was common for monarchs to have concubines, right? Phainon wasn’t exactly sure, considering that Kremnoan tradition was so much different compared to what he had known his whole life. Though, if he did have a concubine, or two, one of them would be accompanying him. And, none of the attendants were close enough to the King to appear as his concubine. But, there was absolutely no way a man as beautiful as Mydeimos was single; Phainon refused to believe it.

Phainon led the King and his attendants to their private quarters, where they were finally able to relax after their long journey to Okhema. Before Phainon had taken his own bath, he had instructed the maids to reheat their baths so that they would still be warm by the time they finished their dinner. They had spent basically their entire day in the training grounds; truly, the rumors of Kremnoans living for battle were true enough. Phainon would

have never imagined being asked to spar with the King within their first exchange of words.

“Then, I will be returning tomorrow. Tomorrow, our ruler, Miss Aglaea, would like to speak with you. You will have the entire trip here in Okhema to think over her proposal, if that is suitable enough for you,” Phainon explained to the King. The King had his arms crossed across his chest, and he was leaning against the open door frame of his room while Phainon discussed tomorrow’s plans. The attendants had already retired for the day in separate rooms; they most likely did not have nearly as much stamina as the King, who not only endured the entire journey to Okhema from Kremnos but also immediately engaged in twenty duels upon entering Okhema’s borders.

Mydeimos fell silent, processing the information. “Yes, that is why I came here after all.” The King became deep in thought, seeming to mull over different political impacts and strategies in his mind. It must be quite complicated to rule a kingdom.

“Then.” Phainon nodded. “Good night, Mydeimos.”

The King, who was too busy lost in his thoughts over his own kingdom, glanced up at Phainon’s voice. “Tomorrow, I expect to be treated like your equal, rather than the King that you have seen me as all day.”

Phainon really, *really* could not help how loud the pounding of his heart had become. Seriously, did this man just naturally sound like he was flirting at every possible moment? It didn’t help that the King had such a seriously gorgeous complexion. With a laugh, Phainon could only respond with burning ears, “I will try my best, Mydeimos.”

With a smile, Mydeimos retired for the night, and Phainon was left falling asleep with the searing image of his smile in his mind.

Itinerary Day 2: Aglaea's Proposal

Chapter Notes

> I actually struggled so bad trying to find Okheman food to include in this fanfic thank god the Chrysos Maze Grand Restaurant event released when I was writing later chapters LOL
>
> Or else they were literally going to be eating Golden Honeycakes forever... which I guess Mydei wouldn't complain about

Bright and early the following day, Phainon left the soldier's quarters and knocked on the attendants' doors. He wasn't sure if it was rude of him to report directly to the King, so he reported to the attendants first.

One of them opened the door for him, and Phainon faintly remembered from their initial meeting that his name was Herklas. Phainon greeted him with a smile. "I have come to retrieve you all for breakfast. Has your king risen?"

Herklas stared at him with mild surprise. "I'm surprised you didn't go see him first."

"Pardon?"

"The King will be quite sad that you came to talk to us about him rather than talking to him directly."

With an expression of bewilderment, Phainon lightly laughed. "I don't think the King would be so sad about that."

He cocked his head to the side, leaning on the door. "This is quite possibly the first time the King has ever taken such a liking to someone else. You should listen to him."

"Surely… the King doesn't like me as much as you say." Phainon sheepishly scratched the back of his head at the thought. He didn't

particularly think he received special treatment from the King during the previous day.

“It's true.” Another attendant–Phainon recalled her name was Empousa–showed up at the door. “King Mydeimos has never shown such favoritism to anyone before.”

Phainon frowned. “What favoritism, might I ask? He just genuinely seems like a polite man.”

The two attendants exchanged a look before glancing back at Phainon, with one of them responding, “King Mydeimos is surely a benevolent and strong ruler, and we all admire and look up to him. But he does not normally treat his subjects the way he treats you: the way he asks you to share meals with him, spar with him, and treats you as his equal. King Mydeimos knows his place as the King of Kremnos, but he seems to treat you with extra special attention, even forgoing his title of king to converse with you as equals.”

“That's… not normal for him?” Phainon was just as surprised as the attendants were yesterday, according to them. Their poker faces were truly magnificent; Phainon had been gauging their expressions all day yesterday to see if the King's actions were normal, and they acted as if they were. Now, Phainon was finally learning that they were in fact *not* normal.

Empousa shook her head. “Krateros is surely going to have a fit over this.”

Herklas, who was leaning against the door, widened his eyes at the statement. “Krateros is going to throw a table if he hears about this.”

“Krateros?”

The two attendants’ attention snapped back to Phainon. One of them replied, “Krateros is King Mydeimos’s teacher. You could also say he is his closest confidante. He is currently watching over Kremnos while we are away.”

Herklas continued, raising his head. “Krateros has been trying to find a suitable partner for the King for years now. Who knew that partner would

be residing in a different kingdom?”

Phainon's brain immediately did a backflip. “Wait, excuse me, *partner?* The King doesn't have a partner?”

Empousa laughed. “Surprising, isn't it? Kremnoans treasure the bond that is forged between lovers, as it is one of the strongest things a human can have. But, it has been years since King Mydeimos took the throne, and he has never once found a lover. Krateros has been in a fiery determination to find him a suitable partner and set him up but to no avail.”

“He seems to have taken a liking to you though.” Herklas leaned his head back against the door. “Who knows, maybe you will end up returning with us to Kremnos by the end of the week.”

With a burning face, Phainon wasn't sure how to respond to that statement. “There's… The King doesn't like me in that manner.”

Herklas scoffed. “Are you going to believe yourself, who has only known him for a day, or us, who have known him almost our entire lives?”

Jabbing him in the side with her elbow, Empousa sighed. “Although we do not know the King's true feelings, what we do know is that he has taken a very specific liking to you, Phainon. A very special liking.”

Her words only made Phainon burn even more. *A very special liking…*

“Done with your rambling?”

All three of the heads immediately turned in the direction of Mydeimos, who was already dressed and standing outside his bedroom door. The two attendants hurriedly jumped back into their room to prepare themselves for the day.

“Mydeimos.” Phainon smiled at him, mentally clapping himself on the back for remembering to call him by name. How long was he standing there? And, how much of the conversation did he hear? “Did you have a good rest?”

The King stared at him with a blank gaze. Phainon wasn't sure what exactly on his person the King was so intensely looking at, as he was wearing the exact same garb as when they had first met.

“The way you talk to my attendants.” Mydeimos glanced at the door adjacent to Phainon, which was now closed shut as the attendants inside rushed to get ready. “Speak to me how you speak to them.”

Phainon stared back at Mydeimos with wide eyes. “With… such casualty?”

“Is that so wrong?” Mydeimos returned his stare.

“Well… No, but,” Phainon couldn't help stammering at the sudden request. “It will… take me some time to become accustomed to.”

“That is of no matter. We have time. Didn't you say you would try your best?”

Last night's conversation flashed in Phainon's mind and the verbal promise that he had given the King. With a light chuckle, Phainon nodded. “Yes, of course I remember, Mydeimos.”

“And next time, report to me instead of my attendants.”

Phainon smiled. “I will do that, Mydeimos.”

The attendants opened the door again, and before they could shut the door behind them, Phainon could see how much of a whirlwind their room had become in the process of rushing to get ready. The maids will certainly have a trip attending to that mess later.

Once all the attendants in the other rooms were ready, he led them down to the dining room where they ate their dinner the previous night. As they were settling in their seats, the King gave Phainon a look, and Phainon knew what he was referring to.

“May I sit across from you, Mydeimos?”

“*Hmph*, you don't need to ask.”

With a laugh, Phainon settled in the seat across from the King. Sitting across from the King and being able to fully appreciate his radiance… Phainon could easily see why anyone would worship and follow this man as their king.

The chefs brought out their breakfast on shining silver dinnerware. Silver dinnerware was always used, especially for those of higher ranking, to detect any poisons that may be in the dish itself. It was a form of trust to indulge in someone else's cooking, and for the palace, it was a form of trust to pass their dishes onward on a silver platter for their guests.

The dish that was brought out for breakfast was a classic Okheman delicacy. Although it was originally a dish reserved for royalty, it has now become a popular favorite among the masses with how fluffy and sweet it was. The dish was named Golden Honeycakes. With a self-explanatory name, the honeycakes were served in stacks, with a sweet, viscous syrup oozing down the sides. Shining under the lights, the syrup only made the fluffy honeycakes look even more enticing. And with an addition of berries scattered among the plates, the sourness balanced out the sweetness of the syrup.

Butter was served separately, so the guests can indulge in as much of as little as they would like. The table was set with utensils, napkins, silver creamers containing even more of that delicious syrup, and sugar bowls in case the guests would like to add powdered sugar on top of their honeycakes. Bowls of fresh berries could also be found around the table in case the guests would like to add more, and pitchers of some sort of pink milk were set on the table. Was that the pomegranate juice mixed with milk that Phainon saw before as their special food request?

Phainon didn't think about this before when he was told to dine with the Kremnos guests, but he didn't know the first thing about dinner etiquette or what good table manners consisted of. He only had brief lessons from when he first became a soldier, but that was years ago. As someone whose main job was to guard or fight, and as someone who was born and raised in the countryside by farmers, he had no need to know how to properly eat at the table. Digging through his brain for those few lessons he received, Phainon decided to just eat as little as possible so as to not appear rude or

unbecoming in front of the guests. Later, Phainon could return to the kitchen and find something else to eat to satiate his appetite.

The Kremnoans indulged delightfully in silence in front of him; while scarcely picking at his food, Phainon eyed them every now and then just to ensure that no one needed assistance with anything or a request they needed tending to. But overall, they seemed to be happily enjoying the food, much to Phainon's relief.

“Is this dish not to your liking?”

Phainon glanced upward at the voice directed at him and was met with golden eyes. Based on the state of his plate, it seemed that the King thoroughly enjoyed the dish set before him.

It seemed Phainon couldn't get away with anything in front of this man. He set down the silver utensils in his hands with a smile, his Golden Honeycakes barely touched. “No, I am just not particularly hungry today.”

Mydeimos hummed, glancing down at his plate at the few remains that were left. “This dish is truly worthy of my attention.”

Phainon laughed lightly. “I'm glad you enjoyed it. It's a popular local delicacy of Okhema.”

Humming, Mydeimos agreed. “I can see why.”

One of the Kremnos attendants poured the King a glass of the pink milk. Even though the attendant was in the middle of explaining to the King that he had already tasted the milk, Mydeimos had already taken a mighty swig from his glass. It was like absolutely nothing could kill this man, and this man was not afraid of anything either.

“I saw your special food request.” Phainon nodded in the direction of the glass in Mydeimos’s hand. “Is pomegranate juice and milk a common beverage in Kremnos?”

The attendants all looked puzzled at his statement, with one of them opening their mouth to answer his question: “The King just happens to enjoy it himself. It's weird.”

The attendants all nodded and muttered amongst themselves in agreement. Phainon was shocked that they so blatantly knocked their king's choice of drink, but the man in question didn't seem to pay them any mind as he continued drinking his glass full of pomegranate juice milk.

“It's common in Kremnos culture to drink pomegranate juice,” the female attendant that Phainon was speaking to earlier, Empousa, chimed in. “To us, it is named sanguine honey brew. As a way of forging alliances, we will share a chalice of blood among our new allies. That ‘blood’ would be pomegranate juice.”

Phainon has heard that tradition before, where Kremnos would sustain their bodies with blood, and it was also believed that, by drinking the blood of powerful enemies, they would be granted the valiance of the deceased. Although Phainon didn't know if those rumors were true or not, now he knew that they were drinking pomegranate juice the entire time.

“So, Mydeimos,” Phainon smiled in his direction, “do you just prefer the taste of goat's milk and mix it in with pomegranate juice?”

Mydeimos set down his glass. “I prefer the color.”

That answer made him pause. Tilting his head to one side, Phainon asked, “Pink?”

Swirling the glass, Mydeimos gently smiled. “It is quite a pleasant color.”

Phainon was surprised at how gentle his smile was. This intimidating man, known as probably the most powerful person on the entire continent of Amphoreus, was smiling so gently over the color of his beverage. With his softened golden eyes and his soft lips upturned into a smile, Phainon felt as if he were mesmerized by the sight of the man before him; he almost wanted to reach out to brush his hand across his cheek, even swiping a

thumb along his lips that were shimmering from the syrup from the Golden Honeycakes that he had just enjoyed.

As much as Phainon wanted to continue staring at the King as he admired the color of his glass, he knew it was time for his meeting with Aglaea. Swallowing dryly and pushing all those indecent thoughts about the King away, he stood from his table and instructed the maids waiting nearby to clear the rest of the dining table. Phainon even added an extra instruction to save his own dish in some corner of the kitchen so that he could indulge in it later. Receiving his request, the maids quickly went to work while one of them had carefully taken Phainon's plate away separately.

Only two attendants continued on with the King while the rest were escorted away by other soldiers. As the King was meeting with Aglaea, he didn't need all of his attendants there, so the remainder of them would have the freedom to do whatever they would like around Marmoreal Palace or around Okhema with the protection of the other guards. Phainon led the King and two of his attendants to Aglaea’s personal office, where Phainon was previously given this task of being the Kremnoan's escort during their temporary stay in Okhema.

“Miss Aglaea will let me know when to come get you, so for now, I will inform her of your arrival.” Before Phainon could disappear into her office to speak with her, the King's voice cut him off.

“You do not need to worry about manners around me.” the King's gaze bore straight into Phainon. “As I said before, we are equals. No need to treat me as if I would break.”

Phainon stared at him with wide eyes. “I apologize, where is this coming from?”

“I saw you ask the maid to take your plate away separately. Were you afraid of eating improperly in front of me?”

Pausing for a brief moment, Phainon laughed at his words. “You caught me, Mydeimos. Truly, nothing can get past you.”

Mydeimos huffed, but he didn't seem the least bit angry. “Just eat your food next time. Did you think I invited you to the table just to ridicule your table manners?”

Phainon chuckled. “I just didn't want to offend.”

“You would never offend me, Phainon.”

Seriously, can this guy stop with all of these flirtatious statements? Phainon was afraid he was going to get the wrong idea at this point. It was barely the second day of meeting the King of Kremnos, but the amount of times his heart had beat so loudly in his ears over what the King had said to him was more than in his entire lifetime. The way Mydeimos so plainly stated his feelings as if they were a fact was something that always made Phainon's ears burn.

“Then,” Phainon tried to avert his gaze from the man as his ears were so obviously as red as Mydeimos's cloak. “I will let Aglaea know you have arrived.

Raising a fist, he knocked on the door. Once he heard Aglaea’s voice, he let in the King and his two attendants.

“Then, I will see you all later.” Phainon smiled before shutting the door behind him.

“Thank you, Phainon.” Aglaea returned the smile as Phainon disappeared behind the closed door. Glancing at the King who took the seat that was prepared in front of her desk, she placed down the scroll that she was previously reading.

“King Mydeimos, what an honor to finally meet you. I was quite surprised when I received news that you would be attending the grand ball this year.” Aglaea leisurely rested a chin in the palm of her hand as her elbow rested on top of her mahogany desk. “Would you like some tea? I have prepared Okhema's finest in preparation for your arrival.” Aglaea waved a hand toward the maid who was standing in a corner of the room. Nodding, she

quickly wheeled her cart over, pouring the King some tea in a delicate, ceramic tea cup.

“It's an honor to still be welcomed after declining your invitations so many times previously,” Mydeimos said as one of his attendants took the tea from the maid's hands. “Now that things have settled in my kingdom, I thought it was time to make my public debut to the other kingdoms.”

Aglaea nodded in understanding. “How do you like the guard I sent you? I couldn't find much information about you, but I felt that Phainon would be the best fit to show you around our country.”

“His growth has stagnated by being here.” Mydeimos wasted no time in revealing his true thoughts. He took a sip of tea from the tea cup his attendant returned to him. “He has a great potential that this kingdom is not taking advantage of.”

The smile on Aglaea's face only grew as she stirred her own cup of tea on her desk. “I am so glad we are of the same, King Mydeimos. That is the reason why I have brought you here today. Phainon is someone who deserves more than what is given to him, but I need some help.”

“Speak, why are you delaying this?”

Aglaea, unbothered by his comment, brought out the scroll that she was holding, detailing the Okheman government. “I cannot do this alone, you see. As you may already know, I am not the sole ruler of Okhema. It is me and the Council of Elders, which you see here.” She gestured to the scroll portraying the duties of the Council of Elders. “I have been working to create a specific regiment, you could say. It would consist of the strongest warriors in Okhema; of course, Phainon would be a part of it.”

Mydeimos crossed his arms, glaring at the scroll being shown to him. “And I am assuming you are in conflict with the Council of Elders, as they are refusing this personal guard?”

“I haven't been quite as successful as I would like to be,” Aglaea agreed. “However, if a kingdom whose expertise was war happened to want to

collaborate through this specific regiment, arrangements could certainly be pushed through. It would make sense that this valiant country would rather work with only a specialized few rather than the entire Okheman guard, as no crisis in Okhema is large enough as of right now to warrant needing to be in contact with our whole guard."

Narrowing his eyes, Mydeimos commented, "And why should Kremnos become involved in your inner political conflict?"

She placed the scroll down on her desk, but her constant smile only served to unnerve the King. "I am assuming you already have a price in mind. Tell me, is it something I can grant you?"

"You already know what I want. Why not spell it out?"

Aglaea chuckled. "I am torn. I had originally thought you wanted Okhema to welcome your citizens as our own in times of conflict. I have heard your people have been fighting for decades against the Black Tide monsters on your borders, and I had assumed you came to discuss peace with Okhema in the case your kingdom falls." She examined her fingernails, polished in a brilliant gold. "However, it seems as if you also have eyes on my guard. Am I wrong?"

Mydeimos scoffed, ignoring her last comment. "You want me to back your plans for a specialized regiment in return for housing my citizens in times of war? It seems like you are neglecting to mention something else."

"Why?" Aglaea tilted her head with an innocent smile. "Does the deal seem too good? It is an alliance with Kremnos, after all–the strongest military might in the world. If that doesn't appease you, would you like me to throw in my guard as well? I've heard you have no concubines or lovers."

"Why does that concern you?" Mydeimos growled.

Aglaea laughed, covering her mouth with a gentle hand. "My apologies, King Mydeimos. I only said that in jest. If you truly wanted my guard, you would have to speak with him first."

Mydeimos only stayed silent, waiting for the golden woman to continue speaking.

However, Aglaea wasn't the least bit intimidated by the King in front of her. “I would like your help with a little something. You see–” Aglaea raised the scroll again into the air, staring at the sun peeking through the scroll from the window. “–the Council of Elders is rather… troublesome, might I say.”

Mydeimos narrowed his eyes once more at the trade she was insinuating. “*Hmph*, so you don't want my help in supporting your specialized regiment. You want to take them down entirely.”

Aglaea was beaming at the King. “Oh, I didn't say that, did I?” She chuckled to herself. “Well, King Mydeimos, is that a fair trade? Of course, I don't expect an answer right away. I will give you the rest of your time here to ponder it over.” She set the scroll back down upon her desk, practically grinning at the King seated across from her.

“The political implications of your actions…” Mydeimos muttered more to himself than to Aglaea. He sank deep into thought, weighing the pros and cons in his mind over her proposal.

“I hope you enjoy the rest of your stay here in Okhema,” Aglaea said. “I hope you continue to enjoy your time with my guard, King Mydeimos. He is a wonderful man.”

Mydeimos stared at Aglaea, unmoving and without another word.

Nonetheless, Aglaea only smiled at him. “Do not worry, Your Majesty. I think of Phainon as a son of mine. I witnessed him join the ranks of soldiers when he was quite young and have only watched him grow overtime. There is no need to fear any competition on my part.” She hummed in delight, taking a sip of her tea. “Hasn't he grown to be such a handsome man?”

Mydeimos only let out a *hmph* in response before Aglaea gestured to the maid once more. “Please summon Phainon for me.”

The maid nodded at her order and exited the room.

Phainon was currently in the training grounds, practicing his swings against a dummy. He usually trained at the beginning of every day if he did not have any special missions or assignments to complete. Because he had to attend to the Kremnoans every day of this week, Phainon didn't expect he would get much training done until they departed.

He stopped mid-swing, his wooden sword hovering in the air at the thought. He had completely forgotten that Mydeimos would eventually leave. Well, he knew they were all going to leave once the Okheman festivities were over, but actually thinking about it sent a ball into the pit of his stomach. He had to admit it: Phainon had been enjoying the King’s company as of late. He was a great sparring partner, for one, and he genuinely enjoyed speaking with the King. Occasionally, he would even forget that he was actually nobility, but that was exactly what Mydeimos wanted.

Mydeimos was going to leave eventually… Phainon didn't think he would become so attached to a king that he had just met only the previous night. Especially as a commoner, Phainon didn't think he would become so close to a king in his entire lifetime. It was something he wouldn't have even entertained the idea of. The moment he had dropped Mydeimos off in Aglaea's office, it was already too quiet. Even just finishing the rest of his breakfast earlier in the kitchen, Phainon wondered how he had spent most of his time alone so often. In just a day, Mydeimos had already secured a spot in Phainon's life.

Maybe it was because Phainon had never felt close with the other soldiers. Sure, he was on good terms with them. He spoke with them whenever they had down time together, they completed assignments together, and they had even fought side by side before. But, Phainon wouldn't refer to any of them as his “friend.” Actually, would Phainon even refer to Mydeimos as a “friend”? He felt that would be too forward and presumptuous of him, especially considering his own position. Phainon scratched the thought from his mind. Sure, Mydeimos emphasized numerous times that he wanted to be treated as an equal to Phainon, but how was that possible when their social statuses were the complete opposite? And, even if he did treat him as an equal, that didn't necessarily mean that they were “friends,” right?

He swung at the dummy, chipping off a part of his sword from the impact. His brain was hurting too much mulling over a man who was going to return to his own country in approximately five days from now. There was no point in worrying about whether they were “equals” or whether they were “friends” if he was never going to see Mydeimos again. Their social statuses were too great to warrant them ever meeting again. The next time he would probably see him was during the next Okheman ball in a few years, and that was assuming that Mydeimos even wanted to attend again.

His chest squeezed tightly at the thought. Phainon really didn't realize how attached he would become to the King. He thought he would be scared, even, of the King of Kremnos, but here he was, depressed at the mere thought of the King leaving him. Maybe Phainon should try and take leave again to go training in Kremnos as he originally wanted to do? Although the thought came up again as to why Mydeimos took the life of his own father, after meeting the King in person, Phainon could only assume it had to be for a good reason. Was he perhaps too trusting of a man he had just met yesterday?

His thoughts were halted when he heard the doors to the training grounds open. Glancing over, a maid had rushed inside, informing him that Aglaea was summoning him. He thanked the maid, who nodded and rushed back inside.

Ideally, Phainon would have taken a bath after his training session before seeing the King, but he was so absorbed in his thoughts that he barely had time to do either. His gaze turned toward the sky, and the sun was beginning to lower in the sky, signalling that they were more than halfway through the day. Phainon didn't even realize how long Mydeimos was away to speak with Aglaea, and he didn't realize himself how long he had been outside in the training grounds just thinking about the King.

Placing the wooden sword back where he had retrieved it, Phainon began running the rest of the day through his head. The only mandatory engagement on the King's schedule for the day was to speak with Aglaea. He wasn't exactly sure what else Mydeimos would want to do to fill the rest of the day; he figured that they already indulged in a midday meal during their meeting. Maybe he would leave it to Mydeimos on what he would like

to do, and Phainon could suggest him any activities or locations based on his mood. He wasn't exactly sure what Aglaea had discussed with Mydeimos, only that Aglaea had a proposal of an alliance with the Kremnos, so he hoped that Mydeimos was not in a sour mood.

Straightening his uniform and tidying his clothes as much as possible, Phainon continued on his way toward Aglaea's office in Marmoreal Palace and politely greeted any palace staff he passed, resolving himself to finally stay true to the words he had given Mydeimos. This time, when he saw the King again, he wanted to be able to express his true self without the barrier of their social status standing between them. As much as their difference in class still intimidated Phainon, he truly, deeply wanted to feel that Mydeimos was really a close “friend” of his, however close a commoner and a king could be, that is.

Phainon had figured that, because Mydeimos was going to depart Okhema in just a few short days, he should probably try his best to adhere to the King's requests of treating him as an equal as soon as possible. As someone who Phainon actually felt close with and knew that he would definitely be affected by his departure, he wanted to be able to express that to Mydeimos even if it was only for just a couple of days. While walking over to Aglaea's office to retrieve him, he had been practicing saying more casual lines to the King over and over again in his mind.

If Mydeimos was going to depart so soon, and they would never see each other again, Phainon thought it would be best if he spent this time with Mydeimos with no regrets. Though, if he were being honest with himself, it still felt a little odd conversing with a king so casually. With how elaborately dressed Mydeimos always was, even without a shirt, how could he possibly forget that he was of noble rank?

When he finally reached Aglaea's ornate office door, all he could hear were voices, but it was hard to make out what they were discussing. Phainon knocked on the door and heard Aglaea's voice beckon him inside, and as he entered the office, he found Mydeimos and Aglaea, who had just finished their midday meal, and the two attendants off to the side.

“Well, King Mydeimos.” Aglaea set down the tea cup that she was sipping on. “It was lovely speaking with you today. I hope to see you again during the ball.”

Mydeimos returned the pleasantries as the two attendants scurried out the door to await their king. Phainon stayed in the room while the King prepared to leave.

“Please do treat King Mydeimos well.” Aglaea smiled at him.

Phainon nodded at Aglaea before exiting the room behind the King and shutting the office door. Although he was curious as to what they had discussed, it was improper of him to pry in on their private discussions. It was most likely about politics and government anyway; something that someone in Phainon's position should not pay any attention to.

“Mydeimos.” Phainon smiled at the King. “There is nothing else on your schedule for the remainder of the day. Was there anything you would like to do?”

At his words, Mydeimos glanced at the two attendants silently. Somehow, they seemed to understand exactly what he was trying to communicate, because they nodded wordlessly and scurried off down the corridor.

Phainon, who was left in a daze at that silent interaction, only snapped out of his stupor once the two attendants were out of sight. “I–They should–I should probably–”

“Don't worry about them.” Mydeimos stopped Phainon before he could take a step toward stopping the two attendants. “They have gone to join the other attendants. I believe they wanted to peruse the markets, as many vendors are selling specialty items for the festival.”

“I… Should I be leaving them alone?”

“Aglaea has already called upon some guards for them. They are meeting at the entrance to the palace.”

“I see.” Phainon breathed a sigh of relief as he stared down the hallway that the attendants disappeared from. He wasn't sure how he was possibly going to chase after those Kremnoan attendants while also trying to attend to the King, but he was grateful it didn't have to come to that. Turning back to the King, he asked, “Well, Mydeimos, was there anything you wanted to do today?”

Mydeimos seemed to assess Phainon with keen eyes after hearing his words, and all Phainon could do was stand there and let the King do what he wanted with his eyes. He tried not to feel so anxious, but it was difficult when such a good-looking man was staring at him so intensely.

After a few moments of being scrutinized under the King's gaze, he finally broke the silence. “Were you just in the training grounds?”

Phainon laughed, as he wasn't expecting Mydeimos to mention that. “Sorry for my unkempt appearance. I didn't have time to wash off before coming here.” *I didn't have time because I was too busy thinking about a certain someone*, but Phainon pushed those thoughts away.

Smirking, Mydeimos began rolling his shoulders and eyeing Phainon. “Need a sparring partner?”

Phainon couldn't help another laugh escape him. “You want to fight *again*, Mydeimos?”

“We were tied yesterday. I believe that means we are due for another match.”

Laughing once more, Phainon couldn't retort and led Mydeimos back to the training grounds. He really couldn't believe how close he had become to this king.

Throwing open the doors to the training grounds, Phainon and Mydeimos both strolled inside. While Phainon went to peruse the training weapons to find which wooden sword was in the best condition, Mydeimos was already out in the field warming up. He had already shed his cloak and nobility sash, throwing it on the ground to one side away from the main field.

“Is it okay to just throw your stuff like that?” Phainon approached the field once he had found the most suitable weapon. “I can get a chair or something for you to place your things on.”

Mydeimos halted in his warm-up punches, raising an eyebrow at Phainon. “You seem to be speaking much more casually this time around. Did something change while I was away?”

He didn't think the King would notice so quickly. Instead of expressing his deepest regrets over never being able to see Mydeimos again after he left in a few days, Phainon opted to laugh instead. “What? I thought this was what you asked for, Mydeimos.”

The King scoffed in response, readying into a battle position. “Prepare yourself, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

Phainon had just barely assumed a defensive stance at his words when Mydeimos charged at him, his vambrace clashing against his wooden sword. As he wasn't prepared for such a hit, Phainon stumbled, and Mydeimos took the chance to follow through and aim straight for his chest. Because Phainon's defenses were unsteady and unbalanced, the only thing Phainon could do was dodge, ducking underneath his fist before springing back into his feet to slash widely down his chest.

The two men went at it against each other in the training grounds, wooden sword striking against gold gauntlets in an endless dance. In a whirlwind of dodging, blocking and attacking, the two men sparred until the sun began to set and the cool, night breeze began to fall upon them. With the sky erupting into a multitude of colors as the sun dipped below the horizon, casting a soft glow onto the two men below, they continued their equally matched battles. With neither of them gaining a lead over the other, this perfectly equal score only spurred the two men to continue on for longer, even until the sun had fully disappeared and the stars began to shine high above them.

Phainon was panting for breath, swiping sweat off his cheek as he charged forward against Mydeimos, who had blocked his wide swing and aimed straight for his abdomen. The wind was knocked out of his chest in an

instant, and he couldn't dodge the second hook that went straight for his shoulder. He stumbled on his feet but had managed to throw his sword up, blocking another fist that was aimed straight for his chest.

That rush of adrenaline and the exhilaration running through his veins that Phainon had felt when they first sparred had returned, and he couldn't wipe the ridiculous smile spreading across his face the longer he clashed with Mydeimos. With every bruise that blossomed on his skin and every little slice that Phainon had managed on Mydeimos's person, his heart pounded in his chest and his eyes beamed in the heat of battle. No one had ever fared so equally against Phainon before, and that excitement continued to grow the longer he sparred with the golden-haired man in front of him.

In this moment, with only Mydeimos on the training grounds with him, he truly felt free. He didn't feel like a commoner. He didn't feel like some country boy who had moved to a big city. He didn't feel like a soldier. He felt just like *Phainon*. And in turn, the man he was exchanging strikes with was just Mydeimos–not a king, not nobility, and not a man who had travelled from a foreign country, but just *Mydeimos*. It felt like the two were meant to be in this place, under the moonlight, fighting like there wasn't another difficulty to worry about other than how to dodge their next attack.

With them equally winning twelve rounds each, once again, they ended in a draw. A maid had come to fetch them now that supper was ready, bringing their sparring sessions to an end. Phainon and Mydeimos were panting heavily across from each other in an effort to catch their breaths, and the night breeze worked wonders on cooling their heated skin.

“Still a draw, Mydeimos?” Phainon smirked at the other man, propping the wooden sword upon his shoulder.

With a *hmph* in response, the two men quickly cleaned up the training grounds and embarked toward the dining area with the maid following after them. The maid had explained that the Kremnoan attendants had already indulged in their evening meals after returning from the downtown market, and they were now retiring to their rooms for the night. Phainon spared a glance at the King, but he didn't seem the least displeased at the news, only nodding and continuing onward to the dining hall. It seemed that the King

of Kremnos was quite the independent man, even doing things without his attendants in tow.

It was just the two of them indulging in their meals in the dining area, excluding the servants who were running around and serving them food. It felt a little awkward that Phainon was one of the people being served, as the people serving him were also his colleagues. But he thanked them nonetheless, enjoying the extravagant food in front of him that he would normally never be able to eat.

Today's meal was a rocklamb steak, seared to perfection. The scent was absolutely delectable, and the exquisite taste matched up to his expectations. It was perfectly cooked on its surface, yet soft on the inside once he had taken his first bite. With the meat basically melting in his mouth, the golden sauce that was slathered over the steak gave it an even richer flavor. Vegetables were served separately on silver platters along with extra servings of the golden sauce.

Although Phainon was hesitant to showcase his extreme lack of table manners to the King seated directly across from him, he swallowed his nervousness aside and opted to focus on his food rather than his mannerisms. He really, truly wanted to try his best to be comfortable with the King, even if it was something he would most likely never do again. He couldn't imagine there being another king in this world who would treat a commoner equally to them. Phainon kept stealing glances at Mydeimos to gauge his reaction, but Mydeimos didn't say a word as he focused on his own plate.

They ate in silence, with the occasional sounds of silver hitting silver and the rustling of the chefs taking away empty plates or refilling servings. The more Phainon advanced into his own steak, the more he felt the tension leaving his body as he soon became accustomed to eating with Mydeimos. Even after a while of dining together, Phainon stopped stealing so many glances at the man in front of him.

The maids rapidly took the empty plates on the table once they had finished their meal. Phainon thanked the servants once more before holding the door open for Mydeimos, who followed after him as he led them back to his

room. As usual, the maids had already prepared a bath for Mydeimos while he was eating so that it would be ready for him immediately once he had retired to his room.

Phainon and Mydeimos approached the corridor that housed all the rooms the Kremnoans were staying in for the week. It was quite silent now, as it was late into the Curtain-Fall Hour.

Stopping in front of the room that belonged to Mydeimos, he offered a small smile. “Thank you for letting me dine with you.”

Mydeimos raised an eyebrow, crossing his arms. “There is nothing you need to thank me for.”

Phainon laughed quietly. “Then, I will see you tomorrow. Good night, Mydeimos.”

Before he could depart, Mydeimos cleared his throat, stopping him in his tracks. It was Phainon's turn to raise an eyebrow at the King.

“Was there something else you needed?” Phainon tilted his head to the side. “I can go get it for you while you take a bath.”

He wasn't sure why he was suddenly now on the receiving end of Mydeimos's glare, but he explained himself before Phainon could ask. Gesturing towards the door, Mydeimos uttered the last request that Phainon would have ever expected: “Would you like to come inside?”

“Huh?” Was all that came out of Phainon's mouth. His brain couldn't even articulate anything else even if he tried. The more he thought about Mydeimos's ask, the more his brain began short-circuiting. It truly felt like electricity was popping in his head.

Mydeimos's glare never ceased. “HKS, did you really not hear me?”

Phainon's eyes widened as he shook his hands in front of him. He really needed to ask what that Kremnoan word meant. “No! No, I heard you loud and clear, Mydeimos. I just–” Phainon's eyes wildly searched the man's

face, wondering if he was just saying all this in jest to tease Phainon. But, Mydeimos looked absolutely serious. “Is… Is that proper of me? For a foreign soldier to enter the room of a king? Isn't there like… Can't only certain individuals enter the quarters of a king? Or maybe–”

“You talk too much.” Mydeimos cut off Phainon's rambling. “When I want someone to enter my room, I will ask them. Will you accept?”

Phainon's brain was barely working at all at the moment, yet at the same time he felt his brain was being overworked. He stared into Mydeimos's golden eyes with an exasperated expression, still wondering if Mydeimos was just joking. *Of course* he wanted to go into Mydeimos's room! But, was that weird at all? And, didn't Mydeimos still have to take a bath for the night? They were going at it in the training grounds for almost half the day, after all. Was he just going to watch the King take a bath in his own quarters?

Phainon swore his ears began to burn at the thought. He couldn't help being physically attracted to the King. The King was strong and extremely built, yet his features were so gorgeous and almost ethereal. He objectively had the features of a beautiful man, and added on to a strong body, Phainon couldn't help but always ogle his appearance whenever he got the chance. But, now he was going to see him *naked*?

“How long must I wait for your answer?”

Mydeimos's voice interrupted Phainon's brain that was only now running purely on adrenaline at the thought of entering Mydeimos's room all by himself. Well, it wasn't like anything was going to happen in there, but he still felt the nervousness and jitters rushing through his body at the thought of being with Mydeimos alone in such a confined space.

“I–” Phainon felt like his mouth was flapping like a fish out of water. Barely above a whisper, Phainon finally managed to mumble, “I… would love to, if you would have me.”

With a smirk, Mydeimos turned around to open his door. “Took you long enough.”

Phainon stepped into the room after Mydeimos, and although he already saw the interior of the bedroom yesterday when he was making sure nothing was missing or out of place before the Kremnoans' arrival, it felt different now that Mydeimos was actually standing inside. Scanning the area, the bedroom was in the exact same state Phainon had left it in before their arrival. Though, he tried his hardest not to make eye contact with the steaming bath in the corner that was practically waiting for Mydeimos's unclothed body. He grimaced inwardly, trying to wipe the thought from his mind before he actually pictured such a tempting sight.

That was, until he tried to find Mydeimos and found him *stripping* in the middle of his bedroom.

Phainon jerked back so fast he hit the bedroom door behind him, banging his head against the wooden frame and fumbling for something he could grab onto until he fell under. Grasping at absolutely nothing while massaging his pounding head, Phainon could only kneel on the ground in defeat with the image of Mydeimos's flexing back muscles seared in his brain.

Groaning, Phainon faintly heard Mydeimos calling for him or asking him something, but he hit his head so hard all of his senses were blown out momentarily. The only thing he could focus on was how badly the back of his head ached.

"You're uninjured, at least."

Phainon had barely managed to catch those words, but he sounded way too close than where they were originally standing before Phainon slammed into the door. Glancing upward, grimacing in pain, he found himself face to face with the King, and he jerked back again at their sudden proximity. A hand on the back of his head, however, held him in place. A very big and warm hand. A hand that was basically the size of Phainon's hand.

"M-Mydeimos?" Phainon was trying his absolutely hardest to not lower his gaze towards his chest, where he could see two perky red buds in the corner of his eyes.

“You didn't answer when I called for you.” Mydeimos started running his hand through Phainon's hair, massaging his scalp. Phainon's eyes almost fluttered shut in that moment just to revel in how *good* his hands felt.

“I'm fine, Mydeimos, thank you,” Phainon mumbled and pulled his head away, staring at literally anything in the room but the naked man in front of him. He hoped that the man couldn't see how red he had become, but with how close they were, he knew that was a wish that fell on deaf ears.

Mydeimos was silent for a few moments, his hand still hovering in the air from when he was originally running it through Phainon's hair. Although Phainon wasn't looking at the man, he could still feel his gaze boring straight into him. He wasn't sure whether he should get up now and exit the room before he made any more of a fool of himself, but he also didn't want to give Mydeimos the wrong impression that he was ungrateful for his concern.

After a couple beats of silence that felt like an absolute eternity to Phainon, Mydeimos stood up and proceeded back to his bath. “Please, make yourself comfortable.”

Phainon didn't spare a single glance at Mydeimos, only hearing him lower himself into the wooden tub and disturb the water. He wasn't sure how comfortable he could exactly make himself with the most attractive man in Amphoreus showering in front of him, but maybe he could just keep Mydeimos company with his back turned the entire time. Why had the King even invited him into his private quarters in the first place?

He barely pulled himself up from the ground, his head still dully throbbing, and made his way over to the edge of Mydeimos's bed. He scanned the area in front of him, admiring the lavish decorum in the room while being careful not to stare in a certain corner with a certain man. But every so often, he couldn't help his drifting eyes from sneaking glances at Mydeimos. The way the water droplets dripped down his biceps, the way his back muscles flexed as he cleaned himself of the traces left from their sparring sessions, the way his damp hair clung to his shoulders, and how Phainon so wished that the hand running across his body was his instead. It was a shame he couldn't see anything underneath the water.

He swallowed dryly, immediately whipping his head around and staring holes into the wall opposite of Mydeimos. Okay, maybe he should just leave right now. Yeah, that sounded like a good idea. He couldn't trust his brain anymore if he were in here any longer, and a certain lower area in his body was starting to get excited. How could he have such indecent thoughts about a *king*, no less! There was no way in the entire Nether Realm he would ever have a chance with someone like him.

Phainon cleared his throat, grabbing the attention of the bathing man. He pushed himself off the edge of the bed and glanced briefly at Mydeimos, who was staring at him. “I should… probably get going. I don't want to disturb your bath after all.”

“No.” Phainon heard Mydeimos say before he could even approach the door. “Stay. I am almost done.”

He froze in place and glanced at Mydeimos at those words, but he had already resumed his bath. Phainon inwardly sighed in an attempt to reach inner nirvana and calm the aching that was going on in his pants. If the King said so, then he must. But, why did Mydeimos want him to stick around? And for the entirety of his bath, no less?

While standing in the middle of the bedroom and mentally reciting the Code of Chivalry for knights and soldiers, the sounds of splashing disturbed his mantras. Instinctively glancing up at the sound, he immediately whipped around with burning cheeks at the sight of Mydeimos's bare, wet waist as he was leaving the bath. He had almost forgotten why he was reciting the Code of Chivalry in his mind in the first place and then was just directly reminded all over again.

Were Kremnoans just really comfortable with their naked bodies? Maybe their naked body wasn't something to be shameful about? Phainon could see that after all. Maybe they thought it was prideful to show off their strong build as a way of displaying strength? Yeah, that made sense. He tried to wrack his brain on how to make sense of this situation, but all he could do was make up Kremnoan traditions in his mind that just made sense.

In the middle of making up nonsensical traditions, he hadn't even realized that Mydeimos had already covered his body in a silk, crimson red robe that matched the tattoos crossing all over his body. Mydeimos approached him with narrowed eyes, and Phainon jumped when he realized Mydeimos was already finished with his bath.

“You are quite jumpy today,” Mydeimos remarked. “I told you to make yourself comfortable, yet here you are just standing in the middle of the room.”

How could Phainon *not* be jumpy when the most beautiful person he had ever seen in his life started stripping in front of him, walking around naked, and even bathing in front of him?! And, how could he get comfortable when even his pants were not?

“I…” Phainon's brain worked in complete overdrive mode to come up with an excuse on the fly. “I didn't want to get comfortable before you.” Yeah, that sounded natural, right?

“*Hmph*.” Mydeimos approached the luxe bed centered in the room. It was adorned in crimson silk sheets with golden lining, along with matching pillows that spelled intricate designs on its surface. The bed was perfectly made in its dark mahogany wood frame, courtesy of the maids who frequently came through to tidy up all the rooms while they were away.

Mydeimos slipped under the sheets, and Phainon couldn't help his eyes from wandering toward his bare legs before they were covered. With his eyes still trained on where Mydeimos's naked legs were before, he hadn't even realized that the man was gesturing to him.

“Phainon.” Mydeimos broke Phainon out of his stupor. “Are you joining me?”

Phainon's eyes widened, instinctively stepping backward as he stared at this alluring man, almost tempting him into his bed. “I… I don't want to disturb your sleep, Mydeimos. If you are retiring now, I should be on my way.”

Mydeimos looked downward, and it looked to Phainon as if he were a little sad? With the way his eyes were turned toward his lap, it looked almost as if the man were pouting. But, it was definitely just Phainon's imagination. Definitely just his imagination.

“Back to the formal talk?” Mydeimos raised his gaze back onto Phainon, who was still just standing in the middle of the room.

Phainon hadn't even realized; he was so nervous that he just defaulted back to his formal, polite language. “My apolog–I’m sorry, Mydeimos.”

Mydeimos lightly chuckled at the mistake Phainon had almost made. “If you're truly sorry, then come sit with me.”

Phainon could swear he immediately broke out into a nervous sweat. “In… In the bed? With you?”

Mydeimos narrowed his eyes. “HKS, did you think I wanted you to sit on the floor beside me? Or perhaps, pull up a chair to my bedside as if you were nursing me to health from a sickness?”

“Well… I…” It was time for Phainon's brain to overcome yet another challenge. With his brain in overdrive mode once again, he barely managed to think of an explainable reason. “I haven't had a bath yet.”

“Sit with me, Phainon,” Mydeimos repeated, ignoring Phainon's very sound reasoning.

Aglaea's words began echoing through his mind that he should do his absolute best to fulfill any and all requests of the Kremnoans while he was their guard for the week. Though, he wasn't sure if Aglaea accounted for the Kremnoan king asking his guard to join him in bed. Hesitantly, Phainon stepped forward, his footsteps ringing louder in his ears than usual as he made his way to the other side of the bed. Almost as if he were made of mechanical parts, he rigidly peeled open the covers of the bed before slipping off his boots and sliding into the covers.

“That wasn't so hard, was it?”

Phainon's mouth immediately went dry when he glanced to his side and saw Mydeimos. Mydeimos, with his hair still damp, and the silk robe tied loosely at his waist. It was tied so loosely that it shouldn't have even been worn at all with how little it covered his chest and those tempting, pink buds that Phainon could not stop staring at earlier. Mydeimos, who was sharing a bed with him and was even under the same sheets as him, Phainon could feel the blood rushing to his face and to an even lower part of his body once again.

“I wanted to learn more about you, Phainon.”

Phainon's eyes quickly snapped back to Mydeimos's face; he hadn't even realized how far down his gaze had wandered as they were previously glued to his bare chest. Mydeimos definitely knew that Phainon was staring, right?

“About me?” Phainon had barely caught what the man was saying. He was mentally applauding himself that he had actually caught what he said.

Mydeimos nodded. “I have been mulling over Aglaea's proposal today, but I do not know a thing about Okhema. I thought you could tell me a bit about yourself, as a way for me to learn.”

Phainon's mind began to relax. Okay, that sounded like a very reasonable reason to have Phainon stay with Mydeimos. But, did he really have to wait in here while he was taking his bath? And, did he really have to tell Mydeimos about his life story while sharing the same sheets as him? Were Kremnoans just always this physically vulnerable in showing off their naked bodies and sharing body heat in the same sheets?

Inhaling deeply, Phainon searched through his mind. But, there really wasn't much about him to say. He was just a common soldier and a common boy; there really was not anything special about him. “I don't particularly have a very involved past.”

“Any information will be valuable to me. Speak your mind.”

Phainon shook his head. “Really, there isn't much, Mydeimos. I'm sure your life is much more interesting than mine.”

He softly chuckled in response, and Phainon couldn't help his eyes from staring at his shaking chest as he laughed. “I can tell you all about myself another day. Tell me about you.”

Acquiescing to the golden-haired man, Phainon leaned against the dark mahogany headboard, relaying his humble beginnings with his eyes staring up at the grand, golden chandelier suspended over them in the center of the room. “I was born and raised in the countryside. It is just a small farmer's town, where we mainly grew wheat. We did grow other crops, of course, but our main source of income was our wheat fields. I helped my family out in the fields for some time but, eventually, I moved away and came here to become a soldier and help others.”

Phainon sighed, reminiscing about his days in the golden fields that always seemed to glisten under the warm sunlight. “It was always my dream to save others. That's why I moved away. I am still in contact with my parents, of course. I send them some of my salary and a letter every now and then. But, that’s really all there is to it. Nothing grand in my life.” He laughed softly to himself. “I am just a humble soldier, fighting for this country and its people. Nothing more, and nothing less.”

Mydeimos seemed to fall into silence, listening quietly to his story. “Aedes Elysiae… I am assuming this is where you hailed from.”

Phainon hummed in agreement. “I would tell you to go and visit sometime, as the scenery out there is quite beautiful. But I'm sure there is no need for a king of your caliber to visit such a small town.”

“You should take me,” Mydeimos said. He stared into Phainon's blue eyes which looked quite surprised at the suggestion. “Take me and show me around.”

“I…” Phainon laughed once more at how outrageous the suggestion was. “I'm sure you have better things to be doing. You are quite a busy man, after all, with running an entire kingdom.” He gazed again at the chandelier

above them, emitting that warm, golden glow that was reminding him of the same colors of his hometown. “Although, I haven't gone back to visit in quite a long time. Maybe I should make a trip back.”

“I suggest you take me to your hometown, yet here you are making plans to go without me?” Mydeimos raised an eyebrow at the man next to him. “How audacious.”

Phainon's eyes immediately shot back down to Mydeimos. “No! No, that's not what I meant at all.” Phainon laughed at how anxious he became at the King's words. “If you really would like to join me, you are more than welcome to. But, I really don't anticipate seeing you again after this week.”

“And why is that?”

With how serious Mydeimos’s voice became, Phainon couldn't help glancing over at the man. He had an unreadable expression on his face. Was it wary? Longing? Exasperation? Phainon couldn't tell what he was thinking.

“Well,” Phainon trailed off, unsure how to explain this to the King who seemed to want to join his trip back home for some reason. “I just… There would be no reason for your return, right? You belong to another kingdom, and as their king, no less. I can't imagine it would be easy for you to return so often.”

Mydeimos scoffed and crossed his arms, joining Phainon in leaning against the headboard. “I am the king of my own country. I can do whatever I want.”

“That is true enough. Then, let us make plans to return to my hometown then.” Phainon couldn't help but laugh at Mydeimos's statement. But, he knew Mydeimos was only saying this all in jest. There was no way the King of another kingdom could just come and go to visit an unimportant soldier so often. Phainon wasn't special at all.

“Let us then.” Mydeimos shut his eyes, and they fell into another silence. Phainon continued staring at the man, watching his chest rise and fall with

every soft breath as he slowly fell into a deep slumber. Was the King just really confident or extremely careless for falling asleep in front of a foreign soldier with which their kingdoms shared no alliance?

Chuckling softly to himself, Phainon reached over, pulling Mydeimos down from where he was leaning against the headboard into a more comfortable position in the bed. He tried his best not to focus too much on the feeling of his muscular body under his hands, as the silk fabric of his robe was so thin that it left little to the imagination. With burning ears, he had managed to tuck Mydeimos into the sheets before encompassing the entire room into darkness and returning to the public baths near the soldier's barracks.

It was completely silent with no sounds of movement once he shut Mydeimos’s bedroom door behind him, as it was late into Curtain-Fall Hour now. Everyone had retired to their rooms save for a few guards on night patrol and some of the maids tending to last-minute requests. Phainon quickly surveyed the area in front of him every time he approached a new part of the palace, but there was no one else left around. Though, he didn't exactly fully survey the area because he was in a bit of a rush.

Pushing open the palace doors, he bid a quick good night to the guards at the entrance that were on duty for the night. It was finally time for him to have a bath after such an experience that he endured back in Mydeimos's private quarters. Although his lower half had calmed down after talking about his hometown, it flared up again when he had tucked Mydeimos under the covers, and Phainon was rushing in hopes that no one would catch him in such an indecent state. He was just thankful that there was barely a soul roaming outside, and Phainon could quickly return to the baths which were most likely empty.

After grabbing a change of clothes to sleep in for the night, Phainon approached the public baths, quickly stripping himself of his outerwear and dipping into the water that was still quite warm. Okhema was famously known for their public baths, and many travellers from afar visited Okhema solely to experience these baths. Phainon was just thankful he didn't have to think about freezing cold water for his late night bath, but maybe the freezing cold water would've been helpful at this very moment.

Glancing down at his lap, he heaved a sigh. Throughout the entire rush from his bedroom to the public baths, the blood had never ceased rushing down to his lower half. It didn't help that he kept reminding himself of Mydeimos, and his dick continued to pulse with every thought of him.

He lowered his hand to relieve himself, thankful that no one else was in the baths at this time. Once his hand had grasped his length, he couldn't help the sigh that escaped his throat as he began pumping his needy dick underneath the water. Phainon watched with half-lidded eyes and quivering lips as his fist quickened its pace and the pleasure began shooting through his body all the way down to his toes. He watched as his abdomen flexed with every pump as his breaths started to become ragged.

His breaths became heavier and heavier as he panted among the steam that wafted through the baths. His body grew hotter, and he had no doubt that his face was absolutely flushed. With parted lips, Phainon's eyes fluttered closed, and he couldn't hold in the soft mewls and gasps that erupted from his throat as pleasure continued to build in the pit of his stomach. He threw his head back against the edge of the bath with a loud groan, arching his back and almost banging his head when he had begun to tease the head, swirling the precum that was beginning to leak from his tip.

Phainon's chest was rising heavily now with every gasp for breath, and he didn't bother hiding the moans that resounded through the bath as his legs shook underneath the water. He was approaching his release, and he couldn't stop his trembling legs from spreading wider and hips from thrusting into his hand as the other hand clenched against the edge of the bath to ground himself in some way. His dick twitched wildly underneath his tight grasp the more Phainon roughly swiped a thumb against his tip and rubbed underneath the base of his pulsing, hard shaft that was desperate to cum.

The more he felt that pleasure churning deep in his stomach, the more he felt his abdomen flex from the pleasure, and the more his mind began to crumble. Moan after moan slipped past his parted lips, echoing in his ears and increasing higher in volume with every thrust of his hips and every pump of his hand. His thrusts were becoming erratic, and his crumbling

mind began creating mental images without his permission the closer he approached his release.

Images of bath water running in rivulets down certain biceps; images of certain back muscles flexing with every movement; and even images of certain red tattoos that crossed down to a certain perfectly sculpted rear that he had barely caught before he had averted his gaze. How much Phainon wanted to thrust against that delectable, tempting rear; how much Phainon imagined that the warm hand around his dick was actually something else entirely–or rather, *someone else* entirely.

His hands still clearly remembered how his body had felt underneath him as he tucked him into bed, and they tingled at the thought of those previous sensations. He remembered how desperately he had to hold himself back from running his hands all over his body and the urge he had to stop before he peeled that thin robe off of him and began ravishing his naked body, licking, sucking, and biting wherever he could. His mind still clearly remembered how his hand had felt against the back of his head, running through his silver snow hair, and his body shivered at the memory.

Images of unkempt, damp golden hair clinging to bare shoulders; images of his smooth waist that was just asking for Phainon's hands upon them; images of hard, perky buds atop his sculpted breasts that were peaking through that silk, red robe that left little to the imagination; images of soft, red, shimmering lips. He imagined them quivering, parting in loud moans underneath him, and his glowing golden eyes brimming with tears as Phainon rammed himself deep inside his wet, enticing, and warm–

Phainon yelled aloud, moaning a certain name as his body jerked violently and his head was thrown forward. Cum spewed from his tip in streams as his hand grasped tightly around his length, pumping to finish the rest of his orgasm. His toes clenched around nothing under the water as jolts of electricity ran through every limb in his body, and his vision was replaced with white. His body didn't stop twitching, his shoulders didn't stop tensing, and the moans and gasps didn't cease, until his hand under the water finally stilled.

He was panting heavily for breath as if he had just finished running laps around the entire palace. Slowly opening his eyes, he was met again with the warm bath water encompassing his body and the empty public baths of the night. Suddenly, it was almost too quiet in the baths now that Phainon had ceased his activities, and Phainon had quickly finished up the rest of his bath before returning to his bed for the night.

Laying in his bed that was among the many other beds in the barracks, Phainon shut his eyes with flushed cheeks at the outrageous thought that he had ended up masturbating to the Kremnoan king–the same king that he had to continue accompanying for another five days.

Itinerary Day 3: Preparing for the Ball

“Good morning, Your Majesty.”

“Why did we go backwards this time?”

Phainon flinched at the question. He couldn't say his name without having flashbacks of the night before when he was in the public bath by himself, especially since he had specifically called his name too. Everytime Phainon echoed his name in his mind, all he could think of were the accompanying pants and moans from when he was alone, and he couldn't help his ears from burning from the memories.

He flashed a wry smile in response. He had previously prepared an answer on the way here, as he knew the King was going to question him about it. “We are going to the downtown market today. I just thought it would be appropriate to display proper manners in front of others.”

Mydeimos eyed him suspiciously, but he did not comment any further as he shut his bedroom door behind him. Phainon noticed that he was sporting new outerwear today–most likely lighter clothes that prioritized mobility and breathability. As they were spending most of the day in Marmoreal Market, the market in the downtown city, where crowds often gathered, Mydeimos most likely opted to wear clothes that weren't so focused on the golden armor that he had previously sported before.

Although he still wore those golden gauntlets, he no longer wore the golden greaves that he had arrived in. Instead, he was wearing umber leather boots with a small heel that reached to his thighs, with leather gaiters dyed in maroon that were locked in place by golden buckles. His dark trousers were tucked into the boots, clinging tightly to the shape of his legs due to the maroon garters encircling each of his upper thighs, and the golden belt he originally wore around his waist was now gone as only the same sash across his torso could be found. The most intriguing part of all was that half of Mydeimos’s hair was gathered in a loose bun at the back of his hair, and by all the Titans did Mydeimos need to continue wearing his hair like that.

However, a part of his hair was separated to form his signature braid that could always be found on the left side of his face.

The same crimson velvet cloak was still hanging off one shoulder along with his gold pauldron, but the thing that drew in Phainon the most was that he was actually wearing a shirt this time. Even though the shirt was open halfway down his torso, it was a collared maroon button-up that was tucked into his gauntlets while the end of his shirt was tucked loosely into the waist of his pants. His clothes were so tight against his frame that it truly almost looked like the button-up would burst at the seams even though it wasn't even closed all the way, and Phainon couldn't help his gaze from being glued to his bare chest. Somehow, it tempted him even more from when he didn't wear a shirt at all.

“HKS.”

Phainon's eyes immediately shot up at his voice. At this point, Phainon was no longer being discreet at how he basically ogled Mydeimos's body, and he was sure Mydeimos knew it too.

“I… I apologize. That was improper of me.” Phainon sheepishly scratched the back of his head. He was too ashamed to even gaze at the man before him, instead gluing his eyes on the man's leather boots and the maroon gaiters that wrapped across the tops of his feet. Embarrassment washed over him in waves as he thought about how Mydeimos was aware of how often Phainon had just been staring at him. He probably thought Phainon was crazy.

“Stop apologizing.” Mydeimos clicked his tongue in annoyance. “I truly thought we were making progress the previous day. What changed with you?”

The fact that I touched myself with thoughts of your naked body, but Phainon just kept his mouth shut and his eyes glued to the floor. He still couldn't believe what indecent thoughts he held for someone of such noble status; if Mydeimos even so much as found out, he would probably be beheaded. He was sure even Mydeimos, who had been emphasizing to treat

him as an equal this entire trip, would be disgusted at the thought of a mere soldier thinking of him in such ways.

Mydeimos sighed heavily at Phainon's silence. “Speak to me as you spoke with me yesterday.”

“I will do my best.” Phainon offered the King a small smile, turning his head upwards. But, he still could not reach his eyes.

“HKS,” Mydeimos repeated that Kremnoan word with a firm tone. “Look at me.”

Although Phainon did manage to meet his unyielding golden gaze, he still couldn't help the unbelievable amount of shame that washed over his entire being at meeting his eyes. He wasn't sure what kind of pitiful expression he held, but he saw Mydeimos sigh once more when they made eye contact.

“Did something happen after departing my room?” Mydeimos narrowed his eyes, searching on Phainon's face as if his expression would give away any answers.

Flashes of last night and the public bath vividly flew through Phainon’s mind, and his eyes widened as he quickly exclaimed, “No! Nothing… Nothing happened, Your… Mydeimos.”

Clearly, something obviously happened. Phainon wasn't exactly the best liar, after all, and he knew Mydeimos did not believe a single word that came out of his mouth. But, before Mydeimos could confront him any further, the rest of the Kremnoan attendants filed out of their rooms, cutting their conversation to a close. As Marmoreal Market was often bustling with activity, only a few of the attendants were accompanying Mydeimos while the rest stayed in the palace.

Phainon led them down to the dining area as usual, where they ate a quick breakfast consisting of salted golden egg rolls topped with herbs and the same concoction of pomegranate juice mixed with goat's milk. The plan for today was to spend the majority of their time in Marmoreal Market in preparation for the ball that was to take place tomorrow, and Mydeimos was

getting the last preparations to his attire completed in time for the occasion. As such, they only indulged in a small morning meal to get themselves ready for the remainder of the day.

With the palace entrance opened and sunlight flooding his vision, he led the party toward Marmoreal Market. Action Hour was beginning, and the sun was approaching high into the sky as he directed them to the market's entrance and introduced them to any sights that they passed on the way. It was a clear day, and most of the Okheman citizens were out in the city, soaking in the warm sunlight as they wandered about. The Kremnoan attendants chatted amongst themselves as they admired all the sights to behold, and Phainon was amused with each one of their amazed reactions. However, Phainon never turned in the King's direction.

When they finally reached the entrance to the downtown market, it was already a bustling sight as vendors were flooded with customers, and Okhemans citizens lined every corner of the streets. The chatter of the crowds filled his ears as he faced the attendants with a polite smile.

"So, to where do we need to go?" Phainon glanced at the closest attendant.

It happened to be Empousa again, who he had previously conversed with earlier. "We need fabrics to finalize the King's attire. If you know the best place for fabrics or clothing, that would be great."

Phainon nodded with a hum, running the different stores in his mind as he glanced to the side. "That should be no problem. Follow me." He whirled around on his feet, directing the Kremnoans to the tailor shop that dealt with most of the clothing items for high nobility. He frequented this vendor fairly occasionally with Aglaea, and this was the tailor shop where Aglaea had gifted him his own outfit that he saved just for special occasions. Although Aglaea was a tailor of her own, she shopped many of her own pieces from this owner as well.

Passing through the bustling streets, they eventually arrived at the tailor shop. Owned by Aphrea, it was famously known by the upper class, and Phainon was extremely grateful he actually owned a piece tailored by Aphrea's hands, courtesy of Aglaea, as he would never be able to afford

such attire on his own soldier salary. Since the outfit was for the King of Kremnos, Phainon thought there was no other suitable place to bring them to other than this shop.

He opened the glass doors of the shop, and the Kremnoans passed through into the cool air that was circulating inside. Aphrea was currently in the main area of the store, sorting and organizing fabrics to be stored away in their respective spots.

“Phainon!” Aphrea beamed when she spotted the man. He was surprised she remembered him so well, as he never really had a reason to visit this store other than if he was accompanying Aglaea.

“Hey, Aphrea.” Phainon nodded in her direction. “I am sure you are busy during these times of the festivities, but do you perhaps have time for the King of Kremnos today?”

Her eyes widened like saucers at his request. The fabric that was in her hands dropped to the floor as she was shocked into a stupor, but she quickly scrambled for the fabric again, smoothing it out in her hands. She glanced between the Kremnoans and Phainon as if she couldn’t believe what he had said. “Of course I do!”

She quickly ushered the Kremnoans to approach deeper into the store, and Phainon nodded at them as they passed. He was sure a client such as a king would be a high-priority customer for Aphrea.

“I’ll be waiting near the entrance.” Phainon informed to the last attendant to pass by him, which was Empousa. “If you need me, just beckon me over.”

Empousa nodded in acknowledgement as Phainon departed to wait near the entrance of the store. There was no need for Phainon to be with them as they were preparing the King’s attire, after all.

With the silver-haired man out of earshot, Empousa immediately took the opportunity and whipped her head to Herklas, the other Kremnoan vanguard in attendance. “Did something happen between the King and the guard?”

“I was thinking the same.” Herklas stared in Phainon’s direction, who they could barely see now from where they were standing. “Did it seem like the guard wouldn’t even glance at the King?”

“That’s what I was thinking!” Empousa hissed. “Actually, I’m surprised you even noticed such a thing.”

Herklas gawked at her, but he couldn’t retort because a voice interrupted them.

“Done with your rambling?”

The two attendants immediately straightened their back, standing to attention at their king who was currently getting his measurements taken by Aphrea. His cloak and pauldron were currently set aside on a nearby wooden table as the measuring tape in Aphrea’s hands ran across his body. He was narrowing his eyes in their direction, clearly unamused at the conversation that directly centered around him.

“We were just worried about you, King Mydeimos.” Empousa anxiously laughed. “Is it our imagination?”

Herklas gawked at her again, not believing that she even had the audacity to ask him so bluntly to his face.

But, even more unbelievable to Herklas, the King ended up sighing in response. “I am not sure what happened either.”

It was almost as if Empousa was jumping in place at the thought of engaging in this sort of conversation with the King. Although King Mydeimos was always very benevolent with his subjects and happily conversed with them, because he was often busy as their king, that chance almost never occurred. Thus, Empousa was not going to let this opportunity slip away.

“What happened last night?! Wait, wait wait, just to make sure, you *are* interested in that Okheman guard, correct?!” Empousa slammed her hands down on the table in anticipation for the story, and she almost knocked the

King’s golden pauldron onto the floor. The other attendant with them, Georgious, had barely caught it before it hit the floor. Because the attendants parted from the King halfway through the day, they didn’t know what had occurred between the two of them while they were alone. Empousa muttered a rushed apology to Georgious before turning back to the King, eager to not miss a single detail.

The King furrowed his eyebrows, raising his arms so Aphrea could measure them. “I invited him yesterday. To my private quarters.”

Empousa almost fainted, and Herklas had never gawked so much in a span of a single quint. Georgious almost dropped the golden pauldron that he was trying to place back onto the wooden table.

Empousa was trying very, *very* hard not to scream. Who knew their king was so forward! Though, she should have expected it–it was the Kremnoan’s way of always making the first move, after all; it was the best way to ensure true victory. Of course their king would embody that value. “So, what happened?”

Their king seemed to be recalling last night’s events as he gazed downward, deep in thought. “Nothing happened.”

“Did you want something to happen?” Georgious hesitantly asked. It seemed that everyone was now interested in their king’s love life.

King Mydeimos gazed in Georgious’s direction silently, seeming to mull over his words. He seemed to be entertaining the thought of what if something had actually happened and if he would have permissed it. “I took a bath.”

The three attendants were slightly puzzled on how their king indulging in a bath had to do with Georgious’s question, but it seemed that the answer hit all of them at the exact same time as they recalled his previous answers: *He indulged in a bath while the Okheman guard was inside his private quarters?!*

“And…” Empousa’s eyes were wildly searching the King’s face. “And nothing happened?”

A deep breath seemed to escape from the King’s lungs. “No.”

Empousa almost marched over to the Okheman guard still waiting by the entrance to slap the man across the face. Clearly, the Okheman guard was interested in the King as well; it was written all over his face since their initial meeting. How could he have the audacity to stand inside the private quarters of the King and do nothing?!

“Wow.” Herklas was breathless at this turn of events. He stared into the air, playing an imaginary replay of the events in his mind.

“Did…Did anything else happen?” Empousa stared intently at the King, who was now finished with his measurements. Georgious was now turning to Aphrea to discuss the types of fabrics that they were looking for.

“I invited him to bed.”

It seemed that all three of the attendants’ minds immediately turned blank. It wasn’t until a couple of beats later that Empousa could force her mind to work again, wracking her brain at the King’s statement that insinuated so many things. She was trying extremely hard to recall if she had heard any suspicious noises or activity from the previous night, as her room was directly adjacent to the King’s. But, she really did hear absolutely nothing. Truly, the King was right; nothing happened.

“Did he join you in bed?”

Empousa glanced at Herklas who had uttered the question, who he was leaning forward against the wooden table, clearly deeply involved in this conversation.

“He did.” the King’s gaze seemed to wander, staring at nothing in particular. Empousa was gauging each one of his expressions, ensuring she really did not miss anything that came from their king, and as she was about to ask whether anything had transpired once the guard had joined the King in his

bed, he mumbled a question to his attendants with furrowed eyebrows. “Am I… not attractive?”

The three attendants’ minds went blank once more, both in shock that he had even asked such a question, and also for the fact that the answer was so obvious. Had he not seen a mirror recently? King Mydeimos was worldly famous for inheriting his beautiful looks from his mother, the late queen, Queen Gorgo. Empousa could still clearly recall Queen Gorgo from when she had first joined the Kremnoan vanguard, and she was absolutely awestruck at her radiance. The previous queen was a ferocious and formidable warrior, but she possessed one of the kindest souls that Empousa had ever witnessed, treating even the children of Kremnos as her own. When she had become acquainted with the then prince, she was shocked at how many similarities they shared, both physically and personality-wise. It still held true even now with King Mydeimos as their ruler.

“King Mydeimos,” Empousa could barely breathe those words from her chest, “I do not mean to make this sound offensive by any means, but it is quite obvious that you are the beauty of Kremnos.”

The other two attendants stayed silent in agreement, and they stared at their king as he seemed to take those words to heart. He nodded at her words with a serious gaze as Aphrea emerged from the back of the store with a handful of fabrics in tow. Empousa hadn’t even realized when the tailor shop owner had disappeared. Clearly, she was getting too invested in the King’s words.

“He really did nothing?” Herklas stole a glance at the Okheman guard who was still, thankfully, out of earshot. “Even after joining you in bed?”

The King glanced up at Herklas. “I had closed my eyes during our conversation, and it seemed that he thought I had fallen asleep.”

While Georgious was busy picking the right fabrics with Aphrea, Empousa and Herklas leaned even more forward against the table, waiting in great anticipation for what their king had to say next.

“He covered me with the sheets and departed from my room, turning out all the lights.”

Empousa almost dropped her head against the table, and she heard a slapping noise to her right from Herklas, who had a palm against his burning forehead. Was there something wrong with this Okheman guard? Or perhaps, was it just Okhema entirely? Were their cultures really so different that this Okheman guard could not understand a single clue that their king was practically throwing in his direction like a bone to a dog?

She almost cried aloud, *“He just left?!”* but she had to hold in her voice, else the Okheman guard actually picked up her voice from the entrance from where he currently awaited. Truly, Okhema was another beast entirely, and it was one even their unbeatable king was having difficulty facing. Though, she could at least applaud the Okheman for not jumping a sleeping man–well, the guard had *thought* the King was sleeping.

“There must be something wrong with that man.” Empousa had barely heard Herklas mutter these words under his breath, and she agreed wholeheartedly. If there was ever a chance she had time alone with that guard, she had to beat some sense into him. Or maybe, she had to sit the guard down and explain Kremnoan’s culture of courting from the very beginning so that he could understand what he had done wrong.

Contrary to the Okheman guard’s words, the noble status meant very little to the Kremnoans. Although it did matter somewhat, what mattered more was their display of strength, valiance, and honor. Rank and status were granted based on accomplishments, exploits, and victories achieved in battle. The late Queen Gorgo also was not of noble status, yet she was invited to be queen by the late King Eurypon after they had tied in a duel for the throne.

It was interesting that Okhema valued so much of what ran through a person’s blood rather than their achievements and valor throughout their lifetime. Why would a culture center around a part of an individual’s life that was uncontrollable rather than what that individual has achieved? Empousa couldn’t possibly wrap her head around such a culture, but it seemed this was the line that the Okheman guard refused to cross.

However, it was clear to all the Kremnoans in attendance in Okhema that this silver-haired guard was strong–so strong that he even rivaled their own king, similar to the late king and queen. There was no better match for their king than someone who rivaled him in strength. And, from what Empousa has seen and experienced so far, he genuinely seemed like a caring man as well–it was quite the plus that the Okheman guard was also quite handsome to boot. It seemed their king was set on this guard when they had drawn to a tie after multiple rounds of sparring during their initial day in Okhema.

“I have an idea,” Empousa announced to the party. If that Okheman guard wasn’t ever going to make a move due to their extreme differences in culture, then they would have to hit that man so hard that he would have no choice but to. She glanced at Georgious with a fiery determination burning in her eyes, and he looked surprised at how intense she was. “Georgious, we are changing the King’s attire for the ball.”

“*Pardon?!*” Georgious looked almost ready to fight her in the middle of the tailor shop. “Empousa, we are just now finalizing the fabrics–”

“Then tell the tailor shop owner that we require something else,” Empousa impatiently huffed. She glanced at the King to gauge his reaction to her abominable request, but he only narrowed her eyes at her. If he wasn’t saying anything to stop her, then he was going to allow it to happen.

“And? What fabrics should I ask for?” Georgious was running out of patience with this woman.

She smiled deviously at the Kremnoan soldier, resisting the urge to rub her hands together at the thought of her own little scheme. “If that Okheman guard refuses to approach the King, we will make it–no, *make sure of it*–that he absolutely cannot resist.”

“That didn't answer my question.”

In Kremnoan culture, one's body equaled one's strength. A person could gauge an individual's physical strength merely by the appearance of their body. Kremnoans valued this strength, and in turn, they valued the build that an individual could have. Displaying that body was almost as if they

were displaying their own strength. It meant power to the Kremnoans, and it explained why their king was always showing off his body–because obviously, he was the strongest being in all of their kingdom. Naturally, there was a royal garb that displayed even more of his body than his normal attire. Although they hadn't brought it with them when they traveled to Okhema, it would be a simple task for this tailor to craft it for them, right?

She explained her idea to the party in attendance, and the King's attendants all muttered in agreement, completely immersed in this new plan and not even bothering to consult with the King in question who was actually going to be sporting the attire. Georgious was running the calculations in his head for exactly everything that they needed, and they needed a lot of gold to adorn their king in. *A lot* of gold.

“It is certainly doable.” Georgious nodded. “Let us prepare both outfits.” He quickly beckoned for Aphrea, who was in the back gathering the fabrics for the original outfit. As they discussed quietly about Empousa's new plan, she turned to the King, who continued to stand there with narrowed eyes.

She shot him a smile. “What do you think, my King?”

King Mydeimos only shut his eyes for a brief moment before slowly reopening them to stare at her with a plain gaze. “Do what you wish.”

Empousa almost cheered in the middle of the tailor shop. She was shaking with so much anticipation and excitement that she almost sprinted over to that oblivious Okheman guard standing at the entrance of the shop to tell him to prepare himself. She still couldn't believe that the King had invited the guard into his private quarters, took an entire bath with the guard in tow, and even invited him to his bed, yet nothing had occurred between the two. There *must* be something wrong with the Okhemans, right?

After a few quints spent in the tailor shop, they began finalizing the payments for all the materials and outfits for King Mydeimos that Aphrea had finished, and they were soon on their way from the shop. Their next stop to finish the King's outfit would ideally be a jeweler, so they could purchase the amount of gold jewelry that they would need to complete his attire.

Phainon saw from the entrance that the Kremnoans began to approach him with fabrics in their hands. They had spent quite a few quints in the tailor shop getting his outfit prepared, and he could only see from a distance that they were excitedly chatting about something. Perhaps, they were buzzing with excitement for the ball that was to occur tomorrow.

The female attendant, Empousa, stared at him with an almost too-pleasant smile; they must have really been excited for the ball. “Do you perhaps know of a jeweler we could visit?”

Phainon raised an eyebrow, running through the list of vendors available in Marmoreal Market in his mind. “Of course I do. Let me show you the way. But, I must ask, would you all like to eat a meal first?”

They had spent so much time in the tailor shop that they had completely skipped their midday meal. Although Phainon was quite used to going many days without eating, he wasn't sure about the noble class in Kremnos.

Empousa waved his question away, eager to complete their shopping trip. “No need. Let us go to the jeweler now.”

Phainon glanced at Mydeimos who nodded in confirmation at his attendant's words, and he thanked Aphrea before leading them out of the tailor shop and back to the blazing sun that beat down on the downtown market outside. The crowd was still bustling as ever as they navigated through the busy streets, visiting numerous caravans selling the goods that they needed. Dromas caravans, pulled by dromas that were great, strong, yet gentle beasts, often sauntered throughout the markets selling foreign or specialty wares that could not usually be found in Okhema. Especially during these times of festivities, the number of dromas caravans were much more generous than normal. Phainon didn't know much about jewelry, as he could never afford such a thing, but from the amount of gold and gemstones that they bought from each caravan, he could tell that the Kremnoans were at least satisfied with the places that he had taken them to.

As they were on their way to visit another dromas caravan to see what goods they sold, he ran into another individual that Phainon would say he was closer to than the average soldier.

“Castorice!” Phainon couldn't help exclaiming in delight when his eyes fell upon her usual purple and white ensemble.

Even though Castorice was of noble blood as well, they were actually quite close. Although she was not of royal blood in Okhema, she was actually related to the ruler of Styxia; in fact, the ruler of Styxia was her twin sister. But, Castorice came to Okhema very early in her age to learn more about the different kingdoms and to hone her magical power, and it was because of how long she had stayed in Okhema and how many years they have worked together under Aglaea that Phainon and Castorice grew close together despite Phainon usually keeping a respectable distance away from the upper class.

Castorice was a mage; to be specific, she was a necromancer. In Amphoreus, almost all members of the upper class possessed some form of magical affinity; for example, Aglaea was a weaver, and she could create objects out of thin air. Castorice was a necromancer and could summon death itself to fight for her. She had come to Okhema to hone that magical energy inside of her; she had previously explained to Phainon that she had a peculiar institution when she was born where she could not control her magical energy, and she would bring to death anything and anyone that physically came into contact with her. Although it proved just how strong the magical energy inside of her was, she came to Okhema to learn how to control her powers so she wouldn't have to dodge and avoid anyone anymore.

She and Phainon were classmates at the Grove of Epiphany where Castorice had also further honed her power–another reason lending to why Phainon and Castorice had grown so close. Phainon was only sent to the Grove because of Aglaea's orders; otherwise, he would have never been able to afford the steep tuition. The Grove of Epiphany and Okhema had quite a close alliance together, as many scholars visited Okhema, setting up lectures and schools around the kingdom, and many of the nobility class that could afford the travel and stay would go to the Grove of Epiphany for even more specialized teachings.

Phainon hadn't had the time to see Castorice due to the hustle and bustle of the festivities, but it seemed she was also a guard for the envoys of Styxia

that came to visit for the ball. Styxia was a kingdom located near the ocean, and they believed that the departed would drift among the River of Souls on their way to the afterlife. It was why the kingdom centered heavily around water to ensure peaceful passage of their citizens. They were quite a tranquil kingdom that mostly kept to themselves. She was currently wheeling her sister, Queen Polyxia, who was seated in her usual wheelchair.

“Phainon.” Castorice cast a soft smile in his direction, and Phainon greeted both Castorice and Polyxia with a polite nod. “It has been a while. How are you doing?”

Phainon beamed at her. It truly felt like he hadn't seen her in quite a long time. “I’m doing great, Castorice. I see you are accompanying Styxia during their time here in Okhema, as usual.” Phainon directed his smile towards her twin sister. They truly shared quite the resemblance. “I hope you enjoy your time here in Okhema, Queen Polyxia.”

The queen smiled at Phainon. They had already been briefly acquainted before during previous balls due to Phainon's acquaintance with Castorice. “I always enjoy my time here in Okhema, and it is always even lovelier to spend time with my sister again.”

“I see Aglaea has tasked you with accompanying Kremnos.” Castorice nodded in their way. “I had wondered who she would choose to accompany them when I heard of their arrival.”

The Kremnoans attendants extended polite greetings to the Styxia attendants once they were brought up in the conversation, and Mydeimos stepped forward to give his greetings to Castorice and the queen, introducing himself as the King of Kremnos.

The three chatted away, most likely consisting of more pleasantries and discussions of their own kingdoms. Phainon had already stepped off to the side to give them some space, and he decided to use this spare time to run through the rest of their day. Action Hour was approaching its end with the beginning of Parting Hour, so most of the shops in Marmoreal Market were going to close soon. He hoped that the Kremnoan attendants were able to purchase all of the materials that they needed to finish Mydeimos's attire.

He turned to the King’s attendants, grabbing their attention. “Do you require anything else from the market? I think the shops are about to close up very soon for the day. I could point out any other caravans nearby while Mydeimos is here in case you need anything else.”

Empousa shook her head. She seemed quite satisfied with the haul that she and the other two attendants were carrying on their persons. “I think we have quite enough! In fact, I think we have just enough.” She glanced at both attendants next to her who nodded in confirmation.

“I see,” Phainon said. “Then, we should return to the palace once Mydeimos is ready before the sun begins to set.”

The attendants hummed in agreement, watching their king from a distance converse with the envoys from Styxia. Phainon was sure Mydeimos had a lot of work cut out for him at the ball tomorrow, as this was Kremnos's first public appearance in another kingdom in years. Especially as Kremnos's new king, he was sure Mydeimos had a lot of people that he would need to speak to from the other kingdoms. Phainon inwardly sighed at the thought. That meant he had to escort Mydeimos to every single kingdom's envoy in attendance at the ball tomorrow as his personal guard in Okhema. Although Mydeimos had a lot of work to complete tomorrow, as his Okheman guard, that meant Phainon also had a lot to do tomorrow.

“You should prepare yourself tomorrow.”

A voice cut his thoughts short as he turned around with furrowed eyebrows towards the origin of the voice. “What are you talking about, Empousa?”

Empousa smirked in Phainon's direction, shaking the bags of jewelry she held in her hands. “Prepare yourself tomorrow. You will soon behold a sight that will absolutely blow you away.”

Phainon smiled sheepishly, tilting his head to the side. “Do you mean Mydeimos’s attire for the ball tomorrow? Is it some sort of special Kremnoan attire?”

The female attendant nodded quite proudly. “Even *you* wouldn't be able to resist.”

“I'm sorry, *resist?”* Phainon was getting more lost by the second. What was she referring to? What was he resisting? Was there a foreign enemy that Empousa knew the arrival of?

“That's what I said.” She continued beaming with pride, but Phainon couldn't question her any further as Mydeimos had finished his conversation and rejoined their group.

Phainon cast one last smile to Castorice who was a few paces away as a way of bidding his farewells, and she returned quite the timid smile. She kept glancing between Phainon and something else with flushed cheeks– what was she looking at? He tried to scan in that direction she kept glancing toward, but only Mydeimos, who was standing right beside him, was in that direction. Did Mydeimos mention something to her during their conversation? But, what could they possibly speak amongst each other that would make her face redden like so?

Pushing his confusion away, he quickly explained to Mydeimos that the sun was about to set and the vendors were going to close shop, so they were going to return back to Marmoreal Palace before the sun disappeared under the horizon. With Empousa confirming that they had enough materials for his attire, they soon strolled down the streets of Marmoreal Market once again. They no longer had to navigate through bustling crowds as the people perusing the market dwindled in number with the setting sun.

With the sun no longer beating down on them, and the cool air of the night began to settle around them, it was quite a relaxing stroll back to the palace. Since the streets were no longer as packed, Phainon was able to point out more Okheman sights for the Kremnoans to admire and learn about as they made their way back from where they came. It was a beautiful sight to behold, with a burst of colors flying through the air above them as the sun dipped low beneath the horizon, casting its orange, glowing light upon them. Phainon couldn't help but steal glances at the King who walked beside him, who paid him no mind, because his glowing golden hair and red attire looked breathtaking under the sunset.

Arriving back at Marmoreal Palace, they decided to wash up and drop off the hefty amount of purchases to the bedrooms before indulging in supper, so Phainon bid them a quick goodbye after walking them back to their bedrooms.

He entertained the idea of just not showing up to dinner and picking them up afterwards, but he wasn't sure if Mydeimos would chastise him again for not eating dinner with them. But, it was hard; Phainon was still having trouble making eye contact with the man even after the entire day of leading him around the market. Although Phainon was able to avoid almost all conversation with the King due to how busy they were in the market, he knew he wouldn't be able to avoid the man during supper, especially if he was going to be sitting directly across from him at the table.

Tossing the idea in his mind, he made his way over to the palace training grounds, hoping to get a few good swings in before taking a bath. He also debated the idea of inviting Mydeimos to the training grounds with him, but he wasn't sure if it was too forward of him to ask a king to spar with him. In their past two sparring sessions, the King had initiated it. Phainon didn't want to overstep by any means if the King happened to be too exhausted after the market, after all. Though, it would be nice to have a partner to spar with, and maybe he would be able to forget about last night's solo activities if he were engaged in an intense battle with the man who was at the forefront of his mind all day.

He hummed, still debating the idea with himself as he stared at the wooden swords in front of him. He had already reached the training grounds, and he was sure Mydeimos was already washing himself off of all the sweat and grime from perusing the outdoor market all day. He was sure the King would refuse his request for a spar if he asked now, anyway. Maybe he will just ask Mydeimos next time, if there even was a next time.

After all, what was left of the agenda for the week was to attend the ball tomorrow, a rest day for everyone following the ball, and then only one more full day before the Kremnoans returned home on their last day. Phainon was sure Mydeimos wouldn't want to spar with him tomorrow, during his rest day, or during his last full day in Okhema as the King had to speak with Aglaea again on that day.

Sighing after running through the rest of the week's schedule in his mind, he plucked one of the wooden swords and headed over to the main area of the training grounds. He hadn't realized that the previous day would be the last time he would get to spar with the King, and the thought echoed in his mind as he swung his sword against the training dummy in front of him. Aiming for the dummy's shoulder, neck, and abdomen, the thought continued repeating over and over again in his mind, and no matter how many swings he struck upon the dummy, the more he could not ignore his aching heart.

Was he really that attached to Mydeimos? After only *three* days? Was it just because he had never spent so much time with another individual in a single day? No, that wasn't true at all; Phainon had guarded many other guests for the majority of the day, and it wasn't as if he got attached to them like he was now. So, what was so different with Mydeimos? Was it the fact that he was handsome, strong, valiant, skilled, supportive, kind, fair, intelligent, well-spoken, well-mannered…

Okay, clearly Phainon was heavily attracted to the man; his previous night's activities were also evidence of that. But, did that explain why he was so attached to the King? Because he liked him?

His mind cut short as he immediately stopped in his tracks at his own thoughts. Wait, Phainon *liked* him? The King*?* As in, he held *feelings* for the King*?*

He struck his sword against the crook of the dummy's neck, and his weapon flew out of his grasp before he could react. His brain felt static, and only that previous thought whirled around in his head as he faintly caught the sound of his wooden sword tumbling into the dirt.

With widened eyes, Phainon began mumbling incessantly to himself like a madman, glancing all around the training grounds with a dry throat and a pounding heart. Being attracted to someone was completely different from having feelings for someone, and the more the thought resounded through his mind, the more he could not deny the notion. It explained why he was so attached to the King, why he was always looking at the King, and why he was always thinking about the King.

No, not the King. Well, he was attracted to the King of Kremnos for sure; he was overwhelmed with how beautiful he was when they had first met, after all. But, Phainon held feelings specifically for *Mydeimos*: the man who had said Phainon was worth so much more, the man who had treated him as an equal, the man who tied with him multiple times in battle, and the man who asked to visit his hometown with him. He had feelings for the man who loved the color pink, who wasn't afraid of showing his body, and who wasn't afraid of mingling with anyone regardless of birth or blood. He was honest, forward, confident, and strong; the complete opposite of Phainon. He wasn't afraid of speaking anything that came to his mind, and Phainon *yearned* to have those qualities to himself, of having *Mydeimos* to himself.

His heart was pounding so loudly in his chest that it reverberated through his head, and he couldn't hear a single other sound other than his own heart. Phainon cursed himself for realizing his feelings so early when he *still* had to accompany the King for another three days in Okhema. Another four days, and then he would be gone. Gone forever from Phainon's life just as quickly as he had come in.

He warily turned himself around to pick up his sword, dusting it off and placing it back on the rack. He wouldn't be able to fit in any more swings in this unstable state he was in, as his heart continued twisting in his chest along with the feeling of his stomach dropping. He had to endure another three days with a man Phainon realized he had feelings for, and a man that Phainon knew he would never have a chance with. Mydeimos was a *king*, after all. He may have realized that he had feelings for a man, which didn't bother him at all, but that man just happened to rule a kingdom. If he was a normal man, maybe he would have had at least a slight chance, but definitely not with a king.

Phainon had never held such strong feelings for someone else before, so he hadn't actually known what it felt like to truly like someone in such a romantic manner. The soldiers in the barracks often discussed feelings of love, and they often conversed about the maids in the palace that they were attracted to. But, Phainon never really understood all those discussions. Sure, he would entertain the other soldiers, join in on the conversation, and even tease those blushing soldiers that described the ones that they loved,

but he had never felt that same way before until now. Now, he could understand how those soldiers could drone on and on about one person and how their faces could become so red just *thinking* about that person. Because, now that was Phainon's reality.

The doors to the training grounds shut behind him with a loud *bang*, but before he could proceed any further, he was met with an exhausted maid who was practically running toward him with her skirt bunched up in her hands so she wouldn't trip.

“Phainon!” She stopped in front of him, bending over and gasping for breath, and Phainon knelt down to get a good look at the maid to ensure she was okay.

“Is everything okay?” His eyes wandered her face, gauging her reactions. But, other than being out of breath and her face flushed from running around, she was okay.

“Yes, I… I'm so sorry.” Bringing a hand to her chest, she shut her eyes and took deep breaths as Phainon raised himself from the floor.

“Take your time.” He smiled, but it seemed like the maid was in a bit of a rush.

The maid opened her eyes once more, staring up at Phainon. “I was looking for you everywhere. I went to the barracks and to the soldier's bath because that's where they all said you went.”

“*They?”* Phainon raised an eyebrow.

Clearing her throat, the maid straightened her back, finally regaining her composure. “The Kremnoan attendants and their king all came down for supper. But, halfway through supper, it seemed that their king was in a foul mood, and his attendants ordered me to find you.”

Phainon's eyes widened at her explanation. *Oh shit.*

His shoulders dropped. “What time is it?”

Phainon truly did not want to know what time it was, but the maid hummed in thought. “I would say it is five quints into the Parting Hour. The Kremnoans came down to eat four quints into the Parting Hour. ”

Oh shit.

Phainon rushed past the maid, thanking her quickly before darting down the corridor in the direction of the dining hall. It was basically almost Curtain-Fall Hour, and he had completely missed the time to eat dinner with the Kremnoans. Sure, he did debate on the idea of skipping out of it so he didn't have to face the King, but he didn't mean to *actually* skip out. He had meant to get a quick workout in before heading to the baths and then meeting them at the dining hall for supper. But, how long did he spend in the training grounds that the time had completely escaped him? How long was he just thinking of Mydeimos after they parted? He was never this disorganized and unattentive, and he had no one to blame except for himself and these new feelings that he kept experiencing. These feelings just kept disorienting and confusing him, and they were about to cost even his life depending on how furious the King was.

It was now Phainon's turn to gasp for breath as he turned the corner and abruptly halted in his steps, coming face to face with the door that led to the dining hall. Mydeimos was definitely still waiting in there, right? They pretty much waited for him to arrive for an entire quint, and Phainon never so much as made an entrance even after Mydeimos had explicitly expressed wanting to eat with him. He couldn't even begin to imagine Mydeimos’s fiery gaze, and he certainly did not want to have to face it when he opened this door.

Phainon really fucked up this time. If Kremnos decided not to engage in an alliance with Okhema by the end of this week, he might as well kiss his life goodbye. Or, maybe he could just drop to his knees in Aglaea's office and plead for her mercy. Maybe he should just turn around from the dining hall door, avoid Mydeimos’s wrath, and cling onto Aglaea's knees right at this moment.

He tried his absolute best to tidy his appearance after the training session he just had and after practically sprinting over to the dining hall. Running a

hand through his unkempt hair, he realized just how much he was sweating, but he didn't have enough time to wash himself off from the day's activities. He couldn't possibly keep the King of Kremnos waiting any longer.

Inhaling a deep breath, he firmly grasped the handle to the door and pushed them open. Acting as normal as possible, he was met with the attention of all the Kremnoan attendants and their king at the table.

Doing his utmost to appear as mannered and polite as possible, Phainon tried to mask how truly anxious he actually felt. “I truly apologize for my rudeness today. The time seemed to have escaped me, but I know that is no excuse for my behavior. I would accept any and all punishment you would have for me.”

He was too frightened to even look at the King, but he knew that he would have to if he wanted his apology to be perfect for the King. Locking eyes with golden ones, he expected irritation, anger, and exasperation. Phainon was expecting to have a plate thrown at him or a fist to knock the breath out of his chest. He was also assuming he would have to get on his knees and bow to the King before him.

But, his heart shattered when all he saw in Mydeimos's golden eyes was complete and absolute betrayal.

It was hard to keep his mask from dropping when he saw how deflated he looked, and it was even harder to stop himself from rushing over to comfort the man. He wasn't expecting such a headstrong and confident man such as Mydeimos to even know what “sadness” felt like, yet here he was, locking eyes with his heartbroken ones.

He waited a few beats for anyone to say *anything* at all, but they all continued to wordlessly stare at Phainon. He couldn't even begin to imagine what this dinner was like with him absent the entire time.

“I…” Was it appropriate to call him “Mydeimos” right now? Phainon wanted to call out to him, ask him to yell at him, ask him to make him kneel to the floor and apologize, but all of those words died in his throat as he didn't know how he should refer to him. Should he say “Mydeimos”?

Should he continue his formal apology and say “Your Majesty”? What if he said the wrong one and further disappointed him? If it was any other noble figure, this formal apology would be easy to recite, but because it was Mydeimos, Phainon hadn't a clue what to do. He had never met a nobleman such as Mydeimos before, and it was making his brain and his heart spiral.

“My king.” The attendant next to Mydeimos, Empousa, gently nudged him. “Would you prefer some time alone?”

Phainon almost blurted out, *Please don't leave us alone*, but he did his best to hold his tongue as he watched the King's gaze drop to the table with a silent nod at her words. The attendants all stood up at once, sparing a glance at Phainon before retreating from the room. Empousa's eyes seemed to linger on Phainon's, but he couldn't decipher what she was trying to soundlessly communicate to him before she passed him by.

The door shut behind him, and the sound was so much louder than what Phainon was used to. Besides the Okheman servants cowering in the corner, only Phainon and the King were left in the room.

“I truly, deeply apologize for what I have–”

“*Drop it*.”

Phainon inwardly flinched at the sharp, seething tone, but he did his best not to waver under the King’s stern gaze. There it was–the King's fury was now starting to come to the surface. The betrayal Phainon had seen in his eyes before was now gone, replaced with that fiery glare that Phainon was first expecting when he had stepped into the room. Most likely, he was holding it in front of his attendants until they had a moment to themselves.

Phainon fell silent at the King's orders, bringing his hands together in a tight grasp in front of him as he awaited his fate from the King. He was taking deep breaths to calm himself, but his anxious and pounding heartbeat was drowning out the rest of his senses. He could have his eyes picked from their sockets if the King ordered him to do so right at this moment, and Phainon could do nothing about it as he had so blatantly disobeyed the King's orders. Because Phainon was not a person of status in Okhema, it

really did not matter what happened to him even if someone from a foreign kingdom harmed him. At least the last person Phainon would ever be able to lay his eyes upon was the King, so he guessed it wasn't that bad.

He kept waiting and waiting, standing upon his own two feet in front of the King's glare, but the King didn't say anything to him at all as he continued to bore his eyes straight through Phainon's soul. The only sound reasoning Phainon could think of for his prolonged silence was that the King was mulling over which body part of Phainon's he wanted to sever first.

“First, I tell you to drop the formalities. Then, I ask you to indulge in meals with me. But, it seems like you can do neither.”

Phainon grimaced at his harsh tone, gritting his teeth together at the pain he was expecting to feel after some body part of his was separated from his body. He was anticipating it now with the way the King continued to glare in his direction.

“I truly am–”

“I said to *drop it*.”

Phainon quickly shut his mouth, gritting his teeth once more to prepare himself for the pain and the blood. Maybe he shouldn't speak unless he was told to.

He heard an exasperated sigh come from the King's direction–when had Phainon's gaze dropped to the floor? Slowly raising his eyes, Phainon watched as the King rose from his seat and pushed the chair back into the table. His footsteps echoed in his brain as the King approached him, and Phainon could do nothing but tighten the grasp he held against his own hand.

The King cocked his head to the side, continuing to bore his eyes into Phainon's, and he felt as if he were trembling under his firm gaze no matter how much he tried to appear composed. He couldn't help the feeling of his heart continuing to drop into his stomach the longer the King glared at him.

“I…” Phainon hesitantly started, waiting to see if the King would permit him to speak. Because he didn't interrupt him, Phainon continued. “If you would like to arrange a new guard for the remainder of your stay, I could certainly have that arranged for you.” Phainon's heart was breaking with each word he spoke, but he thought it was for the best if it was so difficult for Phainon to follow the King's orders. Would that mean this would be the last conversation he would ever have with Mydeimos? He hated that thought. “If you would like me to, I can speak with Aglaea who could–”

“*Drop it*.”

The rest of Phainon's sentence died in his throat as he shut his mouth once more.

The King sighed once again, and the glare dissipated from his eyes as he glanced off to the side. “How could I continue my anger when you look like a kicked puppy?”

“I… I apologi–”

“*Drop it*.”

Phainon shut his mouth once more.

Another deep sigh escaped the King. “Did you not hear a single word I said?”

Phainon's eyes slightly widened in confusion as he replayed the entire conversation in his head. What was he referring to? Which part was he talking about? All he basically told Phainon to do was shut up, so what was he missing?

“It seems like you didn't.”

This was it–this was where Phainon would lose his arm. Or his leg, or his eyes. Saying a quick, silent goodbye to his body and thanking them for all that they have done for him, he also quickly bid his career a goodbye, as he wouldn't be able to serve the kingdom if he were handicapped. Now,

Phainon would be known all across Okhema as the man who blatantly disobeyed the King of Kremnos and had to retire from being a soldier. But, Phainon was more disappointed in himself for letting Aglaea down like so; she had such grand expectations for him, and he had severely let her down in just a matter of a few days. And, thinking about it even further, if he retired and returned to his hometown, how would he possibly be of help in the fields if he was handicapped? Not only could he not help Aglaea, but he could no longer help even his own family.

A fourth sigh from the King could be heard. “Did I not tell you to drop the formalities? Then, why are you still speaking to me in that way?”

Phainon's body grew rigid. When the King said to *drop it*, he was referring instead to Phainon's *manner of speech* rather than Phainon merely speaking?

Chancing a glance at the king–when had his sight dropped to the floor *again?*–the glare was no longer evident on the man's face. He only plainly stared at Phainon as he awaited his answer.

“I… I'm really sorry, Mydeimos, for missing dinner.”

With a scoff, Mydeimos crossed his arms across his chest, and Phainon was shocked when a soft smile graced his lips. “That's a good boy.”

Phainon's eyes widened in response. It was as if, at those words, Phainon was never frightened or afraid for his life. It was as if all the tension immediately disappeared from his body, and the blood that was pounding in his heart in nervousness and apprehension immediately rushed to his dick. Phainon could not even believe how quickly his body had gone from fight-or-flight to turned on in a matter of two beats of his heart.

“Truly, how could you even insinuate such a thing?” Mydeimos was muttering under his breath, and Phainon tried to ignore the strain in his pants to listen to his words.

“Sorry?”

Mydeimos glared sharply at Phainon, and his erection immediately died. “Do not ever suggest replacing my guard again, do you hear me?”

To be honest, the only thing Phainon really heard was Mydeimos referring to him as “my guard.” It really was like music to his ears, and Phainon just really wanted to hear him say that again. Instead, Phainon nodded his head once his brain had finally processed the rest of his sentence.

“I won't.” He smiled at Mydeimos, thankful that he was so merciful with him. Truly, how did Phainon get so fortunate? If he had disobeyed any other noble in Okhema, he would have lost a limb by now.

“Then,” Mydeimos began, approaching the entrance to the dining hall, “if you are so sorry, then accompany me to my quarters.”

Phainon couldn't help the grin that spread across his face as he eagerly bounded to the door, opening it for Mydeimos to walk through. He waved a quick farewell to the servants who were still in the dining hall, and they all shared an expression of relief between each other that they did not have to clean up any blood that night.

They reached the door to Mydeimos's private quarters, and they both stepped inside to the room that Phainon was now so familiar with. It was in the exact same state that Phainon had seen before he departed the previous night, but Phainon was mostly thankful that he did not have to endure the hardship of watching such a beautiful man bathe again. He wasn't sure if he could handle another erection today.

“So, what made you so late to dinner?”

If it wasn't for Mydeimos's casual tone, he would have assumed he was being brought here in the privacy of his quarters to be interrogated.

“I was training in the training grounds, and time seemed to have passed me by.”

Mydeimos hummed, beginning to shed his velvet cloak and pauldron as he readied himself for the night. “And you didn't bother to invite me?”

Phainon laughed softly at the irony of his question. Really, why did he question himself so much over extending the invite to him? “I thought you would be too tired from shopping all day in the market, so I just planned on getting a quick workout in before taking a bath and joining you all for dinner. It really was not my intention to miss it.” Phainon purposefully left out the part where he had actually debated on skipping out.

Shedding the royal sash across his body and unbuttoning the rest of his shirt, Mydeimos scoffed. “If you are not tired, then neither am I. Do you really underestimate me so?”

He couldn't help the laugh that escaped him. “You’re right. I should've thought about that, Mydeimos.”

Mydeimos stripped the rest of his clothes, and Phainon averted his gaze to give him that bit of privacy as he slipped into more comfortable clothes to retire for the night. Somehow, Phainon was getting more used to being in the King’s naked presence which was quite an odd thing to get used to. Maybe after the nervousness he had felt earlier in the dining hall, nothing else would be able to scare him for the remainder of the day.

When he heard Mydeimos approach his bed, Phainon brought his gaze back to the man, who was adorned again in that all-too-tempting silk robe. “If you are retiring for the night, I should go now. Good night, Mydeimos.”

There was something with this man always preventing him from leaving, because before Phainon could take a step toward the exit, Mydeimos's voice interrupted him. “Stay. Join me in bed tonight.”

Phainon's eyes couldn't help but fall into the ample, empty space next to Mydeimos before returning to the man who was now covering his lap with the sheets. “Would you like me to accompany you until you fall asleep again?”

With his back leaning against the headboard, Mydeimos raised an eyebrow. “I meant for you to stay for the night.”

Phainon had meant to be teasing the King with his question, but with the way Mydeimos had so plainly asked him to sleep in the same bed as him for the entirety of the night, Phainon's heart began beating wildly in his chest.

“To stay?” Those were the only words that Phainon could manage. His brain was too busy processing the idea of falling asleep under the same covers and in the same bed as Mydeimos.

Mydeimos furrowed his eyebrows with a frown as if he couldn't believe he had to repeat himself. “Yes. Stay. And sleep. In this bed with me, HKS. What more do you need me to say to get it through your head?”

Attempting to suppress the blush that crept over his cheeks, which did not succeed, Phainon rigidly willed his legs to carry him over to the other side of the bed. Standing there, staring down at the clean, silk sheets that the maids had so meticulously spread across the bed, he felt sorry that he was about to sully them.

“Could I… take a bath first before climbing into your bed?” Phainon sheepishly smiled as he ran a hand through his hair, feeling the day's weight through his fingertips.

Mydeimos seemed to eye him carefully, gauging whether this was another tactic for Phainon to escape or not. But, with a sigh, Mydeimos agreed, and Phainon had never rushed out of the room to take a bath so quickly in his entire life. He felt as if he practically flew out of the palace as he headed to his belongings in the barracks before rushing once more to strip himself and step into the baths.

Again, as it was so late into Curtain-Fall Hour now, no one else could be found in the baths at this time. He felt as if this would be a repeating pattern for the remainder of the week. Phainon felt he had been so busy and caught up in so many things while escorting the Kremnoan envoys that he felt he could not return until it was late into the night. And, although being alone in the baths did remind him once again of his solo activities from the previous night, he had no time to dwell on those embarrassing memories as he quickly dressed himself and hurried back to Mydeimos's quarters. After

being on the receiving end of his wrath and almost losing a limb today, he didn't want to keep the King waiting anymore than he needed to.

He brought a hand up to knock on the ornate door that led to Mydeimos's temporary bedroom, and he faintly heard his voice beckon him inside. Softly shutting the door behind him, he made his way back to the edge of the bed, propping his beloved Dawnmaker near his bedside, and climbed under the covers in one swift movement before he could overthink and hesitate again.

Mydeimos was still in the same place on the bed; he had been reviewing scrolls and documents with a keen gaze before Phainon had returned. However, once Phainon had made his reappearance, he had set the documents aside on the matching mahogany bedside table.

“Don't let me disturb you.” Phainon eyed the documents that were stacked away. “I'm sure you have a lot of work that needs to be done.”

Mydeimos, who had his back against the headboard, shuffled in bed until he had joined Phainon in laying down under the sheets. “No need. It doesn't need to be done today.”

Phainon softly laughed, heart pounding when he saw how close they were laying side by side in the same bed and even under the same sheets. He could only hope that Mydeimos could not hear his racing heart. “How much work are you behind on now that you have come to Okhema? I'm sure there is a lot of work waiting for you when you return.”

“I have my teacher watching things over for me while I am here. He should be doing more than fine in my absence.”

“Right, his name was Krateros?”

“Did my attendants speak of him?”

Phainon recalled the first conversation he ever had with his attendants. “Yes they did. They–” He immediately shut his mouth when he remembered exactly why they brought up Krateros in the first place. It was because they

were gossiping about how Mydeimos didn't have a lover, and his teacher was trying to arrange matches for him.

“They?”

“Nothing. It was just meaningless chatter.” Phainon, the worst liar in all of Amphoreus, could only avert his gaze from scrutinizing golden eyes.

Mydeimos hummed, clearly not convinced, but he let it slide. “Yes, my teacher is named Krateros. He was made a close confidante and general after proving his strength in front of my parents, and he has been serving the royal family ever since.”

“You must really rely on him then,” Phainon remarked, eager to continue the conversation and learn more about Mydeimos's story.

“Yes, he is quite reliable and strong.” Mydeimos nodded. “He… scolds me quite often. We argue about how to run the kingdom, but I know he has good intentions.”

“It's nice to have someone next to you that you could trust to hear their thoughts.”

“I agree. Krateros is exactly that. He raised me, after all.”

“*Raised* you? Did your parents not raise you?” Phainon recalled that the news spread of Mydei ascending to the throne after his parents’ death was only a few years ago. But, Mydeimos made it sound like Krateros had been watching over him for a long time.

Mydeimos raised an eyebrow at his question. “I'm sure the passing of my parents is no secret to you.”

“I… don't mean to be so forward, but didn't that happen only a few years ago?”

Mydeimos fell silent, and Phainon wasn't sure if he was incorrect. But, did Kremnos really go on for more than those years without a king? He truly

believed the news of Mydeimos ascending the throne was only a few years ago, but did his parents pass many years before that?

“You don't have to tell me.” Phainon softly chuckled, offering the man a small, reassuring smile. He could see how seriously Mydeimos was thinking to himself. “I know, as king, there are probably many things that you cannot tell me. I won't question it any further. We can talk about something else. Say–”

“No.” Mydeimos stared firmly back into Phainon's eyes. “I was just recalling everything. It seems the death of my parents truly did not reach your ears, or the outside world, I am assuming.”

“Sorry?” Phainon blankly blinked at him.

“My parents passed when I was quite young. My mother passed away when I was a child, and I killed my father with my own hands a few years later.”

“Wait, a *few years later?* Not just a few years ago?”

Mydeimos shook his head. “Once my father killed my mother, I–”

“Your own father killed your mother?!” Phainon was sitting up in bed now, clearly invested in the drama unfolding in Mydeimos's family.

The man still lying in bed chuckled at Phainon's dramatic reaction. “A prophecy was foretold when I was a child that I would soon ascend the throne. As a new ruler of Kremnos would only ascend to the throne only after killing the current ruler, the prophecy meant that my father was going to be killed by my hands sooner than everyone originally expected. After all, I was only a child. How could that prophecy foretell that a child would ascend to the Kremnoan throne so soon?”

“So he… wanted to kill you for that?” Phainon could only guess where this story was going.

“Yes, and my mother was against it.” Mydeimos closed his eyes as if reliving those memories. “I don't really remember my mother as I was quite

young; I can only hear of her valor from Krateros and the other vanguards. But, she had challenged my father to a duel and lost her life. Subsequently, my father banished me from Kremnos and left me to die.”

“He just banished a *child?!”*

“Lower your voice; you are too loud.

“But that's–”

“I am alive and well now, am I not?”

Phainon couldn't argue with that logic and fell silent at his words.

“A group of Kremnoans followed me during my banishment, including Krateros, and it was outside Kremnos's borders that we staged a rebellion against the King. Many years later, I killed my father with a blade, and it was the last time I ever wielded one.” Mydeimos's eyes were open now, but they were downcast at recalling all his dark memories. “Many lives were lost; I lost all of my trusted confidantes in that detachment of ours, but we came out victorious. I didn't take the throne until I was of age a few years later.”

Phainon laid back down in bed, thoughts swirling in his brain as he digested this information. That explained why he couldn't find a weapon on Mydeimos when they had first met, and it also explained why he did not wield a weapon when they were sparring. “That's… Are you… okay?”

He stared at Mydeimos who looked quite shocked that he was being asked that question. But with a small smile, Mydeimos answered, “It was a long time ago. I am content with my place as King of Kremnos now.”

“The attendants all love you.” Phainon returned the smile. “They all seem to get along quite well with their king.”

“You seem to get along quite well with my attendants too.”

Chuckling, Phainon agreed, “Yes, they are easy to get along with, and they seem like enjoyable company.”

The man beside him nodded. “They are very reliable, quick-witted, and strong in battle. It was why I asked them to join me here in Okhema.”

“I'd love to see them in battle.”

“As confident as I am in my people, none of them would be able to best you if you are equally matched with me.”

“That is of no matter!” Phainon exclaimed with a grin. “It would be fun to spar with other Kremnoans. I'm sure I would have a lot to learn from you all.”

Mydeimos chuckled. “They would be eager to spar with you. We should, one of these days.”

One of these days? Was Mydeimos planning on trying to fit in sparring sessions during his last four days in Okhema? It was technically only just three days left, as they were leaving early on their last day here.

Admiring the glittering, golden chandelier above them and reviewing the schedule in his head, Phainon didn't think there would be any time suitable to visit the training grounds with the Kremnoans envoys again, but he didn't say anything, choosing to lament their short time left together in silence.

“Mydeimos?”

“What do you want now?”

He glanced over at the man beside him, and the sight never failed to take his breath away. The way his silk robe covered absolutely nothing, the way his golden hair draped along the pillows and sheets, the way his golden eyes stared right into Phainon. If Phainon outstretched his arm, he would be able to caress his cheek, brush his soft lips, and maybe even run his fingertips through his hair…

He heard a scoff, and Phainon's inappropriate thoughts were immediately cut short.

“You are staring, HKS.”

With burning cheeks, Phainon buried himself in the blanket, mumbling an apology. “Sorry. You are just… very eye-catching, Mydeimos.”

He couldn't see anything with his face buried away, but he heard an amused hum above him. “So, you do find me handsome.”

“Of course I do!” Phainon shot up from the blanket but quickly reeled back at how close Mydeimos was to him. When was the man practically above him? His golden hair was almost brushing Phainon's face.

“If that were the case, why did you avoid me all day today?”

Phainon's body froze up. So, he really did notice that Phainon was trying to avoid him the entire day? He thought maybe, or at least hoped, with all the hustle and bustle in Marmoreal Market, that Mydeimos would be too preoccupied to notice.

“I…” Phainon averted his gaze once more as his body burned at his memories from the previous night in the bath. With the silence from Mydeimos, he knew he wasn't going to back down from an answer, but he couldn't just plainly tell the man he had masturbated to him last night.

With wandering eyes, Phainon couldn't think of a single excuse to explain his actions. “I'm sorry. I really don't think it is appropriate for me to explain. But–” Phainon whipped his eyes back onto Mydeimos’s. “–it is not of your concern, nor is it your fault. That, I can promise you. “

“So, the fault lies with you?”

“Yes.” Phainon frowned when his face began to redden once more. “Please, don't ask any more questions.”

With a sigh from Mydeimos, at least Phainon was being let off the hook. “Fine. Then, at least stay the entire night this time.”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. This time? Wasn't this the only time Mydeimos had ever invited him to stay the night? But, Phainon couldn't dwell on it any longer, as Mydeimos shrouded the room into darkness as he

retired for the night. And Phainon, who was still left with his pounding heart, had to fall asleep to the dark silhouette of Mydeimos falling asleep right beside him, who was so close he could practically feel his body heat upon his own person.

“I had never seen the King look like he did today.”

Empousa was wringing her fingers together in anxiousness as she sat at the edge of her bed. They had just departed from the dining hall, leaving that Okheman guard alone with the King. She tried to reassure the guard that he wouldn't be harmed–their King was never the type of ruler who harmed his own subjects–but the man was so frightened out of his wits that she was sure he did not understand what she was trying to convey. She felt bad with how the man had practically shook under the intense gaze of their King–a stark contrast to the man she saw spar against their King in the training grounds.

“He looked almost abandoned.” Herklas was removing his armor for the night, setting it at his bedside for easy access.

Empousa nodded with a saddened gaze. “He looked so lost. So betrayed, even. He didn't even look like that when his own mother passed. When his mother passed, he was with an air of vengeance and resolution. But here, I have never seen the King look so defeated in all my life.”

Herklas stayed silent at her words, and Empousa's eyes wandered the room, soon finding the haul that they had purchased thrown together in a corner of their room as she continued to fill the silence. “I'm sure, with the Okheman guard avoiding him the entire day, that him skipping out of supper as well didn't bode very well with King Mydeimos either.”

She suddenly slapped her hands against her thighs, jumping to her feet and making Herklas jump at the sudden noise. “It’s time! We are going to make the most stunning outfit for the King tomorrow. Come, help me put the jewelry together for his attire.”

Empousa rushed out of their shared bedroom before dragging Georgious from his room into theirs, and the three of them spent the remainder of the night preparing the King's new ball attire, determined to send the Okheman guard into cardiac arrest at the sight of their King.

“But–” Empousa whirled her attention over to Georgious. “–why did you suggest getting his original ball attire made still? If we're changing what he's wearing, we might as well not get the original outfit arranged.”

Georgious huffed, never breaking attention from the chains he was connecting together. “In case that guard ruins it.”

“Huh? Ruins?” Empousa furrowed her eyebrows. “What do you mean by ‘ruins’?”

Georgious did not comment any more on the subject, and Empousa was left wondering why the Okheman guard would ruin such an expensive outfit.

Itinerary Day 4: The Royal Ball

Phainon was surprised he even managed to sleep that night with how loudly his heart was racing at watching Mydeimos sleep next to him. Upon opening his eyes in the morning, he was momentarily shocked to be met with such an elaborate ceiling and the grand chandelier that hung in the middle of the room, as he had completely forgotten he actually went to sleep in the King of Kremnos's room.

He turned to the side and found himself face-to-face with the king in question. The robe was falling off his shoulders and being covered instead with Mydeimos’s golden hair as he slept with lips slightly parted and long eyelashes brushing against his cheeks. Phainon watched, mesmerized, as his shoulders rose and fell with each breath, and he had to resist with all his might not to wrap his arms around his waist, pull the man close to him, and breathe in his scent.

With the morning sunlight streaming through the closed curtains, dimly lighting the room, Mydeimos looked absolutely breathtaking. His hands were curled loosely near his face, and it was probably the first time Phainon had ever seen his bare hands as the King usually wore gold gauntlets. His hands were big, yet his fingers were lithe, and Phainon just wanted to interlock their fingers together and feel his skin against him. He could see calluses on his hands from all his efforts in training, yet his hands still looked so alluring, graceful, and elegant. He wanted to rub little circles in his hand, trace his calluses, and plant little pecks and kisses all along the tops of his hands.

Phainon inwardly sighed. Why did he have to realize his feelings so soon? He wished he could have stayed ignorant, then maybe he could have treated Mydeimos as close to a friend as possible before they parted ways by the end of the week. He would have had fond memories to look back upon as he thought about the one week he got to spend time with a king that treated him so generously. Now, Phainon will feel nothing but regret the moment the King of Kremnos disappeared from Okhema, never to return again for the next couple of years. Would Mydeimos even remember their time

together? Or would he just be the one of many people that a king would meet in his life, never to be thought of again.

Pushing those negative thoughts away and pulling himself from the bed, Phainon decided to start his day and distract himself with something else. Today was the day of the royal ball, and most of the royal guests spent the majority of the day preparing their appearance for the ball that started in the evening during Parting Hour. That most likely meant that Mydeimos would spend the majority of his time in his room, preparing his attire and hairdress for the ball tonight.

That also meant that Phainon would not be needed until it was time to attend the royal ball as Mydeimos's personal guard. There was no need for Phainon to prepare himself in the same way the other guests did; after all, he was only there to guard a high-profile guest. He was not actually an invited guest. Although it was more proper to wear a uniform that matched the occasion, he didn't have to worry about other things such as styling his hair, for instance, or decorative armor and jewelry. As such, while Mydeimos was spending the day getting ready, Phainon had a lot more free time today until the ball started.

He swung his legs off the edge of the bed to stand up, strapping Dawnmaker back to his hip where his greatsword often sat on his person. It was when he was fiddling with the straps around his waist to secure the greatsword in place when he heard a soft groan coming from the bed.

Phainon glanced up with a small smile, admiring how Mydeimos was adorably blinking the sleep out of his eyes and pushing his tangled bangs from his face with his bare hand. Truly, the individual that would lay their eyes upon this sight in the future every single morning would have to be the luckiest person to ever live.

"Leaving?" Mydeimos grumbled, eyes wandering to the sword now strapped against Phainon's person.

Phainon tried hard not to admire how beautiful his soft but husky voice in the morning sounded. "Good morning, Mydeimos. I was just on my way out. Did I wake you?"

“You were going to leave without telling me?”

Titans, was this man sprawled out in the bed in front of him *pouting* up at him? Mydeimos was stretching in the middle of the bed, hands balled into fists as he arched his back, his stomach pressed against the bed as he pouted up at Phainon with a sleepy, half-lidded gaze. Holy Titans, Phainon had to get out of here before he exploded–before his lower half exploded, to be exact. Was this what drowsy Mydeimos was like every morning? Phainon burned in envy again thinking of his future partner who would be able to witness him like this every day.

“I didn't want to disturb your sleep,” Phainon muttered, bending down toward him with a smile. “I'll be picking you up for the ball later today. The chefs are still serving morning meals today, so you may go to the dining hall to enjoy before getting ready. Just know that the chefs are preparing food for the ball, so the morning meal may not be as exquisite as previous days.”

Mydeimos nodded languidly, and Phainon couldn't help his smile from growing as he cherished the soft view before him. In a gentle tone, Phainon continued, “Then, Mydeimos, I will see you tonight.”

Phainon had only briefly turned around and taken a few steps toward the exit when he heard Mydeimos's voice faintly call from the bed.

“Stay.”

Raising an eyebrow, Phainon faltered in his steps and turned around. “Stay?”

Mydeimos nodded with another languid nod. “Come back.”

Phainon was unsure if Mydeimos still needed something from him, so he approached his bedside and knelt down until they were nearly eye level.

“Did you need something from me before I go?”

“You.”

“Sorry?”

“I need you.”

His eyes slightly widened. Smiling, Phainon teased, “Me? You need me?”

Another nod of golden hair.

Phainon lightly laughed. Kneeling on the floor, he propped his forearm upon the edge of the bed, leaning his chin on his wrist until he was now face to face with Mydeimos. “What did you need of me?”

“I need you.”

“I'm here, Mydeimos, what do you need?”

The man pouted at him again, and Phainon couldn't help the laugh that escaped him at how cute Mydeimos was. Really, he was going to miss every single moment from this week. He truly felt like he was in heaven right now.

“I keep saying ‘you,’ so why do you keep questioning what I need?”

“Well, I'm not sure what else you need from me.” Phainon chuckled. “I'm here, awaiting your orders, Mydeimos. Was there something you wanted me to get you? Perhaps, you want me to bring you breakfast in bed?”

Mydeimos hummed, tempted by this new idea he hadn't thought of before. After entertaining the idea for a few moments, he ended up shaking his head. “Take off your sword.”

“My sword?” Phainon slightly raised his eyebrows at the unusual request, but he did as he was told, standing up on his feet to undue the straps that he was just fumbling with earlier. Maybe Mydeimos just really wanted to look at his sword?

With Dawnmaker now removed from Phainon's hip, he held it up for Mydeimos to see. But the man nodded without taking the greatsword from his grasp. “Put it back down.”

“Back down… here?” Phainon hesitantly placed it back against the bedside table where he had previously stored Dawnmaker while he was asleep in his bed.

Mydeimos hummed in approval. “Come back here.”

Phainon was still unsure what Mydeimos needed from him, but leaving Dawnmaker back against the bedside table, he approached the edge of his bed once again. “I'm here, Mydeimos.”

“*Mmm*, closer.”

Smiling, Phainon sat himself down on the edge of the bed. “Here?”

“Closer.”

He shifted his weight until only his feet were hanging off the bed. “Here?”

“Closer.”

Phainon softly laughed. “Mydeimos, if I go any closer, I'm going to join you back in the bed.”

“That's the point, HKS.”

In one swift motion, a hand upon his tunic pulled him down to the bed. Disoriented, Phainon couldn't even fight back as he floundered about in the bed until he landed with his back against the sheets and the breath knocked out of his lungs. He was still trying to understand how he had possibly gotten back into the bed when all thoughts flew out the window once he felt Mydeimos slotting himself right into his lap.

“My–Mydeimos?!”

Anything else that Phainon had planned to say all died in his throat when Mydeimos leaned forward, brushing the very tips of their noses against each other. Phainon couldn't help his eyes from flickering between the golden, half-lidded eyes and his plump, parted lips.

“Mydeimos, are you… are you half-awake?” Phainon's hands just hovered in the air because he wasn't exactly sure where he could put them. Should he just put them down on the bed and lay like a dead body? But the blood pumping down to his lower half where Mydeimos was currently seated upon was proof that he was definitely still alive. He couldn't exactly just push off a king, but he also wasn't sure if Mydeimos knew what he was doing in the first place.

With hands grasping on Phainon's shoulders, Mydeimos leaned forward, and Phainon did his very best to lean his head back as far into the bed as he could.

“My–Mydeimos, wait–”

"You shared a bed with me all night, yet you still call me ‘Mydeimos’?”

“I–”

“We slept with each other all night, yet you refer to me so coldly.”

“That's–I–Don't say things like that!”

Phainon gulped loudly, his face and neck burning red the more Mydeimos's mumbles brushed his lips against his. And yes, his lips were just as soft as he had imagined them to be, but having the real thing with his warm breath tickling his lips was sending Phainon into overdrive. His heart was pounding wildly in his chest, and his heels were dug hard into the sheets as Phainon tried with all his might not to make his erection noticeable underneath Mydeimos's rear. Any slight shift of his hips, and any slight touch against him would probably make Phainon explode in his uniform.

“Mydei.” Mydeimos's voice interrupted his thoughts, and Phainon ripped his gaze that was glued to his lips back to his eyes. “Call me ‘Mydei’.”

“Mydei?” Phainon barely managed to breathe back.

Mydeimos hummed lowly, his eyes fluttering toward something much lower than Phainon's eyes. “Again.”

“Mydei–*mmph!*”

Soft lips pushed against his as the grasp against Phainon's shoulders tightened. With widened eyes, the hands that were warily hovering in the air at his side flew to the nearest thing he could possibly fist at, but he felt the smoothness of the silk robe underneath his fingertips as he grasped at the curve of Mydei's waist.

With Phainon's fingers digging into his waist, Mydei pushed himself deeper, hands crawling against Phainon's neck and up his jawline as he tilted his head back against the bed to deepen the kiss. Phainon's eyes shut tightly as his head was pushed back, and with Mydeimos pushing himself forward, they were engaged in a passionate, deep kiss that Phainon was trying his utmost to return properly. However, electricity tingled down his body when he felt a swipe of Mydei’s wet tongue against his lips.

The sounds of their activities echoed in that morning room, followed by the noises of soft pants and moans, with Mydei snaking his way inside Phainon's mouth and sliding his warm tongue against his. Phainon couldn't help the groan that escaped him at these new sensations that felt so good to him both above and below, and his face burned at the strange noises that continually came from his lips.

His grip tightened on Mydei's waist when he began dragging his hips along Phainon's erection, and Phainon's hips buckled instinctively, thrusting against Mydei in chase of that sweet friction he had barely gotten a taste of. Mydei moaned wantonly at the action, and the two men began grinding their hips desperately against each other, causing the bed to creak underneath them as they continued sucking in each other's tongues. Mydei's big hands that Phainon had been admiring just a few moments ago were now caressing his cheeks, holding him in place as Mydei continued his assault inside his mouth.

His heels were still planted into the sheets underneath him as his legs trembled wildly the more Mydei thrust against his body, and he didn't have time to even think about what they were doing as all his mind could focus on was the feeling of Mydei's own hard erection grounding against his. His tip was peaking out of his robe the more it became tangled and pulled in

different directions from their rough movements and leaking precum from that delicious slit. Soon, the hands that were tightened around his waist began to maneuver Mydei's hips up and down to grind against his own as the familiar pool of pleasure began burning in his lower body.

Phainon thrust wildly against Mydei, and their kiss soon became desperate pants for breath as they both approached their orgasm, their thrusts and grinds become erratic as the precum stained the fronts of their clothes. Mydei's now naked dick was trembling against Phainon's clothed one, precum running down his length and dripping onto where Phainon had already stained his own clothes. The creaking of the bed became faster, in tandem with the moans and whines that were coming from both Phainon's and Mydei's throats. Hands dug into Phainon's silver hair and he groaned deeply, driving himself forward and shoving Mydei roughly down against him. He hadn't realized when his hands had crawled onto Mydei's behind, but he took advantage of that momentum to shove Mydei down deeper and deeper against his dick, desperate to reach his sweet release. He couldn't stop his hips even if he wanted to; he had never realized how much better he could feel with Mydei sliding his body against his compared to doing it by himself.

Close, close, he was so close. Goosebumps erupted on his skin as he could no longer feel anything else except for pleasure sparking from his lower half. The pit of his stomach was swirling, and another wanton moan escaped Phainon as his abdomen flexed in search of his orgasm. Phainon and Mydei had been alternating between messy kisses, tangling their tongues together, and loud pants for breath as their hips moved nonstop against each other. Phainon had barely felt the brush of Mydei's dribbling dick against his abdomen, and he almost came at the slick sensation.

“M–Mydei!” Phainon whimpered, feeling his legs shaking against the bed against his own will as his dick pulsed wildly in his stained clothes.

“*Mmm*, cum for me, Phainon.” Mydei dragged his tongue across Phainon's lips, and Phainon's eyes rolled back into his head as his back arched off the bed at his words.

“Mydei, Mydei, I'm–!”

Three loud knocks came from the door, and their bodies immediately stilled. Phainon's eyes shot wide open as if he had just awoken in a cold sweat from a dream, but instead, all he came to was the image of Mydei's flushed cheeks, bruised red lips panting for breath, messy golden hair sticking to his sweaty skin, and a gorgeous dick dripping precum onto his clothes.

They both stared at each other, gasping for breath, but Phainon couldn't ignore how erratically his dick twitched in his pants against Mydei's own pulsing dick as he was quite literally about to reach orgasm. He was still coming to, still trying to figure out what in the world just happened, when three loud knocks came from the door again.

“My king?” They faintly heard a voice through the door, but Phainon's heart was ringing so loudly in his ears he couldn't tell who it was.

“You should–” Wow, Phainon's voice was absolutely wrecked. “–get that.”

Mydei stared down at Phainon, clearly unconvinced. “And show the other person behind that door what you look like? Not a chance.”

Mydei's voice was also wrecked too; it was much huskier than usual. Though, Phainon had no idea what he was referring to; what *did* Phainon look like at this moment? What he knew himself was that he didn't want the other person behind the door to see *Mydei*.

“Give me a few moments.”

The knocking ceased at Mydei's words, and he breathed an exasperated sigh. “They must be coming to get me to prepare for the ball tonight.”

Phainon laughed breathlessly, his hands sliding against Mydei's waist. “You should probably do that.”

The man above him stared longingly down at Phainon, as if he were debating whether the repercussions were worth *not* attending the ball tonight.

Smirking, Phainon cocked his head to the side, reading his mind. “Not attending is not an option, Mydeimos.”

He raised an eyebrow. “‘Mydeimos’? So you will only call me ‘Mydei’ when we share a bed?”

Phainon's cheeks flared up once more as he averted his gaze to the side, staring at Dawnmaker who was just a witness to their inappropriate activities. “You would like me to refer to you even more familiarly? Do you know how long it took for me to even become comfortable with calling you ‘Mydeimos’?”

He heard a scoff above him. “And do you know how long it took me to finally get you in my bed?”

“I–!” Phainon whipped his head around to retort, but the man was already pushing himself from Phainon's lap, straightening out his now wrinkled and stained robe.

“You should get ready now.” Mydei was standing now, glancing over to Phainon who was still sprawled out in his bed.

As if he had snapped out of a daze, Phainon pushed himself up from the bed and latched onto Dawnmaker to strap back on his waist. Heaving deep breaths to steady himself, he looked over at Mydei who had somehow successfully rewrapped his robe so that the obscene stain was not visible.

“I will see you tonight, Mydei.”

Mydei smiled the sweetest smile Phainon had ever seen grace his beautiful red lips. “I look forward to tonight, Phainon.”

Phainon opened the door and was met face to face with Empousa, whose eyes practically bulged from their sockets in shock at seeing Phainon emerge from her King's room first thing in Lucid Hour. She rapidly shoved something behind her back, and from the cloth that Phainon could see peeking out from behind her, he could only assume that would be Mydei's attire for the ball.

“Good morning.” He flashed the Kremnoan attendant a smile before quickly darting down the corridor toward the public baths. Phainon quite desperately needed to get out of these soaked pants.

“My King!” Empousa darted inside the open door after seeing that Okheman guard escape down the hall. She shut the door behind her at lightning speed, bounding straight to the only man left in the room. “You– He–Did you–”

The King turned around, and Empousa couldn't help becoming giddy with joy at how disheveled both the Okheman guard and the King looked this morning. Their lips were clearly bruised, faces flushed, and clothes wrinkled from activity. It was extremely obvious that certain *deeds* occurred just a few moments ago.

The King opened his mouth, but Empousa gasped sharply before he could utter a word. “Wait! Did I interrupt?!”

But the King only sighed exasperatedly, gesturing to the clothing in her hand. “I assume that is for the ball?”

Empousa nodded enthusiastically, holding it up in front of her to the best of her abilities, as the King was clearly a much bigger stature than Empousa could show with her arms. “Georgious and Herklas are finalizing the jewelry. Let us get you ready!”

Phainon dropped his head against the edge of the bath, ignoring how the back of his head ached from the action.

What did he just do?!

Phainon deserved another twelve more blows against his head as his mind kept envisioning the previous scenes like a play on repeat inside his brain. Was he really just rutting up against a king like a dog in heat?! Was he really about to cum a whole load against a king?! Of all people, a *king?!*

Phainon groaned to himself, slapping a hand over his eyes as if that could shield himself from the truth. He had never engaged in such close relations with another person before, but never in a million years would Phainon have guessed his first time would be with *royalty*. He was just an average soldier, for Titan's sake, so how was he suddenly cozying up and even grinding himself against a king in just a matter of four days of meeting him?!

He should not have done that. He should not have done that. He should *not* have *done* that.

How was he supposed to face the King again? How was he supposed to handle the entire rest of the day? Or even the rest of the week, for that matter? If Phainon could barely even look at the man after masturbating to him, then how could he possibly manage to be in the same room as him after having *those* kinds of relations with him?!

And the most important part: He was a *king!*

Abruptly sitting up in the bath, Phainon glanced around at all the other bath attendees who were paying him no mind and carrying about their day. He wished that he was just one of them as well, carrying about a normal day as if he didn't just almost cum underneath a king. He really, *really* shouldn't have done that. How could he have done such a thing to the nobility? Was Phainon about to get flanked the moment Mydei came to and realized what he had done?

His heart yearned at the thought of Mydei's name. Should he even be calling him that anymore? No, definitely not. It would just remind them of their time together in bed. Phainon groaned to himself once more. If he kept getting erections just being in the same room as Mydeimos, what made him think it was a good idea to jump into his bed? Why did he even fall asleep there? He should have just left the moment Mydeimos fell asleep.

With an aching heart, Phainon continued cleaning himself off. He kept repeating how awful of a man he was. How could he possibly succumb to his own desires like that? He shouldn't have climbed into bed with him, he shouldn't have fallen asleep with him, and he shouldn't have done *that* with

him. It was impermissible and even more unforgivable. He should apologize to Mydeimos tonight. He had to set the air straight between them that Phainon had practically jumped the man in his own room. He couldn't believe how he had pushed himself like so against Mydeimos–he didn't even enjoy it, right? Phainon was both inexperienced in bed *and* aggressive with him. He couldn't have imagined Mydeimos even felt the least bit satisfied with him.

Phainon shook his head, splashing water onto his face. No, it didn't matter whether Mydeimos felt good or not. What mattered was the fact that Phainon had committed such a grave sin against the nobility. He had to apologize to Mydeimos and hope that he would be forgiven. Sure, Mydeimos said to treat him as an equal, and he even said to drop the formalities. But, in no way, shape, or form did that mean he could go committing such acts against the King. Phainon overstepped his boundaries. He couldn't ever do that again to Mydeimos. *He shouldn't ever do those sort of acts with Mydeimos again.*

Ignoring his twisting heart that rejected every single one of his thoughts, he solemnly finished the rest of his bath. Did he feel good with Mydeimos? Of course he did. *Of course he did.* Why wouldn't he? Mydeimos was just ethereal and breathtaking. He was gorgeous and beautiful and just absolutely lovely. Anyone would be lucky to even be graced by his presence. Of course Phainon craved more of Mydeimos, to be even closer to him than they ever were today. His body still very clearly remembered the feeling of their bodies together and their intertwining limbs, and he so strongly yearned for him. But, that was impossible for someone in his position. It was unthinkable to even entertain that idea for someone in his position.

Plucking the clothes that he set for himself, it was the attire that Aglaea had gifted him so long ago. Since he had to attend the royal ball as a guard, he had to at least be dressed for the special occasion. Even if he was mostly going to be off to the side just monitoring Mydeimos from a distance, he still had to be dressed in a uniform that was more fitting for the ball. Although the guards that monitored outside Marmoreal Palace and in the

corridors wore their regular uniforms, the guards inside the actual event had to be dressed properly.

He didn't wear this outfit very often. Actually, it was safe to say that, after Aglaea had made him try it on the very first time after she had gifted it to him, he never had a need to wear this attire again. It was so complicated to wear, and there were so many extra pieces that Phainon was unsure where to hang what. There were so many different embellishments that Phainon wasn't used to, considering that his usual soldier uniform consisted of a plain tunic, simple pants, and leather boots.

The fancy attire consisted of a black collared shirt that stood straight up adjacent to his neck. With a slightly opened chest and a leather choker, the dark shirt would be adorned by a long, white coat with gold embellishments that reached all the way down to his ankles. With a gold interior, the coat was slightly cinched at his waist with a leather belt, and royal blue sashes hung loosely down either side. A matching royal blue cape with a matching gold interior was strapped to one shoulder that fluttered down even past the white coat, and strapped on top of his cape was a leather pauldron.

On his other shoulder, a much grander, metal pauldron was strapped to him, coated with a white and a gold trim. But the highlight of this pauldron was definitely the golden sun that shined right at the peak of the pauldron that matched the rays of the sun spanning across his chest. There were actually multiple sun motifs on his person, with one on the back of his collar and even another on his leather gauntlets. Dark pants led into black leather knee high boots, but what really confused him were the amount of belts incorporated into the outfit.

He had a belt around his chest that kept the pauldrons in place, another belt that cinched the waist of the coat, another belt that cinched his actual shirt, a belt around his thigh, some more belts that kept his boots up, and two more belts that strapped the leather pauldron to his blue cape. Seriously, how was he expected to dress himself in this outfit with the number of belts he had to buckle into place? He wasn't even sure he could buckle even half of these by himself.

Phainon spent a good few quints just attempting to wear the outfit correctly. He would wear it one way, feel that something was out of place, then have to remove the entire outfit again so he could manually fix with two hands whatever was out of place. He repeated this process numerous times–so many times that his arms were getting tired from putting on and removing his clothes over and over again. And, all the leather pieces and the metal pauldron were *not* light by any means. And sometimes, he would wear the entire outfit and forget a belt or a sash, and he would have to remove parts of his outfit again to get those pieces into the correct place. He was getting a headache just from wearing pieces of clothing.

Phainon had debated running to the training grounds to fit in a quick training session before taking a bath, but after how long he had spent trying to adorn himself correctly, he was thankful he went straight to the baths. Though, the main reason he did so was because he could not stand the feeling of his previously stained pants. In addition, the last time he thought he could fit in a training session, he ended up being an entire quint late. If he had shoved in a training session and then tried to wear this outfit, he couldn't even begin to imagine how late he would have been today.

Strapping the rest of the belts on his boots, Phainon deemed himself complete with the attire. Was he really done, he wasn't exactly sure, but Phainon's head could not deal with any more belts and buckles. What an inconvenient outfit. Though, he could not deny that it was quite the grand outfit, and it made Phainon appear a lot more important than he truly was. What was even more important to Phainon was that the outfit also matched Dawnmaker, which was now strapped to his side once more. If the outfit matched his beloved sword, Phainon figured he could deal with a multitude of belts.

The time was soon approaching Parting Hour. He had departed from Mydeimos’s room around Lucid Hour. Where had the time disappeared off too? He definitely spent way more time trying to adorn himself in this attire than he had originally thought. There was no way he spent the entire Lucid Hour and almost the entire Action Hour just taking a bath and figuring out this outfit, but with how breathless he was from fighting his own clothes, he

could almost believe it. He had spent so long on his clothes that even his hair had now completely dried.

He figured it was now time to drop by and see Mydeimos. Although he was a little early, he figured it wouldn't hurt, especially after he was so late yesterday. Phainon also wanted some time to apologize to Mydeimos for what happened this morning. Because he didn't have a mirror, as mirrors were luxury items that only the upper class could afford, he could only hope that his appearance wasn't in too much of a disarray.

Phainon exited the barracks and made his way back to Marmoreal Palace. It seemed most of the soldiers and servants were preparing for the ball as they were running wildly throughout the palace grounds, but many of them did stop to compliment Phainon on the outfit, which he explained he was only wearing because he was accompanying the Kremnoan envoys to the ball. He could only owe it all to Aglaea, but he also needed an apology from her for incorporating so many belts.

It was quiet in the corridor where the Kremnoans were staying for the week. Usually, the maids were often found cleaning the interior of the rooms and even outside in the halls, so it was unusual seeing it so bare and empty. But it made sense, as all hands were on deck to ensure the royal ball was a success.

Bringing a fist up to Mydeimos's door, he knocked a few times. He had figured the Kremnoan attendants were in there helping the King get ready, but he couldn't hear a word at all through the door. Instead, all he heard was the King's muffled voice beckoning him inside.

Phainon stepped inside, shutting the door behind him, but he froze in his tracks the moment he caught a glimpse of Mydeimos.

It was… Phainon couldn't even begin to describe it. Actually, he couldn't, because his brain immediately combusted upon laying eyes on Mydeimos. Even if he wanted to describe the tantalizing sight that he saw, his brain refused to describe it.

“My–Mydeimos?”

The ethereal, golden-haired man faced him and narrowed his eyes. “I'm back to ‘Mydeimos’? Why are we going backwards again?”

“I…”

Mydeimos waited for a response, but Phainon couldn't even utter a single syllable. He just stared, gawking at the King in front of him with wide eyes, parted lips, and blushed cheeks as he was frozen in place. It wasn't until fingers were running through his hair that he snapped out of his stupor.

“Your hair is a mess,” Mydeimos huffed, attempting to straighten out Phainon's hair that most likely became so tousled from changing his clothes so many times earlier.

“I… Wait…” Phainon fumbled in place with lips flapping and no sound being emitted from his throat as Mydeimos’s gorgeously perfect fingers tangled themselves with his hair.

Mydeimos frowned and patted Phainon on top of his head. “I'll have to get my attendants to straighten your hair for you.”

“No!” Phainon’s hand flew out and grasped Mydeimos's wrist, pulling his hand away. “No… I… Wait.” He released Mydeimos's hand to pinch the bridge of his nose, inhaling deeply to calm himself down. Phainon came here to apologize to the man for jumping him in bed, yet here he was ogling at the sight in front of him like a fool. As if he didn't just give himself a whole scolding earlier at how he should never touch Mydeimos like that again.

Phainon opened his eyes again, breathing in another breath, before turning back to Mydeimos. Holy Titans, he still couldn't believe what Mydeimos was actually wearing. He felt as if he wandered into a dream.

Adorned in a gold diadem atop his head and matching dangling earrings, Mydeimos was wearing gold sandals that strapped up to his knees and tied behind his legs. His legs…Phainon couldn't help but be drawn to the sight of them because they were completely bare, save for the red tattoos that ran down his body. His bottom half wore a light red himation, and although that

attire is usually wrapped around one shoulder, Mydeimos had left his top half entirely bare and had only wrapped the cloth loosely around his waist– a little *too* loosely for Phainon's liking. It was cut in an interesting pattern in that it completely exposed his legs and hips.

What was the most eye-catching was how embellished his torso was. Mydeimos had a different version of his usual necklace around his chest. Although it looked exactly the same as the gold necklace he wore when he first arrived, this one was a bit smaller, because hanging off of the necklace and twinkling against his naked torso were elaborately long golden chains that wrapped around his body and even draped down to hang off his exposed hips. Nothing covered his hands, and with the golden pauldrons placed on a nearby table in the back, Phainon could only assume that he was in the middle of putting them on.

“I…” Phainon was having trouble making eye contact with Mydeimos when all his eyes wanted to focus on was his exposed chest and his two red buds that occasionally brushed against the body chain. “I came here to apologize.”

“Apologize?” Mydeimos raised an eyebrow.

“For… this morning.” Phainon opted to just gluing his gaze on his feet instead, but now he had a clear view of Mydeimos's sculpted legs. “I… I shouldn't have done that to you this morning. I'm sorry.”

Silence followed his apology, and Phainon glanced upward only to see a flash of hurt across Mydeimos's expression, but it quickly disappeared when he narrowed his eyes and crossed his arms. Was Phainon just imagining things?

“Do you regret it?”

Regret? Phainon's heart squeezed so tightly in his chest that it was hard to breathe. He had to say, “Yes,” right? He had to say he regretted it, because he did–because he was supposed to. Because he shouldn't have done that, and he regretted his actions. He wished he hadn't done that, right? He wished he could go back in time and reverse his actions so that he had never

gotten back into bed with him, right? He wished he hadn't touched him, kissed him, and held him. That's what he was supposed to feel.

Then, why was it so hard to answer?

“I see.”

These two words broke his thoughts, and Phainon had finally come to, face to face with Mydeimos who had quickly hidden his expression. But, in just that one moment, Phainon had clearly seen it.

Mydeimos turned around and strolled back to his golden gauntlets. With the room completely silent, his footsteps resounded loudly in Phainon's mind, and his hands twitched at his sides to pull him back. But it felt like his feet were rooted to the ground, and he couldn't move.

“You should ask my attendants to tend to your hair.” Mydeimos plainly stated, grasping one of the gauntlets in his hand. “They are in the next room over.”

It was quiet. It was almost too quiet in the room. Phainon silently watched as Mydeimos fiddled with the gauntlet, inspecting the exterior.

“My–”

“The ball will begin soon. It will take time to finish your hair.”

He was basically ordering Phainon to leave, right? He was basically shouting at him to get out. But, out of all the orders Phainon had followed, why did he feel it was wrong to follow this one? He had briefly caught that expression on Mydeimos’s face that he tried to hide–that expression of hurt, rejection, and guilt. Phainon had never wanted to see that expression on Mydeimos's face, and his heart ached at the mere thought of the sight he had witnessed. It was etched into his brain like a painting, and he would never forget it. Phainon probably really would have left if he hadn't caught that brief expression, but now he couldn't leave after he had seen it.

“Mydeimos–”

“Did you not hear me?”

A glare shot in his direction, and Phainon flinched. He tried not to cower under Mydeimos's gaze, but he felt like a small animal–almost like prey, even–as he stared back at Mydeimos. He felt similar to last night when he had faced Mydeimos's wrath, but he felt that something was different this time. Rather than the exasperation he faced last night, this time, it felt almost like Mydeimos was pleading for him to leave rather than ordering him.

Phainon chanced a step forward, his feet as heavy as a block of steel. Gauging Mydeimos's reaction, he saw that his gaze had dropped briefly to Phainon's feet before returning to his eyes. But, he didn't stop Phainon from moving forward, and they were now face to face again, with Mydeimos's back against the table.

“Mydeimos,” Phainon whispered, almost pleading to Mydeimos. But, what was he supposed to be pleading for? “I'm… supposed to say I regret it, right?”

Phainon's vision blurred, and he could no longer see what Mydeimos was feeling or what he was thinking. All he could see was a faint silhouette of gold and red in front of him as Mydeimos stayed silent. Filling in that intimidating silence, Phainon continued blabbering about nothing, hoping that Mydeimos would say *anything* back.

“I shouldn't have done that to you, right? I shouldn't have touched you; no, I shouldn't have even shared your bed in the first place. I shouldn't have come back. I shouldn't have fallen asleep here. I should have just left.” Phainon took a shaky breath. It was hard for him to see, and even harder for him to breathe. He wasn't even sure what was coming out of his mouth anymore, even the last sentence that he muttered.

“Why is it so hard for me to say I regret it?”

A warm hand caressed his cheek, swiping a thumb against his eyes. Phainon's eyes widened; he hadn't even realized that he was crying, but the

tears flowed down increasingly so once he had realized. And soon, both of Mydeimos's hands were upon his cheeks, wiping his tears away.

“You are supposed to say what you feel,” Mydeimos chastised him gently, following the tears that continued to trail down Phainon's cheeks and drip down his chin. “Not what you think you are supposed to say.”

Phainon's lips quivered. His throat ached and burned while trying to fight the tears. “But, how could I say that to a king?”

“You're not.” Mydeimos rubbed his thumb along Phainon's trembling lips. “You're saying it to *me*. To Mydei. And to no one else.”

His words echoed in Phainon's mind. It was just to Mydei. It was just him and Mydei in this room. And no one else. How could Phainon possibly see anyone else but *Mydei? Mydei* wasn't a king, he wasn't nobility, and he wasn't of the upper class. *Mydei* was a strong, skilled, and experienced warrior, and he was an intelligent, loved leader. *Mydei* was honest, almost a little *too* honest, but it was what Phainon needed. And, *Mydei* was gorgeous. In fact, there weren't enough words to even begin to describe his beauty, his elegance, and his radiance. He was sure he had repeated the same adjectives over and over in his mind because no number of words could describe his allure. Phainon hadn't fallen for a king; he had fallen for *Mydei*.

“Mydei?”

“Hmm?”

“I…” The tears began to overflow again at the thought he was about to utter, and Mydei quickly resumed swiping them away. But, Phainon had shed so many tears already that Mydei’s hands had become drenched, and they didn't do much to catch the tears upon his face.

Phainon wasn't sure if he was supposed to be saying this. He wasn't sure what would happen between them if he said it out loud. Would things change between them? What would their future look like? Mydei had to

leave in just three days now. He shouldn't be saying this. He shouldn't even be *thinking* this. They didn't have the time anymore.

Barely above a whisper, Phainon couldn't stop the feelings or the tears that poured out of him. No matter his second guesses, and no matter how intimidated he was for their coming days. He couldn't stop himself from telling him. “I really like you, Mydei.”

A soft laugh. The most beautiful laugh Phainon had ever heard. The most ethereal voice his ears had ever caught. How could he have been so blessed to ever meet this man in his life?

“I really like you too, Phainon.”

Phainon keeled over at his words, shutting his eyes as he cried into the crook of Mydei's neck. He wrapped his arms tightly around Mydei, begging him not to go. Running his hands underneath the golden chains that adorned Mydei's body, Phainon pushed him backwards against the table with another sob. Mydei stumbled back, throwing his arms around Phainon and running his fingers through his hair.

He wasn't sure how long they had stayed in that position, with Phainon sobbing into Mydei's neck and Mydei rubbing small circles in Phainon's hair. His shoulders shook with every sob, and every time, Mydei had held him even tighter against his body, as if telling him that he was there. That *Mydei* was there.

Phainon inhaled as deeply as he could to stop the tears from overflowing, and he was embarrassed at how stuffed his nose was. He had been crying into Mydei for what felt like too long, but he also wanted to stay wrapped in Mydei's arms forever.

With his sobs now quieted down, the two of them continued standing against the table with their arms encircled around each other. Phainon hadn't realized that Mydei was leaning his head against his while playing with the silver strands atop his head.

“You look good.” Mydei broke the silence now that his cries were no longer filling the room. “This armor on you. It looks good.”

Phainon laughed breathlessly, inhaling once more. “Yeah?” He picked himself off of Mydei with a small smile, and Mydei quickly reached a hand over to wipe the remaining tracks on Phainon's cheeks.

“You should wear it more.” Mydei had swiped a thumb across the corner of his eyes, but he was now rubbing small circles into his cheeks.

“It was… so hard to put on.” Phainon laughed again, recalling all those quints he had spent frustrated over his own clothing. “You should have seen how long it took me to get everything on properly.”

Mydei softly chuckled. “Is that why your hair is in such disarray?”

Phainon leaned down with another smile, and Mydei seemed to almost twinkle in his gaze under the warm lighting above them. Getting lost in those deep golden pools that swirled in his irises, Phainon broke the short silence between them as he mumbled, “Can I hear it again?”

Scoffing, Mydei clutched his face and roughly pulled him down. Phainon barely had time to throw his hands out in front of him as his hands met the cool surface of the table they were leaning against, barely stopping himself from tumbling into the man before him. He was caught in such surprise that he hadn't realized how closely Mydei had brought him in, and he felt his lips brush against his as he answered his request.

“I like you, Phainon.”

Who leaned towards the other first didn't matter as they both shut their eyes, locking their lips together in a deep kiss. The tension seemed to immediately wash away from Phainon's body as he felt Mydei move against him, and he leaned his head forward to get an even better taste of his lips. Bringing a hand up toward Mydei, he grazed his fingertips delicately through Mydei's soft golden hair, and Mydei sighed contently at the touch, wrapping his arms around Phainon's shoulders.

The taste of sweet pomegranate mixed in with the remnants of Phainon's tears as he kissed Mydei deeply. Did Mydei go to the dining hall earlier to drink his daily concoction of pomegranate juice and goat's milk? Phainon smiled at the thought, holding in a laugh at how adorable the man was, but he yelped when a sharp pain attacked his bottom lip.

“What are you thinking of while kissing me?” Mydei's glare was the least convincing with how red his lips and cheeks were. “Surely, you would not be thinking of something else.”

“I was thinking of how cute you are.” Phainon laughed at how the blush deepened on Mydei's face and even crept down his neck. It almost even matched the color of his tattoos.

“You… HKS.” Mydei gritted his teeth, tightening the hold his arms had around Phainon's neck.

“I've been meaning to ask, but what does that word mean?” Phainon frowned as he did his best to recall the sound. “*Hai… kas?*”

Mydei clicked his tongue. “You pronounced the wrong syllable, *scoundrel*.”

“Scoun–?!”

Phainon was pulled into another kiss, effectively cutting his retort short, but it didn't matter because the thought immediately left Phainon's mind. Instead, all he was now focused on was how soft Mydei's lips felt against his, and how right they felt as they moved against him. Phainon's eyes fluttered shut, reveling in the sounds of their lips between them and the soft breaths that they shared.

Mydei's hands crept down to underneath his jaw, pulling him closer and grazing his fingertips along Phainon's choker. Phainon swallowed dryly, gasping for air in between kisses, and Mydei took the chance to snake his way inside. Moaning at the sensation of Mydei's warm tongue sliding against his, he swung his hands underneath Mydei's thighs, propping him onto the table.

With their tongues tangled together, Mydei grunted in surprise when he was placed upon the tabletop. Phainon pushed himself between Mydei's legs, tilting his head upwards to savor the pomegranate taste inside Mydei's mouth. He swiped his tongue all over every crevice and surface inside his deep cavern, and Mydei fisted at the choker around Phainon's neck, wrapping his legs around Phainon's hips and pulling him even closer.

The panting and moans in the room increased the more they pushed and pulled against each other and the more their bodies collided. Saliva dribbled from the corners of their mouths as Phainon roughly shoved against Mydei, impatient for more of his body on him. Mydei moaned wantonly, throwing his arms around Phainon's shoulders and clawing at the coat on his back.

Mydei liked it rough–Phainon made a mental note of that. Separating their lips, he attached himself down Mydei's neck, trailing his red tattoos and kissing and sucking down his body and onto his chest. Mydei gasped sharply, shaking in Phainon's arms as he tugged desperately against his white clothes and rutted upwards against Phainon's body.

"*Hah…* Mydei, did you want it that bad?" With another hard suck against Mydei's collarbone, he leaned upwards and planted another kiss on his lips. Phainon pushed his hips forward, grinding his hips against Mydei. He could feel the blood rushing to below his waist and how tight his pants now felt as Mydei whimpered, continuing to thrust himself against Phainon with his trembling legs clinging onto Phainon's waist.

The table groaned under their weight as they slid their hips against each other, chasing the pleasure of stimulating their hard cocks. The fabric around Mydei's waist was in complete disarray as their hips didn't stop driving into each other–no, more like they *couldn't* stop. There was no way they could separate from each other with the pleasure that pooled in Phainon's stomach, and he could feel his thrusts turn sporadic as his toes curled in his leather boots. With lips slightly parted, strings of moans slipped from his throat the more his twitching dick rubbed against Mydei's own needy length.

Mydei took Phainon's hand that was leaning against the table and placed it among his inner thigh. Due to the cut of his clothing, his thighs were

completely exposed as Phainon gently brushed his fingertips against the bare skin and elucidated goosebumps upon his thighs, contrasting how roughly his body was thrusting against Mydei.

“Here, Mydei?” Phainon rubbed small circles closer to the heat that radiated between his thighs, and Mydei gasped. With a smirk, Phainon placed both hands against his thighs, pushing his legs wider on the table and getting even more access to his desperate heat. Mydei’s legs were spread as far as possible with his feet planted on the table's surface and knees shaking in the air.

Moaning loudly, Mydei threw his head back, falling onto his elbows as Phainon slipped his hands into the cutouts near his waist and thrust sharply. Grasping at the hot skin, he pushed his hips against him, feeling the delicious outline of Mydei's own straining dick over and over again as he resumed pounding himself against Mydei. With another moan, Mydei grasped at the edge of the table that continued creaking and wobbling under the strain of their activities.

Ahh, should he just unbutton his pants right now? He could only imagine what it would feel like if he could thrust his naked dick underneath Mydei’s clothing and be able to feel his pulsing hot length flush against his as he brought Mydei closer and closer to complete ecstasy. With Mydei's quivering red lips parted, panting and moaning for breath underneath him as if asking Phainon for more, his opened legs shaking in the air in pure bliss, and hands tightly grasping the edge of the table, he couldn't begin to imagine what Mydei would look like if they continued their activities with their lower halves bare.

“Closer… Here.” Mydei's words cut Phainon's plans short as he tugged his hand underneath his garment, and Phainon froze when he felt his knuckles brush against his hard, hot length. Whipping his head down to his lap, he noticed he could clearly see the outline of his tip poking against the fabric, and the stain of precum that leaked against it. From the angle that Phainon was looking down from, he could see the fabric tenting from his dripping erection, and faintly, he could catch the sight of bare skin and golden hair that was being revealed underneath.

Phainon gulped thickly and eyed the stained clothing with wide eyes. “Mydei… Are you not wearing–”

“*STOP!*”

The two men jumped, and Mydei's legs had snapped closed around Phainon's hips. Phainon shot his hands back toward his side as if he had been caught in the middle of a crime. Whirling his head around, Phainon saw Empousa at the entrance of the bedroom with her arms raised as if she were halting a sports match.

She was panting as if the yelling took all the breath out of her lungs. “As much as I would *love* to have you guys resume your lovely activities, we have a ball to get to that we absolutely *cannot* skip out on.” She shot a warning glare at the man behind Phainon, already knowing that the King was debating on the idea. “Phainon, you look great.” Her warning glare immediately melted away when she smiled upon him.

“Th–Thanks.” Phainon could only laugh awkwardly, as her King still had his limbs wrapped around him and refused to let go.

“My King.” She suspiciously eyed the clothing around Mydei and sighed exasperatedly. Empousa muttered something under her breath, but Phainon couldn't catch it and could only hear her following words: “Georgious has prepared another outfit for you for the ball. Please come with me.”

Phainon turned around to glance down at Mydei, and he agreed. With his golden hair messily clinging to his face, bruised red lips, and marks evident of their activities dancing across his neck and chest, there was absolutely no chance Phainon was going to let him waltz down into the grand hall with his disheveled clothing that was even stained below his waist.

He felt Mydei retract his arms and legs from him, and Phainon stepped off to the side for Mydei to prop his feet back into the ground. Empousa waited patiently as Mydei gathered his gold gauntlets that were knocked onto the ground at some point during their love-making.

Exchanging a glance with Mydei, he offered him a small smile, gesturing for him to continue getting ready for the ball. Mydei stared intently at him for a few moments and released a sigh before suddenly leaning in with a serious gaze, peering deeply into Phainon's eyes.

“Meet me in my bedroom tonight.”

The breath caught in Phainon's throat as his eyes widened at what Mydei was insinuating. He couldn't even say anything back as Mydei had already exited the room without waiting for his response.

“*Hah…*” Phainon had brought a hand up to cover his face that was now blooming a bright red.

“Phainon.”

He jumped again, whipping his head over to Empousa who apparently did not follow Mydei out of the room.

“I thought you left.” With another awkward laugh, he rubbed a hand down his face in a poor attempt to ease the blush across his cheeks.

Ignoring the embarrassment written all across his face, Empousa grinned and beckoned him over to a nearby chair on the opposite wall. “King Mydeimos has told me to fix your hair.”

“No, I'm quite alright.” He chuckled. “No need to trouble yourself. I'll only be guarding from the sidelines, after all. My hair will settle after some time.”

She furrowed her eyebrows. “The King didn't tell you?”

“Tell me what?”

“That he was bringing you as his partner for the ball.”

Phainon blinked blankly at the Kremnoan attendant. “Who is bringing whom as his partner for the ball?”

“King Mydeimos has chosen you for his partner at the ball.”

“...One more time?”

“Just get over here!”

He scurried over to the chair, sitting down and letting Empousa brush her fingers through his hair. Guests were always provided a plus one at the royal ball; usually, this was reserved for the guest's significant other or family, but in theory, it could be whomever the guest wanted to bring. Because Mydei didn't have a significant other and, unfortunately, no family either, Phainon just assumed he was going to bring an attendant or no one at all.

Wait…

Phainon's head shot up, interrupting whatever Empousa had been doing to style his hair, and a smack landed at the back of his head.

“I almost messed up!”

“Am I Mydei's lover?!”

“Put your head back down!”

He didn't have to do anything because Empousa had already shoved his head back into position, which gave Phainon time to lament his own question. Sure they had confessed to each other and had even engaged in.. certain activities together, but did that mean they were officially partners? As in, Mydei was his lover?

Phainon immediately, and mentally, lest he be on the receiving end of Empousa’s impatience again, shook his head. Mydei was a king; he was sure there were a lot more steps he had to go through before he was officially recognized as Mydei's significant other. He may be being taken to the ball as his partner, but that didn't necessarily equate to being his lover.

“Of course you are the King's lover. What kind of stupid question is that?”

Phainon heard a huff above him, and he peeked through his bangs to see Empousa's fingers perfecting the part positioned on the side of his head with a glass of wax in her other hand.

“Isn't he a king though? Wouldn't he have to get approval, or I would have to get recognition, before it is official?”

“Get approval from whom? Get recognition from whom?” Empousa snapped. “He is a king–the highest authority in Kremnos. The only person you will have to worry about impressing is Krateros, and that is only because he is technically the King's father figure. Do not forget that we are not Okhema.”

She continued running her hand through his silver strands, and Phainon blushed at the thought. Did Mydei think of him as a lover already? Or was he getting ahead of himself? If his personal Kremnoan attendant said so, then she must know Mydei well enough to confidently say those words, right? Phainon had never had a romantic relationship before–he didn't know the first thing about having a lover. Well, if he *was* officially his lover, after all, as he still didn't really know what he was to Mydei at the moment.

“You're as red as a maiden in love,” Empousa teased with a laugh.

“I… don't really know what it feels like to be in love.”

The hand in his hair froze. Phainon peeked upwards through his bangs once again, but he couldn't make out the expression on the attendant’s face through his hair.

“*REALLY?!”* Empousa practically screamed once she had gotten over herself, slamming the glass jar down on a nearby end table. “Never?! You?!”

“I–”

“I thought you were a player!” Empousa fell to her knees, and Phainon wasn't sure whether to comfort her or if moving too roughly would ruin his hair.

“Huh? A… what?”

Empousa began mumbling under breath, and Phainon couldn't decipher a single word that came from her mouth: “That man has never been in love before? He has never courted a woman or man in his life? No, technically, you don't need to be in love to be a player. That man definitely has the looks and the charisma to charm anyone to his bed regardless of his feelings. But, it makes perfect sense considering how oblivious he was to the King's charms, but I cannot believe a man of his stature has never seen anyone in his life…”

“*Err.*.. Empousa?”

Her clean hand that wasn't covered in hair wax slapped his knee, and he jumped in his seat. Grasping firmly at his knee, she stared at Phainon with a resolute gaze.

“Never? Never at all?” Empousa vibrated her hand violently against Phainon.

“Is… Is that bad? Does the King want someone with experience?”

“So you've never charmed anyone into your bed either?!”

Empousa began wailing about something that Phainon was unsure what she was talking about. Why would he need to charm someone into his bed? Why would he bring anyone to his bed?

Oh.

Phainon's face bloomed a bright red once he had understood what the Kremnoan attendant was implying. Bringing a hand up to his face to mask his embarrassment, he could only bring himself to sheepishly laugh at the situation.

“No, Empousa, I have never brought anyone to my bed before nor have I had close relations with anyone else before.”

The woman practically lying on the floor gazed back up at Phainon. “You are… No one in Okhema asked you?”

“Asked me what?”

“To sleep with you.”

Phainon’s cooling face immediately flared up once again. “Why would anyone ask me that?!”

“Have you seen yourself in a mirror before?!”

“I can't afford that!”

Empousa sighed heavily, pushing herself back onto her feet. “Is the social class gap really that large in Okhema? I thought all the women would practically fall at your feet. Not even the maids or servants have asked to join you in bed?”

With a light chuckle, Phainon replied, “I think you overestimate me, Empousa.”

“I am most certainly not.” She grabbed the jar of wax once more, perfecting the strands of hair that had gone astray during their conversation. “The Okhemans are certainly missing out. I'll have to go ask the servants around the palace what they think of you.” She heaved another sigh. “Well, at least they do not have to be on the receiving end of the King's rage.”

Phainon furrowed his eyebrows at her words “Huh?”

“And, you're done!” Empousa slammed the jar back down on the table, and Phainon almost felt a little sorry for how much that glass jar was going through. Glass was not cheap, after all. “Since you're going to be accompanying the King as his partner, I thought to style your hair rather than just fix it back to normal.”

Phainon instinctively brought a hand up to meet his hair, but before he could even touch a hair on his hand, Empousa smacked his hand away with

a scolding following immediately after: “Why do you keep trying to ruin your own hair?”

Chuckling, Phainon brought his hand back down. “Thank you, Empousa. Truly, it has been such a pleasure to meet you.”

She raised an eyebrow as she finished closing the top of the jar. “Why are you saying this as if we will never see each other again? Now get up. Let us go get your partner for the ball.”

Empousa practically pushed Phainon out of the King's room, shutting the door behind her, before leading the way to what Phainon could only assume was the attendant Georgious's room. She waltzed in without knocking on the door, grabbing the attention of all the people inside. Phainon wasn't so used to such brash behavior, but he quickly gathered himself and followed Empousa inside.

Inside, there were quite a lot of attendants. From the people Phainon could recognize, Herklas was sitting on the edge of someone's bed, and Georgious was perfecting the heavy cape with a lush fur collar that was draping down Mydei's back. Mydei, meanwhile, was standing in front of the mirror with his eyes shut, as another attendant was tending to his hair.

Through the mirror, Phainon could make out his new attire for the royal ball. It was completely different from what Phainon had previously seen him in, with an open, deep red surcoat that was opened more than halfway down adorning his torso and golden chains that hung across his bare, tattooed chest from a grand golden brooch that kept the cape in place. Wearing his golden gauntlets once again that shined under the chandelier light, his surcoat was tucked into dark trousers, and his golden belt that had made its initial appearance during Mydei's arrival was secured against his hips. His dark trousers disappeared into Mydei's usual golden cuisses, and golden bands decorated with sapphire wrapped around his biceps on top of his sleeves. That same golden diadem sat on top of his head, indicating his royal status.

“This is a completely different outfit from what you were wearing before.”

Mydei opened his eyes upon hearing his voice in the room, but he didn't turn his head lest he disturb the attendants' work. "Disappointed?"

"I–No! I–" Phainon couldn't help stumbling over his words as his cheeks began to heat up. "I was just saying that I didn't expect your backup attire to be so different from the first one."

Unbeknownst to Phainon, the outfit that Mydei was currently wearing was his original outfit for the ball, and the outfit Phainon had previously seen him in was mostly made to catch his eyes. But, none of the attendants said a word to explain this to him.

"Did you want other people to see me in that attire?" Mydei gazed at him through the mirror set in front of him.

"Well…" Phainon could still very clearly envision his previous attire: the way the cutouts completely exposed his bare skin, the way his torso was shining from the golden chains that wrapped around his body, and the fact that he wasn't even wearing… *anything* underneath his himation. "No."

Mydei laughed, and Phainon could faintly see his golden eyes sparkling in his reflection. "That's what I thought you would say."

Phainon averted his gaze, heart beating erratically at the thought that Mydei only wore that outfit for him. Did Mydei even have plans to wear that to the ball if he was asking Phainon that question?

Hesitantly, Phainon opened his mouth to ask the burning question at the forefront of his mind. "Were you… only wearing that for me?"

"What do you think, HKS?"

Phainon could only breathe out an incredulous laugh, covering his burning face with his hand that was equally just as hot. He couldn't even say anything in defense because he truly did pounce on Mydei in that outfit. Absolutely no one but Phainon should ever see Mydei in that outfit, Phainon swore to himself. The seductive ability of that outfit was way too effective.

“Then.” Phainon could only glue his eyes to the floor at the incredulous notion swirling in his brain. “If you only had that outfit made for me, do you plan to wear it again?”

“Do you think I would only have an outfit made just to wear it one time?” Phainon could feel Mydei's gaze bearing deep into him from the mirror’s reflection as he said those words.

Phainon's face reddened even further from the implications that Mydei suggested as his blush creeped down all the way to his neck and exposed chest. Mydei's way of saying things really was way too forward for Phainon to handle.

Throughout the entirety of the two men's blatant flirting, all the attendants in the room struggled to continue their silence as if they weren't even there. They couldn't even believe that after so many years of their King being a single man that he was now so obviously flirting with his beloved in a room full of Kremnoan attendants. They all either struggled with containing their blush or containing their teasing as they continued tending to the King's appearance.

“You're done, King Mydeimos.” Georgious's voice rang clearly in the room as the other attendants stepped away to give Mydei space. Mydei turned to Georgious to thank him before turning around to face Phainon, who was still just standing in the middle of the room.

Herklas nodded at the King's appearance. He was still sitting on the edge of the bed behind Phainon. “You look good, King Mydeimos. You did good, Georgious”

The other attendants all agreed, thanking Georgious for planning basically the entire outfit. Meanwhile, Phainon still couldn’t get over how he was basically attending as Mydei’s partner for the ball. Does he still go about his guard duties despite hanging off the arm of the King of Kremnos? His face couldn’t stop burning at the idea that he was still attending the ball with a guest rather than as a guard.

“Are you ready?” Mydei's deep voice interrupted his thoughts, and Phainon instinctively jumped up to look at him only to realize that all the Kremnoans had their attention on him now.

Composing himself, he managed to muster a response: “Yes, let me show you to the ball, Mydei.”

Mydei scoffed. “Didn't my attendant tell you? You are coming as my partner, not as a guard. You won't be leading me anywhere.”

Phainon laughed, but it was cut short when fingers interlocked with his. Glancing down at his fingers now intertwined with Mydei's, he was pulled out of the room, quickly waving a goodbye to the attendants left behind in the room.

They made their way down the corridors and stairs of Marmoreal Palace. Even though Mydei said those words, he still didn't actually know where the grand hall was where the royal ball was mainly taking place, so Phainon happily led him there. He just only hoped that his palms were not sweating so much from holding Mydei's hand.

“Should I still act as your guard when we are there?” They had just turned a corner and were nearing the grand hall, and Phainon couldn't help his heart was pounding in anxiousness. He still didn't officially hear from Mydei's lips that he was his lover, so to think that he would enter the royal ball with his hand locked with Mydei's sent Phainon into another spiral.

“What do you think?” Mydei shot a glare in his direction.

“Well, I just–”

“You're overthinking again.”

“Are we…” Phainon suddenly blurted out, stopping in the middle of the hallway. Because their hands were still locked together, Mydei was pulled back from going further. “Are we… You know…”

Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Just spit it out.”

“Dating?” Phainon's voice was so meek that he was unsure if he was even heard. But based on his reaction, the question was loud and clear.

The other man's eyebrows shot straight up. “*Dating?*” Before Phainon could do anything, perhaps even take back his own question, Mydei sighed loudly and exasperatedly. “We've slept together in bed, had sexual relations, confessed our feelings, and are currently holding hands on the way to the royal ball, and you dare to even ask me that question?”

“So, is that a ‘yes’?”

“You truly think way too much than your brain should allow.” A flick of Mydei's finger hit against Phainon's forehead, and Phainon yelped with a jump at the quick pain. “Did you want me to spell it out for you? Fine.”

Mydei quickly closed the distance between them, grasping tightly at Phainon's hands so that he couldn't escape. With the noses barely brushing against each other, Mydei, with a faint blush across his cheeks, stayed true to his word: “I think of you as my *partner* and my *significant other*. I wouldn't do *these* types of things with anyone else whom I didn't hold feelings for.”

Mydei whirled around on his feet, dragging Phainon down the corridor who was left with an entirely short circuiting brain at his words.

I'm his partner… *his* significant other… *Mydei* likes *me*… *Mydei has* feelings *for me*…

These thoughts continued to swirl in Phainon's mind as he was dragged towards the ball. Mydei, who obviously still didn't know where the royal ball was occurring, happened to run into other well-dressed individuals and followed them to where he could only assume was the grand hall.

The guards patrolling the entrance to the grand hall opened the doors for them, and they were led into a grand banquet hall with sparkling chandeliers and intricate banners draping from the ceiling. With the entire center of the floor cleared so that people could join in song and dance, surrounding the dance floor were grand pillars reaching toward the sky and

smaller round tables each decorated with glass vases of the most in-season flowers. Waiters and waitresses were perusing the floor, offering drinks and other refreshments to the guests, and on the far back wall was a grand, sparkling staircase that led to a second floor that overlooked the first floor. Grand windows framed by luscious curtains that practically reached from floor to ceiling covered the walls, and Phainon could see the clear, moonlit sky outside. And, against the walls were the guards that were attending to all the guests tonight.

Phainon glanced around him in awe, unfamiliar with such elaborate surroundings. He wasn't even sure where to start in such a giant hall, where the guests were flying in and out of the dance floor, speaking amongst each other, or perusing the second floor. Phainon could only rely on Mydei, who was currently speaking with a waiter nearby who rushed off after they were done.

“Did you ask for something?” Phainon watched as the waiter disappeared behind a set of doors that Phainon could only assume led to a kitchen.

Mydei hummed. “I asked for some for you too.”

“For me too?” Phainon raised an eyebrow, but he couldn't ask what he had gotten as someone began calling out to Mydei. Grabbing both of their attention, they glanced ahead of them to find an incredible beauty dressed in all gold approaching them.

“Phainon, you look lovely.” Aglaea graciously smiled in his direction. Phainon didn't think Aglaea’s dress could get any fancier, but there she was in an even more stunning garb than what she usually sported. “Though, if you had told me you were coming as King Mydeimos’s plus one, I would've had an even nicer outfit prepared for you.”

Phainon chuckled awkwardly, realizing that she had already noticed their intertwined fingers. He wanted to pull them away in front of his boss, but he also didn't want to be separated from Mydei. “It's quite fine, Miss Aglaea. I actually didn't know I would be attending either. I thought I would be with the other guards tonight.”

Aglaea smiled at him with a nod before turning to Mydei. “King Mydeimos, it's an honor to have you join us at the royal ball this year. Would you like anything to drink or eat, perhaps?”

“No need, I've already told one of your waiters what I would be needing.” Mydei shook his head.

“Great, in that case.” Aglaea turned around on her twinkling golden heels, scanning the grand hall for someone. “I would like to introduce you to a few people, if you were welcome to it.”

Mydei nodded, and she beckoned them across the hall to a corner where Phainon could see the envoys of Styxia and the envoys of the Grove of Epiphany conversing together.

He hadn't seen the envoys of the Grove for quite some time ever since he graduated from the Grove. Every ball, the envoys that are sent from the Grove changes, as there were seven sages that collectively governed the Grove of Epiphany. This year, the sage that they sent was someone very familiar to Phainon. It was his previous teacher, Professor Anaxagoras, and beside him was his assistant teacher, Hyacinthia. Although, they were not dressed in their usual clothing that Phainon was so used to, as they were also dressed appropriately for the royal ball.

“Welcome back, Miss Aglaea.” Castorice bowed her head as they approached the group. Phainon wasn't sure if it was his imagination, but Castorice's cheeks seemed to tinge pink upon laying eyes on the two men behind Aglaea. He wasn't sure why, as Mydei and him had already separated from each other on the way over.

“Thank you, Castorice. I wanted to introduce you all to the King of Kremnos.” She gestured to behind her, and Mydei nodded politely at their attention.

“It's an honor to make my debut outside of Kremnos to meet you all,” Mydei said in an all-too perfect and noble tone. “My name is Mydeimos, King of Kremnos.” He glanced toward Castorice and Queen Polyxia and smiled. “I believe we have already been acquainted.”

Castorice and Queen Polyxia returned the nod with a slight bow of the heads, with Castorice raising her head and locking eyes with Phainon. “Phainon, are you accompanying the King tonight?”

Phainon smiled at his former classmate. He wasn't sure how vague or specific he should be, so he only answered, “Yes, I am.”

Castorice’s smile grew ever so minutely, averting her gaze while she became deep in her thoughts. Phainon wasn't sure what she could possibly be thinking about after his answer, but he was used to Castorice's behavior after being acquainted with her for so long.

Mydei turned to acknowledge the envoys from the Grove of Epiphany. “It is an honor to meet you all today as well.”

Phainon's former professor and his assistant teacher nodded.

“Likewise. I've heard so much about the King of Kremnos.” The green-haired sage seemed to scan Mydei up and down, assessing his entirety with one eye, as his other eye was covered by a black eye patch elaborately decorated with gold embellishments and trim.

Mydei laughed lowly. He probably couldn't even begin to imagine the rumors that ventured outside Kremnos’s borders regarding the King. “I hope none of them have had too much of an impact on your opinion of me.”

The professor scoffed. “Of course not. I prefer to evaluate things with my own eye.”

“What Professor Anaxa means to say, is that we are honored to have met you, King Mydeimos.” His assistant teacher effectively jumped into the conversation. “It really is an honor to meet you during your debut outside of Kremnos.”

She flashed a smile in Phainon's direction, which he returned back to her. “It's nice to see you again, Phainon!”

“It's nice to see you again too, Hyacine.”

Hyacine tugged at her professor’s cape. “Do you remember Phainon too? He was the same year as Castorice.”

The professor narrowed his eye at Phainon, and Phainon felt as if he were immediately taken back to the Grove when he was just a student of his.

“Hi, Professor Anaxa.” Phainon smiled under his keen gaze. He was quite used to that inquisitive stare of his after learning from him for so many years.

“*A–nax–a–gor–as*,” Anaxa hissed.

“Phainon was the ten-time Great Debate champion,” Hyacine reminded the professor. “He also threw the entire physics lecture into disarray that one time.”

Phainon could faintly hear Mydei covering laughter with coughs under his breath. Why were his student days suddenly being uncovered for Mydei's ears? And, why were those the two things he was known for during his days at the Grove?

“*Ah*,” Anaxa plainly said. “I remember you.”

With that tone of voice, Phainon wasn't sure if it was a good or bad thing that he was remembered.

“I'm glad you remember me, Professor Anaxa.” Phainon bowed his head toward the sage.

With a click of his tongue, Anaxa sharply ordered, “Don’t call me that.”

“King Mydeimos,” Hyacine, once again, effectively jumped into the conversation. “How are you enjoying your trip in Okhema? Is this your first time outside of Kremnos’s borders?”

“Not my first time outside of Kremnos’s borders, but my first in Okhema. I have been enjoying my time here so far,” Mydei answered the pink-haired woman.

The four kingdoms began to converse with each other in that little corner, with each of them covering general news of what was occurring in their kingdoms of Okhema, Styxia, the Grove of Epiphany, and Kremnos. Many of them had questions about Kremnos, which made sense since Mydei's kingdom had been in isolation for so many years during the early days of his ascension to the throne. Phainon silently listened to their conversation as he received updates of the other kingdoms. It was good to know that everyone was still doing well even after not seeing them for so many years.

“King Mydeimos.” Aglaea smiled at him. “I believe that waiter is looking for you.”

Mydei gazed over his shoulder, and Phainon trailed his line of sight to find the waiter that he was previously conversing with when they had first entered the grand hall. He was balancing a silver tray upon his palm, with two glasses of a dark red liquid swirling inside.

“Thank you, Miss Aglaea.” Turning back to the rest of the group, Mydei bid his farewells. “It was an honor meeting everyone here, and I hope I will get the opportunity to see you all again.”

They all returned their goodbyes to Mydei and Phainon, and Phainon offered them all a smile as he bid his farewells as well, specifically to Aglaea as they were planned to see her again tomorrow. He followed Mydei, but he had stopped some distance away from the waiter.

“Mydei?” He glanced at Mydei before glancing at the waiter, and he saw that the two glasses were gone. But what he did see was a faint flash of black scurrying away.

With eyes widening, he charged ahead without any hesitation in the direction of the disappearing color, weaving between crowds of guests before reaching the base of the grand, ornate stairs. He whirled his attention around the area, but he had lost what he was chasing after.

“Cipher!” Phainon called out. “I know you're here!”

A silence followed his words. Mydei had quickly caught up to him and was staring inquisitively at Phainon who continued to keep shouting into the air. Thankfully, because it was so loud due to all the guests in the grand hall, Phainon yelling into the air was nothing out of the ordinary.

“Cipher! You're stealing a king’s drink!”

“Thanks for confirming that this is expensive!”

A female voice rang through their heads almost as if she were speaking directly into their minds. Because of that, Phainon couldn't decipher in what direction she was hiding in, but at least he confirmed that she was here.

He was about to yell something else into the air, but he suddenly heard very dramatic spitting noises. And soon, from around the stair's banister came a woman dressed in a sleek, black dress that hugged tightly to her lithe frame and a head of purple-gray hair. And in her hands were two glasses of that same dark red liquid.

“I thought you were drinking some expensive wine,” Cipher whined with a sigh, holding the glasses out for Phainon. “Here, just take it back. I'm going to go steal some actual drinks from the other guests.”

“You know you can just ask the waiters for a drink, right? You're Miss Aglaea's daughter, after all.” Phainon took the glasses from her hands.

Cipher sighed exasperatedly, dropping her head. “Aglaea ordered all the waiters not to give me wine tonight.”

Phainon quickly recalled the previous ball where she had swung from chandelier to chandelier after drinking multiple glasses of an extremely strong and expensive wine. “I… see.”

Her head shot up, determination filling her pupils. Her prior resignation had disappeared as if it never existed. “You're right! I'll just go and steal some more. Thanks, Phainon!”

She was about to depart at the speed of light, but she stopped dead in her tracks when her eyes laid upon Mydei. At the familiar glint sparkling in her eyes, Phainon quickly shoved himself between Mydei and Cipher.

“I'm not letting you steal a hair on the King's head, Cipher.”

“Letting?” Cipher laughed. “Would it even be stealing if you let me?”

Phainon narrowed his eyes, ready for the woman to pounce in their direction, but she only shrugged her shoulders. “Since Aglaea gave you the task of following the King around, I won't make your job any harder this time, Phainon.”

He relaxed his shoulders. She truly loved Aglaea even without directly saying it, and he had her respect to thank for not having to fight for Mydei's jewelry out of Cipher's grasp.

“Well, see ya, Phainon! And it was nice to meet you too, King of Kremnos!” She darted before they could fit in another word, and silence soon fell between the two of them.

“What an… interesting woman.” Mydei finally broke the silence, approaching Phainon's side.

Phainon sighed in response. “She's always like that. Don't worry about her, but that was Miss Aglaea's adoptive daughter.”

Mydei hummed, taking one of the glasses from Phainon's hand. “It seemed that she thought I ordered wine.”

“You didn't?” Phainon observed the viscous liquid in his glass as he swirled it.

“I'm not fond of drinking.” Mydei raised the glass to his lips, but Phainon quickly raised a hand to stop him.

“I'm still technically your guard, Mydei. Let me taste it for you.”

“A little poison wouldn't kill me.”

“It could definitely kill you, Mydei.”

“Do you notice anything about my appearance, Phainon?”

He furrowed his eyebrows at the random question, but he did as he was asked anyway. Observing Mydei's build, he couldn't exactly find anything out of the ordinary. The only thing was that he wanted to close Mydei's shirt so that no one could see his bare chest but him. He also noticed how the golden belt seemed to cinch in his waist; and the golden bands on his biceps tightly outlined the shape of his strong arms; and his trousers were clinging just a little too tightly against his thighs, and–

“HKS.”

“I'm not staring!” Phainon, who was so obviously staring, blurted out.

Mydei sighed exasperatedly. “Do you remember leaving marks on me?”

Immediately flushing a bright red at his blunt statement, Phainon ran over to further close his surcoat, only to realize that none of the marks were there. He distinctly remembered leaving a mark near Mydei's collarbone, but nothing was on his neck, collarbones, or chest.

“Wait, did I?” Phainon squinted at the naked chest in front of him, frowning when he could find nothing except for the red tattoos.

Mydei huffed. “You definitely did.”

“Then–”

“They're gone, Phainon.”

“Well, obviously! Where did they go?!”

Phainon almost wanted to rip off his entire top just to inspect him from top to bottom. He wasn't going crazy, right? Was the crowd in the grand hall making him lose his bearings?

“You studied at the Grove, correct?” Mydei recalled their earlier conversation with Anaxa and Hyacine. “I'm sure you've met many magic users during your time there.”

He paused in his floundering. “That does remind me. Since you are of noble blood, you must possess magic.”

“That, I do,” Mydei confirmed.

“That's… You didn't use it at all when sparring with me?” Phainon hummed, recalling their previous sparring sessions. But, it was true. All Mydei had fought with were his gauntlets.

“That, I did.”

“You did?!” Phainon's eyes wildly wandered in the air. “You didn't fight with anything but your gauntlets though.”

“I have a special constitution. I am sure you are familiar with it, when someone's magic is too strong and uncontrollable.”

Phainon immediately recalled Castorice. It was why she was staying in Okhema and previously studied with him at the Grove, after all.

Mydei continued. “For me, it is that I can never be harmed nor can I die.”

Eyes widening, Phainon scoured as much bare skin as he could see on Mydei. True to his word, there was not a single blemmish, scar, or wound on his person. The only thing Phainon could recall were faint callouses on his hands, but even those were just faint.

“Never?” Phainon hadn't paid too much attention to any injuries on Mydei's person after their sparring sessions, but was it just because they didn't catch Phainon's eyes because they never existed in the first place?

Mydei gazed off to the side, deep in thought. He hummed lowly, shutting his eyes before reopening them at Phainon. “I will tell you later. But know that no poisons could ever harm me.”

Recalling his previous days with Mydei, it explained so many of his rash behaviors now. Phainon had just previously thought he was overconfident with his strength when he drank beverages from a foreign country without confirming there was no poison in it or even falling asleep in front of him upon their second day or knowing each other. His uncontrollable magical energy was protecting him the entire time.

“You are truly a formidable warrior.” Phainon could only lightly chuckle at this new information. “I can see why everyone hails you as the strongest in all of Amphoreus.”

“*Hmph*, even if I died in every single battle, that wouldn't make me the strongest. Obviously, I am strong from the number of battles that I have won.” He tried to take a sip of his glass, but Phainon raised a hand to stop him once more.

“Even if you are basically immortal, still, let me taste your drink for you.”

Mydei scoffed, resignedly handing Phainon his glass. “How persistent.”

Smiling, Phainon raised the glass to his nose, swirling the beverage in front of his eyes and smelling the sweet scent it gave off before raising it to his lips to take a sip. Phainon wasn't sure what to expect, but he was not expecting it to be pomegranate juice that Mydei had ordered.

He passed the glass back to Mydei, confirming that there was nothing amiss with his drink. “You ordered pomegranate juice?”

Mydei raised the glass to his lips, and Phainon watched, mesmerized, as they sucked on the same spot on the glass where Phainon had previously tasted the drink. Electricity ran down his spine when his lips left the rim of the glass, and a tongue swiped languidly along his reddened lips.

“You're staring, HKS,” Mydei bluntly remarked, attempting to suppress his own blush.

“You're doing this on purpose, aren't you, Mydei?” Phainon whined with a sigh. He glanced down at the floor in hopes that no one else in the grand

hall could see how red his face had become.

“You were the one who insisted on tasting my drink.”

“You could've used another spot to drink!”

“And why would I do that?”

Phainon, with wide eyes, had just barely caught Mydei smirking, sticking his tongue out to lap at a stray droplet of pomegranate juice on the outside of the glass.

Phainon dryly swallowed, averting his gaze once more. “You're unfair, Mydei.”

Chuckling, Mydei swirled the remaining pomegranate juice in his glass. “It's for all those times you left me on my own.”

“On your own?” Phainon frowned. “When did I do that?”

Mydei scoffed once again. “Let's see. When I brought you to my room, stripped down naked, and you practically ran out the room. When you avoided me the entire day in the downtown market. When you skipped supper…”

With a blooming red face, Phainon exasperatedly waved his arms in the air. “Okay, I get it. You can stop now.” He sighed, running a hand through his hair that Empousa had spent so long to style so meticulously. “But, I had very good reasons for those.”

“Oh?” Mydei raised an eyebrow. “Let's hear it then. You refused to tell me before.”

Phainon brought a hand up to hide the lower half of his red face as he recalled the embarrassing memories once again. How did they keep conveniently coming back to this conversation? “I–”

A glass chime echoed in the grand hall, and everyone went silent. He was saved!

Upon facing the grand set of stairs against the far wall, a group of very well-dressed individuals stood near the middle of the stairs, with one of them raising a glass high into the air to garner everyone's attention in the hall. The one in the center who was raising her glass wore a very elaborately crafted white and gold dress with a gold laurel wreath adorning her head. It was Caenis, the leader of the Council of Elders who ran the Okheman kingdom alongside Aglaea.

“Welcome, everyone!” Caenis bellowed from the stairs, lowering her glass to meet everyone's gazes. “Welcome to Okhema, and welcome to our ball.”

The crowd began applauding at her words. For courtesy's sake, Phainon joined in as well, but he didn't particularly favor the Council of Elders. Their way of running the kingdom was quite… not to Phainon's taste, so to speak. They preferred doing many things behind the scenes, and Phainon was not in favor of the lack of transparency.

For instance, they were in charge of a secret assassination regiment deemed the “Cleaners,” for they were in charge of eradicating the “darkness” in Okhema in secret under the guise of “cleansing” their kingdom. It was something that Phainon was definitely not in favor of, and he was more than positive those Cleaners were even in this grand hall, scouring all of the attendees. He was just grateful he worked more with Aglaea than with the Council of Elders; though, Phainon did feel bad Aglaea had to deal with them so often, especially since she was in such a power struggle against them in running the Okheman government.

“I would like to sincerely thank everyone who has attended tonight and those who have journeyed from faraway kingdoms to unite in our Okheman borders,” Caenis continued. “In this Month of Joy, tonight is a night of celebrations and festivities, where borders are of no importance, and we may honor and flourish our relations and alliances with each other. I hope we may continue to grow our bonds with one another, and I hope there may even be new bonds that we create tonight.”

Applause erupted at her speech, and Phainon, who admittedly was only half-listening, joined the noise. He was sure these “new bonds” she was referring to were directed at Mydei and Kremnos Kingdom, as the

Kremnoans were the only new kingdom in attendance this year. With the strongest military might in the entire continent, any kingdom would be scrambling for an alliance with Kremnos. An alliance with Kremnos basically spelled assured victory.

Caenis continued on, droning about Okhema's hard work and their successes over the past couple of years since the last ball. Frankly, as much as Phainon loved Okhema and did his best to serve his kingdom, he didn't particularly care for Caenis or the Council of Elders at all, and it didn't take much for him to completely tune her voice out. Caenis usually just droned about what the Council of Elders did specifically, completely ignoring all of the policies that Aglaea had implemented. In fact, it was quite offensive that they didn't even invite Aglaea to speak with them, as she had quite a big hand in planning and preparing the ball as well. But, Phainon wasn't even the least bit surprised that they didn't invite Aglaea, and even if they did, he wasn't even sure if Aglaea would want to join them up on the stairs.

With the speech coming to a close, applause resounded through the hall once again, and Phainon automatically began clapping his hands at the sound. He glanced quickly at Mydei and saw that at least one of them had listened to the speech. Though, Phainon couldn't tell if Mydei was interested in what they were saying or scrutinizing every word. He was sure there were many things running through Mydei's mind as a king, and especially when he was considering an alliance with Okhema.

Only one thing came to Phainon's mind while observing Mydei from afar, and it was that Mydei was certainly handsome while he was in work mode. He was truly dangerously alluring while like this, and Phainon couldn't help but admire him for the remainder of the Council of Elders' words as another member, Lygus, took the stage. Although Phainon didn't interact with the Council of Elders very much, from the few conversations he has had with them, there was something *very* offputting with Lygus, and he quickly tuned out his words as well. Phainon only applauded when necessary, and a sigh of relief left his body when the Council of Elders finally departed the stairs.

“Mydei.” Phainon graced the man with a smile once he had garnered his attention. “Would you like to eat something first before we go?”

Mydei nodded, and Phainon had gotten the attention of a wandering waiter for some food. Most of the food that was being served for the ball was finger food, so that the guests could spend the majority of their time mingling with others and “flourishing alliances,” in the words of Caenis. The dishes that the waiter served to them on a silver platter were garnished egg rolls and steaming, bite-sized pieces of tender dromas meat slathered in a golden sauce. Phainon was also positive that there were other wandering waiters that were serving dessert. Thanking him, Phainon picked enough food that he could hold for both him and Mydei.

Glancing over at Mydei, he could see the man still deep in his thoughts. He must still be in work mode, Phainon assumed, as he approached the King to hand him his meal for the night.

“It's important to eat even if you have work to do.” Phainon held up the food for him after tasting it himself, and Mydei gratefully accepted it.

“I am just thinking about their words,” Mydei explained as he took a bite of the dromas meat.

“The Council of Elders?”

Mydei hummed. “So, that was indeed the Council of Elders.”

Wow, Phainon didn't even realize, but the Council of Elders truly did not introduce themselves. Were they that confident in themselves and their work? Maybe they were of the mindset that their work spoke for themselves. Either way, Phainon was still quite unsettled about them.

“Yes, did Miss Aglaea tell you about them?”

“A little bit,” Mydei answered. “I will meet with her again soon, correct? I will have to give her my answer then.”

Phainon raised his eyebrows in surprise. “You already have an answer for her?”

Mydei's gaze was turned toward the floor, deep in thought. “There are still things to work out, which I will have to discuss with her. But, ultimately, my answer will stay the same.”

Tilting his head to the side, Phainon recalled the last few days that he was with Mydei. Since when did Mydei put so much thought into Aglaea's proposal? He was basically glued to Mydei's side the entire week, but he couldn't recall when Mydei even had the time to review her proposal. “I'm surprised you had so much time to think about the proposal.”

Mydei nodded, locking eyes with Phainon. “I contemplated her proposal every day.”

“*Every* day?”

“I cannot let a single day go to waste,” Mydei stated. “Especially when it comes to my people.”

Wow, was it too soon for Phainon to say he was practically in love with the King of Kremnos?

Pushing that completely impulsive thought aside, Phainon smiled in response. “You really love your people. That's what makes you such a great king.”

Mydei smiled. It was such a soft and tender smile that Phainon felt he had practically melted from Mydei's gentle expression as he thought about his kingdom.

“I only wish for the best for my people,” was all Mydei said as he finished the rest of his food.

Once they finished their meals and even indulged in a quick dessert of sweet, honey-coated apple slices, they agreed to go find Aglaea to bid their farewells before departing from the ball. As it was soon approaching Curtain-Fall Hour, some of the attendees were beginning to retire to their quarters, but a great many of them were still dancing on the main floor, drunk out of their minds from all the expensive wine being provided at no

cost to them. As Aglaea was one of the main hosts for the ball, it was safe to assume that Aglaea was glued to the royal ball until everyone had departed.

Weaving through the crowds of guests, Phainon finally spotted her sparkling golden gown from afar. Grabbing Mydei's attention, they both approached the ruler of Okhema where she stood against the wall while speaking to three very small women. Although their appearances did resemble that of young children, Phainon knew they were much older than everyone in the grand hall.

“Miss Aglaea,” Phainon called out to her, and she and the three women all turned to look at him. “And, Miss Tribbie, Trinnon, and Trianne. It's been a while.”

“Snowy!” Tribbie beamed, enthusiastically waving at him as he stopped by their sides.

“*We* told you not to sound so formal,” Trianne huffed at him.

Phainon laughed softly. “Sorry, Miss Trianne. It's a habit of mine.”

“You're still doing it!” Trianne pointedly remarked.

Mydei stifled a laugh at the interaction, and Phainon turned to him inquisitively and silently raised an eyebrow for his explanation.

“I see I am not the only one you've had difficulties dropping formalities with.” Mydei smiled with amusement.

“It's…” Phainon sighed loudly, as there was nothing he could say to defend himself. “Sorry.”

“It only means he is good at his job.” Aglaea chuckled softly. “It took him quite a long time for him to become comfortable with me.”

“Agy!” Tribbie whined, turning to Aglaea with a pout. “You just have to assign Snowy to more missions in Janusopolis!”

Mydei's eyes slightly widened at her words. “So, I assume you are the Holy Maiden of Janusopolis?”

The three women all turned to the newcomer with wide eyes. “You must be the King of Kremnos!”

Mydei nodded, bowing deeply at the three of them. “My name is Mydeimos. It's an honor to meet the Holy Maiden.”

The Holy Maiden was quite the famous figure all across Amphoreus. She was the representative of Janusopolis, home of the many priests and priestesses who were the followers of Janus. As the Titan of Passage, Janus governed not only the physical paths that people would take but also their fates and paths of life. As such, Januspolis was a great sanctuary for all in Amphoreus, and the divine Holy Maiden herself who held the words of Janus was held in the greatest esteem. Januspolis and the Holy Maiden nary had an enemy, as having an enemy would mean opposing Fate itself. And as supporters of Aglaea's rule, that also meant the Council of Elders could not easily demote Aglaea.

“It is quite the honor to finally meet you, De!” All three of them smiled up at him. “*We* are Tribbie!”

“*We* are Trinnon.”

“And *we* are Trianne!”

They all introduced themselves one by one, but Mydei was more surprised by the new nickname he was suddenly granted. Phainon had to stifle a laugh at the expression across his face upon hearing the sudden name.

However, Mydei didn't point out the nickname, and he only smiled and nodded at each one of their names. “It is a pleasure to meet you all.”

“No, it is *our* pleasure to meet you, De!” Tribbie grinned up at him.

“*We* have heard so much about you,” Trinnon added.

“Many, many great feats!” Trianne chimed in, eyes sparkling with excitement. “*We* heard you are the strongest in Amphoreus–never to be beaten.”

Mydei chuckled. “Phainon here isn't too bad himself.”

Phainon whipped his head at the King as he was suddenly dragged into the conversation. “*Me?*”

“*We* agree!” Tribbie nodded enthusiastically.

“*We* suggested to Agy that if there was anyone who could match the King of Kremnos, it would definitely be Snowy.” Trianne crossed her arms with a confident nod.

Phainon's eyes widened. So it was Tribbie that suggested he be Mydei's guard this whole time? When Aglaea said she had tried to gather information about the King of Kremnos, she had actually consulted Tribbie? Everything all made sense now; if there was one individual who could find out information about a mysterious king of a closed country, there was no doubt that it would be the Holy Maiden of Janusopolis. Phainon had just chalked it up to being Aglaea's informants and lots of skilled gathering of information, but with how short of a notice Kremnos gave in confirming their attendance for the ball, it made much more sense that Aglaea went straight to Tribbie for information.

“Snowy is all surprised,” Trianne snickered.

“It is true.” It was now Trinnon's turn to nod. “If anyone could match up to De, in all of Amphoreus, it would be Snowy.”

“They are a good match.” Tribbie continued to grin in their direction.

“*Quite* the good match,” Aglaea chimed in with a knowing smirk, and Phainon couldn't help but turn red under her teasing gaze. Aglaea really always knew too much for her own good.

“Thank you.” Phainon could only sheepishly smile.

“Have you both fought yet?!” Trianne was practically jumping in place from anticipation.

“We've sparred,” Phainon answered.

“And we were tied,” Mydei bluntly finished.

Phainon shot a look toward the King. “I'm sure if we sparred one more time, I would best you this time.”

Mydei crossed his arms. “If we sparred another time, I would win.”

“I think I would win twice in a row.”

“Says the one who left himself wide open to attack the first time we sparred.”

“I won't be so careless next time.”

The three women, all with eyes wide, *ooh'ed* and *aah'ed* at their bickering. Well, Trinnon's eyes were covered, but Phainon could only assume she had the same reaction as the other two.

“*We* were right!” Trianne was now officially jumping in place as she cheered, and Tribbie joined her in the celebration.

“*We* hope you enjoy the rest of your stay in Okhema, De.” Trinnon smiled as the other two continued their cheering in the background. “If Kremnos is in need of any divinations, please come speak with *us* in Janusopolis.”

Mydei nodded with another smile in acceptance, and they all conversed for a bit longer before finally bidding their farewells. Phainon wasn't expecting to run into the Holy Maiden when they went to find Aglaea, but it was now getting late into the night after they had finally departed from the grand hall. It was officially Curtain-Fall Hour, and Phainon was more than ready to retire for the night.

The farther they went from the grand hall, the quieter the corridors became as the music and festivities were now far behind them. The guards were still

faithfully patrolling Marmoreal Palace, and even more so as it was the important night of the ball. Phainon was more than happy to finally be out of that ball, as they had conversed with so many people. However, he still had quite the grand time and was even able to reunite with so many others that he hadn't seen in a long time.

Approaching Mydei's door, the day had finally come to a close. Tomorrow would be the Kremnoans' rest day, so, thankfully, there was not much that Phainon needed to do tomorrow. It was a much-deserved rest for everyone in the Kremnoan party, as all the previous days have been building up to the royal ball. They could now relax and fully enjoy what Okhema had to offer.

"Well, Mydei." Phainon smiled at him once they had stopped in front of his bedroom door. "It's getting quite late into the night. I will see you tomorrow."

Before Phainon could take a step away, he caught Mydei crossing his arms across his own chest while narrowing his eyes. "You're going to leave even after my previous words to you?"

With slightly widened eyes, Phainon, in a panic, briefly ran through every single conversation with Mydei from the long day to see what request of the King slipped his mind. He was then quickly reminded of their previous activities before they were interrupted to prepare for the ball.

"I…" Phainon's face immediately bloomed bright red as he stuttered over his words. "Are you–Well–I–"

"Or, am I the only one who wants this?"

"No!" Phainon blurted out a little too loudly and a little too quickly for his liking. "Well–I just–"

With a smirk, Mydei tilted his head toward his door. "Then get inside, HKS."

Heart pounding violently in his ears, Phainon shakily placed his hand on the door's handle, pushing the bedroom door open. Upon stepping inside, the

room was just as tidy as ever, all thanks to the palace maids. However, even with the room appearing the same as ever, Phainon felt as if he were in an entirely different space. He couldn't help his palms from becoming clammy, and his eyes refused to make contact with the large bed that was so glaringly in the middle of the room.

“Would you… like to bathe first–*AH!”*

With a harsh shove against his back, Phainon landed face-first into the bed with a muffled yelp. He scrambled back up with as much effort as he could muster, as the breath was knocked out of his lungs, but a hand against his chest pushed him back down until he was sitting on the edge of the mattress.

Mydei, with fingers spread wide against Phainon's chest, slipped a knee in between Phainon's thighs and leaned close. With flushed cheeks, his warm breath tickled Phainon's lips as he murmured, “You would make a king wait that long?”

Phainon was having much difficulty staring up at the alluring man in front of him, and his eyes wandered to the bedroom walls over his shoulder. “Well–I just thought… Maybe you would want to freshen up or–*mmph!*”

Lips pressed against his, silencing whatever thoughts were going to continue rambling out of his mouth. Phainon's eyes immediately fluttered closed at the soft sensation of Mydei's lips, and his hands grasped desperately against the sheets he was sitting on top of as his fingers trembled in pleasure. A faint noise barely managed to take him out of his pleasured stupor only for his ears to recognize the sound of buckles.

Before Phainon could react, he felt his pauldrons slip from his shoulders, immediately followed by a loud clattering to the parquet wooden floor. A weight was lifted from his shoulders as the sounds of buckles and wet kisses filled the air. His coat was pushed from his shoulders, his black undershirt became uncinched, and the belts around his thighs loosened. One by one, as Phainon was too deep in locking lips with the man in front of him, clothes and accessories were shed from his person only to be discarded haphazardly onto the floor.

They finally separated for air, and Phainon was left only in his trousers, leather boots, leather gauntlets, and black undershirt. In a daze, he barely registered that Mydei had basically stripped him of almost all of his clothing that he struggled with much difficulty to wear earlier, and a cold air began to send chills down his spine when Mydei stepped away from him.

“Take off your clothes.”

That one commanding sentence seemed to erupt something in Phainon's mind as he quickly snapped out of his daze, getting to work in removing his gauntlets from his hands. He wasn't sure if Mydei was just standing there and watching him peel his clothes off, but he didn't want to check to confirm lest his face begin to burn even more brightly.

He heard a faint shuffling in the background, but he didn't take notice of it as Phainon slipped off his leather boots and gauntlets and began unbuckling his pants. Though, his hands faltered against his waistband. Without Mydei essentially seducing him at his side, the gravity of the situation began to dawn on him.

Phainon was stripping. He was becoming entirely and wholly naked in the bedroom of a king. He was taking off all of his clothes to do who-knows-what with a king. It was different compared to shedding his clothes for the public baths; it was in the intimacy of the king's private quarters, and Phainon didn't know the first thing about sex. All his knowledge came from conversations that he had overheard in the barracks from fellow soldiers, and he wouldn't say they were a completely educational source to refer to. Yet, here he was now, about to do *something* with the King of Kremnos.

He stared with wide eyes at his hands in his lap, where his fingers completely stilled against the waist of his trousers. Suddenly, the dim chandelier lighting was way too bright for Phainon's liking, as they only emphasized exactly what they were doing in the room. His heartbeat took over all his senses as it pounded sporadically in his ears, and all he could feel was the thumping against his chest and the heat that spread across his entire body, blooming from his chest. Should he just run out now to perhaps educate himself before he made a fool of himself in front of a king? And, it

wasn't just a king; it was *Mydei* of all people. He didn't want to hurt Mydei with his lack of knowledge, and he most certainly didn't want to look like a fool in front of him either.

Two warm hands encompassed his frozen hands, breaking him from his thoughts. “You're still dressed?”

Warily, Phainon glanced upwards, and his eyes bulged out of his sockets when he saw Mydei's naked torso now being adorned with that same body chain he had been so acquainted with earlier in the day.

“You're… this attire…” Phainon's wide eyes selfishly wandered Mydei's body. His chest twinkled under the lighting due to the chains wrapping around him, and the cut himation revealed his tan skin and the crimson red tattoos that only led to deeper and enticing parts of his body. It took all of Phainon's strength not to run his fingertips along his smooth skin.

“I told you I wouldn't have an outfit made only to wear it once.” Mydei gently pushed his fingers out of the way to begin unbuckling his pants for him. However, instead of pulling his pants down to his ankles, Mydei kneeled onto the ground, placing his hands on Phainon's knees and pushing until his knees almost hit the bed he was sitting on.

“Mydei?!” Phainon's hands began floundering in the air. He wasn't sure if he should snap his legs closed or pull Mydei from the floor first.

“Be quiet.” With tinted, rosy cheeks, Mydei's warm hands grasped his length in his pants that was slowly being roused, and the cool air against his dick made Phainon wince as it was pulled from his pants.

Phainon watched, completely dizzy and mesmerized, as Mydei's bare hands wrapped around his dick and began pumping up and down and bringing Phainon to full hardness. Each touch and slide of his fingers sent shivers down Phainon's spine, and he had to bring a hand up to his mouth to muffle the pants and moans that threatened to slip from his throat.

Watching Mydei on his knees, slotted between Phainon's opened legs, while he pumped his cock was a sight that Phainon would've never expected to

behold in his entire life. Mydei's hands perfectly wrapped around his dick, and Phainon's toes clenched against the rug underneath their feet as Mydei began speeding up his pace. His lips inched close to the the head of Phainon's dick, and he had to push himself down on the bed to stop himself from thrusting against Mydei's tempting lips as his warm breath ghosted over Phainon's now hot and pulsing length. Phainon was frowning with narrowed eyes as he held back from moving his hips for more of the hot breath that Mydei kept unconsciously teasing against him.

A tongue swiped against the curve of his tip, and Phainon's hand flew to grasp Mydei's golden hair as a loud moan escaped his chest. Pleasure ripped through his body, and that single action left Phainon gasping for breath and craving for more.

Mydei chuckled breathlessly, and his warm breath against Phainon's tip sent precum flowing down his shaft. “You must've liked that.”

Phainon groaned loudly as Mydei lowered himself on his cock, swallowing his tip and shifting himself lower down his length. His dick breached the insides of Mydei's mouth, and he felt his warm tongue vibrating against his length as Mydei moaned at the sensation of being filled. Phainon was practically pulling and tugging on Mydei's hair as another moan escaped him when he felt his tip hit the back of Mydei's throat, and his face bloomed an even brighter red at the strange noises that kept slipping from his mouth. Yet, another moan escaped him when Mydei began sucking him hard.

“Wait–*mmm!*” Phainon threw his head back with another hard suck, and his eyes rolled back into his head as Mydei began bobbing up and down his length. Phainon could barely register the chandelier lights above him as all he could feel was Mydei's lips against his dick and his tongue running down his shaft, and the only sounds he could hear were the wet slopping noises coming from Mydei's mouth sucking on his cock.

His hips instinctively thrust upward in search for more of Mydei's warmth, eager to go deeper inside his enticing cavern, but Mydei's hands immediately flew to Phainon's hips to pin him down against the bed. Phainon could do nothing as he was held down and at the mercy of the pleasure that continued ripping through his body, and his opened legs

trembled violently around Mydei. The sheets were gathered in a messy bunch in Phainon's fist while his other hand still continued tugging on Mydei’s hair.

Mydei sucked hard around his dick another time, alternating between sucking at the base and sucking at the head, and Phainon swore he was seeing stars rather than chandelier lights. The pace continued increasing as Mydei bobbed his head up and down his shaft, and Phainon fell to his elbows as another groan echoed in the bedroom. Arching his back, Phainon felt that familiar pleasure churn deep in his stomach, and he flexed his abdomen in an attempt to hold himself back from exploding in Mydei's mouth.

“Mydei–*mmm!*–Mydei, I'm cumming–*AHH!*” With Phainon's lips forever parted as another moan escaped his being, he pulled desperately at Mydei's hair in hopes that he would get the message. But, his words only willed Mydei to lower himself even further on his cock, and with another moan from Mydei that reverberated through Phainon's lower half, soon his entire dick was inside Mydei's warm and wet mouth as he sucked hard around him. It was as if Mydei were eager to suck the cum out of his tip that was already dripping precum down his throat.

Tears brimmed the corners of Phainon's eyes as his vision blurred, and blurry stars were the only things he could manage to see above him. His quaking legs spread even wider to allow Mydei even more space on his aching cock, and moan after moan echoed in his chambers as Phainon could no longer hold himself in anymore. With another sharp arch of his back and another loud groan, he spilled himself inside Mydei's mouth, convulsing against the strong hands that kept his hips in place against the sheets.

Riding out his orgasm, Phainon was breathless, and he collapsed into the sheets, untangling his fingers from Mydei's golden strands. With hazy vision as he came down from the best orgasm of his life, he heard a *pop* coming from the base of the bed, and his dick was now brushing against the cool night air flowing through the bedroom.

Phainon had already covered his eyes with the hand that was previously tangled in Mydei's hair, and he was gasping desperately for breath. He felt

the bed dip to his side, and he wearily managed to peak through his hand to see Mydei settling in the empty spot next to him.

“You…” Phainon's voice was destroyed. It was raspy from all the moaning he had done earlier, but he was too tired to even be embarrassed by all the sounds he emitted before. His head was spinning trying to recover from that orgasm, and the lights above him were still just a hazy mess of blurry stars. “Why were you so good at that?”

“I learn well.”

Phainon had barely managed to catch Mydei swipe a thumb under his lips at a stray drop of cum that had escaped his mouth, and he swore that even after all that, he still felt his dick stirring at the seductive sight.

“From who?” Phainon wasn't sure what his voice sounded like at that moment, but he felt the resentment swirling in his chest. He envied the person who was the first to receive from Mydei, and he despised them for even letting someone as beautiful and perfect as Mydei slip away from their grasp.

“Who do you think?” Mydei narrowed his eyes down at him.

“I don't know,” Phainon snapped, and he grimaced at how clearly annoyed he sounded. “Why would I know who your last boyfriends were?”

Mydei hummed. “My last boyfriends, huh?”

“Who else would you learn from, if not them? Where else would you learn how to pleasure a man so well?” Phainon knew he needed to just close his mouth for one single moment, but he couldn't help the jealousy that spilled out of him. Of course it was fine if Mydei had previous relationships, but it still didnt make Phainon feel any better that he wasn't his first. It especially made Phainon feel worse over the fact that Mydei was *his* first. But, for someone as gorgeous as Mydei, of course he would have had previous partners.

“You were my first, HKS.”

Phainon's eyes widened at his words, but he couldn't bring himself to believe such an obvious lie. That was what his attendants had said too, but after that fantastic blowjob, there was no doubt in his mind that Mydei must have had secret partners or something that no one else knew about.

He turned his head to the side, refusing to even look at the stunning man before him. “Yeah, and I'm a king, Mydei.”

A kiss was planted on his temple, and Phainon inwardly scolded himself when his face heated up.

“Did my attendants not tell you that Krateros has been trying to find a partner for me for many years?”

Phainon's head immediately whirled around to face Mydei, and he slightly cowered at how close they had become. He didnt even realize that Mydei was basically leaning over him with his hands placed adjacent to his head, and his golden hair was brushing Phainon's cheeks. “You knew we talked about that?!”

“When you refused to tell me how Krateros came up in conversation, I went ahead and asked my attendants myself.”

“That's–That's cheating!”

“They're *my* attendants, are they not?”

“Then–” Phainon averted his gaze once more, his face growing hotter by the second. He had to go confront Empousa about this later. “–what did you mean by you ‘learn well’? You've never given me a blowjob before, Mydei.”

Mydei sighed. “You thought I had a partner before because I said that?”

“Where else could you learn from if not another person?” Phainon grumbled.

“From *you*, HKS.” Mydei frowned, and Phainon yelped when a flick landed on his forehead. “From all the sounds you made, I obviously learned what

you liked best.”

“From–” Phainon cut himself off as the blush bloomed all the way down to his neck. “*That's* what you meant?! Jeez, Mydei.” Phainon exasperatedly rubbed his hands across his face, eager to wipe himself of, or even hide from, his prior embarrassment.

“So, I only know how to suck your dick and not anyone else’s.”

“Can you not say that so bluntly?”

“It won't get through your thick skull unless I say it this bluntly, HKS.” Another flick against his hand this time, as Phainon's forehead was covered, and he yelped once more.

“So,” Phainon mumbled with his voice muffled, as his face still covered by his hands. He was sure even his chest was red now at the question that kept burning in his mind. “Am I your first then?”

“Isn't that what I just said?” Mydei pecked another kiss where he had flicked Phainon's hand, and Phainon could feel his face burning against his palms. He still couldn't believe that he was Mydei's first ever partner. “And *you* better be my first.”

“Of course you are!” Phainon blurted, pushing his hands aside to stare up at Mydei above him. “I… I actually…”

He turned his head and averted his eyes once more, and he heard Mydei click his tongue in annoyance. “Just spit it out.”

“I don't know how to have sex.” Phainon wished he could turn tail and hide in a corner, or even just run out of the room. But it would take too long for him to gather all his clothes that were now strewn about all over the floor, and it was the only thing that kept Phainon rooted to his spot in the bed as he waited for Mydei's response to his embarrassing statement.

Mydei laughed breathlessly, and Phainon jumped when he felt his warm breath brush against his ear. “Then,” Mydei whispered lowly, “I'll teach

you.”

Phainon had to bite his lip from not moaning on the spot from his husky voice in his ear, but the blood all rushed down to his lower half at Mydei's words.

Chuckling at Phainon's reaction, Mydei smiled against his ear and began pressing tender kisses against him. Phainon moaned softly, shifting his legs to hide the hardness that was now evidently standing tall.

“How do you…” Phainon panted as Mydei began sucking on his earlobe. “If I'm also you're first, then how do you know so much more than me?”

“As part of a noble’s education.” Mydei snaked his tongue out and lapped against Phainon's ear, earning him another moan from the silver-haired man. “I was taught everything. This is just my first time putting it into practice.”

“Everything?” Phainon breathlessly asked, and a whimper escaped him when a hand grasped at the base of his shaft.

“Everything,” Mydei whispered into his ear, and a shiver went down Phainon's spine at his low voice. “On top and on bottom.”

“So, am I–” Phainon's eyes fluttered closed when he felt Mydei's soft lips pressing against his neck underneath his ear. “–am I top? Or am I bottom? I… will be frank that I don't know either.”

Mydei hummed, pressing a hard kiss underneath his ear as he rubbed a single digit against the skin where Phainon's dick met his balls. “Which do you prefer?” He pushed himself up on one elbow until he could make eye contact with Phainon once more as he awaited his response.

“What I prefer?” Phainon's eyes widened. Truly, the thing that mattered to him most was that he was with *Mydei*–whether he was top or bottom, Phainon wasn't sure if that really mattered to him.

“Let me rephrase this.” Mydei's eyes wandered before gluing themselves back onto Phainon. But now, there was a faint splash of red tinting his cheeks. “Did you want to see me underneath you, calling your name? Or, did you want to be pampered by me instead?”

Phainon's heart stopped in his chest. Okay, maybe he *did* have a preference– a very, *very* clear preference.

“I definitely…” Phainon's face grew red as he envisioned the thought. From their previous activities, both Mydei and Phainon had been on top of the other, but in terms of only one of them actually being on the receiving end… Phainon could only imagine golden hair spilling over tan shoulders as his sculpted body was pushed over and over into the bed. He could only imagine loud moans erupting from soft, red lips as he clung onto Phainon's shoulders and clawed marks into his skin.

His dick strained in Mydei's palm, and he faintly heard a chuckle from the other man that broke his thoughts. Before he could answer, Mydei had already settled himself in Phainon's lap. His dick brushed against Mydei's clothed behind as the man above him tugged at the end of Phainon's shirt.

Wordlessly, Phainon raised his arms, and Mydei discarded the black shirt somewhere in the room. The expression on Mydei's face didn't escape Phainon as he eyed his bare torso up and down with golden, half-lidded eyes.

“Like what you see?” Phainon laughed with a smirk plastered on his face as Mydei's hands began to roam his naked body.

With a *hmph* from the golden-haired man, he leaned down and pressed his lips against his once more. The chains along Mydei's body pressed against Phainon's, and he moaned into the kiss at the sensation that continued to tickle his skin. Phainon slid his hands into the cut of Mydei's clothing, rubbing his fingertips along the skin of his thighs and tracing his red tattoos.

Mydei sucked along Phainon's bottom lip, and Phainon moaned, lips parting only for Mydei to invade inside. With their tongues tangling together as they both attempted to invade and explore each other's mouths, Mydei had

wrapped a hand around Phainon's wrist and pulled it behind him until he could feel the curve of Mydei's ass.

“Underneath,” Mydei panted against his lips as he slid both of their hands underneath his himation. Similar to earlier in the day, Mydei wore absolutely nothing underneath his clothing, and Phainon could feel his fingertips brushing against his twitching hole that was situated in between his ample cheeks.

Phainon's face grew hot, his blush creeping down to his chest once more as Mydei pushed his digits against his entrance that seemed to try and suck his fingers inside. He felt the very tip of his finger slip inside, and Phainon swallowed thickly at the thought that he would soon be inside this pulsing and cavernous warmth.

Mydei grunted against his lips, separating himself from the kiss. “It needs to be wetter.”

“...Wetter?” Phainon panted the question, his eyes following the string of saliva that still connected his lips to Mydei's.

Mydei pulled Phainon's fingers from his clothing, and Phainon did try his best not to feel slightly disappointed that he could no longer feel the warmth radiating from his behind. But, that thought quickly flew out the window when Mydei wrapped his lips around Phainon's fingers.

Phainon froze, watching with rigid shoulders as Mydei lapped against his digits, coating them as fruitfully as possible. He sucked against his knuckles, sinking his fingers inside the warmth of his mouth. He could feel his tongue weaving between his fingers, and he could feel his hot breath every time Mydei panted for air.

With a *pop*, Mydei released his fingers and brought them back down to his entrance. Phainon's heart beat erratically against his ribcage as Mydei pushed one of his coated fingers inside, and Phainon could truly feel his pulsing warmth against his digit.

“Move,” Mydei panted as he maneuvered his hips against Phainon's finger.

Phainon wasn't sure what he was supposed to be doing, but he did as best as he could. With his pounding heart continuing to take over his sense of hearing, he sank his finger deeper inside Mydei's warmth. His face flushed with every squelch of his hole as Phainon began pumping his finger up and down inside of Mydei. He couldn't get over the feeling of this ring of muscle that continually pulsed around his finger, twitching with every movement that occurred deep inside.

He glanced at Mydei's expression to gauge how he was feeling, and the man had fisted the sheets underneath Phainon with his eyes fluttered closed. His bruised lips were parted as he panted for breath, and his back arched the deeper Phainon ventured inside.

Phainon pulled his finger out, hitting the clothing that still hung loosely around Mydei's waist. Mydei opened his eyes at the sudden loss inside of him, and he opened his mouth only for a loud moan to erupt from his lips instead when Phainon shoved two fingers inside.

His fingers slipped inside with such ease–with so much ease that Phainon doubted this was Mydei's first time. Narrowing his eyes, he sharply pushed his fingers inside, and another wanton moan escaped from Mydei's throat.

“Are all men this loose?” Phainon began pumping his fingers in and out of Mydei, and strings of moans and gasps spilled from the man above him. Hands grasped tightly on Phainon's shoulders as Mydei began riding his fingers, desperately pushing back against his digits and arching his back in an attempt for him to go deeper. Phainon genuinely wasn't sure if Mydei was really just made for this or if all men were really just this easy to go inside. He had never touched another person's entrance, after all.

“I–*mmm!*” Mydei had attempted to explain, but another moan slipped from his lips as he pushed himself up into a sitting position and continued riding Phainon's digits. In an uncontrollable manner, Mydei's hips couldn't stop moving as his pulsing insides continued to suck Phainon deeper and deeper inside.

His thighs began shaking around Phainon, and the himation in front of Phainon's eyes began to stain against his dripping tip as it strained against

the loose clothing. Phainon could so clearly see the curve of his cock's tip as it pushed so roughly against the fabric with every one of Mydei's thrusts, and Phainon's own dick strained and twitched with every accidental brush from Mydei's erratic movements.

Phainon added a third finger, and a loud moan echoed in his ears as Mydei jolted in his lap. His golden eyes were rolled into the back of his head as his golden hair clung to the sweat dripping down his torso. With parted lips that spilled sweet moans over and over again with every thrust of his own hips, Phainon was sure Mydei had completely forgotten his question as he was now a slave to the pleasure erupting in his core. He watched the chains jingle around his torso with every bounce, and he watched Mydei's abdomen desperately flexing as he tried to stave away his oncoming orgasm. The more Phainon watched the man bouncing in his lap, chasing pleasure from the fingers that breached his insides, the more Phainon could feel his own pleasure swirling in the pit of his stomach.

With Mydei sucking his fingers deeper inside, Phainon wanted to feel more of Mydei. Pushing his fingers with each one of Mydei's thrusts, he began curling and stretching his fingers, brushing his fingertips against the pulsating walls that surrounded him in warmth. It wasn't until Phainon had curled his fingers a certain way did he feel something different, but before he could even begin to describe what he had felt so deep inside Mydei's hole, the man above him jolted violently.

"*Phainon!*" Mydei whined. His arms gave out and he collapsed onto Phainon's chest, and Phainon swore he almost came just from how his name was so sweetly called. He stilled his fingers as Mydei came, spilling his cum onto their abdomens as his dick had slipped out of his loose clothing. His warm insides throbbed violently around Phainon, and as he was pulling his digits out from inside, Mydei's entrance had fluttered in an attempt to suck him back inside. Phainon could only swallow dryly and ignore his body, pulling his fingers out before he actually shoved them back inside.

Mydei was panting for breath against Phainon, but Phainon was trying his utmost to ignore Mydei's hard nipples that kept brushing against his with every breath. Soon, the both of them were panting for air but for completely different reasons, as Phainon was trying to think of anything except for

burying himself inside of Mydei's warm entrance or the buds on his chest that kept pressing against him. He felt like it was his second day of meeting Mydei once again where he had recited the Code of Chivalry in hopes of forgetting about his straining erection.

With one last deep breath, Mydei pushed himself up, staring down at Phainon with a hazy gaze. Swallowing, Mydei barely managed, “You questioned me for being able to pleasure you, yet I should be the one questioning you over how you fingered me so well.”

Phainon laughed, slipping his fingers inside the cutouts near his hips and rubbing circles into the skin. “I just have a good teacher.”

In one swift motion, Phainon flipped Mydei onto his back, ensuring that he landed safely on the mattress underneath them. Phainon crawled between Mydei's open legs after throwing his trousers off somewhere on the floor, watching how Mydei’s face grew a deep crimson.

“HKS,” Mydei mumbled and averted his gaze. He hated how that explicit display of strength made him immediately hard again. He could've never imagined that someone could so easily spin him around, and the feeling turned Mydei on extremely so.

“Are you going to answer me now?” Phainon slid the fabric to the side, eyes dilating as he stared at the wet entrance that was revealed to him under his clothing. Dragging his fingertips along his twitching entrance and occasionally feeling his fingers dip inside, Phainon repeated his previous question: “Are all men this loose down here, or is it just you?”

Silence followed his question, and Phainon had to, regrettably, tear his eyes and fingers away from the clenching hole to gauge Mydei's reaction. But, the man was bright red, and he had covered the frown on his lips with his hand as he stared straight at the bedroom wall next to them.

“Mydei?”

He mumbled something, but Phainon couldn't hear anything behind his hand. He grasped a hand against Mydei's wrist, but Mydei refused to tear

his hand away.

“Mydei, I can't hear–”

“–to you.”

Phainon raised an eyebrow. “Can you say that again?”

He saw Mydei grimace underneath his hand. Refusing to tear his eyes away from the wall, he practically shouted at him: “I touched myself to you.”

“To *me?!*” Phainon shouted back, eyes widening. He almost toppled off the edge of the bed from the news.

Mydei's blush only crept lower down his chest, and Phainon could see his throat bobbing at the thought. “Every night in Okhema that you weren't here.”

“Every… night…” Phainon's face flushed as he recalled the last few days. He had slept in Mydei’s bed only one night, last night, which was the night of their third day. Which meant the nights of their first and second day…

“Wait.” Phainon shook his head. “I watched you fall asleep on the second day.”

Mydei clicked his tongue in annoyance, finally meeting Phainon's gaze. “I didn't fall asleep; you had just assumed so.”

“So–” Phainon was breathless as his brain was running on overdrive. “–you touched yourself to me after I left that night?”

Mydei narrowed his eyes, averting his gaze once again as silence fell over them. Phainon sat there, in between Mydei's spread legs, absolutely dumbstruck as he recalled their last few days together.

“I'm not the only one?” Phainon muttered as his eyes wandered the wrinkled sheets they were laying on.

“Not the only one?”

Phainon's eyes shot up to meet golden, and he immediately realized that he had accidentally said that out loud. With a sheepish laugh, Phainon could only avert his gaze. “I… uh… . I… “

“Which night?”

“The second night.” Phainon snapped his mouth closed. Why did he just automatically answer?

“So, you got hard after watching me bathe that night, and you immediately left my bedroom to get yourself off.”

“Was I supposed to tell you I got turned on watching you get naked and wanted to touch you on our second night?!”

“Why else did you think I stripped in front of you that night?!”

Phainon's jaw went slack at the sudden confession. “You… wanted to sleep with me that night?”

“Why else would I invite you into my private quarters just to watch me bathe?” Mydei huffed, sinking his head into the bed. “I can't believe you left to go get yourself off while I was also in here, getting myself off at the same time.”

He swallowed thickly once again, recalling the night when he had masturbated in the public baths to Mydei. But now he knew that Mydei was doing the same thing at the exact same time in his bedroom that Phainon had just departed from.

“Is that why you couldn't look at me yesterday?”

Phainon flinched at the question, dropping his gaze to the bed. “How could I even stand to look at you after masturbating to a king?”

Mydei sighed once more. “Then what about now? Are you going to leave me like this?”

Picking his gaze up once more to take in the sight that Mydei was referring to, Phainon practically became hypnotized by the view. It was exactly as Phainon had pictured: Mydei, with his hair spilling all over the sheets that they had just dirtied; with sweat dripping down his torso and being caught in the golden chains that adorned his body; his bruised, red lips that were slightly parted; and his spread legs that revealed his enticing entrance that waited for Phainon's length.

He cleared his throat as he was so obviously staring at the man, shifting himself upward until he was face to face with Mydei. “Why did you ask me what I preferred when you so obviously like it back here?”

Mydei gasped sharply when he felt Phainon's tip brushing against his hole, and his entrance clenched hungrily against it. “I thought to be generous and give you a choice, seeing as you were so hesitant to sleep with me because of your lack of experience.”

Phainon hummed, slightly shifting his hips so his dick continued to tease his clenching hole. “You should've just told me you liked it back here more.”

Scoffing, Mydei rolled his eyes. “Says the one who refused to tell me anything before.”

Phainon's shoulders shook with laughter. He couldn't exactly refute Mydei's words as he was plenty correct. Refusing to give him an answer, Phainon grasped Mydei's hips through the cutouts of his clothes, rubbing his shaft against his entrance. He watched with narrowed eyes as he dragged his cock up and down Mydei's entrance, and his greedy hole clenched around nothing as he was eager to have Phainon deep inside. He still couldn't believe that in just a few moments, Mydei would be letting Phainon inside that delicious warmth that he had felt with his fingers earlier.

“Just put it inside,” Mydei snapped impatiently after a few moments of Phainon admiring his glistening entrance. He glared up at Phainon and threw his legs around Phainon's waist to pull him closer.

With another laugh, Phainon took the base of his dick, and with a deep breath to steel himself, he slipped himself inside. Mesmerized, he watched as the tip of his dick disappeared inside Mydei's entrance, and a low groan escaped Mydei's chest at the feeling of finally being filled. Phainon was conflicted as his eyes fluttered between his dick that continued to sink inside Mydei’s burning and pulsing hole and Mydei’s expression that was full of ecstasy: his mouth parted wide open as his eyes rolled into the back of his head with a blush that spread all the way down his neck. Mydei's hands flew to Phainon's shoulders, sinking his nails into his skin once Phainon's hips had become flush with Mydei's behind.

Phainon was panting hard, trying his best to stay still even if Mydei's warm hole kept fluttering and twitching around his hard length. He wasn't sure if he should just start moving now or if Mydei needed time to adjust, but the longer Phainon had to wait, the more his mind became numb to the heat that tightly surrounded his dick. He tried to ignore how his cock pulsed and ached inside Mydei's insides, desperate for friction.

He placed his hands under Mydei’s knees to shift his body upward, spreading his legs wide and getting a clear view of where his dick disappeared inside Mydei. With a soft whimper, Mydei's body was pulled down the bed as his legs were pulled up into the air.

Pushing Mydei's body against the sheets, Phainon tested a thrust, pulling himself out until only his tip was left inside of Mydei before quickly sinking his entire length back into his warmth. His face burned red when their skin slapped against each other, and it had basically resounded throughout the whole room. But Mydei's moan was even louder as he threw his head back with his legs trembling in Phainon's grasp.

“More,” Mydei faintly gasped as he clawed against the choker that was still around Phainon's neck. “Deeper, Phainon.”

“*Hah…*” It was like a spell had broken inside of Phainon, and he roughly pulled out and shoved himself deep inside Mydei's greedy hole. Mydei moaned loudly as Phainon continued ramming himself inside his warmth without any mercy, spreading Mydei’s legs wide to hit every angle inside of

him. Mydei's legs shook in the air, toes clenching at nothing as Phainon leaned forward to sink himself deeper and deeper inside his wet hole.

"*Mmm!* Phainon, Phainon! *Ohh! Yes!"* Mydei scratched and clawed all over Phainon's back the deeper his dick breached inside, and Mydei spread his legs as wide in the air as he could to allow Phainon more space to pummel inside.

Phainon felt like his dick was melting, as Mydei's warm and wet hole perfectly clenched around him, sucking him inside and pulsating against his own needy dick. The sounds of their love-making echoed loudly in the room, with Mydei's whimpers and moans loudly resounding with the creaks of the mahogany bed frame that continually hit against the wall with every thrust. Phainon couldn't help moaning and grunting as well at this newfound feeling of pleasure that he could've never imagined before.

Mydei burrowed his face into the crook of Phainon's neck, his warm breath spreading through Phainon's body as he moaned and gasped against his skin. Phainon continued to push his hips forward, thrusting into Mydei and becoming addicted to the sound of their bare skin slapping against each other. The golden chains jingled with every thrust as they brushed against Mydei's chest, and the himation around his waist became tangled with the stained sheets.

Phainon couldn't stop his hips even if he wanted to; he was too far gone with how his cock slammed inside Mydei's hole and the pleasure that erupted from each thrust. Pleasure began building in his core, and Phainon continued to chase after that feeling of electricity tingling down his legs from his dick. He had no idea this was how sex felt with someone else–he could've never have begun to imagine this indescribable feeling of being inside someone else, and it didn't even compare to getting off by oneself. He was addicted, and he wanted to keep thrusting inside of Mydei all night long if all he felt was this pleasure that continually ran throughout his limbs.

Sweat began dripping down his forehead, and a deep groan slipped from Phainon's throat when Mydei had tightened around him. He watched below him as Mydei had thrown his head back, red lips parted to release moan

after moan into the night air. Clinging tightly to Phainon's shoulders, Phainon watched as Mydei's hard and gorgeous dick slapped against his own abdomen with every thrust of Phainon's hips, adding to the sounds that reverberated through the room. His eyes were closed tight as he succumbed to the pleasure that filled him inside, and his abdomen flexed and lips quivered every time Phainon sank himself especially deep inside Mydei's warmth.

Grasping tightly on Mydei's hips through the cutouts of his himation, Phainon rammed himself deeper inside over and over, using Mydei's hips to maneuver his body against him. His eyes were glued to Mydei’s entrance, watching as his length continued going in and out of Mydei repeatedly. Phainon still felt like he was in a daze over the fact that he was actually having sex with Mydei, and his dick was pulsing violently inside at the thought. He could feel himself trying to hold himself back from exploding inside of Mydei.

With his thrusts becoming erratic, Phainon was inching closer to his release. He shifted one of his thrusts upward, and Mydei suddenly screamed into the air, arching his back as cum flowed from his tip and splashed onto their torsos. He tightened dangerously around Phainon, and Phainon could no longer hold back as he moaned loudly, slamming his hips against Mydei and spilling himself inside of his deep hole. Phainon watched Mydei's flushed expression and quivering lips as he slowed his hips, thrusting softly inside of Mydei as they both rode out their orgasms together. He couldn't even believe that Mydei had cum untouched, but he also couldn't believe that he had accidentally cum inside of Mydei. He had meant to pull out once he was about to cum, but Mydei unexpectedly clenching around him made Phainon cum earlier than he had expected.

“Sorry,” Phainon panted, swallowing to moisten his dry throat from all the noises he kept releasing.

“You…” Mydei gasped for breath as he came down from his high. He glared up at Phainon, but it wasn't very convincing with how red his face was and how dilated his golden eyes were. “Better not be apologizing again while you are still inside of me.”

Phainon laughed breathlessly, pulling his cock out from Mydei's fluttering entrance, but his laughter came to a halt when he saw his cum oozing out of his clenching hole. He swallowed dryly, watching how the cum dripped down his entrance and pooled onto the bed. “I meant… sorry for… cumming inside.”

“You don't look sorry.”

“I'm really–”

“I wouldn't have let you cum outside.”

Phainon's body grew rigid at his words, and his already flushed face burned even more. He couldn't even believe he was hard again after hearing Mydei's words, but here he was, with his half-hard dick brushing against Mydei's thighs.

“I… Sorry, I–”

Mydei smirked, wrapping his legs around Phainon's waist once more and pulling him down until their lips were but a breath away. “Again, Phainon.”

With the blood rushing down to his dick, he flipped Mydei over so that his back faced the ceiling and he was on all fours. Before Mydei could turn around and retort, he shoved his dick back inside of Mydei's eager hole, and Mydei groaned, burying his face into the sheets as he arched his back and fully presented himself to Phainon.

“Fuck, Phainon. *Ohh!”* Mydei moaned when Phainon began rocking his hips once more. He tightened around Phainon's dick as he soon resumed his breaking pace, skin slapping against skin echoing in their ears once more, and the bed continued creaking on its wooden legs. Phainon pushed the himation aside, watching his dick ram in and out of Mydei's entrance. With the cum that was still inside of Mydei, the noises of his hole grew louder as the squelching reverberated through Phainon's brain, and Phainon was eager to see just how loud his entrance could be.

He pushed himself forward, remembering that sweet spot that had made Mydei scream. Angling himself while trying to recall that spot, he knew he had succeeded when he grimaced, throwing his head forward when Mydei screamed once more and clenched tightly around Phainon.

“PHAINON!” Mydei's legs shook violently underneath him as he collapsed onto his elbows. His legs barely kept him up, but Phainon was mostly lifting him up by his hips.

“You like it here?” Phainon thrust sharply once more against that spot, and another wanton moan ripped through the air.

“*OHH!* Yes, Phainon, right there!”

Chuckling, Phainon rammed himself forward, pinning Mydei against the bed as he succumbed to the pleasure blooming in his lower half. Moan after moan erupted from his throat with each thrust from Phainon, and he clawed at the sheets underneath them as he fisted them tightly.

Phainon swallowed thickly at the saliva that pooled underneath Mydei's parted lips that were pressed against the bed, and it only spurred him to quicken his pace against Mydei's sweet spot. His golden eyes were rolled into the back of his head as his insides sporadically convulsed under the pressure and pace of Phainon's dick.

He swept Mydei's hair to the side, pressing a tender kiss to his shoulder that completely contrasted the breaking pace in which he slammed inside of Mydei. Phainon worked his way down, pressing his palms against the bed as Mydei flattened against the sheets. He was no longer able to hold himself up without Phainon supporting him, and he yielded to the pleasure of Phainon's dick ramming inside of his unquenchable hole. Mydei's body was pushed further into the bed with every thrust, and his dick tangled with the sheets underneath him as precum spread from his tip to stain the bed. It was hard for him to breathe with the way he was being stimulated both in the front and behind.

Sprinkling kisses down his back, Phainon moaned against his skin when Mydei had considerably tightened up even more so around Phainon, so

much so that he had stopped thrusting to hold himself back from cumming once again inside of Mydei.

“Do you… like it here?” Phainon hesitantly pressed near the middle of Mydei's back, and the man groaned loudly as his hole clenched dangerously tight around Phainon's length. His hips jerked wildly, and Mydei was left gasping for breath from a simple touch to his back.

“*Phainon*,” Mydei whined, and Phainon froze at his voice. These new sides of Mydei that Phainon was witnessing in bed would be something that he would repeat in his mind for the rest of his life.

“Yes, Mydei?”

Mydei threw a hand back, searching for something as he pushed himself back onto all fours. Phainon offered his hand to Mydei, who immediately snatched at his wrist to press his fingertips against the middle of his back once more.

“Again.”

Phainon grinned, pressing his digits hard against his back. Mydei gasped sharply, arching his back and pushing his ass back against Phainon's hips.

“Good–*ohh!* More, deeper, Phainon.” Mydei panted, glancing over his shoulder and sending the most desperate golden eyes that Phainon had ever seen.

Who was Phainon to refuse?

Phainon snapped his hips against Mydei's ass, and Mydei's elbows buckled as he fell face-first into the sheets. A scream ripped from Mydei's throat when Phainon pressed against the spot on his back once again, massaging his digits into the skin and kissing and sucking around the spot on his back. Even though he was told that Mydei's body could never be marked, he was eager to leave evidence of their love-making against his back, and he roughly sucked and lapped at his skin along his sweet spot.

“*OHH!* Phainon, yes! Just like that! *AHH!*” Mydei was rocked into the bed, golden hair flying into his face as his lower half became numb from pleasure. He was sure he was cumming, but he couldn't even tell as Phainon had never broken his pace. He didn't even have a chance to breathe and recover from his orgasm before Phainon was pummeling once more against his twitching prostate, and the overstimulation left Mydei gasping and panting for breath.

With his cum now all over the sheets underneath him and Mydei’s body jerking violently from the overstimulation, Phainon didn't even notice. He kept massaging that sweet spot on his back, pressing his dick deeper against his sweet spot inside, and every thrust made his aching dick brush against the soaked mattress underneath him. Mydei couldn't help the moans that kept slipping from his throat, and they turned into embarrassing whines and whimpers over the overstimulation. His face grew hot, but he couldn't stop the whimpers as his sweet spots were repeatedly ravaged over and over again. Even his dick began to stir again at the pleasure that he was continually hit with.

His back arched even more with another moan as he heard Phainon moan his name loudly above him, stilling his hips and spilling himself once more inside. Mydei felt he could cum again just from the feeling of being filled to the brim with Phainon’s cum, and he whined at the feeling of Phainon's cum spilling deep inside of him. He could feel Phainon's dick pulsing and twitching inside of his hole as the last of his load released into him.

Phainon collapsed on top of Mydei, heaving breaths as he overcame his third orgasm of the night. As much as he wanted to stay encompassed inside of Mydei's warmth that kept fluttering around his dick even after he had finished cumming, he regrettably pulled himself out, flipping himself over so that his back lay on the bed. He stared up at the chandelier lights, dizzy after three orgasms, but he didn't get to stare for long before a weight shifted on top of his lap and covered the chandelier that was suspended from the ceiling.

“Done already?” Mydei, with his husky voice, tilted his head to the side, and Phainon noticed that he had rid his lower half of the himation. He was sure the fabric was already soiled anyway.

Phainon laughed breathlessly, bringing his hands to the side of Mydei's thighs and grasping tightly. “If you're not tired, then I'm not tired.”

Mydei smirked, bringing a finger underneath Phainon's choker and pulling him upward until he was now sitting upright in the bed. “Are we seeing who lasts longer tonight?”

“It'll definitely be me.” Phainon jutted his chin upwards, brushing his lips against Mydei's. He was still panting for breath, and Mydei's warm breaths danced along his lips.

“*Hah!*” Mydei scoffed. “Overconfident, for someone who was too scared to have sex with me earlier.”

“I don't seem to recall.” Phainon hummed, slipping himself inside of Mydei's warm entrance that was now perfectly stretched out to fit the shape of Phainon's cock. He ignored the gasps and groans from the golden-haired man as he continued to ease himself inside the hole that kept dripping his cum onto Phainon's thighs. “Are you ready to lose tonight, Mydei?”

“I should be asking you that question.” The statement would've seemed more convincing if he was not quivering in Phainon's lap. His legs shook as his ass met Phainon's thighs, and he took his length in even deeper than usual. Their position perfectly made his dick brush against his prostate, and Mydei had to stifle some more whimpers the more Phainon's dick twitched against that spot deep inside.

Phainon hummed once more, settling his hands onto Mydei's waist and thrusting upwards. Mydei's eyes widened with a choked gasp as it hit right against his prostate, and Phainon soon began pushing himself against that same spot, emitting more wanton moans from the man above him as he bounced up and down in his lap, his golden hair spilling all over his shoulders and becoming tangled with his body chain.

“*Mmm! Ohh*, Phainon!” Mydei moaned, completely succumbing to ecstasy as he bounced on Phainon's lap once more, the noises of their skinship rebounding off the bedroom walls. “You feel so good, *OHH!* So good right here!”

“Right here, Mydei?” Phainon panted, angling every thrust against that spot he knew Mydei loved. “You feel good right here?”

“*AHH! YES!”* Mydei threw his head back as Phainon sank especially deep inside of Mydei's greedy hole. He began rambling sweet nothings to Phainon that he didn't know spilled from his lips: “You're so good, Phainon! *OHH!* Such a good boy–so good for me! You feel so–*AHH!–GOOD!”*

Phainon gritted his teeth, and his grasp against his waist tightened. He was sure it would've left marks if Mydei wasn't so magically gifted. He thrust sharply inside of Mydei at his words, quickening his breaking pace as his needy dick breached even deeper inside.

“*MMM!*” Mydei gasped. He barely managed to laugh as Phainon erratically quickened his pace, and he had figured out what he had done. “Did you like that, Phainon? Being–*mmph!*–called a good boy?”

Phainon groaned deeply, roughly shoving Mydei down into the bed and hammering violently inside his squelching hole. Mydei's back hit the bed as his trembling legs were spread wide into the air. His insides were pummeled violently with no room for breath, and the pit of his stomach churned in pleasure at being manhandled so roughly.

“*OHH!* PHAINON! *YES!* Such a good boy for me. You make me feel so good, Phainon! *OHH!*” Mydei was running out of praises, but the man above him was taking in every single one. He could feel Phainon's dick pulsing sporadically inside as he propelled himself further and further inside of Mydei, even breaching a part of him that Mydei had never reached before. The more the squelching of his hole echoed in Mydei's ears and the more the bed creaked and groaned under the weight of their activities, the more something began churning in the pit of his stomach that was unlike his previous orgasms.

“*AHH! AHH! AHH!* PHAINON, WAIT–” Mydei tried to push the man off, but to no avail. His limbs felt like jelly, and they refused to work after being treated so forcefully by the other man. And, Phainon wasn't even listening to him anymore, as the praises were the only thing swirling through his mind.

Phainon swore he almost came with every praise that spilled from Mydei's lips. Every word tingled in Phainon's brain, and he was desperate to hear more from the man underneath him who was now spilling tears down his face and moaning at the top of his lungs. His stomach churned for more pleasure, and his ears ached to hear more from his golden-haired lover.

He sank his teeth on the crook of Mydei's neck, earning another moan and a jolt underneath him. Continuing to thrust into Mydei's warm cavern, he planted kisses and marks all along his neck, collarbones, and chest. Sucking and biting at his skin, he lapped at the red buds that were just asking to be teased.

"*MMM!* PHAINON!" Mydei arched his back with another loud moan, and his hips and legs continued trembling violently around Phainon as he hammered against his sweet spot that kept fluttering and twitching with every thrust. He ran his tongue along the bud, swirling one with his tongue and grazing his teeth against the hardened nipple. He brought a hand up to pinch and twist at one bud as he went to work on the other with his mouth.

Phainon snaked his other hand behind Mydei's arched back, massaging that spot that he had pointed out earlier, and an aggressive shiver ran down his spine as he was stimulated all over his body.

"*AHH! OHH!"* Mydei ignored how his stomach twisted at this new sensation as his golden eyes rolled into the back of his head. His bottom half was numb with pleasure as his prostate was treated so aggressively over and over again, and his back arched even more so as Phainon pushed his digits against the middle of his back. Precum continued spilling from his tip, smearing between their torsos the more Phainon pushed himself inside of Mydei and pressed their bodies together. Mydei could feel his dick rutting up against Phainon's sculpted abdomen, and the feeling of his dick sliding on his muscles sent Mydei into another level of pleasure.

Praises began spilling from Mydei's lips once more, spurring Phainon even faster. The bed groaned under his breaking pace as he heard Mydei's moans increase even louder, until they had essentially become a mix of screams and whines.

“Phainon, PHAINON!” Mydei whined. It felt almost like he was going to cum, but at the same time, it didn't feel like that at all. “WAIT! *OHHH!* PHAINON–*AHH, AHH, AHH!* IM–IM–”

A scream ripped through Mydei's throat as his body jolted harder than he ever had that night. His legs shook wildly in the air, and he desperately grasped at the sheets underneath him to still his convulsing body as he moaned loudly. His hips wouldn't stop shaking as he spilled himself, spraying between his and Phainon's torsos as his insides violently fluttered and twitched around Phainon's dick that was now spilling inside of him once more.

Phainon grimaced as he slammed his hips to a stop, watching as Mydei came the hardest he ever had that night. With Mydei's entrance quivering and clenching entrance around his dick, Phainon came once more inside, unsure of how much cum a human body could take. As he was overcoming his high, he watched Mydei in a complete daze. He was somehow still cumming as his body twitched and jerked underneath him, and his fluids sprayed between them. Phainon was more shocked about the fact that it was so clear.

“Mydei?” Phainon hesitantly opened his mouth, calling to the man who looked like he just passed out. His lips were parted, panting for breath, and Phainon watched his chest rise and fall with every gasp. He couldn't see his eyes as they were covered by a messy head of golden hair.

“I told you… to stop, HKS.” Mydei weakly shoved Phainon's shoulder, and Phainon breathed a sigh of relief–he sounded okay, at least. But, he needed to ask Mydei what he had just cum later.

“Are you conceding defeat then?” Phainon dazedly glanced down at Mydei, ignoring the mess that Mydei had made as the sheets they were laying on were quite literally drenched. “Is this my victory?”

Mydei scoffed immediately, wrapping his arms around Phainon's neck and pulling him down. He answered resolutely, “Not a chance.”

Phainon laughed as he was pulled down, planting a deep kiss upon his lips as he felt his soft golden hair brush against his face. This was going to be an extremely long night.

Itinerary Day 5: Rest Day

The entire Marmoreal Palace was in absolute chaos. As the royal ball was a time where royal guests from all over Amphoreus gathered in one place, despite the heavy workload that went into preparing the ball, it was worth the effort, as they were able to hear all the exclusive news that only people working within the palace would be able to hear. Every royal ball, a new stream of gossip flowed among the servants, and the workers all looked forward to what would happen at this next ball.

Though, no one could have ever expected what the hot new topic was this time.

“There's no way, right?!”

“She must be joking!”

“She said she witnessed it herself, just this Entry Hour.”

“Is she truly assigned to their rooms?”

“Someone needs to go check!”

Whispers upon whispers erupted among all the workers of the palace. Maids, butlers, chefs, and guards were all in an uproar over this new, hot scoop that was occurring right before their very eyes.

Most of the royal guests continued sleeping until later in the day because the royal ball usually ended very late. Thus, every Entry Hour following the ball, it was common courtesy to bring breakfast to all the guests’ rooms rather than have them come down to the dining hall. A tray of various teas, desserts, and savory bites would be delivered to the doors of every guest. And, even if the guests were not awake, after three knocks and still no answer, the maid would quietly bring the food in, place it upon a table near the bed, and quickly step out.

However, one maid had rushed down to the kitchen in an absolute frenzy, her cheeks flushed a bright red as she had basically hurled her tray back onto a counter. The chefs were all yelling at her that the food takes a long time to prepare and to bring it back up, but the maid could not bring herself to return to the corridor, which she was assigned to.

“Phainon and the King of Kremnos are sleeping together!”

The news spread like absolute wildfire. The King of Kremnos, who was making his official debut outside of his kingdom, was very well-known for his strength and valor. He was an intimidating presence, with his cold gaze and his obvious show of power, and the servants always kept to themselves whenever he was around. Although he had never treated anyone in the palace with disrespect, no one was willing to be the first person to get on his bad side.

And Phainon, the man who was known all throughout Okhema. He was a hero who worked closely with the ruler of Okhema, Miss Aglaea. But, he was more than just her guard; he never hesitated to help anyone, regardless of status and regardless of the reward. He completed all of his quests faithfully and truthfully, and his success rate was near one hundred percent. It was why everyone called him the *Deliverer*. Phainon could do almost any impossible feat and could fulfill the hopes and dreams of anyone. He had even slain a dragon, as he had traveled to Styxia long ago to aid in the quest to slay Pollux.

Everyone in Okhema Kingdom knew of Phainon. He was kind, loyal, intelligent, strong, and most of all, he was the most dashing, eligible bachelor among the maids. Almost every maid fell for the sight of him and his radiant smile, and every new maid that was hired in the palace is immediately given some palace ground rules, with one of them being:

“Do not ever approach Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

He was held on a pedestal, hailed to be beloved by all. If anyone could be crowned a knight without noble blood, the first person in line would be Phainon. The only thing stopping him from achieving so much greatness was his blood, and all of the common citizens in Okhema despised the

Council of Elders for that reason, as the Council of Elders only focused on representing the nobility. Phainon represented the common people, and it was he who gave all the commoners hope that, no matter one's blood or background, one could still become a hero known throughout the land. The commoners all hailed him as their true hero, and it was for this reason that he was absolutely off-limits to everyone. For someone who has achieved so much greatness in life, he is a man who should be appreciated and loved by all and never by just one.

For both the famous King of Kremnos and Phainon to be entangled in a rumor together was already news in and of itself, but for the rumor to be *that* kind of rumor–at this point, it was hard to even believe. They all knew Phainon was tasked with accompanying the Kremnoan envoys as their guard, but never in a millennium would they have expected *this* kind of development.

“It's true!” That maid meekly claimed, as all palace workers alike surrounded her. “You can go up to their room and check yourself! You don't even have to go in. You could press your ear against the door and hear everything! No one answered my three knocks, so I tried to bring the food inside only to run into them… them… As they were…” The maid's face bloomed a bright red once more as she shut her eyes. She couldn't wipe the memory from her mind even if she tried.

The maids all rushed in, eager to learn more about Phainon and the King of Kremnos.

“Who was on top?!”

“It's totally the King of Kremnos, right?”

“Wouldn't it be an amazing twist if Phainon was on top?! It would be like a love story!”

“Get out of your head; this is reality! What kind of king would want to be taken by a mere guard?”

“It's not a mere guard; it's *Phainon*.”

“If anyone could top a king, it would be Phainon!”

“It totally depends! Is Phainon well-endowed?!”

“What if they both are?! What then?!”

“They both definitely are.”

“Phainon is definitely skilled in the bedroom, right?”

“Phainon is skilled at everything!”

“What about the King of Kremnos?”

“Hey, tell me, was the King of Kremnos enjoying himself?!”

“Listen here–the King of Kremnos was definitely on top!”

“I am betting on my day's supper it was Phainon!”

The maids all bickered amongst each other as they began betting their day's food and their day's responsibilities, and they even began creating elaborate love stories about how they had gotten together in just five days.

“I bet even the King of Kremnos could not resist Phainon’s charms and had fallen in love with him.”

“No, no! Phainon definitely angered the King and had to pay him back with his body.”

“Oh, please! I can't imagine Phainon ever disobeying someone's orders, so how could he go about angering the King?”

“I actually witnessed Phainon angering the King the other day! The King had ordered Phainon to dine with him, but Phainon had explicitly missed suppertime. The King was *beyond* furious with him.”

“I'm telling you! Phainon had to appease him with his body! Phainon definitely knows what he is doing in bed.”

“Knowing Phainon, he definitely helped the King of Kremnos overcome his trauma of losing his family, and the King fell in love with him from that moment on.”

“Oh, that's a good one!”

“That sounds just like Phainon!”

“He definitely comforted him with his body!”

The first maid quietly slipped away as the maids continued to argue about and theorize their relationship. She hadn't meant to blurt out Phainon's relationship status to the entire palace, but she was so flustered that it had come out of her mouth without her permission. But, how could anyone blame her? She hadn't expected the sight that she saw when she opened the door in her entire lifetime.

The sun was beginning to peek through the windows as it was the middle of Entry Hour, and she stood at the entrance of the open door, shocked into a stupor, as Phainon had the King bent over on the bed as they continued their activities, neither of them noticing the newcomer in the room. Their clothes were strewn all over the floor, and the sheets were stained beyond a degree that the maid had never seen before in all her time as a palace maid. And the sounds… The sounds that filled her ears were so, so lewd, and she had barely managed to shut the door behind her without a sound before dashing back down to the kitchen. They still echoed in her mind without her permission: The sound of the bed creaking under their weight; the sound of wet skin slapping against skin; and even the pants and moans that came from both of the men on the bed that filled the entire room. Her face bloomed once more as she violently shook her head, desperate to rewind the last few quints of her life before she knew what Phainon and the King of Kremnos were like in bed.

She had been somewhat close to Phainon during the past few days, as her schedule mostly lined up with the Kremnoan's schedule. She was the maid who had fetched them when supper was ready while they were sparring in the training grounds, and she had searched up and down for Phainon when he had skipped dinner and angered the King. She was also in the dining hall

as the King was scolding him for missing dinner. She was one of the maids in charge of cleaning the Kremnoans' rooms, and she had noticed on the fourth day that someone else had stayed with the King on the night of the third day. So, she had seen quite a bit of their interactions. And from what she has seen, it was quite evident that the two were very fond of each other. She just could never have imagined that their fondness had blossomed into something more.

But, at this moment, as she had already seen all that there was to see between Phainon and the King of Kremnos–perhaps a little too much to see, only one thought burned at the forefront of her mind as she paced back and forth within the kitchen.

How long were they going to go at it? And, when were they going to stop so she could bring their breakfast up to them?!

She had been going up every single quint since her first visit, pressing her ear and listening through the door for signs of activity. And, every single time, they did not have a break. The chefs did find the whole situation amusing, so at least they were no longer annoyed that she was not able to deliver their food to them. But, she really just wanted to be able to get this tray out of the way, and it was usually not recommended to leave it on the floor by their door in case another passerby or even the guest in the room stepped on it.

How much stamina did these men have?!

It was Lucid Hour now, and she was pressing her ear against the door to no avail once again, as the men were just as active as ever. With the blood rushing to her face as she could so clearly imagine the scene in her mind, a sigh escaped her.

As she was about to turn around and return to the kitchen, she jumped when she locked eyes with one of the Kremnoan attendants who had just exited their quarters next door.

"I–I apologize!" The maid squeaked at the attendant. She looked so big and intimidating, and she was sure it wouldn't take much for the attendant to

silence her. “It's not what it looks like! I–”

“You're trying to get their breakfast over to them, right?” The female attendant laughed lightly. “I can take it to them once they're done. I can hear them through my wall, so you won't have to keep coming back up here anymore.”

A wash of relief immediately enveloped the maid's being. What a kind soul! Scrapping her previous thoughts of her first impressions of the Kremnoan, she handed the silver tray over to the attendant.

“Truly, thank you so much.” The maid bowed her head with a light tint of red across her cheeks. No longer did she need to hear any more of Phainon's bedroom activities.

The Kremnoan attendant laughed, accepting the tray. “It's no problem! They have quite the energy, huh?”

The maid's face beamed red as her eyes dropped to the floor. “I… They truly do.”

“Did you walk in earlier?”

She shot her head up to look at a smirking attendant, and the blush crept down her neck. “It–I–It was–”

The attendant laughed once again. “I was just curious; I wasn't going to do anything about it. Anyway–” She raised the tray in her hands with a smile, setting it inside on a nearby table in her room. “–I'll get this to them whenever they're done with their business.”

The maid thanked the Kremnoan attendant once again, but before she could flee the scene, the attendant opened her mouth once more. “By the way, what do you think of Phainon?”

The maid's eyes went wide as she squeaked, “Excuse me?”

“Well, I just.” The attendant hummed as she thought about how to word her explanation. “I just wanted to know how Phainon's reputation precedes him

in Okhema Kingdom. Is he well-known, or is he truly an average soldier?”

“Phainon is anything but average!” The maid blurted out, and her face grew hot at how quickly she had answered. Meekly, the maid mumbled, “Phainon is hailed as a hero of the common people in Okhema. I'm not sure if Kremnos is aware of the dragon expedition that took place in Styxia, but Phainon was the first soldier to accept the quest and was made the leader of the expedition party. And he was the one who did the most damage in slaying the dragon, even earning himself honors for his deed.”

The Kremnoan attendant's eyes shot wide. “That was Phainon?!”

The maid nodded enthusiastically. She wouldn't admit this out loud, but she was quite a fan of Phainon's. It was hard not to become a fan of someone so courageous, kind-hearted, and handsome. “Many, many people admire Phainon. Every Okheman citizen has heard his name, especially since he is the personal guard of Miss Aglaea, ruler of Okhema.”

At her words, the attendant beamed. “I knew it! I knew I was right!” She began cheering in her open doorway and throwing her fists up in celebration, but she quickly settled. “Wait, wait, wait. As a woman, how do you see Phainon?”

“Pardon?”

“I mean, how do you see him as a *man*?”

Her face bloomed bright red once more as she reflected on the sight this morning. “Phainon is… um… He is a very kind and strong man. He is great with people, both very young and very old. And… He is…” The maid's voice was barely above a murmur as the embarrassment consumed her. “Very, very handsome, and very, very charismatic. He turns heads in the market because of his looks. His body is…quite the sight to behold. And, um…” Her voice quieted to barely being above a whisper as she reflected on the sight she saw just this morning. “He is *very, very*… well-endowed.”

The Kremnoan attendant was leaning in dangerously close to capture every word that she spoke. “And how would you say the other maids in the palace

view him?”

The maid was about to explode with embarrassment. “I… would say all the maids think the same. Even some of the men think the same. Either you are in love with Phainon or look up to Phainon in this palace.”

The Kremnoan attendant fell silent, making sure that the maid was finished speaking before she suddenly cheered, whooping, hollering, and jumping to the point that the other attendant in her room had to tell her to quiet down. “I knew it! I told him! He didn't believe me at all! *‘You overestimate me, Empousa.’* Yeah, right!”

She cheered once more, mocking the voice of whoever had said that statement to her. The maid quietly watched her, stifling a laugh.

“Then, if that was all…”

“Oh, right.” The attendant, whom the maid now assumed was named Empousa, lowered her arms. “Thank you for the information. I'm going to rub it in his face later.”

The maid nodded and quickly fled the corridor. This morning was going to live with her inside her head for many, many years.

“*Hah.*.. Do you… concede?”

“Never… *Hah.*..”

The two men were barely awake, panting for breath and teetering on the edge of consciousness. Every time one of them would ask for the other to admit defeat, the other would surge with energy and pounce up once more. They had been repeating this since the end of Curtain-Fall Hour, and it was now well into Lucid Hour. Not only did they not sleep the entire night, but they were also going at it as if they were in heat the entire time. Now that it was morning, the consciousness of the two men was slipping away due to the lack of sleep and the amount of energy exerted throughout the last few quints.

Phainon swore his vision was going in and out as he hovered over Mydei's body in bed. They were both sticky with sweat and other fluids as they both just finished, probably their 33 millionth round of the day. His dick absolutely ached and throbbed from all the excess stimulation, and he swore he could not cum anymore, even if he wanted to. He was still flush inside of Mydei, whose insides similarly throbbed around Phainon. It was slick and drenched inside as Phainon easily pulled himself out, face flushing from the noises that his filled hole made, and watching the remaining cum inside of his entrance leak out and stain the already soiled bedsheets. Mydei grimaced as a whimper escaped from his lips at the empty feeling he was not used to.

“It's… *Hah.*.. not fair…” Phainon shakily sat back on his knees, bringing a hand to his face to push his bangs away that were sticking to his sweating forehead. His throat felt scratchy, and his voice was raspy from all their activity. “You just… *Hah.*.. lay there.”

Mydei's throat was in a similar condition as he barely managed to respond, “*Hah.*.. Try getting your guts rearranged… *Hah.*.. all night.”

Mydei was gripping the pillow his head rested against, struggling to keep his eyes open as well. The only reason he didn't pass out already was that he couldn't fall asleep on these soiled sheets that had become cold from their fluids that soaked in all night.

“Was it… *Hah.*.. that bad?” Phainon shifted in his spot. “I know it was… *Hah.*.. my first time…. I'm sorry.”

“When did I say it was bad?” Mydei scoffed, still heaving for breath. “I would've… *Hah.*.. stopped you long ago… . if I hated it.”

Phainon swallowed, swiping another hand through his disheveled hair. That statement probably would've turned Phainon on if he could even get hard again for the rest of the day.

“Then,” Phainon panted, “do you concede?”

“If I am awake, I still… haven't lost–*mmm!*”

Phainon sank his digits inside Mydei's gaping entrance, and Mydei threw his head back as his hips jolted. Tears brimmed in the corners of his eyes as Phainon explored him deeply, curling his fingers and relentlessly hitting every single wall and crevice there was to touch inside of Mydei. Mydei swore he was seeing stars as Phainon mercilessly ravaged his insides, and his walls ached and clenched around the invasion.

“Stop–*mmph!*” Mydei threw his head to the side, muffling his noises as best he could while Phainon continued to prod him deeper.

Phainon laughed breathlessly, mesmerized at the cum that still continued to slip from his entrance. “You say that, but your legs are still wide open.” He placed a hand on Mydei's knee, which was trembling in the air, and his feet were rooted to the bed, planted next to Phainon.

Mydei continued gasping for air in between moans and whimpers, and Phainon continued pushing his fingers inside to try and pull all of his cum out. Watching his own cum spilling out of Mydei and pooling onto the bed made Phainon's dick stir at the sight despite seeing it so many times that night. Unbelievably, his half-hard length began brushing against Mydei's thigh as if it were searching for his warmth.

A hand shot to Phainon's wrist, stilling his movements instantly. Phainon glanced up from Mydei's throbbing entrance and was met with a glare.

“I thought… *Hah.*.. you were getting the cum out. So… get your fingers away… from that spot.”

With slightly widened eyes, Phainon glanced down at his fingers again. His fingers were entirely swallowed up by Mydei's twitching hole, and his digits were pressed against that spot that felt smooth and firm inside of him.

“I didn't mean–” He had tried to pull his fingers away but had curled them instead in an attempt to move them out of the way, and Mydei gasped sharply, followed by a loud moan. His hips convulsed in bed as his grip tightened around Phainon’s wrist, and Phainon's eyes were caught by the sight of Mydei's leaking tip as his body twitched and jerked. With his head thrown back into the bed once more, Mydei rode out yet another dry orgasm

with his back arching off the bed and his fluttering insides clenching tightly around Phainon's digits.

“HKS,” Mydei practically shouted at him, panting as he recovered from his high. “Just let me do it.”

At those words, Phainon adamantly refused and pummeled his fingers inside, earning another loud moan and another jolt from the man underneath him.

“Fuck! Phainon–” Mydei whined but was cut off with another sharp gasp as Phainon pulled his fingers out only to push them deeply back inside. “*Ahh!* Phainon, Phainon, stop–”

“Is this your defeat then?” Phainon leaned down at the same time he plunged his fingers inside, earning another jerk from Mydei's body. He brushed his lips upon Mydei's and stirred his fingers, feeling his warm breaths and pants ghost his lips every time his fingertips brushed against his sweet spot.

Mydei stayed silent, gritting his teeth as his legs trembled around Phainon with every slight touch of his aching prostate. His arms had wrapped around Phainon's shoulders in a vice grip, sinking his nails into his back with every jolt of his body. Mydei was still on the verge of passing out, but he couldn't bring himself to admit his own defeat while he was still awake.

“Do you concede, Mydei?” Phainon repeated in a whisper against his lips and planted a light kiss on his mouth.

Mydei groaned at the kiss, running his hand into the silver hair on the back of Phainon's head and shoving him downward. They locked in another deeper kiss as Mydei wrapped his shaking legs around Phainon's hips.

The head of Phainon's hard dick brushed against his filled entrance, and a shiver ran down his body as he whined into the kiss. Phainon continued his relentless movements inside as he stirred, plunged, curled, and scissored his fingers inside of Mydei's overstimulated walls. It wasn't until a few moments later that Mydei had begun moving his hips in tandem with

Phainon's thrusts, chasing the pleasure and even trying to suck in the tip that kept pressing against his entrance.

“Put it in unless you want to announce your defeat,” Mydei breathlessly boasted with a small smirk once their lips had separated for air. “If you're too tired, I suppose I can stop here for you.”

Phainon's eyes widened at golden eyes as he scoffed incredulously at his words, ripping his fingers from his hole and easily replacing the warm, empty space with his length. He plunged his dick inside as the cavernous walls pulsed around him at the invasion, and both men groaned at the pleasure once more as Phainon began snapping his hips against Mydei's behind. Sinking deeper and deeper into Mydei's warmth and pressing against his sweet spot, both men panted and moaned against each other's lips as the bed frame rocked under them once again.

The two men went at it for another few rounds before both of them collapsed at the same time.

It was Parting Hour when Phainon woke. The sun had dipped much lower into the sky from what he could see from the window, and the sun’s rays danced beautifully in the air and reflected off many of the gold embellishments in the room. Much of his day had been slept away, and his limbs felt heavy. With a groan, he had barely managed to shift slightly in place. He was lying on his back, facing the ornate ceiling, and Mydei was sleeping soundly on his chest with an arm wrapped around Phainon's torso.

Running his fingers through Mydei's golden hair, he could feel the entire night weighing down in his strands. Phainon was groggy but thought he should probably clean up. He scanned the room and found it in the exact state as they had left it last night and when they collapsed this morning. It seemed that none of the maids came inside. His shoulders tensed as his cheeks flared at the thought. Wait, did the maids know what they were doing?

Sliding a hand down his face with another groan, Phainon pushed himself off, gently setting Mydei onto the pillow. He climbed off the bed, face

burning with embarrassment with every creak of the mahogany bed frame, as it only served to remind him of their activities last night and this morning.

His skin felt sticky, but he didn't have anything else to wear as he gathered last night’s clothes and began pulling them over himself. Phainon only gathered the black collared top, trousers, boots, and gauntlets just so that he could cover himself while he ventured outside. Sincerely, Phainon did not want to deal with all the belts and buckles right now. Once he was dressed, he attempted to gather as many of the soiled sheets as he could while keeping Mydei covered in the bed.

Pushing open the door with as many sheets Phainon could gather in his hands, he scanned the area, but no one was around. The corridor was completely abandoned, and it only served to further increase the embarrassment inside of his chest at the thought that the maids *definitely* knew what they were doing. They had even cleared the entire floor.

Phainon sighed, holding the sheets in his hands as he quietly shut the door behind him. He knew where the laundry room was within the palace, but that also meant he had to go face all of the workers under the assumption that everyone knew what he was doing to the King of Kremnos.

Steeling himself, he took a single step toward the stairs that led to the direction of the laundry room, only to jump when the door next to him opened.

Phainon sidestepped and locked eyes with Empousa, who quickly glanced at the sheets before assessing Phainon's face. They stared at each other for a few moments, but Phainon definitely did not want to say the first word lest he just make a fool of himself.

“Fun night?” Was all Empousa said, tilting her head to the side.

Phainon immediately burned a bright red at her words. With an awkward laugh, he bowed his head. “Sorry, Empousa.”

She laughed loudly at his obvious embarrassment. “No need to apologize! Whose idea did you think it was to prepare that attire for the King?”

His eyes grew as wide as saucers as he shot his head back up. “That attire was *your* making?!”

Empousa continued laughing at the situation, even having to bring her hands to her knees to keep herself up, and wiping stray tears along her eyes. “I really didn't think you'd like the attire so much, but I guess it was successful.” She pushed against her knees to bring herself back up and held out her hands. “I can bring those down for you.”

Phainon frowned, glancing down at the obviously soiled sheets. “It's really fine, Empousa. I don't want you to have to bring this down.”

She nonchalantly waved her hand in the air, grabbing the sheets right out of Phainon's grasp. “Tending to the King is my job. And at this rate, I'll have to be tending to his Queen as well.”

“Queen?!”

“A certain *queen* from Aedes Elysiae.”

She sauntered off, humming in her steps without looking back. Phainon was left to sigh loudly as his blush only grew. That did bring up another point in Phainon’s mind: What would happen to them once the Kremnoans all departed from Okhema two days from now? Would they still be lovers? Would this just be a fleeting fit of passion that would only last a week before Mydei returned to being a King? Would Phainon just be a short fling in Mydei's mind that he would reflect on every now and then? Phainon wasn't sure what exactly Mydei was thinking in regard to him, and thinking about it further only sent his heart twisting and tightening in his chest.

Willing his footsteps back to Mydei's room while pretending he hadn't heard Empousa's remark, he jumped once again when he locked eyes with gold. Why were the Kremnoans all scaring him today?

“Good… evening, Mydei.” Phainon had to think about what time it was as he returned to his side, seating himself at the edge of the bed and running his hands through his golden hair.

Mydei nodded, letting Phainon do as he wished. “What were you doing?”

“I was about to bring the sheets down for a wash, but Empousa took it from me before I could leave.”

The man in bed chuckled in response. “That sounds like Empousa.”

“Did you want me to call the maids to prepare a bath?” Phainon eyed the dirtied sheets that Mydei was still lying in. “We can have the rest of the sheets cleaned while you bathe.”

Humming, Mydei's eyes hovered over the area where the wooden tub is usually placed. “It depends. Will you join me this time?”

“You–You wanted me to join you last time?” Phainon's face was brightly flushed as he recalled their second day together.

“Will you join me or not?”

“Yes, Mydei!”

Phainon had dashed out the door but immediately halted in his steps when he almost crashed into Empousa in the hallway.

“Sorry, Empousa.” Phainon couldn't help but laugh as he looked down at her as she was raising her arms in the air to stop them from colliding. He always found it so amusing how expressive Empousa was.

“I already called a bath for you guys,” Empousa lowered her arms with a sigh of relief. “When I went to drop off the sheets. Are there any more?”

With a nod, Phainon hurried back into Mydei's room, and he made quick work of stripping the bed of all its sheets. While Phainon passed the rest of the sheets to Empousa in the corridor, Mydei began organizing the rest of

their clothing that was thrown all over the floor. Phainon was shocked to see such a sight when he returned.

“You really don't have to do that, Mydei.” Phainon had practically snatched the clothing out of his hands.

“It's a tripping hazard to leave it.”

“I can do it.”

“I have both my arms and legs. I don't see why I can't also do it.”

“Aren't you nobility?” Phainon frowned while furrowing his eyebrows.

“I wasn't for a few years of my life.” Mydei continued plucking the rest of the items off the floor, and it was then that it dawned on Phainon. He couldn't even begin to imagine Mydei's complete switch in his life when his father had banished him from Kremnos. Most likely, he went from living like royalty to living like a common person outside of Kremnos’s borders, and it was probably why he was so used to speaking with commoners and even treating them all equally. Phainon was too used to the stuffy nobles that made up the Council of Elders, who claimed they “represented the common folk,” yet were never seen interacting with them.

“I'm… sorry.” Phainon warily bent down to help Mydei clean the rest of the room, and another sigh came from the other man.

“Can we ban apologies?” Mydei's exasperated gaze stared deeply into Phainon. “You apologize for the most idiotic things.”

Phainon laughed at his comment. “Do I really apologize that much?”

“Every day,” Mydei huffed, setting their clothing down on the end table. “It's annoying.”

“I'll try not to apologize so much then, Mydei.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes at him, and Phainon nervously shifted in place. How did Mydei know Phainon was just biting back an apology? He wanted

to apologize for apologizing so often, but had barely stopped himself in time.

Three knocks sounded at the door, and Mydei quickly adorned his robe as Phainon opened the door for the maids. Four maids shuffled into the room, carrying in the wooden tub as they prepared the bath. The room was silent as they busied themselves with filling the bath with buckets of heated water, and Phainon soon realized that not a single maid chose to make eye contact with either of the men in the room.

His face flushed with a sheepish smile that he tried to hide. They definitely knew.

In the midst of the maids' business, another, more abrupt, knock echoed against the door. Glancing over to Mydei, who nodded to continue, Phainon opened the door and found Empousa once more with a silver tray in her hands.

"One of the maids tried to send this to King Mydeimos, but you were both too… preoccupied." Empousa really did try her best to find the most suitable word.

With an awkward laugh, Phainon accepted the tray. He thought Empousa would be on her way after that; however, she continued to linger at the doorway with a poor attempt to hide a smile.

"You know how I said I would ask around about you to the maids?"

Phainon narrowed his eyes. Where was she going with this?

"Yes?" Phainon was wary of whatever antics she had planned next.

"Well, I happened to hear of one *average* soldier from Aedes Elysiae who happens to be a liar." The giant smirk plastered all over Empousa's face did little to comfort Phainon. "I happened to… overhear that this certain man is hailed as a *hero* in Okhema."

Phainon hummed, playing along with her antics. “Oh, really? I wonder what kind of guy that is.”

“Yes, yes.” She nodded with a cross of her arms, feigning being deep in thought. “I wonder what other *average* soldier would hail from Aedes Elysiae. Would you happen to know of any, *Phainon*?”

He glanced off to the side and avoided her burning gaze. “My hometown may be small, but that doesn't mean I know *everyone* who hails from Aedes Elysiae.”

She clicked her tongue. “Phainon.”

“...Yes?”

“You dirty liar!”

The Kremnoan attendant started throwing playful punches at Phainon as he tried to fend off every single one with a laugh. Though, he didn't have much success defending himself as he still held that silver tray in his hands.

“I still don't actually know what you're talking about, Empousa!”

“Everyone in Okhema says you're a hero! A Deliverer!” Another punch. “You slayed a literal dragon!” A punch to his shoulder. “Every woman in this place says you're handsome, Phainon! *‘You overestimate me, Empousa.’* I knew it! I told you so!”

“I truly don't know what you're talking about!” A sigh of relief left his body when she halted her punches. She may have just been playfully hitting him, but she was still a strong, Kremnoan warrior, after all.

“Actually?” She blinked blankly at him.

Phainon was still catching his breath. He couldn't believe that would technically count as his first spar with Empousa. “What are you talking about?”

“Everyone in Okhema calls you a hero!” She exclaimed again. “Weren't you the one *claiming* you were some regular schmegular soldier?”

“But, I *am* a regular soldier.”

“What regular soldier leads a dragon-slaying expedition?!”

“They're just exaggerating.” Phainon brushed off her arguments. “I truly was just a part of the expedition. I didn't do much.”

“They said you earned honors for it!”

“That's…” Phainon tried to retort, but he couldn't think of anything. He really did earn honors for it, but he had forgotten because “honors” didn't mean much to him. What really mattered more to him was if the quest was completed successfully and if everyone was unharmed. Where did she even dig up this information from? “That… was a long time ago. And anyway, it was really only a minor achievement. I really didn't do much.”

Empousa hummed, clearly unconvinced. “So what about when you said no one finds you attractive, hm? You have something for that?”

“I am really just an average soldier, Empousa.” Phainon smiled at her. “I don't know where you got this information from, but I am truly no one special.”

She hummed once again and glanced off to the side where the maids were finishing up the bath. “You're either extremely humble or extremely clueless.”

“I prefer to think I'm neither.”

“You're definitely one of the two, if not both.”

After much more bickering over Phainon's reputation, he finally shut the door with a heaved sigh as she left with the maids. Setting the silver tray down on the nearest table, he couldn't tell if Empousa was just playing with him or if she had actually done some field research in the palace. Was that

really how Okhema saw Phainon? He couldn't believe it at all. He didn't particularly think he did anything special, after all.

He turned around on his feet, jumping when he saw Mydei shedding the robe around his shoulders and revealing his naked body once more.

“You were the one who led that expedition in Styxia?” Mydei hung his robe off to the side.

“I truly don't know what she's talking about.” Phainon ran a hand through his hair that was still holding onto the previous day's work. “There was no official leader for that expedition. It was started by Miss Aglaea and Queen Polyxia, if anything.”

Mydei eyed him suspiciously, and he approached Phainon to tug his clothes away. “You'll have to tell me more about this expedition, *Deliverer*.”

Phainon let Mydei pull the clothes off his body as he sheepishly laughed. “I don't know where that title came from. No one actually calls me that.”

“I'm not sure I believe you now.” Mydei pushed Phainon toward the bath, and he stumbled in his steps, grasping at the edge of the bath to steady himself. Thankfully, the bath did not tip over and spill water all over the floor.

“Sit.”

Phainon immediately climbed into the bath and lowered himself into the warm water. There was something about Mydei’s commanding voice that made Phainon follow without question. Was this how his attendants felt? He couldn't dwell on the question anymore once the warm water rushed in soft ripples over his skin as Mydei lowered himself into Phainon's lap. He leaned his back against Phainon's chest, breathing a deep sigh.

He wrapped his arms around Mydei's waist and propped his chin upon his broad shoulder. “I'd rather hear more about you.”

A scoff could he heard from the man in his lap. “I already told you everything there is to know. Clearly, you have been hiding things from me, Deliverer.”

“I swear no one uses that title!” Phainon laughed as Mydei eyed him suspiciously another time.

“You will have to tell me all there is about you, even rumors.” Mydei shut his eyes as he basked in the warm water. “How else will I bring you back to Kremnos without knowing a thing about you?”

“I didn't even know such rumors about me were even circling.” Phainon chuckled. “Truly, I didn't know so many people knew who I was.”

A silence passed between them, and Phainon paused, rewinding the conversation. His shoulders tensed, his eyes widened, and he would've jumped up if Mydei were not sitting in his lap. “Wait, what?”

“That took you faster than I thought.”

“You're bringing me to Kremnos?!”

Mydei gazed up at Phainon. The water droplets glistened in his hair, and even if his body looked relaxed, there was something different swirling deep within his golden eyes. “Only if you want to.” Mydei faced forward, shifting in place. “I cannot force you to come back with me if you do not want to.”

“I…” It was something that Phainon hadn't given a lot of thought to. Leaving Okhema? He had never entertained the idea before, except for when he had wanted to polish his combat skills in Kremnos, except even that would just be a temporary trip. But, moving to Kremnos permanently? Well, it wasn't as if he had any truly strong connections in Okhema Kingdom, besides his parents, who still resided in Aedes Elysiae. However, it wasn't as if he would be trapped in Kremnos never to return; he'd still be able to return and visit his parents whenever he wished. And, he didn't have anything chaining him to stay in Okhema. The only thing was that he wished he could help Aglaea more in her rule against the Council of Elders.

“You don't need to give me an answer right now.” Mydei settled back into Phainon's chest, facing the ceiling. “Even if you waited until the moment I hopped into my carriage to return home, I would still take you with me if you came running out at that moment.”

“I'll do it.”

Mydei narrowed his eyes at Phainon at the sudden acceptance. “Did you even think about it?”

“I just did.” He smiled at Mydei, tightening the hold around his waist. “I would want to speak with Miss Aglaea first, but I want to be with you, Mydei.”

A tinge of pink splashed Mydei's cheeks, and he turned to the side while clearing his throat. “I agree. It was going to be part of my conversation with her tomorrow.”

They sat in silence for a while in the bath, and Phainon watched the ripples of the water with every movement of their bodies. Phainon, despite his eagerness to stay with Mydei, still had second thoughts about leaving Okhema Kingdom. Would he just drop all his responsibilities as a soldier in Okhema? And, what would he become in Kremnos? Would he join the vanguard in Kremnos or become something completely different?

Logically, it would be quite easy for Phainon to move. He didn't have very many possessions, considering that he didn't have much space to himself in the barracks. Honestly, he could pack two bags and be on his way with Mydei to Kremnos. But, the idea intimidated him only because he didn't know the first thing about Kremnos. Would he just continually make a fool of himself and of the King because he was the one to bring Phainon there? Would Phainon even fit into Kremnos?

A sharp, small pain landed on his forehead, and Phainon yelped with a flinch.

“Are you second-guessing coming with me?”

Phainon, rubbing his forehead, locked eyes with gold. With a small chuckle over his thoughts being completely exposed, Phainon asked, “What does my face say?”

Mydei frowned. “It says that you are clearly overthinking this. Were you not eager to join me just a few moments ago?”

“I still am!” Phainon claimed. He tightened his hold around Mydei's waist and buried his face in his shoulder. “I just… I don't know the first thing about Kremnos.”

“I will teach you.”

“What if I make a fool out of their King?”

“You won't.”

“Would Kremnos even accept me?”

“They will.”

“What would I become if I moved to Kremnos?”

“We will figure that out together.” Phainon heard a splash from the bath water being disturbed, and he soon felt a hand running through his hair, dripping water down the back of his neck. “I told you, you are overthinking. All of your worries have such simple answers. And, you will not be chained to Kremnos. You can go back to Okhema whenever you wish.”

“You mean–” Phainon shifted his gaze from the skin of Mydei's shoulder to his eyes. “–like I could leave you at any time?”

Mydei scoffed. “I meant you can visit Okhema whenever you want.” A smack landed on the back of Phainon's head, and he yelped again. “I wouldn't let you leave me so easily.”

Phainon smiled softly, burying his face back into Mydei's shoulders. He mumbled against his skin, but Mydei couldn't hear him.

“What did you just say, Deliverer?”

Phainon chose to stay silent as he began rubbing circles into Mydei's waist, feeling the softness of his skin under the water. His face burned at the words that slipped from his lips, even reaching his ears as they turned red as the words repeated in his mind.

I love you, Mydei.

The two men finished their bath, with another round in the wooden tub because Mydei felt a little too much over Phainon's fingers trying to clean out his insides. With the water now at a much cooler temperature, and the sun through the window now submerged underneath the horizon, Phainon and Mydei dressed themselves in clothing that was washed during their bath, courtesy of Georgious, who was called inside to bring their clothing to the laundry room. Well, Mydei had brand new clothes and didn't need to reuse his ball attire, but Phainon still only had that black collared shirt and dark trousers from the previous day with him.

They picked at the food that Empousa had previously passed to them: an assortment of pastries, both savory and sweet, and tea. Empousa had warmed it up for them before bringing it to them, but because of their bath, it had now cooled down again. Phainon offered to run to the kitchen to warm it up again, but Mydei had refused the offer.

A knock sounded at the door, and with Mydei's permission, Phainon opened it and was met with a maid who was carrying a basket of their freshly washed sheets. Though, he did notice she had slightly tinted cheeks as she scurried inside the bedroom and began setting the bed.

Even though the maid refused, Phainon still helped her set all the sheets and pillows into place, and together, they made the bed and restored it back to its original state while Mydei was at the desk on the opposite wall, attending to his work. While fluffing up the pillows, Phainon faintly heard a murmur on the other side of the bed.

“Sorry, did you say something?” Phainon smiled at the maid across the mattress. “Could you repeat that?”

The maid jumped and almost dropped the pillow from her hand. “I… I… I just… wanted to… apologize.”

His eyebrows shot up. “Apologize?”

“For…” The maid's blush from before had now become a deep crimson. “It…It's all my fault.”

Phainon stayed silently as he watched the maid fidget in place with the pillow still in her hands. He waited patiently for the maid to finish her explanation; he could faintly recall that her name was Chara.

“It… I… tried to deliver breakfast this morning…” Her voice was barely above a squeak, but Phainon had caught enough of her sentence to understand exactly what she was trying to convey.

Immediately turning a bright red, Phainon quickly attempted to busy himself with the rest of the sheets, trying to act as nonchalantly as possible. “That? Ahh, don't worry about it.”

“I'm really sorry, Phainon…”

“You were just doing your job!” Despite his words, Phainon could no longer look at Chara anymore. “I cannot get angry at you for doing your duties.”

They finished the rest of the sheets in silence, and soon enough, the bed had returned to the image that Phainon had seen during the first day of the Kremnoans’ arrival when he was reviewing that everything in their bedrooms were in place. He wasn't sure if Mydei had heard any of their conversation at all, but Phainon was sure Mydei had already caught onto the fact that all the servants knew of their newfound relationship. From the way all the maids had flushed cheeks every time they approached his quarters, it would be a wonder if Mydei didn't catch on.

Once Chara had departed from Mydei's room, Phainon realized that it was now Parting Hour. The day passed extremely fast, but it may be more due to the fact that they had awoken during Action Hour. Mydei’s days in Okhema

Kingdom were coming to a close, with only one final day left before the Kremnoans all departed during the morning of their seventh day. And, it may also be Phainon's final days in Okhema if he really did depart with Mydei to Kremnos.

Phainon couldn't believe that so much had happened in such a short number of days. His usually monotonous schedule of attending to the citizens of Okhema and fighting monsters threatening their borders immediately took a turn when he was assigned as the Kremnoans' personal guard. He didn't think his life could change so much in just a couple of days.

Because of their late midday meal, which was supposed to be their breakfast, they opted to skip supper for the day. The other Kremnoan servants went ahead and dined without the two men, while they decided to stay in the bedroom for the remainder of the day. They didn't really do much except lounge around on the bed, exchange occasional kisses, and talk about nothing and everything.

Phainon explained the campaign he participated in when he went to Styxia to fight the dragon, and he also learned more about Mydei's life while he was in exile. Surprisingly, Mydei was more of a food-lover than Phainon originally thought, and he had even grown and cooked his own food while he was outside Kremnos's borders. Phainon begged Mydei to prepare a meal for him next time, who begrudgingly agreed. The time they spent together just lying in bed and talking was truly what Phainon would consider one of his most memorable days.

"You're staying tonight." Mydei, who was lying in bed next to Phainon, stated this more as a fact rather than a question. It was approaching Curtain-Fall Hour now, and Mydei and Phainon had spent the last few quints exchanging stories from their lives.

Phainon laughed, turning his body to face him, as he was originally facing the elaborate ceiling above them. "Of course I am. Unless you don't want me here?" He batted his eyelashes in a feign of innocence, which earned him a scowl from the other man.

“Don't kid with me, Deliverer.” Despite his words, Mydei reached his arms forward and buried his face into Phainon's chest. Somehow, Mydei had learned to tease him by constantly overusing this title.

The words almost slipped out of Phainon's mouth once more as he ran a hand through golden hair. Instead, he opted for a smile, swallowing those words into his throat. It was way too soon to say those words right now, right? They had only known each other for just a couple of days; he couldn't possibly spring those words so suddenly onto Mydei. He was sure even Mydei didn't feel that strongly compared to Phainon. After all, it felt that Mydei was much more grounded and self-assured than Phainon ever was.

Well, he *was* considering moving countries to follow said man he had only known for a couple of days, and even said man *wanted* him to move countries with him. Maybe they did feel the same way?

As he felt Mydei's breathing even out as he fell into a deep slumber against his chest, Phainon continued tangling his fingertips within golden strands, whispering into the air.

“I love you, Mydei.”

Itinerary Day 6: Aglaea's Proposal, Again

Phainon was getting used to the sight of the elaborately decorated ceiling above him now. He didn't think it would be a sight he would ever become accustomed to, but here he was, opening his eyes in the midst of Entry Hour to that grand chandelier above him once again.

Mydei had an arm thrown over Phainon's abdomen with his head resting on Phainon's chest. From the angle that Phainon was seeing, he couldn't tell if Mydei was awake or not because his face was turned away from him; he could only watch his head of golden hair rise and fall with each one of Phainon's breaths. Phainon watched, mesmerized, as the morning sunlight peeking through the windows only served to illuminate his golden hair. As if he were wearing this golden crown or even a halo around his head, it was as if nature itself recognised Mydei in all his glory and royalty.

He brought a hand up to run his fingertips through his soft, glowing strands but jumped when Mydei shifted in his place. Lifting his head up toward his face, Phainon could now see Mydei’s somewhat drowsy expression.

“You're awake.”

“That, I am,” Mydei mumbled. “For a while.”

“Did I keep you waiting?” Phainon teased with a smile, lowering his hand onto Mydei's head.

Much to Phainon’s surprise, Mydei was completely serious when he huffed, “You did.”

“I… I did?” Slightly taken aback, Phainon pointed a hesitant finger at himself.

Mydei scoffed while narrowing his eyes. “Every day upon awakening, you were never to be found in my bed.”

“I…” Phainon frowned, furrowing his eyebrows to recall where he had gone while he was staying in Mydei's bedroom. The first day he stayed in this room, he had gotten up to prepare for the royal ball, only for Mydei to drag him back into bed. The second day, he had gotten up to tidy the room. He did return to the room to see him sitting upright in bed after passing the sheets to Empousa–was he looking for Phainon the entire time he was gone?

Phainon's shoulders went slack. “Oh.”

“Is that all you have to say to me?”

“You…” Phainon couldn't even believe the thought that had popped into his head. There was no way, right? “Were you waiting to wake up in bed with me these last few days?”

“The better question is, why do you have so much to do in the morning?” Mydei had pushed himself off of Phainon's chest, and before Phainon could respond, Mydei had draped his upper body to hover over Phainon with his lips ghosting over his.

He couldn't help his line of sight from dropping to Mydei's lips as he felt them faintly brush against his, and a breath caught in Phainon's throat when a chuckle sounded from the man above him.

“Choosing not to answer me?” Mydei smirked.

“I…” Phainon's voice died in his throat as his eyes struggled to focus on either his brightly glowing eyes or the teasing lips that continued to brush against his with every syllable they exchanged. “Well, I–*mmm!*”

His thoughts were silenced when those enticing lips pressed into his, and Phainon's eyes immediately fluttered shut as a moan escaped his throat. Mydei’s fingers had intertwined with Phainon's, pinning him down into the bed underneath them as he deepened the kiss. Phainon's brain melted with every movement of his lips, and his stomach twisted in pleasure at every sound their connected lips emitted.

Phainon slipped his fingers from Mydei's and grasped his waist, and a soft moan slipped from the lips pressing down on him as Phainon felt the delicious curves upon Mydei's body. He couldn't get enough of Mydei's enticing body as he swirled his fingertips upon his hips, the arch of his back, and even ran his fingers upwards to reach as far as the middle of his back.

The man jolted at the touch and pulled back from the kiss. Phainon was in a daze when they finally parted, warm breath tickling his lips as Mydei panted for breath. He stared up at Mydei who just looked absolutely dazzling over him, with his slightly disheveled bedhead, bruised lips, and dilated golden eyes.

“That spot.” Mydei reached behind him to grasp Phainon's fingers, which were still pressing down the middle of his back. “Not too hard.”

“Does it hurt here?” Phainon gently circled his fingers over that spot, earning a shiver from the man above him.

“It's…” Mydei was panting merely from Phainon teasing this small patch in the middle of his back. “I already explained to you that no harm can befall my body.”

Phainon only nodded silently, stilling his fingers that were teasing his back.

“And, you questioned whether this body truly could never be harmed. The truth is that this spot–” Mydei pressed their fingers down against his spine, and he deeply exhaled at the sensation. “–is the only spot that can be harmed. Drive your blade through this spot, and my life will end.”

Phainon almost ripped his fingers away from his back as if it were a burning fire, but Mydei's tight grasp kept him in place. “So, that means you are sensitive here?”

Mydei nodded, wincing when Phainon hesitantly resumed his ministrations upon his back. “So, not too hard.”

“Do the others know?”

“My people only know that my body is immortal, not of this spot on my tenth thoracic vertebrae. No one outside of Kremnos, besides you, knows of my body's disposition.”

Phainon could only imagine the advantages Kremnos Kingdom held merely by having a basically indestructible monarch. Of course, it was something that they could not easily let slip to other lands. The number of people who would even attempt to exploit his disposition and even his weakness would be immeasurable.

“And, you are trusting me with this knowledge?”

Mydei smirked, bending down and brushing his lips upon his once more. “If you are to return to Kremnos with me, you ought to know this information as my guard.”

They locked their lips together once more in a much more heated exchange than before. Relentlessly, Phainon continued teasing that spot on his back, earning him long moans vibrating against him as Mydei arched his back at every press against his spine. He grasped his hands upon Phainon's shoulders, shaking above him as Phainon slipped his tongue between his lips, swirling inside his warm mouth, and sliding his tongue against Mydei's.

Mydei panted into the kiss, refusing to acquiesce to Phainon's actions. He darted his tongue back, tangling their tongues together as they exchanged saliva between them. Phainon couldn't get enough of Mydei's taste as the sounds of their heated kiss reverberated through his brain. With one hand teasing Mydei's back and another grasping his waist, he was almost tempted to pull Mydei onto his lap and resume their prior competition that currently held no winner.

“Don't we have things to do today, Deliverer?” Mydei parted their lips and cocked his head to the side with an amused smile.

Phainon was too busy trailing the string of saliva that connected their lips together as it led back into that warm cavern that he was still craving the taste of. Mydei's warm breath continued to ghost over his lips as Phainon

was locked in a trance, wondering why they had even stopped kissing in the first place.

At that thought, it was as if Phainon finally snapped out of his stupor as he scrambled in his mind for any semblance of sanity. “We–uh–Aglaea! Yes, we are to meet with Aglaea later today.”

Phainon swiped the back of his hand over his mouth and scrambled out of bed, faintly hearing Mydei laughing at him in the background. He was whipping his head around, still slightly in a daze, and he realized he was still adorned in his previous ball attire from two days ago.

“I should return to the barracks to get my uniform.”

Before he could make a mad dash toward his belongings in the barracks, Mydei's voice stopped him.

“Why? We already had this uniform cleaned for you.” He gestured to the remaining belts and armor that were meticulously placed on the desk. “You might as well just use this outfit.”

“Well…” Phainon solemnly glanced at the armor neatly organized together. “This armor is more befitting a Knight's on a day-to-day basis. Now that the ball is over, there's no need for me to wear such extravagant pieces."

“You're the Deliverer, are you not?” Mydei had already left the bed and begun untangling all the belts and buckles. “Come. I will help you put these on.”

“Mydei, there's really no need–”

“Come.”

As if someone had taken over his body, Phainon rigidly met Mydei's side, sitting himself down in the desk chair while Mydei figured out where all the extra attachments belonged. With the two of them, it took a much faster time to become completely adorned in the full outfit compared to when it had taken multiple quints for Phainon to wear it all by himself. Even so, it

was Lucid Hour by the time the two of them were both fully dressed and ready to depart from the bedroom.

Mydei stepped back while Phainon was once again adorned in the fanciest white and blue armor he had ever seen. He still felt a bit uncomfortable, as it was so drastically different from his usual uniform, but he knew Mydei wouldn't allow him even a brief moment of escape back to the barracks to retrieve his normal attire.

“You look good,” Mydei stated. “So, stop overthinking.”

Phainon couldn't tear his eyes away from the leather gauntlets adorning his hands, or the white sleeves embellished in gold that ran down his arms. “I'm not overthinking it. It's just…” What was the right word? Not normal? Unusual? Unfitting? It felt more like Phainon was dressing up in a costume rather than wearing clothes.

“Stop looking at yourself and get up.” Mydei had shoved a knee in between Phainon's legs, and the change in scenery broke Phainon's thoughts. “Let's go.”

Trailing the knee that had slotted itself between his legs, Phainon's eyes ran up his thighs, torso, and neck to finally reach golden eyes peering down on him. He shook his head, clearing his thoughts and pushing himself up from his seat. “You're right. Let's go.”

They met with the Kremnan attendants outside in the corridor, and Phainon led them once more to the dining hall on the lower floor. It was quite the peaceful day, as the attendants had one last full day before returning home, and they were free to do whatever they pleased while Mydei spent a part of his day speaking with Aglaea. Phainon was running the itinerary through his head as he shoveled his breakfast down, not really paying attention to what was set in front of him.

Phainon was to bring Mydei to Aglaea’s office after breakfast, so Phainon would be free until Aglaea called him back. He will probably help accompany the Kremnoan attendants if they decide to venture elsewhere around the city. Regarding whether he would stay in Okhema or join Mydei

in Kremnos would have to be a conversation he would have to have with Aglaea later on in the day, when they were both freer. He wasn't sure what to expect from that conversation, and he didn't want to think about it. Just thinking about it made his stomach churn.

“Eat properly, HKS.”

Phainon's head shot up to the view in front of him upon hearing the Kremnoan word, and he was met with a scowl.

His eyes widened in confusion. “Sorry?”

“I don't want to eat with someone who cannot appreciate the food that is being served to them.”

Phainon blinked blankly at the man in front of him before glancing down at the food he had already eaten half of without actually knowing what he was shoving into his mouth.

It was a bowl of steaming vegetable potage. Filled with cabbage and potatoes that were slow-cooked to become this filling stew, the taste was light enough to be perfectly suitable for breakfast yet satiating enough to power oneself for the rest of the day. Served off to the side in a separate dishwear were an assortment of salads and bread to eat with the potage, and a pitcher made of sterling silver which Phainon could only assume housed Mydei's beloved pomegranate milk concoction.

He let out a breath he didn't know he was holding as he stared down at his food, his tensed shoulders slowly relaxing. Mydei was right; he can eat and enjoy the food now and worry about all of his problems afterwards.

Taking a deep breath, Phainon took a much more appropriately-sized bite this time. Though, he wasn't sure why he was staring at Mydei while doing so. Maybe it was his way of letting him know Phainon had heard and understood his words?

The man in front of him smiled, tilting his head to the side without breaking eye contact. “Good boy.”

Phainon struggled to hold down a cough at his words, his face blooming a bright red as his eyes immediately shot back down to his bowl. He was still struggling to swallow the food he had in his mouth, but it was so hard to breathe as Mydei's words continued to echo in his mind. He had faintly caught the eyes of the Kremnoan attendants, who all looked a mix of either bashful or proud at their exchange.

They all finished with the rest of their meal, and Phainon thanked the maids who had rushed in to quickly clean up the table as they departed from the dining hall. Okheman soldiers met with them outside the dining hall and accompanied the rest of the Kremnoan attendants, while two Kremnoan attendants stayed behind with Mydei as Phainon led them back again to Aglaea's office.

It was nearing the end of Lucid Hour when Phainon brought a fist up to gently knock on the wooden door leading to Aglaea's office. When he faintly heard a female voice sound through the door, Phainon turned to Mydei.

“Well, I'll return once Miss Aglaea calls for me.” He nodded with a smile at Mydei, who only raised an eyebrow at his statement. “I'll see you later, Mydei.”

“Where do you think you're going?” Mydei crossed his arms, tilting his head to the side with a scowl upon his lips.

“Where?” Phainon frowned as his eyes wandered above him. “I didn't think about it yet. I was thinking maybe I'd accompany the rest of the Kremnoan attendants?”

Mydei scoffed. “I thought we were speaking with Aglaea. *Together*. Or did that conversation mean nothing to you?”

“Well, I…” Of course, Phainon remembered that conversation. He could never forget any conversation he had with Mydei. “I just thought you two would be discussing her proposal first–something that I shouldn't be there for.”

“And why shouldn't you be there?”

“Well, does it not concern classified information about both kingdoms?”

“Nothing about my kingdom is classified to you, Phainon.”

Phainon probably would've pinned Mydei to the wall right then and there if the other two Kremnoan attendants were not standing off to the side from them. A blush bloomed across his cheeks as he averted his gaze, ignoring the pounding of his heart that resounded loudly in his chest.

“I… see. Then, if you will have me, I will join you inside.”

Mydei nodded with a smile, gesturing to Phainon to proceed with opening the door. As Phainon did so, he was greeted with the cold air that was circulating inside the office, and two pairs of eyes met his.

“Miss Aglaea. And–” His eyes shifted to the other individual in the room. “–Professor Anaxa.”

A narrowed eye shot his way. “That is *Anaxagoras* to you.”

“Phainon.” Aglaea's gentle voice resounded through the room. “Thank you for bringing the King here for me.”

“It's my pleasure.” He returned the smile, gesturing for Mydei to continue into the room. As Mydei and the two Kremnoan attendants entered, Phainon felt awkward lingering in the room with such high-profile guests, and he had almost pivoted on his feet to rush out of the room if Mydei's voice did not stop him.

“I would like Phainon to stay, if that is fine with you.”

Phainon gulped. There was his one and only chance of escape, now gone with the wind. Hesitantly and anxiously, Phainon studied Aglaea's reaction, and he inwardly winced at how her polite and pleasant smile had grown into a knowing grin.

“Of course, King Mydeimos.” She waved her hand for Phainon to shut the office door, which he complied with. With the sound of the door locking shut, suddenly, the gravity of the situation fell upon his shoulders as his eyes wavered between the three other individuals in the room.

“I assume you have reviewed my proposal, King Mydeimos?”

Mydei scoffed, crossing his arms. “I'd like to hear if you have a plan first before I so readily throw my people to join your cause.”

Aglaea's golden eyes twinkled under the morning sunlight streaming through the grand window behind her. “Of course. I will do my very best.”

She abruptly stood up, the sound of her office chair sliding against the rug under her golden heels as she spread a scroll upon her desk. Phainon hadn't the least clue what could possibly be on that scroll as Mydei approached her side to peer closer.

“Every year, I and many citizens of Okhema attend an assembly with the Council of Elders,” She began to explain. “Every year, the assembly consists of reviewing government legislation in the form of debates. It may be laws that need approval or codes that need to be re-reviewed. However, this year, I plan to bring up the power of the Council of Elders themselves.”

Mydei raised an eyebrow, his gaze still glued to the opened scroll. “And, you are allowed to question the Council of Elders like so? That makes me question why no one has done it before.”

“Although participating citizens are allowed to vote, they cannot raise the laws they wish to discuss,” Aglaea answered. “Only the Council of Elders comes prepared with the discussed legislation for the day.”

“So, how will you bring up the topic of the Council of Elders if only the Council of Elders themselves bring the discussions?”

“With me,” Anaxa interjected, earning an inquisitive glance from the King.

“You see.” Aglaea stared in Anaxa's direction with a smile. “The Council of Elders is aware that the professor and I do not see eye-to-eye on… certain topics. However, that makes it easier for us to infiltrate the Council of Elders themselves.”

“The Council of Elders plans to question Aglaea's rule during this year's debate,” Anaxa added. “And to win the majority vote of banishing Aglaea from the government, they plan to win by involving the Grove and Styxia.”

“Styxia as well?” Mydei finally tore his eyes from the scroll to land on the one-eyed professor.

“Castorice is currently entertaining the Elders as they please,” Anaxa muttered. “They believe she has truly aligned goals with the Council because she was my student.”

“They plan to unite the kingdoms surrounding Okhema to remove me entirely.” Aglaea chuckled. “They believe they can override Fate with numbers. Once the discussion is brought up by the Council of Elders, we plan, in the debate, to turn it around onto them instead.”

“So, you plan to use the debate to strip them of their power?” Mydei narrowed his eyes. “Is there a guarantee you can win the participating citizens’ votes?”

“There is.” With that knowing smile plastered across Aglaea's face, a hand was waved in Phainon's direction, and he was suddenly taken aback that he was being dragged into the conversation. “The Deliverer may be convincing enough for the common people to vote.”

“*Hah!* And that is why you need Kremnos.” Mydei's smirk landed upon Phainon. “A specific regiment built behind the Deliverer and backed by the Kremnoans. Is that the real reason Phainon is my guard? Not to see his stagnated potential, but because he is the Deliverer with the power of the common people beside him?”

Phainon's mind was swirling over the back and forth that was occurring in this office. What were they even talking about? A specific regiment? And

Phainon was going to be in charge of it? What did he mean by it being “backed by the Kremnoans”? Was this the proposal Aglaea had discussed with him previously? And, did everyone actually refer to him as the Deliverer? He swore he never heard that title as often as he did until this week.

Aglaea continued to smile. “I do believe you have been enjoying my choice of guard for you. I am sure you have no right to complain about him.”

Mydei scoffed again, refusing to answer to her implications. “With the power of the Grove and Styxia to fool the Council of Elders and turn the tides of the debate, the Deliverer and Kremnos will win the common people's vote. That is your plan?”

“With the Deliverer being backed by the kingdom with the strongest military might in all of Amphoreus, I am sure no further convincing would be needed for the common people to vote in Phainon's favor.” Aglaea rolled up the scroll on her desk with a satisfactory smile. “Previously, Phainon could not rally any support against the Council as someone born without noble blood, but with the King of Kremnos at his side, that is an entirely different story. So, how about it, King Mydeimos? Military might in exchange for the safety of your people.”

With a sigh, an unreadable gaze landed upon Phainon. “I see no reason to refuse, assuming you keep your end of the deal. I see no reason not to work with the Deliverer. Although I wonder–” Mydei's gaze shifted to Anaxa. “–what you would get out of this scheme, as someone who is not in favor of Aglaea either.”

“If given the choice of the Council of Elders rule or Aglaea's rule, there is but a simple answer.” Anaxa sighed heavily. “I do not associate with stupidity, nor do I associate with blind devotion. Their unnecessary praise for noble blood is something that I have never agreed with since the start.”

“I am glad we are on the same page about something,” Aglaea chuckled.

“Do not joke with me.” Anaxa clicked his tongue.

With a breath, Aglaea seated herself back into her office chair. “If that is settled, then I will begin preparing the necessary documents to solidify our alliance, King Mydeimos. I will have them sent to you in Kremnos in time for the debate. In the meantime, if you have any further questions, please deliver them to my guard. And, professor, thank you for joining us today.”

Anaxa nodded and immediately fled the room as if he could not stand being in there any longer. Phainon, however, was still in a daze over the previous conversation. He felt he was missing certain pieces that made the entire plan make no sense. All he could truly understand was that Aglaea planned to overthrow the Council of Elders in the upcoming debate a few months from now, and the Grove, Styxia, and Kremnos Kingdom were all uniting under that front. And somehow, Phainon was being dragged into this as well.

“Did you come here with plans to already join the alliance, King Mydeimos?” Aglaea twirled the quill pen that balanced between her lithe fingers. “I hope our previous conversation helped you come to a decision today.”

“I cannot agree to a plan that I do not know what you want with my people.”

“Is that so?” She tilted her head to the side. “Pardon me, but I believe you agreed quite readily.”

“*Hmph*, I just don't see any reason not to cooperate if no harm falls upon my people.” Mydei crossed his arms across his chest. “Some of my attendants have already taken a liking to the Deliverer. It doesn't seem like I will have to force them to support him or stand by his side.”

“Do they now?” Aglaea raised an eyebrow, her polite smile never leaving her lips. “It seems the Deliverer is really completing all of his duties.”

Phainon could only widen his eyes and smile nervously under Aglaea's piercing gaze. He still wasn't completely sure what exactly they were discussing.

Mydei stepped up to Aglaea's desk, where Aglaea looked less than surprised upon him overstaying his visit.

“And to what do I owe your presence, King Mydeimos?” That knowing smirk of hers returned as she gazed upward at Mydei.

“Phainon will be returning with me to Kremnos.”

Phainon almost had to throw a hand up to his chin to stop his jaw from dropping to the floor. He was just going to bring it up just like that?! No segue?!

Aglaea chuckled. “Of course, King Mydeimos. How else will Phainon return in time for the assembly with the military might of Kremnos backing him?”

“Pardon?” Phainon blurted before he could shut his mouth. Why wasn't she the least bit surprised by this development?

She grinned in his direction. “I am just approving your indefinite leave for Kremnos.” Aglaea waved the quill in her hand. “Your leave will be on the grounds of improving battle strategies, war tactics, and formations, and combat skills in the city of Castrum Kremnos, capital of Kremnos Kingdom.”

Phainon's eyes widened in shock. “You… knew I would want to leave?”

“If you didn't want to leave yourself by the end of this week, I would have to convince you myself,” Aglaea stated. “I cannot have you be present at the assembly without having set foot in Kremnos Kingdom. No one would be convinced otherwise that you have the support of the Kremnoans. Was that all, Phainon?”

With the gears turning in his head, Phainon replayed the last few quints, no, the entire last few days in his head, recalling every interaction he had during this week ever since the Kremnoans arrived. “Did you plan for this?”

Aglaea's smile only stayed consistent. “I can only plan, but I cannot force any entity to join arms with me. That all fell upon you, Phainon.” As she spoke these words, her eyes grazed over Phainon's body, and she added, “I am very glad you like your new uniform. It is much more befitting of your status than the usual dreary attire.”

With those last words, Phainon, Mydei, and the two Kremnoan attendants exited the office. Phainon was still in quite a daze from the entire exchange that had just occurred right before him, and he shut the office door behind him, only instinctively letting go of the door handle when he heard the click of the locking door.

“I am sure you have questions.”

Phainon shook himself out of his daze to return Mydei's stare. Although he was correct in that he had many questions swirling in his mind, he thought to start with this first mystery. “What was the proposal Miss Aglaea had for you?”

“Walk with me,” was all Mydei answered. He strolled down the corridor, and Phainon had to quickly hurry to catch up with him.

“Where would you like me to take you?”

“Where else?” The smirk that Mydei sent his way made Phainon's blood pump in anticipation. “The training grounds.”

With a laugh, Phainon led the way to the training grounds with the two Kremnoan attendants in tow while Mydei explained the entirety of Aglaea's plan, answering all of Phainon's questions in the process. Her plan would ultimately conclude with the end of the Council of Elders, and with the Council of Elders falsely believing that Styxia and the Grove were on their side, Aglaea would turn the debate around on them and use the support of Styxia and the Grove to support her once the Council of Elders questions Aglaea's position in Okhema.

Winning the majority vote of the citizens fell upon Phainon, who was being supported by Kremnos, which was a way for the citizens to feel self-assured

in placing their vote for someone with no noble backing. Mydei also explained the Black Tide monsters that were multiplying rapidly outside Kremnos's borders, and he was looking for different places to move his people to in the case that their borders fell to the monsters. Although they were fending them off just fine for now, he couldn't say the same in a few years, and he was planning for the worst. That was what Mydei was getting in exchange for his support in overthrowing the Council of Elders.

Phainon couldn't believe such an elaborate plan had been developed in the background the entire week Phainon was accompanying the Kremnoans around Okhema. But for Aglaea, such a feat was but an everyday task. It was one thing out of many that Phainon admired her for as a leader.

Pushing open the heavy doors of the training grounds, Phainon was shocked to see that there were people already in there. He was so used to seeing the grounds always entirely vacant, so this was the most activity he had ever seen in this place.

“Phainon!” Empousa waved from the middle of the training grounds once the doors abruptly shut behind them. She and the other Kremnoans were sparring in the training grounds, and the whole area was bustling with activity as Phainon could catch them swinging their wooden weapons and dodging here and there.

Phainon could only glance at Mydei in absolute shock, and Mydei was clearly fighting the urge to stifle a laugh at his dumbfounded expression.

“You said you wanted to spar with my attendants, correct?” Mydei cleared his throat in another attempt to hold in his laughter. “I thought to give you the chance while you have the home advantage.

With a large grin all over his face, Phainon laughed loudly, grabbing Mydei's arm and dragging him down to the training grounds. The Kremnoan attendants were quite shocked that the King would let someone drag him around like so, but they also noticed how pleased their King looked at the action as Phainon began digging through the leftover wooden swords.

Phainon pushed Mydei onto the training grounds, and the two split into teams. With Mydei leading one team and Phainon leading the other, the two teams had an all-out brawl in the training grounds, betting on who would best the other first. It was absolute chaos with a multitude of weapons swinging in the air, dirt being kicked up and clouding their vision, and constantly dodging the limbs of all the people on the training grounds, but Phainon couldn't argue against the fact that it was the most fun he had had in quite a long time. He was always practicing his swings by himself every day, and it was refreshing being able to go all out against other people who were just as eager as he was.

The quints passed by just like that. Action Hour soon turned to Parting Hour, and Phainon and the Kremnoans were still outside, drenched in a mixture of dirt and sweat, as they neared the end of another brawl. Phainon had learned a lot about the ways the Kremnoans would study their opponents and how they would approach different types of fighters, yet the score was still tied by the time most of the attendants had collapsed onto the floor in complete and utter exhaustion.

Shadows were stretched all along the training grounds as the sun lowered underneath the horizon, signalling that they were now more than halfway through Parting Hour. With an orange glow cast among everything in the sun's path, a draw was ultimately announced. Phainon was gasping for breath, struggling to even stay on both of his feet as the wooden sword threatened to slip from his loose grip. He had never had to fight with such gusto for so long before, besides the arduous missions he took on outside Okhema’s borders, and he felt just as exhausted as the Kremnoans strewn all over the floor. He watched each one of them also gasping for breath, their chests desperately rising and falling for air.

With one last deep breath, Phainon swept the bangs out of his eyes and looked over at Mydei, who was also just as exhausted. He was wearing the same attire that he had arrived in on the first day, minus the royal sash, so Phainon had a clear view of his half-exposed torso that dripped with rivulets of sweat, lining each and every curve of muscle on Mydei's body. With the sunset behind them that only emphasized the shapes of his strongly built body, Phainon couldn't help but watch each and every droplet

of sweat that ran down his body, lining his pectorals down to his abdomen and disappearing into the waistline that left Phainon desperately wanting more.

He swallowed dryly, averting his gaze. He could *not* be having such thoughts in the training grounds, and in front of everyone else, no less.

“*Woo!*” Empousa broke the silence with a loud, breathy cheer. She was sprawled out on the floor by Phainon's feet; she was quite adamant about joining Phainon's team when they were splitting into two groups. “You're good, Phainon! Really… really good.” She began catching her breath again in between short laughs, wiping the sweat and dirt off her forehead that only served to smear it all along her face. “I see why King Mydeimos likes you so much.”

“Truly… your stamina is quite a wonder.” Herklas was kneeling on Phainon's other side and was also a member of Phainon's team. The statement briefly reminded Phainon that Herklas shared a room with Empousa, which was right next door to Mydei’s, and he had to quickly wipe away the thought before the shame enveloped him at the double meaning of Herklas's words.

Phainon could only let out a breathy laugh. “You guys aren't too bad yourself! I learned a lot about the Kremnoan art of war.”

“I'm glad you were able to enjoy yourself,” Empousa huffed. “But please help me off the floor because I cannot do it myself.”

With another laugh, Herklas and Phainon each took a hand to pull her up from the floor. As she was dusting herself off from the remaining dirt that clung to her clothes, Phainon turned to Mydei and the rest of his team with a smile.

“Did you guys want to enjoy some of Okhema's famous public baths?”

Excited gasps resounded between the two teams, with Phainon taking that as a sign of agreement. They spent the rest of the quint cleaning up the training grounds, righting all the dummies that were thrown out of the way

for their group sparring sessions, and organizing the wooden weapons that they took. With the rest of Parting Hour at their disposal, Phainon led their disheveled group over to the public baths to begin washing up.

It was a vast indoor space filled with small waterfalls and pools of glistening, heated water. In the center of all the connected baths was a grand fountain that many children enjoyed playing in, and many speakers would deliver speeches on top of the fountain. The floors leading up to the baths were made of pristine marble that shone under all the excess water that splashed upon its surface, and the warm lighting from the various lamps set up around the indoor space gave the bath a soft, angelic glow that mixed in with the steam emitting from the water.

Phainon was glad he was able to take the attendants here at least once before they departed, because none of the Kremnoans could get over the grand sight before them. It was what Okhema was famous for, after all, and it would be a shame if they missed out on what many travelers visited Okhema for.

The Kremnoan attendants excitedly tore off their marred clothing, grabbing the robes and towels that were provided by the bath attendants and exploring the vast baths in front of them. Phainon chuckled at their excitement and anticipation as they wandered around like curious children and admired the various sights set before them. They were particularly excited about the fountain in the middle and the waterfalls that they could stand under, and as it was now Parting Hour and nearing the day's end, there weren't many people around to get in the way of their antics.

“You're not going to join them?” Phainon shot Mydei a smile, gesturing to his attendants who were floundering about.

“They deserve this moment of rest before we depart tomorrow.” Mydei watched the Kremnoans scattered throughout the bath with a small smile. “They don't need their King to be breathing down on them during this time of respite.”

“I don't think any of them think of you in that manner.” Phainon had to stifle a laugh when he caught Herklas and Georgious dumping a pile of

water onto Empousa’s head. “They all love and respect you, both as their King and also as their greatest fighter. I don't believe they think of you so much as a stern figure whom they cannot enjoy life with.”

Mydei's eyes caught the marble tiling underneath their feet as he digested those words. “Let us get ready for the baths.”

They each grabbed their own provided towel and robe, stripping themselves of their own dirty clothing and handing it to the bath attendants to take for a cleaning. Phainon was getting quite accustomed to the excess accessories on this new uniform, and he was able to remove all the armor and belts with much more ease than he was used to. Thanking them, they proceeded to one of the more secluded baths within a corner of the area. It was much quieter, and they could peacefully watch over the other Kremnoans splashing about in the other pools of water.

Phainon lowered himself into the bath with a contented sigh as the warm water enveloped his body. Mydei followed suit beside him, and Phainon couldn't help but watch the water blanket his built body. Grazing his body with his eyes, Phainon noticed the marks that Phainon had left all over him had healed already, and his body had returned to being completely unscathed, both from their activities from yesterday and that night, and also from their spar from earlier. He was more amazed that such a feat could occur, but magic was always something Phainon was amazed by.

“HKS.”

The deep voice interrupted his thoughts, and Phainon was immediately met with glaring golden eyes and a light blush across Mydei's cheeks.

“Sorry?”

“You're staring.” Mydei's glare only grew when Phainon widened his eyes. “Quite obviously, in fact.”

“Sorry!” Phainon raised his hands out of the water, but it only resulted in splashing water everywhere. “I wasn't exactly *looking* at you or anything; I was just simply thinking about your… magic.”

With a *hmph*, Mydei averted his gaze and relaxed his body against the wall of the bath behind him. “I wouldn't mind if you were staring, Deliverer. You are just making it too obvious.”

A loud cough erupted from Phainon's throat at the comment, his cheeks equally blooming a deep red as he attempted to settle against the wall beside Mydei. Nonetheless, it was to no avail, because he was way too nervous with how their shoulders faintly brushed against each other, and they were completely bare aside from a single towel underneath the water that draped across each of their laps. Every breath sent their shoulders ghosting against the other's, and it only served to remind Phainon of their close proximity and their lack of clothing.

He chanced a brief glance at Mydei, and he had his head thrown back, resting against the marble tile of the floor with his back lounging against the walls of the bath. Golden hair was spread on the marble tile and messily stuck to his neck and shoulders. His eyes were shut as he reveled in the warm water surrounding his body, and especially after the workout that they had in the training grounds, Phainon could see why he was in such bliss. Phainon would be feeling the same way if he weren't feeling so antsy over their proximity.

Once Phainon had caught his eyes trailing down the rivulets of bath water that ran down his exposed neck and pooled down to his collar bones, tracing his red tattoos, Phainon had to rip his gaze away or else he would get too excited. Maybe he shouldn't have invited the Kremnoans to attend the public baths; he felt as if he were fighting for his life here and struggling to stay sane. Or maybe he should've invited just Mydei during Curtain-Fall Hour, where no one would interrupt them.

Phainon violently shook his head at the incredulous thought. Was he crazy?! Did his mind just insinuate such activities in a public setting?! Well, he *did* masturbate in here, so it wouldn't be the first time. Wait, no, Phainon needed to get all these vulgar thoughts out of his mind. There was no way he could entertain such ideas, especially with the person of all his affection sitting right beside him.

“*HKS*.”

The deep voice came again, cutting through his running thoughts. Phainon whirled around and saw Mydei pushing golden hair out of his face and swiping his hand across his eyes. Oops–Phainon must've splashed water on him when he shook his head earlier.

“Sorry!” Phainon immediately moved to swipe Mydei's hand away from his face as Phainon took the liberty of clearing the extra water droplets that had splashed onto him.

Mydei scowled, his cheeks resting in the palms of Phainon's hands. “What could you possibly be thinking about to be shaking your head like so?”

“Uh…” Phainon drawled, his gaze wavering under Mydei's narrowed eyes. He offered a small, clearly unconvincing smile. “Nothing a king such as yourself should worry yourself with.”

“And if I weren't a king?”

“Then it would be nothing a beautiful, handsome man such as yourself should be worrying himself with.”

Mydei scoffed at the idiotic response, letting his chin rest in Phainon's palms. “You speak as if you don't have a brain.”

“My brain only concerns thoughts of you, King Mydeimos.”

“Spare me the pleasantries.”

“It is nothing but the truth.” Phainon smiled as Mydei's eyes fluttered closed. He gently rubbed his thumbs into Mydei's cheeks, cradling Mydei's face in his hands.

“Then tell me,” Mydei continued with his eyes still shut, “what you were thinking about that made you shake like a wet dog.”

Phainon hummed, debating whether he should actually tell Mydei the truth or not. Though, he was curious to see what kind of reaction he would evoke from the other man. Phainon leaned down, bringing Mydei's face closer to

his and brushing the tips of their noses together. At the sudden movement, Mydei opened his eyes and stared into Phainon.

In a hushed voice, so quiet that only the two of them could hear, Phainon revealed his innermost thoughts: “I was thinking about how I wanted to take you for myself right here and now, Mydei.”

He didn't even realize what had happened after that; he could barely register almost being drowned and being enveloped by a copious amount of water. He barely registered flailing for breath, and he also barely registered two large hands either smacking his head or shoving his shoulders. Phainon, gasping for breath in an attempt to resurface, was left as just a pair of thrashing arms above the surface as he fought with all his might against Mydei. Although, Phainon was failing quite miserably since Mydei had the advantage of moving first and catching Phainon completely off guard.

Suddenly, their altercation turned into wrestling, as Phainon's attempts to resurface did not work. Since that wasn't working, he, instead, opted to drag Mydei underneath the water with him, and soon the two began throwing their arms and hands against each other, pulling and tugging at anything their hands could manage to grab in an attempt to pull the other under the water. Their towels were discarded from the mess of moving limbs as Mydei and Phainon kicked and pulled in the bath, splashing water all over the marble tiles to become the victor in this brawl.

Phainon could faintly make out hoots and hollers in the background every time he managed to resurface and breathe in the open air, but it was short-lived as he was quickly shoved back into the water every time, immersing himself back into silence under the water. He wasn't sure how long they had been wrestling under the water to keep one of them submerged for longer than a few beats, but the nearby bath attendants all scrambled to separate the two.

He was gasping desperately for air now that he could sit upright in the bath again; Mydei was mirroring his exact movements right across from him, his bare shoulders shaking with every breath. His hair was drenched and flat against his head, tangled this way and that from the altercation. Phainon was sure he didn't look any better.

Waving the concerned bath attendants away with a reassuring smile, Phainon pushed the hair out of his eyes with a hearty laugh. “I told you not to concern yourself with my thoughts, King Mydeimos.”

“How was I supposed to know you would have such *obscene* thoughts?” Mydei hissed back, running an impatient hand through his hair and slicking his golden bangs back. “We are in a *public* area, HKS.”

“That didn't stop me before,” Phainon mumbled, but he didn't realize that he had let it slip until he felt a hard kick to his shin under the water.

“*Ow!*”

“You *what?*”

“Mydei, that hurt!”

“Didn’t stop you from *what?*”

Mydei was seething as he approached him from the other side of the bath. He looked absolutely ready to shove Phainon back into the water and resume what the bath attendants had previously broken up.

“Wait, wait, Mydei, I'll explain!” Phainon had thrown his hands up into the air once more, splashing water onto Mydei's torso in an attempt to separate them. “I… I…”

“You have exactly 3 seconds to explain, HKS.”

“It was just–”

“Three.”

“It was just the heat of the moment–”

“Two.”

“I couldn't–"

“One.”

“I was by myself!”

That made Mydei pause in front of him, and Phainon's shoulders relaxed once he realized it had worked.

The golden-haired man sighed exasperatedly, lowering his hands that were ready to shove Phainon underneath the surface once again. “You… I thought you had lied to me about your lack of experience.”

“I would never!” Phainon immediately straightened up at the accusation. “I was… truly by myself.”

“So? What did you happen to do here, in such a public area, by yourself?”

Phainon gulped at the revealing question, averting his gaze as his cheeks flushed red. “Well… Did you… really need to know the specifics right now?”

“*Hmph*.” Mydei crossed his arms. It seemed that he also remembered they were having this sort of conversation in front of others.

As he was settling back down into the bath, a voice called to them from farther down the baths. With both of the men turning in their direction, Phainon noticed Empousa waving at them in the distance. He also noticed that the baths were much emptier now that it was getting late into Parting Hour.

“My King! Phainon!” She started this elaborate gesture of scooping her arms in the air towards her direction, jutting her head to the area beside her and the other attendants.

Phainon laughed, cocking his head at Mydei. “I told you they would want you over there.”

With another *hmph*, Mydei grabbed his towel and robe and began making his way over, with Phainon following shortly behind. They spent the rest of Parting Hour lounging around in the baths and enjoying the water. Mydei

and Phainon actually took the time to clean themselves off of the day’s debris while Empousa and the other attendants excitedly pestered the two of them over who had won the wrestle in the bath. They also asked what they had been discussing in their secluded little corner, to which Mydei seamlessly steered the conversation away into another direction. Phainon, however, couldn't hide the embarrassment that washed over his face, and Empousa spent much of her time teasing Phainon by making up theories of what they could have been talking about.

Their time in the baths was brought to an end when a maid had scrambled inside to inform them that the kitchen would be closing at Curtain-Fall Hour, and if they wanted supper, they should start heading over to the dining hall. Because they had skipped their midday meal, again, due to spending most of their afternoon in the training grounds, the unanimous decision was made to have at least another proper meal before the day ended. Drying themselves off and dressing in their newly washed clothing, Phainon bid the remaining bath attendants goodbye before leading the Kremnoans to their usual dining room.

As they all seated themselves in their usual spots, the servants brought out the night's dinner on silver platters, as usual. Setting the table and presenting the dishes in an orderly fashion, their meal for the day was an entire roasted chicken marinated in a rich gravy sauce and placed upon glistening greens. As it shone in the center of the table under the chandelier lighting, the surrounding platters consisted of various salads and a sweet and creamy pumpkin bean casserole. The steam rose from the chicken and casserole, wafting their delicious scents across the entire table, and everyone heartily dug into the food. Especially after a day's worth of sparring and skipping their midday meal, everyone was looking forward to such a filling dish.

The chicken was extravagantly crispy as Phainon took a large mouthful, yet the meat on the inside was deliciously juicy. The flavor spread wonderfully along his tongue as Phainon indulged himself in more of the rich meat. The spices that the chicken was cooked in mixed well with the tanginess of the lemon that was squeezed on its crispy surface, and the steaming pumpkin bean casserole served on the side was a nice offset to the sourness of the

chicken. The salad was a nice touch as well; though, Phainon may be biased simply because he enjoyed salad and thought it should be a staple in every meal.

The entire table was completely silent save for the clatter of their utensils. Everyone ravaged the lavish meal served in front of them as their last full day had finally come to an end. Phainon was sure they would enjoy being able to return to their home kingdom, but he at least hoped they had enjoyed their week's stay in Okhema. This all reminded Phainon that he, too, would be joining them in Kremnos Kingdom. He certainly needed to gather all his belongings together so he was ready to depart with Mydei and the others in the morning, but he definitely wanted to bid some farewells first before he left. The great debate where Aglaea's plans would come to fruition wasn't for another couple of months, which meant Phainon most likely would not return to Okhema until then.

The attending maids quickly removed the cleaned plates, courtesy of everyone who had completely destroyed all the presented food. They had even brought out another serving, to which many of the attendants continued to savor. Phainon smiled as he watched everyone in front of him revel in the food; he was grateful they were enjoying themselves like so.

As they were finishing the last few bites of the food, Mydei had pushed himself up to his feet, and Phainon quickly followed suit. He watched as Mydei gestured to his attendants to continue eating, and all the Kremnoans visibly relaxed in their seats.

“Let us go, Phainon.”

Without waiting for Phainon's response, Mydei had already begun approaching the door to exit the dining hall. As Phainon had already satisfied himself with the food, he scrambled after Mydei, not forgetting to thank all the servants and inform them to take the Kremnoans up to their rooms once they were finished eating.

“You’re not going to wait for your attendants?” Phainon had finally caught up to Mydei's side as he followed him in whichever direction Mydei was taking them to.

“I'm sure they can make it to their rooms themselves.” Mydei continued to walk onward with Phainon in tow.

“What are you in such a rush for that you couldn't wait for them to finish?” Phainon asked this in a curious tone. “And speaking of, where are we going?”

“I recall that we depart this kingdom tomorrow, yet you do not have the least of your belongings with you.”

Phainon's eyes slightly widened. It was as if Mydei could now read his mind. “So, you're taking me–”

“To the soldier's barracks.” Mydei raised an eyebrow in Phainon’s direction. “Unless I am not allowed in there.”

“No!” Phainon blurted out. “You are allowed wherever you wish.”

“Because I am a king, or because I am Mydei?”

“Because you are Mydei,” Phainon confidently and immediately answered with a smile. “If you were only a king to me still, I would be insisting on leading you there myself.”

Mydei scoffed as he continued onward toward the exit of Marmoreal Palace. “You would have.”

Feeling the cool night air against their skin as they stepped into the outside, Phainon took the lead in showing Mydei to the soldier's barracks once they had exited Marmoreal Palace, as Mydei had never been there before and didn't know where it would be. It was nearby since it was directly adjacent to the palace in case an emergency arose, so the soldiers could quickly attend to and defend the palace.

As it was late into Curtain-Fall Hour, most of the soldiers were sleeping, with the exception of the few that were up on guard duty for that quint. Nodding in acknowledgement at the soldiers he happened to cross, Phainon pushed open the shoddy door leading to the shared living space of all the

soldiers. Although there were spacious rooms that separated the soldiers within the barracks, there were usually about twenty to thirty soldiers who each crowded into one room. He wasn't sure why exactly Mydei had wanted to join him in packing his belongings, but Phainon couldn't complain about the company.

He led Mydei to the room where he currently resided; for some reason, some of the soldiers were still up and conversing with each other late into the night. They immediately perked up when they saw Phainon, most likely due to the fact that Phainon had not been sleeping here for the past few days. He could tell they were about to greet him, but they quickly cowered when they saw who was behind him.

Phainon just gave them an awkward smile in greeting before returning his attention back to his bed. It was just a single bed with a simple wooden frame on the floor, and all his belongings were either underneath the bed, in a wooden trunk that sat on the floor at the end of his bed, or in the single nightstand that each bed came with.

“Are you helping me bring everything to your room?” Phainon joked as he began emptying his nightstand’s belongings onto his bed. There really wasn’t much in there; all it housed were various appraisal tools, scrolls, books, and stone tablets. Phainon didn’t have the time during this week of being a guard for the Kremnoans, but one of his hobbies was actually antique appraisals and collecting antiques. He was sure the trunk near the foot of his bed contained only a bunch of real and fake antiques he had collected over the years he stayed in Okhema, and he was, unfortunately, prepared to part with some of his beloved antiques so he could move most of his belongings to Kremnos.

“What do you think I’m here for?” Mydei began sorting through all the reading material that Phainon had haphazardly dumped onto his bed, organizing the different materials into separate piles. “Did you think I came here just to watch?”

Phainon froze as he watched Mydei meticulously sorting through his belongings. “I… I was only kidding, Mydei, you don’t have to do that.”

“Do you expect me to just sit here and watch?” Mydei impatiently repeated.

“Well… yeah.”

He scoffed in response, never taking his eyes off the piles of reading materials. “I thought I came here as *Mydei*.”

“I just thought you wanted to see where I stayed,” Phainon laughed lightly as he resumed digging through his nightstand to ensure he didn’t miss anything. “You don’t have to if you don’t want to.”

“Do you really expect me to sit here and wait if we can complete this faster with the two of us working?” Mydei huffed as he examined one of the appraisal tools in his hand. It was just a balance beam, consisting of two pans that hung from a central beam, and it was used to measure the weight of materials. “Why do you have this?”

“It’s a balance beam!” Phainon pressed a finger down on one of the pans, and they watched as it sank while the other pan was raised into the air. “I use it when appraising antiques.”

“Appraising antiques?”

Phainon grinned in excitement at the thought of being able to talk about antiques and relics. “My entire trunk over there is full of antiques.” He waved toward the trunk sitting on the floor. “I don’t think I can bring them all, though.”

“Why not?”

“Why?” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows at the other man. “Because they wouldn’t fit?”

Mydei equally appeared just as puzzled at Phainon. “Just bring the whole trunk.”

“They wouldn’t fit?”

“Yes, they can.”

“But–” Phainon squinted at Mydei with extreme uncertainty. “–with everyone else’s belongings–”

“They will fit, so stop talking and throw everything into the trunk.” Before Phainon could argue further, Mydei had already taken the liberty of cracking open the trunk and stacking the tablets, books, and scrolls inside. Phainon could faintly hear the rattling of the antiques inside as metal knocked against metal.

Phainon wasn’t exactly sure if he could just take the trunk, as it had come with the bed when he was assigned to this spot in the barracks, but he continued as Mydei had ordered and began rummaging under the bed for the rest of his belongings. All there were under the bed were more appraisal tools that were too big to fit in the nightstand; clothes, which consisted mostly of the soldier’s basic uniform; and tools used to sharpen and polish his sword. Of course, he had to pay special attention to his beloved Dawnmaker, but he was sure Kremnos had even better tools to keep their weapons pristine. He didn’t bother with the whetstones and cloths that he always used for his weapon and only handed Mydei the other belongings he could scavenge from under the bed. He didn’t really need his soldier’s uniforms anymore, but he also didn’t have anything else to wear, so he tossed those as well in Mydei’s direction.

Which immediately earned Phainon a scowl from the other man. “Why are you bringing these?”

“I don’t have anything else to wear.” Phainon sheepishly chuckled.

Mydei clicked his tongue and threw the clothes at Phainon. “Don’t bother. We will prepare new clothes in Kremnos.”

Phainon’s vision immediately turned black when the clothing landed straight on his face, and he could hear the murmurs from the other soldiers that were still awake in the barracks. Phainon was sure that, by tomorrow, the news of his departure to Kremnos would spread throughout Marmoreal Palace. He peeled off the clothing with a laugh, leaving them on the bed for when he could return them to Aglaea before he departed.

They soon finished packing all of his things into the wooden trunk, and Phainon swiped his hands across each other to rid them of the layer of dust that had built up on his palms from digging through everything under his bed. With the brass hinges creaking, Mydei closed the trunk shut, with the lid landing with a satisfied *thump*. After Phainon threw the extra uniforms on top of the closed trunk, Mydei glanced in Phainon's direction, and with a silent agreement, each of them took one of the iron handles on either end of the trunk and hauled it out of the barracks. Even though Phainon struggled with the weight of the wooden trunk, he managed to give a quick wave to the soldiers who were still awake and were watching them the entire time, to which the soldiers quickly returned.

Most of the weight was due to all the antiques that Phainon had refused to part with, and they eventually hobbled their way back to Mydei's temporary bedroom with the trunk swinging between them. The most difficult part of the trip was definitely the stairs, where they were forced to set the trunk down onto the floor while one of them pushed up the trunk on one end and the other pulled and steered at the other end. They were both exhausted by the time they had finally made it to their destination and dropped the trunk down into a corner, and Phainon would have collapsed onto the bed if he had not been adorned in so much armor. Mydei shut the door with a deep breath as Phainon began making quick work of ripping his clothing off and leaving him in only the black undershirt and dark trousers.

"So–" Mydei's deep voice cut through their silence. Behind Phainon, he could hear the gold of Mydei's gauntlets hitting against what he could only assume to be one of the tables in the room as he also prepared to ready himself for bed. "–I think it is time for you to explain what you were doing in the public baths."

Phainon quickly recalled their previous conversation and immediately bloomed a deep red. "Do you really have to know?"

"What did you do in there, Phainon?"

Mydei was definitely not going to let him sleep until he found out the truth, so Phainon could only give him the answer that he sought. "I… may have… touched myself to you… in there." Phainon's voice was barely above a

whisper, but he knew Mydei heard him when a long silence followed his confession.

Phainon didn’t even want to turn around to look at Mydei, but he also felt it was wrong to proceed to the bed as if he had not said a word about what he did. Phainon could only continue to stand, completely motionless, under Mydei’s glaring gaze on his back.

“You…” A deep, exasperated sigh sounded from behind him. “When you said you touched yourself to me on the second night…”

“It… was in there.” Phainon awkwardly laughed, chancing a glance over his shoulder to gauge Mydei’s reaction. His expression was a mix of utter bewilderment and exasperation, but he also looked way too tired to deal with this new information.

“You… would rather masturbate in a public space than just sleep with me?”

“No!” Phainon laughed and immediately whirled around to grasp Mydei's hands. Staring straight into golden eyes, Phainon murmured, “You were just so alluring that I couldn't wait until I got to my bed.”

Mydei's face flushed a gorgeous red color as he cleared his throat and averted his gaze. “You… HKS.”

Mydei was absolutely stunning and breathtaking in Phainon's eyes. He couldn't even believe for a moment that this man was voluntarily his partner.

“Shall we?” Phainon tilted his head toward the bed. “We have a busy morning tomorrow.”

With a nod from the other man, they both returned to the bed after turning out the lights and crawled under the silk sheets. This would be Phainon's last night in Okhema for a long time, and he couldn't even fathom that fact. He spent much time before falling asleep deep in his thoughts about his many years in Okhema and all the things that he did while serving as a soldier for this kingdom.

As he stared up at the ceiling, which he couldn't see since they had already drowned the bedroom into the darkness of the night, he reminisced about all the people he had met, all the food that he had eaten, and all the quests and missions that he had done as a soldier here. Even if he did not have any particularly strong connections in the capital, Okhema was still a dear place in his heart, and he couldn't help but miss it at the thought of moving to Kremnos Kingdom. Of course, he knew that Kremnos would treat him well, but that didn't stop his heart from feeling for his days in Okhema.

Once Phainon closed his eyes and fell asleep, that would be it for his time in Okhema. He couldn't believe it would happen just like that. What awaited him in Kremnos? And, how will the palace handle the news of his departure?

“Not tired?” A deep, husky voice cut through the darkness. From the tone of his voice, Phainon could tell Mydei was exhausted, and he was surprised he was even still awake.

“Not sleeping yet?” Phainon turned his head away from the ceiling to face the direction of Mydei's voice.

The bed shifted next to him; he could only assume that Mydei had turned his body to face him, but Phainon's eyes were still adjusting to the darkness.

“What are you thinking about?” A hand reached out to cradle Phainon's cheek, and he was more amazed over the fact that Mydei had such good accuracy in the darkness.

“Just reminiscing about my time in Okhema,” Phainon responded in a low voice as Mydei's thumb began rubbing small, gentle circles into his cheek. “It's my last night in Okhema now, so it just got me thinking.”

Mydei hummed. “Will you miss it here?”

“Of course I'll miss it here.” Phainon smiled longingly at the thought of leaving his home kingdom. “But, I think I would miss you more if I stayed.”

A scoff resounded in the darkness. “What is with you and these lines today?”

Phainon chuckled, turning his body to face Mydei. “I don't know what you mean. I'm always like this.”

“Says the guy who couldn't even speak with me casually only a few days ago.”

“I don't know what you're referring to.” Phainon feigned ignorance with another laugh.

“You went from not being able to drop formalities to blatant flirting in a matter of a few days.”

“Are you blushing, Mydei?” Phainon teased with a grin and stretched out his arm to feel for his face, but a hand quickly swatted his arm away.

“Just go to sleep, HKS.”

Phainon laughed once more as the bed shifted again under Mydei's weight when he turned his back toward Phainon and effectively ended the conversation. As if it were now second nature, Phainon wrapped his arm around Mydei's waist, pulling their bodies together until his chest was pressed comfortably against Mydei's back. With a soft smile, he buried his nose into golden hair, shutting his eyes so that sleep could overtake his consciousness.

That was, until a deep voice cut through the darkness once again.

“You're not going to say it tonight?”

Wearily opening his eyes at his words, Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “Say what tonight?”

“What you said last night.”

“What did I say to you last night?”

A brief silence followed his question before Mydei roughly replied, “Forget it.”

Silence enveloped them once more, but Phainon couldn't fall asleep now that he had said that. Now that Mydei had raised this question only to tell Phainon to forget about it, it just made Phainon all the more eager to remember. What were they conversing about the previous night? He couldn't recall at all. He could barely even remember what they ate last night, let alone what they talked about. Were they not just exchanging stories from their lives? He frowned, but he truly could not recall what he told Mydei. And, why would Mydei want him to repeat it again?

Phainon could only hope Mydei was still awake as he asked, “Did I promise you something?”

“I told you to forget it, so why are you still thinking about it?”

“Can I at least get a hint?”

“You did not promise to do something for me.”

“...Can I get another hint?”

“HKS,” Mydei hissed. “Were you not the one who said we had a long morning tomorrow?”

“How am I supposed to sleep now after you asked me to repeat something I said to you last night?” Phainon whined while tugging his arms that were still hooked around Mydei's waist. “Please give me another hint?”

A deep sigh and a few Kremnoan words came from Mydei–Phainon could only assume from the way he mumbled that they were not kind Kremnoan words. “You didn't necessarily say it to me.”

“Huh?” Now Phainon was confused. “I didn't say it to you, but you want me to repeat what I said to you?”

“I can only assume you thought I was sleeping when you said it.”

Phainon said something to Mydei when he thought he fell asleep?

He immediately shot up in bed with his heart pounding sporadically in his chest. A rush of adrenaline shot through his veins as his face instantly heated up once the memory was recalled.

“You were *awake?!”* Phainon practically screamed into the darkness. Embarrassment and shame washed over his body. Mydei was *not* supposed to hear those words from him so soon. Were those words true? Absolutely. But, was he sure Mydei didn't want to hear those words just after a few days? Of course he was sure Mydei didn't want to hear it.

Mydei sighed once more. “You always never know when I fall asleep. First, the second night, and now last night.”

“You… weren't supposed to hear that.” Phainon deflated the more the truth settled within him. Mydei had *heard* him? He stared down at the bedsheets with his aching heart as he muttered, “I'm… really sorry, Mydei. Could you maybe… forget I said that for now?”

“You want me to forget that?”

“I… Well… I…” Phainon kept opening and closing his mouth, unsure of what to say next. Was this situation even salvageable at this point? Should he just fall asleep and pretend he was so tired that he fell asleep right at this moment? He wrung his fingers together as he attempted to dig up some sort of statement that could settle the situation for now, but nothing was coming to him. Even in the darkness, he knew he was being scrutinized under Mydei's sharp gaze, and he wanted to shrink himself in some corner of the room–perhaps the corner that temporarily housed his belongings. His only saving grace was that he could not actually see Mydei with the lights out.

“I'm… sorry.” It was the only thing that Phainon could think of saying. There was no excuse he could come up with.

“What are you apologizing for?”

“For… saying that to you.” Phainon shakily let go of a breath he had been holding in his chest, but it still did not calm his twisting heart. “You didn't want to hear that. I know it's… It's quite early. And it unsettled you to hear that so soon. Admittedly, as you already know, this is my first time having a partner, so I understand there are things that I don't know or are unfamiliar with. So, I want to apologize for that and what I said last night. I know I thought you were sleeping, but I shouldn't have said it or thought it regardless. I know you probably–”

“Phainon.”

He was shaken out of his thoughts when two warm hands separated his tangling fingers.

Continuing to stare down at his lap, Phainon wished for a brief moment that the lights were on so that he could see Mydei's hands wrapped around his trembling ones. “Mydei, I'm really–”

“Was it true?”

“Huh?” Phainon raised his head at the question, and he could now faintly make out the shape of Mydei in front of him.

“What you said last night,” Mydei sternly repeated. “Did you mean it?”

With widening eyes, Phainon couldn't help his hands from trembling more in his lap as he digested his question. “I… um… I mean… I did, but–”

“Good.”

A quick peck landed upon his lips for only a brief moment, and Phainon jumped at the sudden action. He stared blankly at Mydei with wide eyes. “Good?”

“I had to make sure you weren't apologizing for being in love with me.” The two hands that were tightly grasping to Phainon's left, and the coldness that he felt brush against his fingers was soon overpowered by the

incredible warmth that soon encompassed his cheeks. “I love you too, Phainon.”

Warm lips pressed against Phainon's lips once more, and his widened eyes fluttered shut at the sensation. With a sound escaping from his throat, Phainon did his best to keep up with Mydei's pace as he deepened the kiss, his fingers twitching in his lap every time Mydei's lips moved against his. Mydei's hands cradled Phainon's cheeks in a gentle, yet firm, hold even when they parted.

“Did you think I would ask you to repeat words I didn't want to hear?” Mydei sharply asked. “And, you seem to forget that this is also my first time too. What makes you think we are so different?”

Phainon was still trying to gather his bearings after that amazing kiss. “You just… You just seem so much more mature and self-assured and grounded that I thought–”

“That I didn't feel the same as you?” Mydei cocked his head to the side. “Did you think a self-assured man would bring someone back to their kingdom who they weren't at least falling in love with?”

Phainon swore he could feel his pounding heart rattling his rib cage as Mydei confessed to him a second time. He gulped loudly at his words as he struggled to contain his blush. “You… love me?”

“Didn't I just say that, HKS?” Mydei swiped a thumb along Phainon's lower lip. “You were going on such a tangent over nothing that I had to interrupt you.”

A laugh rose from Phainon's chest along with the tension that escaped from his body. “Honestly, I was so nervous that I'm not actually sure what I said either.”

Mydei scoffed at him. “How ridiculous. You should have just done what I asked of you in the first place instead of going straight to apologizing.”

Phainon laughed once more. “Sorr–*Ow!*”

“Were you not just listening to me?” Mydei withdrew his hand that had just pinched Phainon's cheek. “Now say it again.”

“You just pinched me for saying it again!”

“Not that, HKS,” Mydei snapped. “Say it again.”

With a grin, Phainon knew exactly what he was referring to. He wrapped his arms around Mydei's waist, pulling him until the man was practically sitting in his lap. “I love you too, Mydei.”

“*Hmph*, took you long enough.” Mydei relaxed in Phainon's lap and ran a hand through his silver hair. He bent down to peck another kiss upon Phainon's lips, murmuring softly, “Good boy. Now we can go to sleep.”

Electricity ran down Phainon's spine, and his grasp around Mydei's waist tightened. “*Mydei*,” Phainon breathlessly whined, staring up at him with a frown. He could feel Mydei’s hot breath brushing against his lips from how close they still were. “You can't just say that and then expect me to go to sleep.”

Mydei chuckled, playing with the hair on the back of Phainon's head. He could feel something hard now poking into his behind. “You're hard just from that?”

“*Mydei*,” Phainon breathed desperately against his lips, feeling the uncomfortable pressure in his lower half. It was taking everything he had to stop himself from grinding into Mydei's behind and chasing that sweet friction his body desperately craved.

With another soft chuckle, Mydei pushed himself off of Phainon's lap. “Fine. Lay down.”

Phainon had never jumped back into bed so fast in his life. His vision was becoming much more accustomed to the dark now, and he could faintly make out Mydei seating himself between Phainon's legs. His heartbeat quickened in his chest at the anticipation, and the pit of his stomach was already churning at the mere thought of the pleasure.

“Be a good boy for me, Phainon.” Mydei had lowered himself down, unveiling Phainon's dick that had been previously straining in his pants. The night air brushed against him, and Phainon's bare dick twitched at the change in temperature.

His breath hitched in his throat at the words, and a satisfied moan was released into the air as the tip of his cock was enveloped in a beautiful and wet cavern. Mydei swirled his tongue around his tip, grazing his tongue under the ridge of his head and swiping along his slit. Phainon's fingers reached for the sheets underneath them as Mydei sank himself lower and lower on his length. Hands shot out to root Phainon's hips to the bed as he began bobbing up and down, taking in more of Phainon's hardness into his mouth every time he sank himself down. Phainon had to throw a hand over his mouth to stifle another long moan once he felt the tip of Mydei's nose reach his silver hair, and Mydei released his dick with a sharp *pop*.

“I told you to be a good boy, so why are you covering your mouth?” His voice was raspy from taking Phainon in so deeply.

The blood instantly rushed down to his dick as it pulsed at his words. Phainon slowly lowered his hand with a loud gulp, feeling the sheets between his fingers once more as the pit of his stomach dangerously tightened.

“*Good boy*.”

Warmth enveloped the entirety of Phainon's dick once more, and his hips jolted violently at the pleasure that rushed through his limbs. Another loud moan escaped him as Mydei's hands steadily held him down, sucking hard around his dick and lapping at the precum that had spilled from Mydei's words. Phainon fisted the sheets as his legs trembled around Mydei, and his abdomen flexed in an attempt to hold down his release that threatened to come out.

“*Mydei!*” Phainon breathlessly whined into the air. “Mydei–*AHH!* Mydei, Mydei, *please!*”

He was trying so hard not to cover his mouth, and he was sure he was close to tearing the sheets that were bundled in his hands. Phainon's face had already bloomed red from constantly hearing the sounds of only his moans and gasps filling the dark room, as the only other sound that accompanied his groans came from Mydei's lips that were wrapped around his cock and messily sucking up and down his shaft.

Mydei moaned around his dick as his tip hit the back of Mydei's throat, and the vibrations sent Phainon over the edge as he suddenly came into his mouth. With his hands flying to Mydei's hair and pushing his head down, his hips jerked as he spilled himself inside of Mydei's throat. Moan after moan continued to spill from his parted lips as his vision turned white and his back arched off the bed. Digging his heels into the sheets, Phainon gasped for breath until his trembling legs finally stilled, and he collapsed into the mattress.

Untangling his fingers from golden hair, Phainon was left catching his breath as Mydei released his dick with another *pop*.

“That was quite fast, Phainon,” Mydei teased.

“You're unfair, Mydei.” Phainon was still completely breathless after coming down from his high as his vision began to correctly orient itself.

The other man laughed from between his legs. “Ready for bed now?”

Phainon was still trying to catch his breath, but he managed to ask, “What about you?”

“It will settle down in time.” Mydei made a move toward the space adjacent to Phainon, but he quickly stopped him.

“Turn around.” Phainon reached his hand out and caught Mydei's forearm. “Come here.”

“Turn around?” Mydei stiffly held himself in the same place as he was unsure what Phainon was asking him to do.

“Come here.” Tugging on his forearm, Phainon led Mydei until his body was hovering over him. With their close proximity, Phainon could see even his golden eyes in the darkness. “Turn around.”

“HKS,” Mydei whispered sharply in the dark. “What are you thinking of doing to me?”

“Don't you want to find out?” Phainon chuckled lowly, guiding Mydei to turn around who only hesitantly did so, until his body was completely oriented the other way.

Phainon swallowed dryly once he had finally settled Mydei into the position he had wanted him in: Mydei, on all fours, holding himself over Phainon's body, with his behind right in front of Phainon's face. Flattening his palms upon Mydei’s lower back, his hands pulled his silk robe up, pushing it up his back and revealing Mydei's bare lower body to him.

“You really do not like undergarments, do you?” Quickly swiping his tongue across his lips at the sight before him that he could barely see, Phainon slid his thumb in between Mydei's ample cheeks, teasing the entrance that was presented so beautifully in front of him.

Mydei jumped at the sensation, and Phainon had to hold a hand to his waist to prevent him from squirming further away. Curses spilled from Mydei's lips as his legs began to tremble around Phainon's torso the more he grazed his fingertips against his clenching hole.

“What… are you doing to me, HKS?” Mydei managed with a groan as his hips continued to quiver over Phainon.

“I wanted to return the favor,” Phainon mumbled. He wished the lights were on so he could have a clear view of the sight before him; it was still too dark for him to fully see everything like he wanted. Although his eyes were somewhat accustomed to the dark, he could barely make out the curve of Mydei's ass that was presented in front of him, and the moonlight barely illuminated his red tattoos that even ran along his skin all the way down here. “But, I know you prefer it down here more.”

He could feel how much Mydei's desperate entrance attempted to clench around his fingertips that rubbed and prodded him. Although Phainon did want to put it inside, it was still too dry; he didn't want to force his fingers in. It may have still been a bit loose from their… previously recent activities, but Phainon was still unsure if he could just stick his fingers inside. But, he also wasn't actually sure if there was anything else he could use to make him not so dry. What did they use before? Phainon recalled their first night together and had flashes to when Mydei had so delectably coated his fingers. Would that be enough?

Shifting in his place in the bed, Phainon tightly held Mydei's waist with both hands and leaned forward. Right as his breath ghosted over Mydei's hole, he hesitantly stuck his tongue out and lapped at the area.

Mydei cursed with another jump, slamming his face down with another groan. “Fuck! HKS… HKS, what–*MMPH!”*

His legs trembled violently around Phainon the more he licked and sucked the ring of muscle that twitched under his tongue. Mydei tried to swing an arm behind him to shove Phainon's face away, but with another hard suck, his hand flew to claw at the bedsheets instead with another moan. Phainon was only really trying to coat his entrance, but it seemed that Mydei was really feeling something from his ministrations.

“Does this feel good, Mydei?” His voice was muffled from being squished in between Mydei's ample cheeks, and Mydei's face heated up at the thought.

“Dont talk when you're in there!” Mydei harshly snapped. He couldn't admit that even the vibrations of his voice felt good against him, and the hot breaths that Phainon released from his lips with every word sent Mydei into a spiral. He swore he could even feel his entrance trying to clench around his breaths as he tried to calm the fluttering in his stomach with his own deep breaths. Mydei couldn't have imagined in an entire millennia that Phainon was inexperienced no matter how much he claimed it to be–what kind of inexperienced man decided to eat him out on their third night as a couple?

Phainon didn't receive an answer to his question, so Phainon wasn't completely positive if this felt good or just plain weird to Mydei. Nonetheless, he continued; if Mydei really hated this, Phainon would have been tossed onto the floor long ago. Flattening his tongue along the spasming hole and lapping across its entirety, he alternated between licking and sucking at his entrance as Mydei continued to claw desperately at the sheets underneath them, struggling to stifle his moans. His entrance continued to convulse under his tongue and even tried to suck his tongue inside.

With Mydei's back arched, Phainon had better access to his hole, and he tilted his head to ravage deeper at his desperate heat. It actually didn't taste as bad as Phainon had originally expected it to; it actually didn't taste like much at all. His mind, instead, was more focused on Mydei's scent and the sounds he emitted the more he cried and groaned from his tongue, and he couldn't help the blood from rushing to the area underneath his waist once again the louder Mydei's moans became.

Mydei's arched back caused his dick to rub against Phainon's torso, and the friction sent a shock of pleasure up Mydei's spine. He couldn't even believe what he was doing as his hips hopelessly began rutting into Phainon to chase that electric pleasure, and every thrust sent Phainon's tongue to press deeper against his hole. He tried so hard to still his hips, but it was as if someone else were in control of his body with the way pleasure continued to run through his limbs with every hard thrust of his hips.

Mydei had already shoved his face down to silence his voice, and it was so hard to breathe. But his moans were embarrassingly loud as he called Phainon's name over and over again the more his hips continued to wildly grind his dick against Phainon's chest. His shivering legs could barely hold him up now with this double stimulation, and Phainon was doing most of the work in holding him up to suck at his hole. Mydei didn't really realize what he had shoved his face into in an attempt to conceal his sounds; it wasn't until he felt something hard brushing against his shoulder that he realized he had shoved his face into Phainon's thigh, and the man underneath him had grown hard from sucking at his hole.

He watched with half-lidded eyes and parted, drooling lips as the moonlight faintly illuminated the curve of Phainon's dick that twitched unashamedly in the air. It was the only view he had the more he panted and groaned from Phainon's tongue, and he was sure his hot breaths brushed against Phainon's dick because it pulsed with every sound that Mydei emitted. It was almost like it was asking to be teased by Mydei, and, even under the immense pleasure he was feeling, he managed to inch closer to Phainon's length to grasp it in one hand.

Phainon jolted when he felt his hard cock was consumed in a warm wetness, and his hips unconsciously thrust upwards to revel in that warmth. Mydei moaned around his mouth, and Phainon flinched at the vibrations that ran along his length. He dug his heels into the bed as Mydei began sucking around his cock once more while grinding himself against his chest. With a loud moan, Phainon threw his head back as he had another taste inside Mydei's mouth as he began bobbing his head up and down his shaft. How was he supposed to get Mydei off when his own dick was having its own fun?

It was quite the struggle, but Phainon managed to snap his chin back down to suck at Mydei's hole again, and his thrusting hips trembled from the resumed pleasure. He was determined to make Mydei cum first before he did; how was he going to win if he already came once? There was no way Phainon was going to allow himself to cum twice before Mydei even came once.

Mydei's muffled moan loudly resounded against Phainon's cock when he felt his tongue snake its way inside his hole. He fell forward against Phainon's hips as his dick slipped out from his mouth, and he couldn't hide the moans and pleas that continually spilled from his lips as Phainon began thrusting his tongue in and out of his hole. It felt so good to finally have Phainon's warmth inside of him, but he didn't expect it at all to go like this. His grinding stilled as his body was now entirely focused on the pleasure that emitted from his clenching hole that tried to suck Phainon's tongue deeper inside, and his hips shook violently as his quivering knees tried their hardest to keep his body up for Phainon.

Eyes were rolled into the back of Mydei's head as he clawed and grasped at Phainon's thighs, and his hot breaths and groans brushed against the base of Phainon's dick. All other thoughts rushed out of his brain as the only two conflicting thoughts he had in his mind were to suck Phainon's tongue deeper inside his hole and to try not to sit on Phainon's face and suffocate the guy. These two fighting thoughts made Mydei push his hips deeper into Phainon's face while attempting to desperately still his hips at the same time.

“I bet I could make you cum first.”

These words snapped Mydei out of his stupor, and his visions suddenly focused on the dick that was still standing proudly in front of him. Was Phainon trying to prove that he had Mydei wrapped around his finger? Not even a chance. With a scoff and a newfound fire brimming through his veins, Mydei's trembling hands pushed him upwards until his lips hovered over the tip of Phainon's dick once more.

“You wish.”

After Mydei's words, he sank himself back over Phainon's length, sinking himself deeper, taking the entire shaft into his mouth, and feeling the head hit against the back of his throat. Phainon moaned loudly against Mydei's hole, and the vibrations sent both men to shudder at the pleasure. Both of them began trying to make quick work of the other as Mydei began sucking up and down his length and lapping at the head of Phainon's dick with tears gathering in the corner of his eyes while Phainon sucked and lapped Mydei's hole.

It was unfair. Mydei was just way too good at sucking his dick, and the muffled moans and pants from his throat from Phainon sucking his hole only served to make Phainon feel more pleasure around his length. He already felt like releasing his cum inside Mydei’s throat and filling him to the brim. Although Phainon wondered how Mydei would feel if he had filled his throat with cum while sucking his insides with his tongue, the competitive nature inside his blood refused to allow him to cum first, and he brought one of his hands on his waist to press against his tenth thoracic vertebrae.

With a scream, Mydei pushed himself off of Phainon's dick as he began to see stars, cumming all over Phainon's shirt and leaving a sticky mess between their bodies. His body convulsed and jerked as he collapsed against Phainon, and his parted lips moaned Phainon's name over and over against the base of Phainon's dick as his quivering hole sucked Phainon's tongue inside. Mydei rode out his orgasm with a tight grasp on Phainon's thighs, grinding his dick softly against Phainon's chest and grinding his hole against Phainon's lips until he could feel that nothing else could escape him.

Phainon finally parted from Mydei's behind, feeling the cool night air brushing against his lips as Mydei still laid limply over his body. He was still catching his breath, and Phainon couldn't help the precum that dripped from his tip with each hot breath that brushed against the base of his dick.

“Mydei,” Phainon gently called out to him, shifting to try and get Mydei's face away from his cock. “Please move your face away.” He couldn't handle the constant teasing of Mydei’s breath anymore.

This only spurred Mydei to do the complete opposite, and while still in a daze, he pressed his parted lips against Phainon's dick. Planting kisses along the base of his shaft, a hand teased the head of Phainon's dick, grazing his fingertips along his leaking slit.

“*Mmm*, Mydei.” Phainon threw his head forward with a groan, sliding his hands along Mydei's waist as he slowly approached his second orgasm of the night. His abdomen that was sticky with their sweat and Mydei's cum flexed desperately in an attempt to hold on for as long as possible, but when Mydei's lips finally reached underneath the head of his dick, Phainon came with another loud moan, spilling himself all over Mydei's lips and fingers. His hips jolted as Mydei gently coaxed the last of his cum from his dick, and with soft whimpers and moans, Phainon eventually collapsed backwards into the bedsheets. Deep breaths left Phainon's chest as he recovered from his high, and the vision that had previously turned white slowly returned to him.

A loud smack landed on Phainon's chest, and he jumped. He was falling asleep before, but now he was immediately wide awake.

“HKS,” Mydei growled, who was now turned back around and grabbing a fistful of Phainon's shirt that was now soaked in cum.

Phainon could only manage to laugh nervously, raising his hands up to his side as the glowering man above him glared down at him. “Hey, Mydei…”

“What the fuck was that?”

“I was just… returning the favor…”

“Where did you learn that from?”

“Huh?” Phainon blinked blankly up at the man.

Mydei sighed exasperatedly, and Phainon could faintly see him running a tired hand through his hair. “You're seriously… unbelievable.”

With a cheeky smile, Phainon laughed softly. “Did you like it, Mydei?”

A sharp click of his tongue followed. “Don't kid with me.”

Phainon's smile immediately wilted. “So, you didn't like it?”

Silence followed his statement, and the grip on his shirt loosened. After a few beats of the two men staring at each other, Mydei finally replied with another sigh, “Just go to sleep.” Due to the lack of lighting in the room, Phainon couldn't see just how bright red Mydei's face was.

Mydei shifted back down in bed as Phainon removed his cum-stained shirt and threw it on to the floor. He felt the bed dip beside him, and Mydei curled into his side, resting his head upon Phainon's arm. With the two of them resting on their sides, with Mydei turned toward him, they both fell into another silence. Phainon shut his eyes and waited for the darkness to overtake him, wondering if he had hurt Mydei from what he did to him. He made a mental note that Mydei did not like what he did and to not do it again in the future, but he could only hope that he would be forgiven for it.

He heard Mydei faintly mumbling something against his arm, breaking their silence, and Phainon's brain later processed what he had said:

“Of course I liked it…”

It took a few moments for Phainon to truly register what he had said and what he was referring to, but he immediately perked up at the realization. With widened eyes, Phainon had to stop himself from jumping up in excitement as Mydei was currently laying on him. “You did?”

Phainon tried his best to crane his neck down to Mydei's expression, but the man had already buried his face into Phainon's chest.

“Just go to sleep, HKS.”

Grinning, Phainon wrapped his arms tightly around Mydei, and with Phainon whispering sweet praises into his ears and planting kisses wherever he could reach, they soon fell into a deep slumber, with arms wrapped tightly around each other.

Itinerary Day 7: Departure

That glittering chandelier hung above their heads as usual when Phainon opened his eyes. He was greeted with the morning light that streamed through the curtains, and he immediately remembered this day to be the day that they would all depart from Okhema together. There was no way he could forget, after all.

They were still in the same position that they had fallen asleep in: Both of them on their sides, facing each other, and wrapped within each other's arms. Phainon had a clear view of Mydei's peacefully sleeping face, and he brought a hand up to gently cradle his cheek, swiping his thumb occasionally along his slightly parted lips and the red tattoos under his eye.

He was beautiful, and it was a sight that Phainon could never tire of. His softly glowing hair under the morning sunlight, and the way his lips were slightly turned downward while he slept. He delicately rubbed at the corner of his mouth and chuckled softly when Mydei murmured under his breath in response. He was so cute.

Phainon continually teased the man trying to sleep in front of him. He ran his fingertips through his hair, cradled his cheek, swiped his thumb along his lips and eyelashes, and even ran his hand along his waist, slipping his own hands inside Mydei's silk robe to palm at his bare skin. The curves of Mydei's body were so tantalizing, and Phainon couldn't rip his hands or his gaze away from the skin that was being revealed more and more from Phainon's ministrations. It felt like his hands were just *meant* to be here on his waist, the small of his back, the curve of his behind, and even the warmth that radiated between his ample cheeks–

"HKS."

Jumping in place, Phainon quickly retracted his hand that was dipping lower and lower down Mydei's body. "Good morning, Mydei." Phainon gave the man an awkward smile, patting Mydei's robe back into place as if he did not just have his hands and arms wandering around inside.

Mydei, who had his eyes narrowed in his direction, ran a hand through Phainon's silver hair and muttered, “A scoundrel so early in the morning.”

“You don't like waking up in bed by yourself, so how else am I supposed to entertain myself here?” Phainon slipped his hands back inside Mydei's robe once more, earning a soft moan from the other man that only served to make the blood in Phainon's body rush down to his stirring cock.

“You just… *mmm.*.. lay there like any normal person.” Mydei's back arched as Phainon's greedy hands met Mydei's behind once more, teasing the area right above his entrance.

“And how do I just lie here when such a beautiful person is sleeping before me?” Phainon whispered, lightly grazing his fingers over that ring of muscle that fluttered deliciously under his fingertips.

Mydei groaned at the touch, his face turning hot at his words, and his blush only grew the more Phainon prodded his hole. “*Mmph!* Phainon, we have… we have things to do today.” He pushed his hand against Phainon's forearms, which, fortunately, got the message across. Mydei held in a chuckle when he saw how deflated the silver-haired man looked with his adorable pout and downturned eyes.

Phainon sighed with regret, stilling his wandering hands. “You're right,” he murmured regrettably.

With a light laugh, Mydei swept the bangs from the front of Phainon's face. Golden half-lidded eyes gazed over Phainon as he whispered, “If you're good today, I'll give you a reward when we return to my bedroom in Kremnos tonight.”

At those words, Phainon widened his eyes and immediately jumped out of bed. “Let us go to Kremnos, Mydei!”

He could faintly hear Mydei's amused chuckle in the background, but Phainon heeded no mind to it as he slipped on his leather boots and gauntlets and proceeded to strap Dawnmaker to his side. A quick glance at his discarded shirt reminded him that Mydei had soiled it last night, so he

opted to wear the tunic from one of his many soldier's uniforms. He had to go see Aglaea anyway to return all of his uniforms, so it wouldn't hurt to just wear one for now while they got his other shirt cleaned.

Mydei had planned for their departure from Okhema Kingdom during Action Hour. Castrum Kremnos wasn't particularly far, but they would still arrive during Curtain-Fall Hour if they kept to the schedule. As it was Entry Hour now, with only a few quints until Action Hour, Mydei and Phainon decided to split up to accomplish everything they wanted before departing. Mydei would deal with the logistics for their journey back: Food and beverages; ensuring everything was packed; the carriages were in good condition; the drivers of each carriage were ready for the journey; and the Kremnoans themselves were ready to return. On the other hand, Phainon focused on bidding farewell to his fellow companions in Okhema and any other last-minute paperwork he must complete to solidify his move to Kremnos.

Once Phainon and Mydei had gotten ready for the day and indulged in a light breakfast, Phainon's first stop was the laundry room to get his shirt cleaned. It was a quick stop in which he passed his black undershirt over to one of the maids, who gave him a quizzical look as to why he was only giving a single shirt. She tried to inspect the shirt out of sheer curiosity, but Phainon immediately waved the question away and asked her to have it cleaned by Action Hour, which she said would be more than enough time to clean a single shirt.

As he was thanking her and preparing to make a mad dash out of the room, the maid asked him, “Are the rumors true?”

What Phainon had learned throughout the last few days was that there were *a lot* of rumors about him–some that he didn't know of even before. Raising an eyebrow, Phainon settled back down into place as he was about to run out of he laundry room. “Which rumors?”

“They say you are to depart today for Kremnos,” The maid explained, and Phainon could see that her question sparked interest among the other maids who were in the laundry room. “Will you ever return?”

“Of course I will.” Phainon flashed her a reassuring smile, and he could see the maids in the back relaxing their shoulders. “I will be training in Kremnos to become stronger and will be back within a few months.” He neglected to tell her he would return exactly in time for the assembly with the Council of Elders, as he didn't want the news of that spreading and for the noble ranks to get suspicious of his planned return.

“Training?” The maid appeared taken aback. “You desire even *more* strength?”

Phainon laughed. “There is no such thing as being too strong. What if another disaster fell upon us? It doesn't hurt to be prepared.”

The maid smiled softly. “You are quite diligent, Phainon. Have a safe trip to Kremnos.”

With a nod, Phainon departed from the laundry room, waving goodbye to the other maids who were in there as well. Even though he was still carrying the extra soldier's uniforms that he had to return to Aglaea, he was also wearing one of the tunics, so he didn't want to return it so soon and walk around the palace half naked until his other shirt was cleaned. So, instead, he decided to make his way to the other individual he wanted to see before departing.

He had previously asked the guards on duty where the envoys of Styxia were staying, and although they had already departed Okhema late during the day yesterday, he figured that Castorice was still there, ensuring that the guest rooms had been cleaned and restored to their original state. Phainon was sure that Castorice may have already known that he was leaving for Kremnos, as she was also being involved in the plan to overthrow the Council of Elders, but he still wanted to say his goodbyes since he would not be seeing her for the next few months.

Making his way over to the part of the palace where the Styxia envoys previously stayed, he began to hear excited voices laughing and squealing up ahead. As he was still quite a ways away, he couldn’t tell whose voices they belonged to, but the closer he approached his destination, the clearer the voices became. He was surprised he could hear them from so far away,

but they were also pretty loud, much to Phainon's amusement. He thought maybe they would be the maids conversing with one another while on cleaning duty, but he couldn't have imagined who they would be upon turning the corner.

“Empousa?” Phainon's eyes widened as his gaze landed on the woman next to her. “Castorice?”

The two women quickly cleared their throats, separating from each other as they had been standing quite close to each other before.

“Phainon!” Empousa acted as if she were not caught in some suspicious act. “Looking for Miss Castorice?”

Phainon's eyes shifted between Castorice and Empousa, who were now standing a reasonable distance apart. “You two know each other?”

“It's a long story,” Empousa chuckled, rubbing a hand on the back of her neck. “I bumped into her in the palace a few days ago.”

Castorice nodded. “Good morning, Lord Phainon.”

He had to blink momentarily at her as if he didn't hear her correctly. “Lord? Where is this new title coming from, Castorice?”

“I… heard you will be joining hands with the King of Kremnos in their kingdom today.” Her face was tinted ever-so-slightly pink. “Did I hear the news wrong? I thought to give my congratulations.”

Phainon already choked halfway through her statement and couldn't even catch what she said in the later half. Catching his breath, he ran an anxious hand through his hair. “I really don't know what you're referring to, Castorice.”

Her eyebrows shot up into her bangs. “So, is the news of your union false?”

“I…” Phainon's face bloomed a deep red, and he brought a hand up to cover as much of his blushing face as he could.

He could hear Empousa snickering from beside her. “Phainon is quite a shy man.”

“Indeed,” Castorice agreed.

“And even after everything they did together, too,” Empousa said with a lengthy sigh.

“You must finish telling me the rest,” Castorice seemed to urge Empousa, and Phainon glanced up at the two of them now that his face had cooled down.

“That does remind me, what were you two talking about? I could hear you from down the hall.”

The two women grew rigid at his question, and as he raised an eyebrow at their unusual behavior, they both quickly returned to normalcy as if they had rehearsed earlier.

“We were just…” Empousa seemed to be looking anywhere but Phainon, and his curiosity only grew at her lack of answer.

“Talking about books,” Castorice finished, but Phainon could still make out a light tinge of pink across her cheeks. “I was asking her for stories about Kremnos to garner inspiration for my writing.”

“Right!” Empousa loudly exclaimed. “Not very many people know about Kremnos Kingdom, so she was asking me to tell her about our customs… for her writing, of course. She isn't writing about anyone in particular or anything.”

Phainon clearly wasn't convinced; when had he ever asked if Castorice was writing about a specific person? He let it slide, nonetheless, as he didn't have all day to spend wondering what they were discussing so loudly and with such excitement. “Right… I suppose that does make sense.” He almost laughed when he saw Empousa let out a breath of relief so obviously.

“Yes, yes, exactly.” Empousa nodded enthusiastically, eager to steer the conversation elsewhere. “So, you were looking for Miss Castorice?”

Castorice perked up when her name was mentioned, and Phainon was reminded of why he had even come to this part of the palace in the first place. Seeing the unusual pair of Empousa and Castorice together had made him forget.

“Yes, that's right. Since you already know the news, I have just come to bid you farewell.” Phainon smiled in her direction. “I'll be in Kremnos for the time being, and then I will return in a few months.”

The noble woman returned the smile, giving Phainon a quick bow in his direction. “You will do great things in Kremnos, Lord Phainon. I look forward to seeing you again in a few months. If there is anything you need, Styxia will always welcome you.”

Phainon's smile grew at her words. “Thank you, Castorice. Do you know if Miss Aglaea is in her office?”

“She should be,” Castorice replied assuredly. “I was just there right before this.

With a nod, Phainon thanked her before bidding the two women farewell and departing from the scene.

The shoulders of the two women immediately dropped once the Deliverer had disappeared from the hall, and a dramatic sigh of relief came from the Kremnoan woman.

“That was close!” Empousa laughed as Castorice's face bloomed red. “I didn't hear him approaching at all!”

Castorice cleared her throat in an attempt to suppress her blush. “Yes, that was… truly quite close.” She took in a deep breath now that Phainon was out of sight.

“I wasn't sure what else to say if he had kept questioning us.” Empousa laughed once more, turning to Castorice. “Where did we leave off?”

“You were describing their position in bed during the fourth quint of Entry Hour,” Castorice reminded her, heart pounding with anticipation as she resumed with the image she held in her head of two very specific men.

“Right!” Empousa exclaimed. “And again, these are all just my guesses as I couldn't *actually* see them, but their sounds were just so loud that I could make an educated guess.”

Castorice hummed with an enthusiastic nod. “Of course, Miss Empousa. Please continue with your description.”

“Now, I actually think during this particular quint, they were standing against the dresser…”

She spent the rest of Lucid Hour excitedly describing the night of the royal ball while Castorice did her best to retain every single detail that spilled from the attendant’s lips. It wasn't until Lucid Hour was nearing its end did another Kremnoan attendant angrily approached Empousa and dragged her back, yelling at her for ditching all the attendants while they were busy cleaning and packing all of their belongings. Empousa was left being dragged down the corridor, yelling a mix of apologies to Castorice and pleas to the attendant who currently held her by the collar. All Castorice could understand was that the attendant’s name was Herklas, from the amount of pleas that came from Empousa.

Phainon dropped by the laundry room just to check if his shirt was cleaned before meeting Aglaea, which the maid had passed to him. Changing back into his black undershirt and with all of his uniforms in tow, he made his way towards Aglaea's office while still reflecting on his conversation he had with Empousa and Castorice. He would have to ask Empousa later what they had been discussing, because for some reason, the peculiar conversation he had with them could not leave his mind.

Bringing a hand up to knock on the door, her familiar voice called him in, and Phainon stepped inside. It suddenly hit him that this would be the last time he would step inside Aglaea's office for a long time.

“Do you have time for me, Miss Aglaea?”

“I always have time for you, Phainon.” With a gentle wave of her fingers, Phainon understood and shut the office door behind him. “To what do I owe the pleasure of your presence?”

“I'm sure you know of the Kremnoan's departure today,” Phainon began as Aglaea set down whatever work she had been focused on. “I just came to bid my goodbyes and return these as well.”

Aglaea's head turned toward the pile of uniforms that Phainon held out in his hands. “If you wish, you may keep them. But, I am sure King Mydeimos is preparing more extravagant clothing for you in Kremnos.”

Phainon struggled to contain his blush at her words. “I… Yes, that is what he said.”

A light laugh resounded from Aglaea. “Of course, it seems that King Mydeimos truly cares for you. I have no qualms with leaving my best soldier in his care.”

“Can you please stop with the teasing?” Phainon was finding it difficult now to continue holding Aglaea's gaze with the way his face was burning from her remarks. “I really came here to say a sincere farewell, you know.”

“I am well aware.” Aglaea threw him a knowing smile. “These are also all simple facts that I am stating. The King of Kremnos quite obviously has a favorite, and I am sure news of this has already reached the ears of the Kremnoans who still reside in Kremnos.”

Embarrassment washed over Phainon at the thought that so many people knew the King of Kremnos was now in a relationship. He wasn't exactly sure what to expect when he reached Kremnos Kingdom. How would his people react to Phainon? He could only hope that there weren't too many

nonsensical rumors about him already, even before he stepped into their borders.

“Your worry is unnecessary, Phainon,” her gentle voice interrupted Phainon's thoughts. “You have already won the respect of the Kremnoan attendants in Okhema; I am sure you will have no problems in Kremnos as well.”

“Thank you, Miss Aglaea.” He nodded at her reassurance. Phainon was still worried, but he knew Aglaea wouldn't speak empty words. If she truly believed it, then she would say it.

“Besides that, I am sure you will learn a lot as well in Kremnos.” Aglaea continued with her reassuring smile. “And when you return to Okhema in time for the assembly, I look forward to seeing what kind of man Kremnos has shaped you to be.”

Phainon returned the smile. “Really, I appreciate all you have done for me, Miss Aglaea, and I'm not just saying that.”

She chuckled lightly at her words. “I appreciate the compliments, Phainon, but you have done much more for me than I did for you. Learn well in Kremnos, Phainon, and return a stronger man.”

As Phainon was making his way out of her office, with the uniforms still in his hand, he suddenly paused, remembering where he had stored all of their belongings. Pivoting on his feet, Phainon opened his mouth. “So I… accidentally packed all of my belongings into the trunk that belonged in the barracks…”

Aglaea laughed. “Yes, you can keep it. It will be no problem to procure another one for that space. Enjoy your honeymoon, Phainon, and Okhema will be waiting for you in a few months.”

It wasn't until Phainon had shut the door behind him that he fully registered what she had said, and he almost busted her office door down just to retort. Instead, he swallowed dryly and rushed off, eager to wipe the red that

covered his cheeks. He wasn't sure if it was his imagination, but he could hear laughter coming from her closed office door.

It didn't seem as if Aglaea had anything for him to complete before he departed, or maybe she had already taken care of it for him. So, Phainon had much more time in his schedule than he originally thought. It was getting late into Lucid Hour, but it still wouldn't be for another one or two quints before it was Action Hour, the time of their departure. He didn't have much else to do before their departure, so he decided to take in the sights of Okhema for one last time before he could no longer.

His feet carried him through Marmoreal Palace, and he made small talk with the maids and soldiers who bid him their farewells. He wandered through the halls, reminiscing about all the time he spent in the palace, whether it was on guard duty or when he would be accompanying Aglaea. He still remembered when she had singled him out during the soldier's entrance exam and had personally taken him through the palace on the day of the exam, and he was frightened out of his mind that Aglaea was punishing him for something he had done. Apparently, she had been so impressed with Phainon's performance that she took it upon herself to personally escort Phainon around, but she singled him out also because she despised his outfit and quickly gave him a soldier’s uniform. According to her, she absolutely hated the yellow and purple that he wore to the entrance exam, but Phainon still didn't think anything was wrong with the outfit. He couldn't even put away the outfit as Aglaea had quickly gotten rid of it. This was one of his earliest memories in the capital of Okhema, and it was the first time he ever met Aglaea.

Upon exiting the palace, he made his way toward Marmoreal Market. Phainon distinctly recalled how overwhelmed he had felt when he had first experienced the downtown market, as it was so much different from the markets he was used to in his hometown. The number of vendors itself vastly outnumbered the number of citizens in Aedes Elysiae alone, and the sheer number of people in the market was enough to make young Phainon's head spin. Phainon remembered with a chuckle how easily he would get swept up in the crowds and how he had to fight for his footing; he was also much shorter than he was now, and young Phainon could barely see over

the heads of the other market goers. He had never conversed with so many different kinds of people before, and he had never seen so many people crowding one place all at once before. It truly put into perspective just how many different kinds of people lived in Okhema, and it also emphasized all the different lives that Phainon would be protecting as a soldier.

He recalled the first time he had ever bought clothes for the bathhouse and was taken aback by how breezy it was. He remembered the first time he met Theorodos, the antique shop owner, and had quickly befriended the man over their shared hobby. He also recalled the first time he ever set foot into the blacksmith shop, and it was on his first day in Okhema that he vowed to have a grand sword crafted by the legendary blacksmith Chartonus. It wasn't until his dragon quest in Styxia many years later did he have this dream fulfilled, and Dawnmaker never left his side after that moment.

With a nostalgic sigh and the bright sun beating down on the market, Phainon perused around for one last time. It wasn't as if Phainon could fit any more things into his trunk that Aglaea let him keep, but it didn't hurt to shop around in Marmoreal Market, as he wouldn't be back in Okhema for many months.

He visited many vendors whom he was already quite familiar with, including Aphrea, the owner of the tailor shop he had brought the Kremnoans to a few days ago, and the news of Phainon's departure had already spread even to the market. He spoke with them all as many of them bid their farewells and wished him well. Phainon stopped by the antique shop as well, where Theodoros insisted he take some more antiques and appraisal tools with him to Kremnos in case there was no antique shop there. With a laugh, Phainon caved and took all of his gifts, which Theorodos graciously packed into a bag for him to easily carry. Stuffing the soldier's uniforms that he was still carrying around with him into the bag, Phainon carried on with exploring the rest of the market.

Phainon dropped by the blacksmith shop as well. It wasn't that he particularly needed anything, but he did want to bid a quick goodbye to Chartonus before departing for Kremnos Kingdom. Upon entering the shop, he waved for Chartonus’s attention, but he seemed to gesture somewhere

outside the shop. It was almost as if Chartonus was waiting for Phainon's arrival.

He frowned, raising an eyebrow and following the direction where Chartonus was gesturing, but he couldn't find what he was pointing to. All he could see in that direction was more vendors and a small number of dromas caravans–now that the royal ball was over, the number of caravans had severely decreased.

“Important product for you, caravan from afar,” Chartonus explained, but it only further confused Phainon.

“They have something for me?” Phainon turned his head back around to stare at one of the caravans that was closest to the blacksmith shop.

Chartonus nodded. “Kremnoan item, you would be interested.”

Phainon's eyes widened at his words. Now he was more than intrigued by this caravan. “Kremnos’s borders have been closed until now. How would this caravan have Kremnoan products?”

“Royal family crest, not sure. Found from discarded scraps.” Chartonus retreated into the shop and re-emerged, holding out his hand in front of Phainon.

A ring was held for Phainon in the palm of Chartonus's hand, and he was bewildered at the sight before him. Indeed, it was a golden ring with a thick band, and upon the head of the ring, he could faintly see the Kremnos royal family crest. It was quite battered and beaten, but it wasn't anything Phainon couldn't clean. Inspecting the ring even more closely and picking it up with his own hand, Phainon could tell the crest wasn't a fake, and it was truly the real thing. Since not very many people knew much about Kremnos Kingdom, let alone their royal family, Phainon was sure that the caravan owner didn't realize what this crest signified. Chartonus may have thought it looked familiar and picked it up for Phainon to verify.

“Do you know where this was originally found?”

“Styxia shores.”

Phainon knew there was a lot of water in Styxia Kingdom, so it wouldn't be far-fetched to say that someone had scavenged this ring along their shores. He wondered whether Mydei knew of this ring, where it had come from, and what it was doing near Styxia.

“Can I keep this?”

Chartonus nodded, and Phainon pocketed the new item. He would show it to Mydei later and hoped that it was something he could at least identify, but the surface was quite ruined. Unfortunately, Phainon didn't think he would have the time to clean it. Maybe he could clean it in the carriage ride to Kremnos? But, he didn't want to show Mydei until it was in a better condition, and there was a chance Mydei would see him while he was in the midst of polishing the ring.

He hadn't realized the time, but it was now Action Hour. Thanking Chartonus and bidding his farewell to him as he wouldn't be back for a long time, he quickly made his way back to the palace so that he wouldn't have to make Mydei wait for him again. Digging through the sack that Theorodos had given him while briskly walking back to the palace, he dug up some tools that would be somewhat useful in restoring the ring to its original state. Phainon could tell the ring was pure gold, so the dirt and debris stuck to its surface wasn't rust, which made Phainon's job much easier. He just needed some tools that could scratch off the dirt that clung to its surface and a burnisher that could polish the ring and make it shine again.

It was quite a shoddy job that Phainon was doing, and it definitely wasn't his best work, but he was able to scrape off most of the debris by the time he reached the doors of Marmoreal Palace. Thanking the guards that held the door open for him, he shoved the tool he was using back inside the bag and dug through the different tools that were given to him. Phainon was unsure what Theodoros had exactly given him, but a sigh of relief escaped his body when he felt his hand hit a hard material that felt quite cool to his touch. Pulling it out from the sack, he instantly recognized it as an ivory burnisher, which was exactly what he needed to polish this ring.

He spent the rest of the journey back to Mydei's bedroom alternating between using the ivory burnisher along the surface of the ring and wiping its surface with a soft cloth that he had also found in the bag. By the time he reached the corridor where the Kremnoans resided, it was almost looking brand new, and Phainon could see the Kremnos crest much more clearly now that all the dirt had been scraped away. Upon seeing that most of the attendants were outside their rooms and hanging out in the hallway, he quickly shoved the ring into his pocket once more and headed towards Mydei's direction.

Mydei was conversing with one of the attendants–most likely regarding the final preparations needed for their journey to Kremnos. With the sound of Phainon’s footsteps, Mydei turned in his direction and excused the attendant.

“You're here,” Mydei said as Phainon stopped next to him.

“Did you think I wouldn't be?” Phainon smiled at him. They had been glued to each other's sides the past few days, so it was actually a little odd being by himself for the majority of the day.

Mydei neglected to respond and, instead, gestured toward the room that Mydei had been staying in for the past few days. “Put on the rest of your armor. I left it in the room for you.”

“Would you like to help me put it on?” Tilting his head toward the side and pulling off the best pleading face Phainon could manage, Mydei sighed exasperatedly.

“Just get inside.”

Excitedly pumping a fist into the air, Phainon quickly passed his sack of appraisal tools, antiques, and extra uniforms to one of the attendants and scurried inside the room with Mydei following shortly behind. The two of them made quick work of the armor; it was a record-breaking feat with how fast they managed to adorn Phainon in all the armor and belts now. But before Mydei could exit the room, Phainon cleared his throat, stilling Mydei’s steps.

He wasn't actually sure why he was so nervous to show Mydei this ring; he had even gone through the trouble of rushing to clean and polish its surface before Mydei's eyes could see it. Phainon couldn't explain his anxiousness, but he dug his hands into his pockets while Mydei raised an eyebrow at him.

Crossing his arms over his chest, Mydei huffed, “Whatever it is, you best hurry it up or–”

His voice died in his throat when he caught what Phainon had pulled out of his pocket, and Phainon almost took a step back at how fast Mydei had approached him to inspect the ring that currently sat within the palm of Phainon's hand.

“Where did you get this?” Mydei's eyes snapped up to Phainon.

It must be important with the way Mydei was acting. Staring with bewilderment into Mydei's eager golden eyes, Phainon did his best to answer: “A caravan was selling this in Marmoreal Market. He said he scavenged it from the shores of Styxia. The blacksmith owner saw the crest and gave it to me, as he was unsure if it was truly the Kremnos royal family crest.”

“This is…” Mydei reached out a hand, and Phainon passed the ring to him. Holding the ring out in front of him, it was as if Mydei couldn't believe what he was holding.

“Is it… important?” Phainon watched as Mydei continually twirled the ring in his hand, inspecting every corner and surface of the golden ring.

Mydei was completely stupefied as he cradled the ring in his hand. “This belonged to my mother.”

“The late Queen?!” Phainon exclaimed, his eyes darting back to the ring in Mydei's hand.

“We all had thought it was lost when my mother passed.” Shutting his eyes for a brief moment, Mydei reopened them to stare at Phainon. “When she

was killed, it was said her body was dumped into the River Styx, the one that flows through Styxia. The ring must have been on her when that happened, and it must have slipped off her person and washed ashore. I can't believe…" His voice trailed off as he stared at the ring once more.

Phainon's mind was swirling with this new information. The late King just dumped his wife, whom he had killed, into a river?

"I'm glad you were able to find it again." Phainon gently held Mydei's hands, closing his fingers around the ring. "May it not be lost in the River Styx again."

Mydei didn't even react to Phainon's joke as he continued to stare at his hand that had been closed by Phainon's. "I owe you one, Phainon."

"There's no need." Phainon moved his hand away as Mydei had one last look at the ring. "I am already satisfied enough seeing that this ring has been returned to you."

"I truly…" Mydei brought his eyes up to Phainon, his golden eyes swirling with memories that Phainon couldn't possibly imagine. "Thank you, Phainon."

With a gentle smile, it was Phainon's turn to approach him as he pressed his lips softly against Mydei's. Mydei's eyes fluttered shut as Phainon reached his hand upward to tenderly cradle his cheek, and Mydei's fingers closed around the ring once again.

Once they parted, Phainon muttered against his lips, "All I needed from you was just that one kiss. Don't tell me you owe anything else to me."

He exited the room, and Mydei was left in a daze, standing in the room alone with his face burning red and a visceral need running through his veins. If Phainon still stood in this room, Mydei was unsure what vulgar things he would be doing to that man's body at this moment. Swallowing dryly, he carefully stored the ring on his person before following Phainon out of the room, ensuring that his face had calmed down before facing all of his attendants again.

The carriages that were already packed with their belongings were all waiting in front of Marmoreal Palace by the time they had exited the palace doors. With guards and maids lining up for their farewell, the Kremnoan attendants all filed into their respective carriages. Phainon was unsure which carriage his belongings were stored in, and he turned to Mydei.

“Which carriage will I be in?” He stared with wide eyes at Mydei, and the other man shot him a glare.

“Where else would he be if not with his lover?” Mydei climbed into the carriage at the front of the line, leaving Phainon in a complete stupor.

He called me his lover. He called me his lover.

Those words echoed over and over in his mind as he rigidly managed to push his feet toward the carriage in the front, climbing into the elaborate cabin and having one of the Okheman guards shut the door for them. Phainon had never ridden in such a fancy carriage, let alone any carriage at all, for that matter, and he stared with wide eyes around the entirely elaborate interior of the cabin as the carriage began moving under his feet.

Thus, starting Phainon's new journey in Castrum Kremnos, he stared outside the windows of the carriage, taking in his last sights of Okhema Kingdom with a full heart.

Epilogue 1: Castrum Kremnos

Chapter Notes

> I met Mydei's English voice actor when I was in the middle of writing this chapter, and he was telling me that the first thing he signed that day was a very graphic Phaidei comic.
>
> I laughed with him as if I did not have a 100k+ graphic Phaidei fanfic sitting in my back pocket.

It was Curtain-Fall Hour by the time they had arrived in Castrum Kremnos. Although it was quite the long journey of sitting around in the carriage, Phainon tried his best to peer through the windows to take in the sights of Kremnos, but it was much too dark to fully appreciate the view. Mydei promised him that when he had time later this week, he would take Phainon sightseeing through Castrum Kremnos. Phainon eagerly looked forward to that promise.

Barely anyone was outside save for the few guards on duty, and only a few attendants were waiting for Mydei's arrival. Upon the door opening for Mydei, the attendants gave a quizzical look at Phainon.

“He is with me.” Mydei glanced at the attendant who quickly nodded at his words, stepping back and allowed Mydei and Phainon space to exit the carriage.

Phainon scanned the area in front of him that was a grandiose mix of royal blue, white, and gold that decorated the palace in front of them. The Kremnoan attendants all moved to unpack the carriages that housed their belongings, and Phainon was so distracted with the sight that he had to catch up with Mydei who was already halfway up the steps leading up to the palace entrance.

He released a short breath once he had caught up to Mydei, who was conversing with one of the guards at the entrance of the palace.

Mydei abruptly turned to Phainon. “I apologize if the trip was quite long, but Krateros would like to meet you.”

Phainon stared at him for one beat, two beats, and three beats in complete and utter silence. It was so quiet between them that even the attendant Mydei had been previously speaking with thought that maybe the silver-haired man hadn't heard the King's words at all. The attendant still was not sure who this man was; obviously, he was not from Kremnos Kingdom, but the armor that adorned his body showed that this man had quite the status. He could only assume that the man was from Okhema, where the King had previously visited, but why was he here? Perhaps, was Kremnos and Okhema forging an alliance? All Krateros had told him was that if the King had brought back someone with him that Krateros wanted to meet with them immediately.

“Right now?!” Phainon practically yelled aloud, and much to the guard's surprise, Mydei smirked.

“He must've already heard about you, and I am sure he would like to meet you before you settle within our borders.”

“So… he's definitely wary of me.” Phainon's shoulders wilted, but Mydei quickly ran his fingertips through his silver hair to reassure the man.

“Krateros has always been like that; it is not specifically you that he is wary of.” Nodding at the guard who appeared baffled at the King's blatant display of tender affection, Mydei led Phainon through the palace. It was dark inside as well, so Phainon couldn't see much of the palace and only focused on following Mydei. If he so much as lost sight of Mydei, he would be lost inside this palace forever. It wasn't Okhema anymore where he knew the entire floor plan.

Two largely elaborate doors stood in front of them, lined with a golden edge, golden hardware, and an intricate golden pattern across its surface. Phainon's eyes widened as he marveled at how grand the doors were as they slowly approached them, and the two guards in front of those doors saluted in Mydei's direction. He could only assume that was the throne room, which Marmoreal Palace did not have because they had no true monarch in

Okhema Kingdom. However, instead of stepping through the doors, Mydei nodded at the guards and turned the corner, leading them down the corridor to a farther door that was much less grand than the entrance to the throne room.

Phainon was still not used to the fact that Mydei could just walk in wherever he could, and he jumped when Mydei immediately opened the door and waltzed inside. In fact, Phainon almost hesitated to just stay out there and wait until he was called in, but the quick glance from Mydei's eyes before he disappeared into the room was more than enough of a signal for him to understand to continue following him. Steeling his nerves, he took a deep breath and stepped inside.

It was quite the simple office that reminded him of Aglaea's office, with a desk near the back of the room and bookshelves lining the walls. The differences were that there were more weapons on display in the room, and the room was sparsely decorated, save for the weapons. Aglaea's office was much more warm with its mahogany wood furniture and warm lighting, but this office was much more cool-toned, with white floors and ceilings and a circular, blue and gold rug that covered most of the floor.

Sitting at the desk was an older man with scars across his face, a graying mustache and beard, and dark hair with graying roots near the front of his head. The most peculiar thing that caught Phainon's eyes was that underneath the bangs that covered one side of his face, the eye hidden underneath was clouded, and Phainon could faintly see a scar run vertically across that eye. The man was adorned in golden armor, similar to Mydei's, with golden pauldrons and golden gauntlets, and a red cloak that was secured in place by a golden brooch sat upon his shoulders and chest.

“You've returned.” With a rough voice, the man scanned Mydei up and down before shifting his eyes to carefully scrutinizing Phainon instead.

“Krateros.” Mydei stared at the older man, crossing his arms across his chest.

Phainon did his best to appear as relaxed as possible under Krateros’s narrowed eyes as he spoke again: “We have suppressed news and rumors of

this… man's arrival, and we have been waiting for your return to hear an explanation."

"I'm not sure what explanation you need from me," Mydei coolly replied. "I'm sure you've already heard all there is."

A loud *bang* erupted from the desk, and Phainon inwardly flinched at the loud sound as Krateros slammed his hands down onto the desk and pushed himself off the chair and to his feet. Mydei didn't seem the least intimidated under Krateros's glaring gaze and only continued to stare at the man.

"You mean to tell me that this *man* is your *lover*?" Krateros waved a wild hand toward Phainon, speaking as if Phainon were not actually in the room. He thought Krateros wanted to meet him, but this conversation seemed more like he wanted to admonish Mydei instead.

"That's right," Mydei continued to answer him plainly. "*Phainon* is my lover, and he will be living with me in Castrum Kremnos."

Phainon swore he could see the man literally steaming in front of him from all the rage he was holding inside.

"You would choose a *man* as your lover?!"

"I think it is quite apparent that Phainon is a man."

"What of the bloodline? What will you do then?!"

"Then this royal family ends with me."

Both Phainon and Krateros gawked at Mydei who continued to keep his calm underneath their incredulous stares. Sure, the continuance of his royal blood was not something Phainon had taken into consideration when he agreed to be Mydei's partner, but was he so willing to just end his family line just like that? Did Mydei think about this all on his own in Okhema? And he didn't bother to tell Phainon about any of these thoughts?

"You… would end your entire bloodline over a man?!" Krateros balled his trembling hands into fists as he glared at Mydei.

But, the golden-haired man didn't cower under his intense gaze in the slightest. “Phainon had no impact on my plans to sever this bloodline. I had already planned to even before stepping foot in Okhema.”

“But, why? Why do this?!” Krateros stepped forward, his legs hitting the desk in front of him.

Mydei stayed silent in response, narrowing his eyes as if struggling to form the words that circulated in his brain. To Phainon's surprise, Mydei brought up an entirely different topic.

“How are our borders?” An unreadable gaze was across Mydei’s face as he stared at Krateros.

Although Krateros was hesitant at the divergence, he responded, nonetheless: “Everything is under control. We had a few outbreaks while you were out, but we have quelled the uprisings of the monsters already.”

Nodding at his words, Mydei took a deep breath. “How would you say their activity has progressed since we started this war with the black tide monsters?”

It was Krateros's turn to fall silent. Phainon's gaze shifted between the two Kremnoans once silence had filled the room. Although the black tide monsters were not nearly as active on Okhema's borders, he knew that Kremnos was being hit hard on their side. It was the whole reason why Mydei had sought out an alliance with Aglaea in the first place, after all, to find refuge for his people if the worst case scenario occurred.

“You would throw away the bloodline upon joining forces with those Okhemans?!” Krateros’s voice shook with every word, seeming to understand the meaning behind Mydei's question.

“The bloodline would not matter in different borders,” Mydei stared. “‘King of Kremnos’ would be a title long forgotten in Okhema.”

“But that's–”

“I wish to rid this bloodline born of strife and bloodshed.” Mydei's self-assured voice seemed to boom in the small office. “If a new monarch is born only from killing the previous one, will this cycle of bloodshed ever have an end? Will we live forever in a cycle of war, throwing ourselves into the battlefield at any chance to attain power?”

“You would throw away all the pride that we have amassed across thousands of years?!” Krateros's voice rose the more he spoke.

“Does that ‘pride’ only come from killing others? Does ‘power’ only mean trampling upon others?” Mydei inhaled deeply, calming his own shaking voice. “This pride holds little significance. This bloodline will end with me, and this monarchy will end with me. And if you wish to take the throne from me and continue this vicious cycle and this vicious bloodline, then take up your sword and strike me down.”

With those last words echoing in the office, Mydei whirled upon his feet, grasping Phainon's wrist and pulling him out of the office. Phainon could only briefly catch a glance at Krateros, who stood dumbfounded at Mydei's words, but Phainon could not gauge his reaction anymore as the office door closed shut behind them.

They walked briskly down the corridors, with Mydei taking this turn and that turn down the palace. Phainon struggled to keep up with Mydei's quickening pace, especially with the hand that was still tightly grasping his wrist.

“Mydei–”

He abruptly stopped in his hasty footsteps, with Phainon carefully stopping behind him.

“Sorry.” Phainon could faintly hear Mydei’s voice, which the monarch refused to turn around and look at him. “You weren't supposed to be there for that conversation.”

A deep sigh emitted from the golden-haired haired man as he finally turned his head, glancing over his shoulder at Phainon. “I had meant to have that

conversation with him at a later time. I truly thought he would be civil when meeting you today."

Phainon offered him a small smile, reaching his hand outward and tucking strands of blonde hair behind his ear. "I don't mind at all. I am only saddened about the fact that I had no idea you were thinking of all of this while being with me."

Mydei quickly shook his head, turning his entire body to face him. "Like I said in that room, I already had these thoughts even before stepping into Okhema. You didn't change my plans at all."

"Still," Phainon murmured, "I would… like to at least hear more about what you are thinking inside of that head of yours." With a frown, Phainon added quietly, "I feel as if you know the inner workings of my brain way better than how I know your brain."

A brief silence settled between them, and Phainon was almost worried that he had asked for too much. He had just wanted to be a shoulder that Mydei could rely on when he was having difficult thoughts, or someone that he could vent to when he was experiencing troubles. But, maybe as a king, perhaps that was too much to ask of him.

He opened his mouth to retract his statement, but Mydei beat him to it first: "I will try my best, Phainon."

"You… you really do not have to." Phainon's gaze was glued to their feet, and his eyes traced the gold stitching upon the rug they were standing upon.

"So do you want me to, or do you not want me to?" Mydei huffed, and two armored hands grasped Phainon's cheeks, forcing his gaze upwards. Mydei, who had narrowed eyes, continued: "Which statement was the true you, Deliverer?"

Phainon laughed, feeling the coolness of Mydei's golden gauntlets pressing against his face. "I am no longer a Deliverer in these borders. Right now, I am just a regular man named Phainon."

With a scoff, Mydei withdrew his hands. “A regular man who is in a relationship with this country's king does not sound like a regular man at all.”

It was Phainon's turn to scoff at those words, a small, but hesitant, smile gracing his lips. “So I guess… I do not have Krateros's approval as your lover?”

“He hasn't seen you in battle,” Mydei retorted. “He is only opposed because we cannot have blood children, and nothing else. I am sure once he sees you in battle, he will come around to change his mind.”

“I thought bloodlines didn't matter in Kremnos, no?”

“They only do, somewhat.” Mydei's eyes wandered the corridor as he gathered his thoughts. “The monarch is, obviously, the strongest in Kremnos. Their offspring, of course, would be the strongest as well, since they share the same blood as the current monarch. Strength matters more, as anyone who could take down the current monarch will become the new monarch, but obviously, great strength is guaranteed if born from the strongest in the kingdom.”

“I see.” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows. “So technically, the monarchy could still continue after your life if the next strongest person takes up the throne, and a new royal bloodline would occur if that new monarch makes a family.”

“Correct.” Mydei nodded. “However, you are missing an important factor about me. The fact that I cannot die and am impervious to any and all harm.”

Phainon swore his eyes widened so much he felt his eyes turn dry. “You– You're unaffected by aging too?!”

“Not to aging, but to the effects of aging,” Mydei corrected. “It would mean I would live much longer than the average human, solely because I am not affected by the wear of old age. My body can grow stronger, but it cannot be weakened by age, or anything, for that matter.”

“That's…” Phainon's mind was swirling once more over this new understanding of Mydei's disposition. Although he thought he understood Mydei's magic, this realization was shedding a new light on him. “That's almost like a curse. You're… going to live basically forever.”

“I will live for a long, long time.” A deep sigh emitted from Mydei once more. “Krateros knows this, which is why he is so against my decision. If he could just wait until after my death, he would.”

“Is that something you really want?” Phainon tried to gauge Mydei's expression, but he was too difficult to read. “Castorice has a different sort of disposition from having too strong of magic as well. Maybe if–”

“Castorice does not have a kingdom to oversee,” Mydei stopped him. “For her, she has Queen Polyxia to oversee the kingdom while she can focus on controlling her magical energy. Unfortunately, I do not have that same time at my disposal.”

Phainon's heart sank at his words. Would there come a time when Mydei would walk this world, knowing that all of his loved ones have already passed long ago? Would he continue to run this kingdom, continuing to bring an end to the cycle of war, all by himself?

Hands ran through Phainon's silver hair, effectively bringing his spiraling thoughts to a halt, and his eyes met golden ones.

“I have already accepted my fate, Phainon,” Mydei muttered, playing with the strands under his fingertips. “You don't need to worry about me.”

“It's my job as your lover to worry about you.” Unknowingly, Phainon frowned at Mydei with disheartened blue eyes, and the golden-haired man had to stop himself from ruffling the other's hair.

“Continue to worry for me, Phainon.” A gentle smile danced across Mydei’s lips as he continued to run his hand through Phainon's hair. “And I will continue to rely on you.”

With a small smile, Phainon let Mydei drag him back to his bedroom, and he spent the entire walk ruminating over different ways he could help Mydei. After more winding steps and corridors, they eventually stopped in front of two grand doors. They weren't nearly a spectacle as much as the doors that led to the throne room, but they were still quite a sight to behold.

Mydei threw open the doors for Phainon, who gratefully stepped inside. The room was much bigger and grander than the guest room that he had temporarily resided in at Marmoreal Palace, and Phainon couldn't even believe that there could even be a room this large. The room was decorated in banners of blue with gold accents, and against the very back wall was the biggest bed that Phainon had ever laid eyes on. Columns of white marble rose from the floor and held the ceiling above them, and, of course, a grand chandelier sparkled from the tray ceiling. Dark blue curtains with gold embellishments draped in front of each window, reaching all the way to the floor, and matching curtains even hung around the bed to create a sort of canopy.

One side of the room held an office area, equipped with a desk, chair, a multitude of bookshelves, and even separate benches for leisure reading, and the other side of the room housed his own private bath with racks of his numerous outfits. He also couldn't believe that there was even a fireplace against one wall, and a comfortable seating area was created in front of it filled with lush cushions and couches. Phainon was getting accustomed to the idea of combining four separate rooms into one giant, luxurious room.

Near the entrance of the room, Phainon spotted his dirty trunk from the soldier's barracks and his sack from the antique shop, and he chuckled at the stark contrast between the extravagant room and his belongings. He was sure the attendants did not know where to store his things, and the Kremnoan attendants that had returned from Okhema advised them to bring them to Mydei's room.

“Where did you want me to put my things?” Phainon approached his belongings and stared at them on the floor. He wasn't sure if there was even room for his things in this room, so he added, “Is there a room that I will be staying in?”

“Yeah,” Mydei roughly replied from the… bath area? “That room is in here”

“I'll actually be staying here?”

“Of course you are.” Mydei scoffed. “Or did you prefer a separate room?”

“Of course not!” Phainon dashed toward Mydei's side, wrapping his arms around the man while he was attempting to undress for the night. “I'd love to stay here with you, Mydei.”

Another scoff escaped Mydei, a blush creeping upon his face. “Then why bother asking about a separate room?”

“I just… didn't know where to store my things.” Phainon, who was still clinging onto Mydei, eyed his belongings from afar. “I didn't know if there was space in this room.”

“Do you see how big this room is?” Mydei did his best, but with much difficulty, to remove the rest of his clothing that Phainon was not clinging onto. “If there is no space, we will make space. Now get off me so I can take a bath.”

Instead of unhanding Mydei, Phainon opted to help him undress, setting his discarded clothes off to the side and finally letting go of Mydei so he could settle into the tub. There was water already in the tub, and when Phainon brushed his fingers along its glittering surface, the water was still warm. It reminded him of a miniature version of the public baths from Okhema. Well, the tub was nothing small at all, but it was just compared to the public baths in Okhema that are shared among the masses. Then again, this tub was only for a singular person, so it didn't need to be that big, after all.

“Are you joining me, or are you going to stand around staring at the water with that dumb look on your face?” Mydei flicked some water on Phainon, and if perfectly splashed across Phainon's cheek.

Phainon, who was still kneeling next to the underground tub from feeling the temperature of the water, snapped out of his daze when water splashed

onto his face. Blinking momentarily and feeling a drop of water run down his cheek, he asked, “I can join you?”

“What is wrong with you today? Why are you questioning everything I tell you?” Water splashed onto the tile's surface as Mydei brought an arm out of the water to lean it against the tile. Resting his face against his hand, he narrowed his eyes at Phainon, who squirmed under his gaze.

“I'm just…” Phainon's eyes wandered everywhere in the room in front of him as he wrung his fingers together. “I don't really know what my position is here… in Kremnos. I don't know how I should act, what is mine, what is not mine, what I can do, where I can go...”

Mydei watched him silently, absorbing his words. Moving through the water, he settled himself next to Phainon's place and began unbuckling the belt situated across his thigh. “You may do whatever you wish, go wherever you wish, and everything that is mine is yours.” He discarded the belt off to the side and began making work of the next thing he could reach from the tub. “You may be Phainon of Aedes Elysiae, but you are also King Mydeimos's lover. And soon, everyone in this kingdom will know that.”

Sweating at the thought of an entire kingdom knowing his relationship status, Phainon watched Mydei unbuckle his leather boots, and he had to sit himself on the floor so Mydei could pull the boots off his feet. “Why did you ask me to call you Mydei? Where did that name come from if your full name is Mydeimos?”

“It is the name I used when I was in exile.” Mydei set the boots off to the side, far enough so that water could not splash onto its surface. “It was the name I used when I was in hiding, planning a rebellion. And, it is the name my fallen comrades used up until we staged that rebellion. Although Krateros refused to call me by that name, there were five others of my closest confidantes who used that name. Ever since they fell in battle, I haven't heard that name since.”

“The name must mean a lot to you then.” Phainon watched Mydei remove the next article of clothing on his person that he could reach.

“The name reminds me of my upbringing, where I came from, and what caused me to be who I am now.” Mydei fiddled with the leather gauntlets around Phainon's hands. “It also reminds me of my fellow comrades, who wished they could have witnessed my coronation day.”

“You should tell me about them someday.” Phainon set the leather gauntlets next to his boots once Mydei had removed them. “I am sure they are great people.”

Mydei nodded with a short hum of agreement. “They were very intelligent, strong people. I am sure you would have also gotten along well with them, if they were still here.” Mydei impatiently tugged on his forearm, and Phainon had to throw an arm out to stop himself from falling into the water. “Are you going to make me undress you entirely? When are you going to join me in the bath?”

With a laugh, Phainon made quick work of the rest of his attire, stowing it away off to the side and easing himself into the warm water. The water enveloped his weary body that was exhausted from the long trip, and a satisfied sigh escaped his lips. He leaned his back against the wall of the tub, staring up at the grand ceiling that spanned before him. The pair sat in silence across from each other, the only sounds echoing between them were soft splashes of water with any movement from their bodies. Phainon shut his eyes, reveling in the warm water that relaxed his muscles.

That was, until his ears picked up faint noises from across the tub. Opening his eyes, they bulged upon the sight that he saw: Mydei, with his legs bent at the knees and spread wide, and with fingers dipping in and out of his own entrance.

Phainon's cock stirred at the delicious sight before him as he struggled to form words. Mydei’s lips were parted, and Phainon wasn't sure if Mydei knew that soft moans, grunts, and pants were slipping from his lips.

“Wha–What are you… What are you doing?!” Phainon almost wanted to reach out to his knees and close his legs, as he wasn't sure if he could handle the sight of Mydei touching himself anymore. But he was frozen in place, mesmerized by the sight.

“I'm… *urgh.*… cleaning myself.” Mydei dipped his fingers back into his hole, and Phainon's eyes were glued to his fingertips disappearing into his warm insides.

“Did… Did we not do a good enough job before?” Phainon swallowed dryly, and he was sure his cock was now standing at full hardness underneath the water. Although Phainon did stick his tongue inside, it didn't warrant how deeply Mydei was fingering himself. The only other time Phainon ventured so deeply inside of Mydei was the night of the royal ball, but they had thoroughly cleaned him up the day afterwards. There was no way he was still cleaning out traces of that night, right?

“I'm cleaning for… *hah.*… for tonight.” Mydei's back arched when his hole had entirely swallowed up his fingers, and his expression twisted in pleasure.

“T–Tonight?!” Phainon stammered.

“Did I not promise you a reward when we returned to my bedroom tonight?” A breathless laugh rattled from Mydei's chest as his fingers continued their ministrations, dipping in and out of Mydei at different angles and elucidating soft moans from his lips.

“I didn't…” Phainon's face was bright red, and he was sure Mydei already noticed just how turned on he was at the view. “I didn't… really do anything to warrant a reward. You really… don't have to, Mydei.”

“Who was the one who found my mother's lost ring?”

“...Chartonus the blacksmith shop owner?”

Mydei let out another breathy laugh. “Who confirmed it was the true crest of the Kremnos royal family and passed it to me?”

Phainon stayed silent at those words, trembling in place from trying to stay still in his seat. Was it improper of him to start touching himself now while watching Mydei? His dick was just begging for stimulation, and the blood rushing down to his lower half left him little rationality to work with.

“Do you have to clean yourself before and after?” It may have been a stupid question with an obvious answer, but Phainon was just trying to get his mind out of the gutter. Which very clearly wasn't working, as his eyes were still staring so clearly at Mydei’s filled hole.

“Of course I do, HKS.” He winced when he plunged his fingers in once more. “Did you not notice I was clean when you ate me out last night?”

No, Phainon *definitely* noticed. He didn't realize it was because Mydei cleaned himself. Wait… Wait a moment… The gears were slowly turning in his head… It wasn't as if Mydei cleaned himself out every single bath, right?

“Wait!” Phainon practically screamed, and Mydei jumped in place at how loud his voice became. “Did you clean yourself thinking we were gonna do something last night?!”

A deep red the same color of his tattoos blossomed across his face, and Phainon swore his legs hesitated to close. Mydei neglected to answer, but Phainon knew based on his reaction that his guess was correct.

“You… We were going to just go to sleep last night, you know.” Phainon's body slumped against the tub at Mydei's silent confirmation. “Did you really clean yourself on the off-chance that we actually did something? Or was it… Was it that you *wanted* to do something?”

“Can you stop talking, HKS?” Mydei snapped, but the blush that was so-evidently across his cheeks was not dissipating in the slightest.

“But I told you, you don't owe me anything for the ring.” Phainon had to keep filling in the silence or else he would remember about his dick that was still begging to be touched. He still very clearly remembered about it, as it continued to sway between his legs under the water's movement, but he needed something to distract himself.

“I want to.” At Mydei's confident words, Phainon’s eyes fluttered to meet his gaze, and golden eyes were staring deep into his soul. “And, it seems that you want it to, so why are you complaining?”

It was Phainon's turn to blush. There was no way to hide his full erection even if he tried to cross his legs, and he could only be in full view under Mydei's gaze. “Well–I mean–I… Of course I would get hard when you're touching yourself in front of me…” Phainon mumbled with a pout. Under Mydei's staring, he felt shy, and he tried to move his hands over his erection.

“Why are you covering yourself when you were so blatantly watching my hole?” Mydei scoffed.

“I–I wasn't–!”

“Touch yourself.”

Phainon froze. The only sound that he managed to emit was, “Huh?”

“Be a good boy for me and touch yourself, Phainon.” Golden eyes darkened as Phainon obediently complied. It wasn't fair with the way Mydei continued to call him that. How would Phainon ever win against Mydei at this point?

A hand that had been previously trying to hide his erection slowly wrapped around his dick, and Phainon flinched at the pleasure that immediately flowed through his veins. Heart pounding against his chest and face burning at the thought that Mydei was seeing every little action, Phainon slowly began stroking his length, and he could see his own dick pulsing underneath his hand.

Pants and gasps soon spilled from Phainon's lips as he quickened his pace, and his other hand grasped tightly at the edge of the tub. His legs began to tremble as they widened, giving a better view of the show to the golden-haired man sitting in front of him. Pleasure coiled in the pit of his stomach the faster his hand pumped up and down, and precum soon began leaking from his tip the more golden eyes continued staring straight into him.

“Mydei! *Ahh!* Mydei!” Phainon threw his head forward as he began thrusting into his hand, imagining that the warmth of his fist was someone else entirely. He could faintly hear Mydei’s own moans coming from across

the tub, and he glanced upwards only to find that Mydei had resumed plunging his fingers into his hole, his entrance twitching at the show being presented in front of him. Phainon swore he almost exploded at the sight of Mydei touching himself to Phainon, and he had to shut his eyes lest he cum right then and there.

Biting his bottom lip, Mydei watched with half-lidded eyes as Phainon continued slamming his hips into his hand as moan after moan echoed in the bedroom. Water was splashing over the tiles around them with how sporadically Phainon was thrusting into his fist, and Mydei couldn't help watching the head of his leaking dick continually disappearing and reappearing in his hand with every thrust.

"*Mmm*, Phainon, under the head. I know you like it there." Mydei continued feeling his quivering insides with two fingers as he observed how Phainon slowly lost himself to the pleasure of his hand.

He seemed to have some semblance of rationality left because Phainon did as he was told, sliding his fingers under his head and emitting a loud groan. Precum flowed down his slit as he teased his tip, and Mydei had to fight back from ducking underneath the water to lap at everything he was spilling.

"Mydei, AHH! Mydei, Mydei, please, *OHH!"* Phainon's back arched as he continued violently snapping his hips into his hand, alternating between swiping his thumb along his slit and desperately pumping his shaft.

"Phainon, is this how you were touching yourself to me in the baths on our second night?" Mydei inhaled deeply as he thrusted his digits inside himself, scissoring inside to stretch his hole to fit Phainon's dick. "Tell me, *hah…* Phainon, were you moaning my name just like this in the baths?"

"*MMPH!* YES, MYDEI, YES!" Phainon was practically screaming now, and his wild thrusts were losing its rhythm. Mydei could tell he was approaching his release, and he gulped as he reflected on the feeling of Phainon spilling his cum down his throat. He plunged his fingers deeper at the thought, a moan escaping from his throat.

He was unsure if Phainon was answering him or if he had finally lost himself and was just moaning randomly, and Mydei chuckled breathlessly. He tried to imagine Phainon touching himself just like this in that vast Okheman bath in the middle of the night, his moans and Mydei’s name echoing along those marble walls as he pumped and fucked his own hand all by himself. The blood instantly rushed down Mydei's body, and his cock twitched at the thought. He desperately wished he had walked into Phainon at that moment to catch him in the act.

“What are you thinking of, Phainon?” Mydei gauged Phainon's face that was twisted in absolute bliss: Lips were parted and breathing sweet moans, eyebrows were furrowed as he chased his release, and cheeks were burning red as sweat dripped down his forehead. Phainon was absolutely beautiful, with the way his glistening silver hair stuck to his forehead, and the way his strong, built body riddled with gorgeous battle scars flexed and trembled under the intense pleasure. Mydei was sure he would never tire of this man's handsome features.

Phainon let out another lengthy moan when his fist unconsciously tightened at Mydei's words. “You! Mydei, MYDEI! *AHH!* All… All I think of… *MMM!* Every day… Every moment… *OHH!* MYDEI, PLEASE!”

Mydei couldn't believe how slick with precum Phainon's shaft had become even underneath the water, and he swiped his tongue along his lips at the delicious show in front of him. He just wanted to pin him to the wall and swallow his pulsing dick to drink his thick cum. He swallowed dryly but held himself back, his golden eyes fluttering between Phainon's face filled with ecstasy and his leaking dick that was continually thrusting in his fist.

“Will you cum for me, Phainon?” Mydei added a third finger inside and began quickening his pace, bringing a hand down to pump his own erection. He jolted at the double pleasure, and he felt his stomach twisting in pleasure as his opened legs trembled. “Can you be a good boy and cum when I tell you to?”

“YES, YES, MYDEI!” Another moan and more precum flowed from Phainon's tip as he continued fucking his hand under the water. “I'll… I'll be a good boy for you–So, so good for you!”

Mydei chuckled lowly, gasping when he felt his fingers brush against his prostate. His fingers began torturing that sweet spot inside of him, and he had to flex his abdomen to stave away his orgasm. “*Mmph!* You're such a good boy, Phainon. Whose good boy are you?”

“YOURS! I'M YOURS, MYDEI, MYDEI, *AHH!*”

Mydei laughed deeply. “You really are a good boy, Phainon. *My* good boy.”

Phainon's body stilled completely, and Mydei paused at how Phainon had frozen in place. Only his chest was heaving up and down with deep breaths, and his jaw was tightened shut. Mydei noticed his blue eyes were now opened again, but he was staring at nothing in particular in the water.

“I… I almost.” Phainon flinched when the hand grasping his cock began to slowly resume its movements. “You can't… *Hah.*.. You can't call me that when I'm trying to hold it in for you.”

Mydei swore he felt something snap within him, and he had never moved so fast in his life. Slamming Phainon against the tub, he slammed himself down on Phainon's lap, and he moaned wantonly at the feeling of his hot, pulsing, and girthy length breaching his insides and touching every crevice inside of him. Golden eyes rolled into the back of his head as he began to see white, and he convulsed in Phainon's lap when he felt his cum spilling deep inside.

Phainon's vision turned white the moment Mydei slammed down into his lap, and he screamed his name. His dick spasmed as he came inside Mydei's fluttering walls. Ropes of cum splattered along Phainon's abdomen as they both came together, and Phainon clawed at Mydei's thighs with tightly shut eyes as he rode out his orgasm. Mydei's trembling walls clamped tightly around Phainon as he milked every lost drop of cum that Phainon had, and he dropped his forehead against Mydei's shoulder as he gasped for breath.

He couldn't handle the intense stimulation of Mydei's hole that continued fluttering around him even after coming down from his high, and he tried to pull himself out. Shifting in his spot to give Mydei a hint, it only resulted in Mydei doubling down and clenching himself around Phainon. Groaning,

Phainon threw his head back, shutting his eyes as he grasped tightly to Mydei’s thighs that were marred with Phainon's previous scratches.

“Where do you think you're going?” Mydei breathed against his lips, and Phainon couldn't believe that his dick was stirring again even after just cumming. “You thought that was the end?”

“It's not?” Phainon panted as he stared into intense golden eyes.

“Did you think that was your reward?” Mydei chuckled. Phainon flinched as Mydei began slowly circling his hips in his lap.

“It… It definitely felt like one.” Phainon gasped when Mydei clenched dangerously around him once again, and his fingernails dug into Mydei's skin.

Scoffing, Mydei pushed himself off his lap, leaving Phainon in the tub as he stepped onto the tile and splashed water all over the floor. “Of course you thought simply being called a ‘good boy’ was your reward.”

Phainon scurried after him, adding to the water that had already splattered over the tile, and he faintly saw Mydei bending down for something on the floor while he was pushing himself out of the tub. He followed after Mydei who was fiddling with something in his hand all the way to the bed.

“Did you need my help with something?” Phainon managed to catch up to Mydei, turning over just in time to see something dark between Mydei's teeth. Biting and pulling at it, Phainon trailed the piece of leather until his eyes found that it was wrapped tightly around his wrists.

“Is that–”

“One of your many belts.” Mydei dropped the leather piece from his mouth, and it hung tightly around him. With a smirk, Mydei stared into shocked blue eyes. “I'm all yours, Phainon.”

As if someone had taken over his limbs, Phainon roughly shoved Mydei back into the mattress. Because his hands were bound together, he could do

nothing except fall into the sheets while Phainon grasped his hips and tossed him further into the bed. Mydei was still overcoming his shock while Phainon climbed on top of him; he didn't think anyone could so easily toss him around as if he weighed nothing, and he inwardly cursed at how his body liked it so much. With blooming red cheeks and the pit of his stomach twisting inside, Mydei whirled his head to the side to avert his gaze away from the handsome silver-haired man who was ready to ravage him from head to toe.

“Where are you looking?”

Mydei jolted in bed when soft lips pressed against his ear, whispering words with hot breaths. He tried to turn his head away, his blush creeping down to his neck, but Phainon continued planting kisses along his ear and whispering sweet nothings, sliding a hand along Mydei's arms and pinning his bound hands above his head.

“You teased me so much earlier. Don't you think it's your turn now?” A tongue swiped along his ear, and Mydei grimaced at the whimper that slipped from his lips without permission.

“It's not my fault you get off from praises,” Mydei scoffed but immediately jolted in bed when teeth bit down on his ear, earning another moan from him.

“I just love you so much, Mydei.” Phainon's breath brushed against Mydei's sensitive ear, and Mydei grew hot the more Phainon spoke. “So, so much. How could you blame me for getting off to such sweet praises from such a beautiful man?” Another kiss upon his ear. “A man so gorgeous and sexy and lovely…”

“Stop…” Mydei tried to push him off, but his wrists yanked against the belt he had tied over his own wrists. Phainon felt him struggle, and he slammed Mydei’s hands down into the sheets with one hand.

“I think I'm not the only one who likes praises.”

Mydei gasped when a finger grazed his slit, and his back arched off the bed at the touch. He hadn't realized it until then, but his dick was already fully hard, and precum was even leaking from the tip that Phainon continued to tease.

“Do you like it when I call you beautiful?” Phainon's hot breath kept tickling his ear, but Mydei couldn't move away with his hands pressed down and Phainon's lips pressing kisses along his ear, temple, cheek, jawline–anywhere that his lips could touch. “*Hmm*, baby? You're not answering me.”

Electricity shot through Mydei's limbs, and he had to bite down on his lips to stop another moan. Tears brimmed the corners of golden eyes the more Phainon pumped his dick, and Mydei's legs trembled open.

Phainon slightly paused at Mydei’s reaction, and a devilish smirk appeared over his face as he bent down once more to whisper directly into his ear: “Did you like it when I called you that, *baby?*”

A whimper escaped through Mydei's bitten lips, and he inwardly admonished himself for it. His dick twitched in Phainon's grasp with every pet name, and he hated how much he loved hearing Phainon call him that. But, how could he blame himself? It had taken many, many conversations for Phainon to stop calling him “Your Majesty,” and now, all of a sudden, he was being called “baby”?

Humming, Phainon sat back, releasing the grip he held on Mydei's hands and dick and spreading his legs farther apart. “Hmm, is it that word specifically, or is it any name in general? Baby? My love? Beautiful? Honey?”

With every name, Phainon crept closer to Mydei's leaking dick that reacted with every word, twitching and pulsing proudly in the air, and his body trembled when Phainon's hot breath hit against his skin as he laughed.

“It seems like you like all of them.” Phainon's face was dangerously close to his length, and Mydei would've closed his legs long ago if Phainon had not been pinning them down to the sheets.

“You wish.” Contrary to his quivering legs and leaking tip, Mydei's voice sounded almost normal. But, it only made Phainon want to bring him closer and closer to absolute ruin and ecstasy. Phainon wanted to make Mydei scream, to make him writhe under his body, and to make him beg his name. And he would do all of that tonight, while he had Mydei's hands bound just for him.

“I do wish that you would react as much as I do in bed, my love.” His lips were basically brushing against his shaft, and Mydei threw his hands down to push against his head.

“Get out of there.” Mydei tugged incessantly at silver hair, the pit of his stomach churning at what Phainon was about to do. His toes dug into the sheets in anticipation as Phainon didn't budge in the slightest.

“I'm just doing my job of serving the King as his guard,” Phainon mumbled against the tip of his cock, and Mydei couldn't believe the absolute incredulity of his words.

“What kind of vulgar guard–*AHH!”* Fisting roughly at Phainon's hair, Mydei's back dangerously arched off the bed when warmth encapsulated his length. Phainon sunk his mouth deeper down his shaft, sliding a hand from his inner thigh to circle at his twitching entrance.

Mydei jolted at the wandering finger that prodded between his cheeks, and he desperately tugged more roughly at his silver hair. “No, Phainon, not there. Not at the same–*MMM!”* He threw his head back as a finger slipped inside his hole, shutting his eyes as he began to see stars above him.

The bath water they were still soaked in wasn't exactly a great lubricant, but Mydei had already stretched himself so much in their time in the bath that Phainon had no difficulties plunging a finger inside. He could also feel his cum inside from before, and his face burned red with every squelch and slick noise that emitted from his hole. While he tried his best to breathe through his nose, not graze his teeth along his skin, and suck up and down his dick, Phainon began swirling a finger against Mydei's fluttering insides, addicted to the sounds his hole was making. He added a second finger

inside at the same time he bobbed his head down, and a long moan emitted from the man underneath him as two thighs clamped around his head.

A noise came from Phainon's throat when his face was clamped between two thighs, and it was muffled from still have Mydei's dick in his mouth. He though one of his hands was holding one of Mydei's thighs down, but it was now bundled up in the sheets with Mydei's legs suffocating the air out of him. Phainon chuckled, and the man under him squirmed with another gasp as the vibrations of his voice trailed down his length that still rested upon Phainon's tongue.

Pushing his arm under one of Mydei's thighs to grasp at his waist, and his other hand plunging fingers inside his hole, Phainon continued bobbing his head up and down in tandem with the thrusting of his fingers. Mydei's legs trembled around him as strings of moans echoed in his large bedroom. His pulsing hole seemed to pull Phainon deeper and deeper inside, and, with furrowed eyebrows, he did his best to swallow as much of Mydei's cock as he could get into his mouth. He couldn't exactly get very far down without feeling like he was going to choke around his girth–how in Amphoreus was Mydei deepthroating him every night like it was nothing? Maybe the size of his dick was just smaller than Mydei's?

Somehow, that only fueled the flames inside of Phainon, and he sank his lips deeper than he ever could before. Tears began gathering in his eyes as the breath was shot out of his lungs, but the squirming and moaning that was coming from the man he had pinned to the bed was, honestly, very worth it. Bobbing his head up and down once more while taking in more of Mydei's cock, he felt his fingers brush against Mydei’s sweet spot inside, and the man convulsed under him, his thighs squeezing tightly around Phainon's head at the same time his hole clenched around his fingers. Phainon swore to himself, with Mydei's dick still in his mouth, that he was going to compare their sizes right after giving him the best orgasm he's ever had.

He chanced a glance upward at Mydei, and he almost bit down at the sight that was displayed before him: Mydei, who still had his bound hands pulling at his hair, with his back arched and his blush spreading from his face all the way down to his chest. Mixtures of bath water and sweat

dripped down his face and chest, trailing his beautiful features and chiseled muscles, and his pink nipples were standing proudly from his plump chest. Pleasure ran through his veins and pooled in the pit of his stomach as he continued to watch Mydei while relentlessly pressing his fingers against his sweet spot and sucking his tip up and down. The golden-haired man, with beautifully bruised lips opened wide, squirmed and screamed under him, his eyes rolled into the back of his as his entire body was a slave to the pleasure.

Phainon's hand that had been grasping his waist ventured deeper into his body, and he had to reach as far as he could to hit the middle of Mydei's arched back. As he pressed upwards and massaged that spot, Mydei convulsed in bed, and Phainon moaned at how harshly Mydei began basically tearing at his hair.

“NO! NO, PHAINON–!” Mydei cut himself off with another moan as his heels dug into Phainon's back. “I'm–-*MMM!* CUMMING!”

Mydei couldn't handle this sudden triple stimulation, with his back and insides being massaged, and his dick being enveloped in Phainon's hot and wet mouth. It didn't take long until Mydei screamed Phainon's name as he came, his body violently shaking as he thrust deeper into Phainon's mouth and spilled his cum inside. His hole clenched tightly around Phainon's fingers, and Phainon stilled his movements, doing his best to control his breathing and not choke around the ropes of cum that were being shot down his throat.

Did Mydei really drink his cum everytime? It did not taste good at all. With a *pop*, Phainon separated his lips from Mydei's dick, with his cum oozing from the corner of his mouth. He pulled his fingers from his entrance, and he watched with a gulp as Mydei's hole tried to clenched around nothing at all. With blue eyes fluttering upwards, he watched as Mydei's chest heaved up and down as he panted for breath. His body was collapsed into the bed, and his fingers were still loosely entangled in Phainon's hair.

Phainon pushed himself up to his knees, setting Mydei’s legs that had been crushing his face down onto the sheets and pulling his hands from his hair. Pressing a tender kiss to the back of his hand, he pushed his arms over

Mydei's head and crawled over him, pressing another kiss to his temple as the golden-haired man was still reeling from his high. He waited for Mydei to recover from the dizzying orgasm as his breaths finally slowed to normal.

“You're… crazy…” Mydei panted, his dilated golden eyes finally meeting blue ones.

“You do this to me all the time.” With a light laugh, Phainon was reminded of his promise to himself. “Speaking of doing this all the time!”

Mydei furrowed his eyebrows as Phainon sat back on his knees and basically slapped his hard erection onto Mydei's stomach. With wide, golden eyes, his face burned again when he saw how far Phainon's dick reached against his stomach as he pressed his hips against the back of Mydei's spread legs.

“What are you doing, HKS?!”

“We're like the same, no?” Phainon wasn't paying the least attention to what Mydei was saying, and he flinched when Phainon flattened his dick, which was still recovering from the orgasm, against his stomach.

Confusion and embarrassment blossomed within Mydei when he realized Phainon was not trying to see how far his dick went inside of Mydei's body, but now Mydei happened to accidentally learn this new information that he *definitely* did not need to know.

“What… What are you looking at?” Mydei didn't have the energy to push Phainon off as his limbs still felt like jelly.

“Our sizes.” Phainon tore his eyes away from their adjacent dicks to stare up at Mydei. “You're not hard right now, but if you were, we're basically the same size, right?”

Mydei stared at him silently with the most baffled expression he had ever held in his entire life. “Are you seriously comparing the sizes of our dicks right now? Right after you made me cum a huge load into your mouth?”

“How do you take me so far into your mouth?” Phainon's eyes dropped back down to their dicks that were lined up on Mydei's abdomen that was still sticky with sweat. “We're the same size, but I couldn't even get as far as you did.”

Mydei was still having trouble keeping up with the conversation. What in the absolute fuck was Phainon thinking of while giving Mydei a blowjob?

“What are you talking about?”

“Our dicks are the same size, but you were able to take my entire dick into your mouth. I could barely even get halfway.”

A loud, incredulous sigh came from the man lying in bed. “*That's* what you were thinking about while sucking me off?”

“How do you go so deeply?!” Phainon was still sitting back on his knees with his shoulders slumped in defeat, staring with a mix of awe and dumbfoundedness across his face. “Is your mouth just two times bigger than mine?!”

“You're saying you tried to copy my technique and couldn't do it?” Mydei scoffed when the man above him pouted.

“Yes, okay?!” Phainon exasperatedly threw his hands into the air. “I tried so hard to go down as much as you did and swore I was going to choke.”

Mydei couldn't help laughing at the ridiculousness the other man was spewing. Smirking, Mydei jut his chin upwards at Phainon. “I guess I'm just better at giving blowjobs than you will ever be, Phainon, and it is something you will just have to admit.”

“No!” Phainon immediately cried. “That's… That's nonsense! Just you wait, Mydei. I will go down on you next time as a new man.”

“I don't want any new man sucking me off.” Mydei rolled his eyes. “I only want Phainon of Aedes Elysiae sucking me off.”

“And he will! After he learns how to take you in fully!”

“And how is he going to practice that?”

Mydei’s eyes were dangerously narrowed in Phainon’s direction, and he realized the implications of his words.

He threw his hands up, quickly waving them in the air between the two of them. “No! No, no, no, I am *not* practicing on anyone else! I was… I was just… a banana, maybe? A cucumber?” Blue eyes trailed down to their dicks once more. “I don't think any of them are actually thick enough. Maybe two? Is that too much?”

Phainon continued mumbling to himself, and Mydei couldn't contain the laugh that rattled from his chest. The laugh broke Phainon's thoughts as his eyes darted back to Mydei’s face.

“HKS, just practice on me.” He chuckled in amusement when he saw how Phainon clearly looked offended at the idea.

“No! I have to be perfect the next time I suck you off. That means I can't practice on–”

“I'll be a good boy, Phainon.”

The erection against Mydei’s abdomen twitched, and Phainon's voice died in his throat as his face burned red.

“I mean… Fuck…” Phainon impatiently ran a hand through his hair, swiping the bangs from his face. “You're… You're so unfair, Mydei.”

Mydei swung his arms off the bed with a smirk, looping his bound hands around Phainon's neck and pulling him down. “If you're done whining about losing, then hurry up and get inside me.”

“I'm not whining! And I didn't lose either!”

“Oh, really? Tell me again, how far can you take my dick again?”

“That's…”

Phainon blatantly refused to answer and pressed his lips against Mydei's instead. Mydei laughed against his lips, but it turned into a moan when Phainon pushed deeper against him. Mydei felt his erection brush against his entrance, and he groaned at the touch, pushing back against him to try and take him inside. It felt like his walls were itching to be touched, and he needed Phainon deep inside of him right at this moment.

Cold air brushed against his lips when Phainon pulled away, and Mydei was greatly offended that they had stopped kissing so soon. Tugging on his neck once more to urge Phainon down, the other man laughed, grasping his hips and flipping him over on the bed with such ease that left Mydei feeling hot.

He landed with his face pressed into the sheets, and Mydei barely had time to breathe before a hand pushed his bound hands above his head, rooting him to the bed. He squirmed, but his breath caught in his throat when he felt something hard brush against the small of his back as Phainon seated himself across his behind.

“What are you–*Ahh!*”

Mydei flinched when something wet swept across the back of his neck, and he flailed his legs when Phainon's other hand crept up to his chest, teasing and pulling his hard nipple. Phainon littered kisses down his shoulders, neck, and back, sucking and biting his way down while pulling and pinching the bud on his chest. Mydei panted and moaned against the bedsheets, digging his forehead into the mattress as his hands struggled against Phainon's tight grip above his head. Electricity ran through his veins, pooling in the pit of his stomach, with each pinch of Phainon's fingers and with each brush of Phainon's teeth, and he could feel the sheets underneath him becoming wet with his own precum.

His insides were craving to be filled, and he swore he could feel himself throbbing over the emptiness inside. Phainon continued to tease and pull his nipple instead despite Mydei's desperate attempts to push his erection inside. He rolled his nipple against his fingertips, but Mydei was more focused on the sensation of the Phainon's dick brushing against his back as Phainon's own precum dribbled onto his skin.

“Stop… teasing,” Mydei grunted, arching his back to try and slip Phainon inside. But it only served to press his dick deeper into the sheets, and he whimpered, pulling on his hands once more that were still bound. “Please… inside.”

Phainon watched with dilated eyes as Mydei began thrusting his hips into the bed, rutting his behind against Phainon and trying to slide his cheeks against Phainon's dick. He gulped, retracting his hand from his chest and pressing into the small of his back. With another loud moan, Mydei convulsed in bed, shoving his face into the sheets to stifle his sounds. Phainon's palm pressed deeply into his back, and his fingers brushed just under his tenth thoracic vertebrae.

“*Phainon*.” Mydei's face burned at how he had practically whined the man's name, but he couldn't take it anymore. Pulling his face from the bed, he did his best to glance over his shoulder, but golden bangs covered his vision. “Phainon, please put it inside.”

“Put what inside?” Moving his hand from his back, Phainon got onto his knees and grabbed a handful of one of Mydei’s cheeks, pulling them apart and unconsciously wetting his lips at how his entrance clenched and fluttered against nothing.

Mydei groaned, feeling the cold air brushing against his desperate hole. “*Mmm*, Phainon–”

“Tell me what you want, baby.” Phainon leisurely dragged his length across his hole, and Mydei's entrance twitched at the warmth and hips quivered at the touch. He felt like he wanted to scream with the way Phainon was so slowly taking his time.

“Fucking–” Mydei gritted his teeth the longer Phainon rubbed his cock against him without putting it in, and he was going to explode. He tried to push himself on his elbows to turn around and yell at him, but Phainon's hand still kept him firmly rooted to the bed.

“What do you want, baby?”

Mydei panted at the pet name again, and he slammed his forehead back down into the mattress. He could feel every ridge and vein of Phainon's dick rubbing against him, sliding languidly along his hole and just barely slipping inside. Hesitantly opening his mouth, Mydei knew his blush had spread all the way down to his back, and he knew Phainon could see it all. “Your dick… Please… I want it.”

“What did you say?”

“You fucking heard me,” Mydei growled into the sheets, and Phainon laughed.

“You're speaking so quietly, baby, I can't hear what you want–”

“Hurry up and just fuck me!” Mydei yelled with his eyes closed shut as if he could hide from the embarrassment that washed over him. “Please just shove your dick–*AHH!*”

He pushed his face deeper into the sheets, stifling his wanton moan at finally being filled with Phainon’s warmth, and he could hear Phainon groaning above him as he slammed himself inside. His walls fluttered around Phainon's cock, sucking him deeper, and Mydei could feel his cum spilling into the sheets as he came at the feeling of his hole finally being stretched.

Phainon winced, tightening his hold around Mydei’s wrists as he felt his hole holding him tightly, clenching and pulsing around him. It was so tight that it became hard to breathe, and from the way Mydei's body twitched sporadically under him, Phainon let out a deep chuckle.

“Did you cum just from me putting it inside?” Phainon watched as Mydei's shoulders slowly untensed, and his fingers untangled themselves from the sheets.

“You took too fucking long,” Mydei snapped, earning another laugh from Phainon.

“I thought you said you were all mine for tonight? It means I could do whatever I want, right?” He snapped his hips against Mydei’s behind, and the man under him jolted with another string of curses leaving his lips.

“Fuck, Phainon, I just came–*MMM!*”

Moan after moan left Mydei's parted lips as Phainon didn't listen to a single word he said. He rested a hand along Mydei's waist and thrusted as deeply as he could at a deafening pace. Mydei was seeing stars with how he was already sensitive from his orgasm, and his stomach tightened as he was shoved in the bed over and over from Phainon's snapping hips. The sound of the bed creaking under their activity filled his ears, and his face burned at the embarrassing squelching he knew came from his abused hole.

Phainon was addicted to the sound their skin made every time he slammed his hips against him, and he chased that sound over and over again. He drilled into Mydei’s hole and left him little room for breath as he aimed for his sweet spot no matter how much Mydei moaned and trembled underneath his hands.

His blue eyes focused on the way his dick disappeared inside of Mydei over and over. He focused on the curves of Mydei's body as his hand rested upon his shaking waist. He focused on the red tattoos that ran down his back and to the deepest parts of his body that only Phainon had the privilege to see. He focused on the rivulets of sweat running across his skin and the love marks that he riddled into his neck and back from earlier. Sweat dripped down Phainon's own forehead as he continued pummeling into Mydei, hearing his sweet moans over and over filling his ears. The pit of his stomach tightened thinking about the way Mydei's walls fluttered and clenched around his dick, and it only spurred him to push even deeper inside, his hips flush against Mydei’s behind.

Mydei's eyes rolled into the back of his head. His face was already pressed into the sheets, saliva pooling onto the bed from succumbing to the pleasure from his lower half. His dick was hard once more as it was pushed into the sheets with every hard thrust, and Phainon was breeching the farthest that Mydei had ever felt him go. It was hard to breathe from the way Phainon was pushing him so violently against the bed and how harsh his thrusts

were, and the overstimulation from just cumming was sending him into overdrive. Even feeling Phainon's dick pulsing inside of him was going to make him tip over the edge, and he just wanted Phainon to fill him up with his cum already.

Mydei called Phainon's name over and over in a series of pleas and whines, the slapping of their skin echoing in the room as Phainon relentlessly continued pushing inside of Mydei. Phainon shifted his hand, grasping at the belt and tugging Mydei upward, and his arms twisted above them. The leather dug into Mydei's skin, and somehow the pain caused his dick to twitch against the sheets. He tightened around Phainon's cock, and the man above him scoffed.

“You liked that?” He tugged on the belt again, earning another loud moan from the golden-haired man. Phainon laughed as Mydei burned brightly, and he tried to shut his mouth to stifle his moans, but Phainon pulled on the belt again, continuing to shove his dick into the deepest parts of Mydei. “I thought you said you'd be good for me, baby. I want to hear you.”

Mydei grimaced. He couldn't handle such embarrassing lines and embarrassing pet names anymore, but his body kept unashamedly reacting to every single word that Phainon muttered. It was then that an image flashed through his mind of Phainon's erection lying across his abdomen as he attempted to compare their dick sizes, and his stomach tightened as he remembered just how far Phainon was reaching inside of him.

A whimper escaped from Mydei, and Phainon tugged at the leather belt once more. “What are you thinking of, my love?”

Mydei panted desperately against the sheets. His brain was fuzzy, and all he could think of now was how tight his stomach felt and how filled his hole was as his prostate was continually pummeled into over and over again. Pleasure shot through his veins as his fingernails dug into the palm of his hands. “Deep–*AHH!* So… So deep!”

“Do you like it deep, my love?”

“YES! Yes–*AHH*, PHAINON!”

His body spasmed as Phainon pressed the palm of his hand flat against the middle of his back while pulling at the belt at the same time. Pleasure blossomed along his entire body, and his legs and hips trembled violently as he screamed.

“Can you say that again for me, baby?” Hips continued snapping into Mydei's behind, mercilessly thrusting into his sweet spot as Phainon pressed the bulk of his weight onto Mydei's back.

Mydei moaned in response, feeling that familiar pressure pooling in his stomach. He was going to cum again–he was so, so close. Mydei's hips began unconsciously thrusting into the sheets, and his dick pulsed and quivered at the stimulation as he desperately chased his release.

“So close, so close, Phainon!”

“You're close, baby? Are you going to cum for me?” Another tug of the belt and another press against his back, and Mydei gasped.

“Yes, YES! Just like that, Phainon! Such a good boy–*AHH!* I'm cumming! CUMMING! *OHH!* PHAINON!”

Both men groaned as they came at the same time. Phainon slammed Mydei's wrists back down into the bed at the same time his hips slammed into Mydei. He spilled his cum deeply inside, and his hips twitched and trembled as he emptied himself with Mydei's words echoing in his mind. Grasping at the sheets, Phainon's eyes were tightly shut as his vision turned white, and all he could feel was the fluttering and clenching of Mydei's hole around his length as the man underneath him came into the sheets once again.

Phainon's shaking shoulders slowly relaxed as he came down from his high, and he watched his cum ooze from Mydei's delicious hole as he pulled himself out. Mydei’s body was limp as he struggled for breath, his arms still outstretched above him, and it was when Phainon was admiring Mydei's naked body that he realized that his wrists were still tightly bound.

“Sorry!” Phainon dashed to untangle the belt from Mydei's wrist, and he saw how red they had become from the leather. But before Phainon could say anything, Mydei had already pulled his arms away, rolling his wrists to loosen and relax them.

Mydei flipped onto his back and stared at the red indents in his skin. With a straight face, Mydei only said, “Wow.”

“Your… Your hands…” Phainon began frantically looking around for any medical supplies, but he wasn't sure where anything was stored in this bedroom. This place was just way too unnecessarily big, and Phainon whipped his head back and forth to find something he could use to cover his wrists.

“I cannot be harmed, remember?” Mydei stared unamusedly at the panicking man. “This will heal by tomorrow."

“But…” Phainon's gaze was downcast as he stared down at Mydei. One of his nipples was so obviously played with from how much redder it was than the other, and Phainon's face burned as he saw the teeth indents in Mydei's neck and shoulders. “Doesn't it hurt?”

Mydei scoffed, his own face growing red once more. “Look at the stained sheets I'm laying in and ask me that again.”

Phainon chuckled, the tension leaving his body. “I guess you're right.”

“You guess?” Mydei raised an eyebrow. “You just pummeled my insides, and you *guess* I liked it?”

“Okay, okay, yes, you liked it.” Phainon raised his hands up with a laugh. “We will have to take another bath though.”

Heaving a deep breath, Mydei pushed himself from the soiled sheets, and Phainon helped him over to the tub once more that still circulated in warm water. Mydei had so many sheets on his bed that Phainon tore the stained ones off, and there were still unsoiled sheets underneath. Tossing the dirty

sheets onto the floor, he joined Mydei in the tub, and they both cleaned up to retire for the night.

"What?!" Phainon coughed up whatever food he was in the middle of swallowing, and Empousa stood up and reached over to pat his back.

“Sorry! So sorry; I thought you heard!”

“No one told me Krateros wanted to fight me?!”

It was the following day, and it was officially Phainon's first day in Kremnos Kingdom. Mydei had a lot of work to do since he was returning from a foreign kingdom, so while Mydei was working, Empousa happily volunteered to keep Phainon company. Phainon had told Mydei that he was fine with Empousa showing him around Castrum Kremnos instead, but Mydei stubbornly refused and told him to wait for him to finish his work.

It was Lucid Hour, and he had just parted from Mydei while Empousa took him out into the city to dine at a local restaurant. It was here that Empousa had so casually mentioned Krateros and how the man wanted to fight Phainon.

“But, the fight is happening today! No one told–”

“*Today?!”* Phainon felt like he was going to faint from how much he was basically screaming. “When?! Where?! Why?! What kind of fighter is Krateros?!”

He began pestering the woman in front of her with incessant questions, and she had to wave her arms to stop the man before he went on a tangent.

“At the Colosseum during the third quint of Action Hour.” Empousa watched as Phainon slumped into his seat. “No one came to your room last night?”

“No?” Phainon's mind flashed back to last night, and his face grew hot. “Oh.”

“*Oh*,” Empousa mimicked him with a roll of her eyes. “I'm surprised the King can even get work done with how you guys keep pouncing on each other every night.”

“That's not true!”

“I had the room right next to the King's in Okhema! Do not play with me right now, Phainon!”

“It wasn't every night!”

“Yes, it was!”

The two bickered back and forth across the table at the outdoor restaurant, attracting the attention of the innocent passerbys. Even the store owner had to come over and tell them to quiet down; but the owner didn't seem the least bit surprised at all when laying eyes on Empousa.

Phainon slumped in his seat again once the owner had left. “Please tell me Krateros isn't strong.”

“That's like wishing dromas could fly.” Empousa snorted.

“Do I even stand a chance?”

Eyeing Phainon up and down, Empousa took a sip of her drink before responding. “Definitely. If you can match up to King Mydeimos, then no one can best you. Just… keep your guard up around Krateros, and you should be fine.”

Phainon heaved a sigh, burying his face into his hands. “On a scale of one to ten, how strong is Krateros?”

“He proved his strength to the King's parents and was granted a special title for his strength.”

Phainon cursed under his breath, running his hands through his silver hair. “That is not promising at all.”

“You'll be fine, Phainon!” She roughly patted his slumped shoulders. “If you lose, it's not like Krateros can kick you out without the King's approval.”

“If I lose, I might as well just return to Okhema.” He buried his face into the wooden table as Empousa spewed reassuring statements at him. However, they all went through one ear and out the other, as Phainon continued to worry about this upcoming battle.

“Phainon.” Empousa stared sorrowfully down at the head of silver hair. “Just… at least finish your food. The King will throw a fit if his lover doesn't eat properly.”

“Am I even truly his lover if I haven't beaten Krateros yet?” He mumbled against the wooden table, and he jumped when Empousa slapped his back.

“The answer is a yes, so get up from the table and eat!” She pushed against his shoulders. “You won't beat Krateros on an empty stomach.”

Agreeing with a sigh, Phainon begrudgingly lifted his head and finished the rest of his food, with Empousa scolding him until he cleaned every last crumb on his plate. They agreed to check out the Colosseum following their meal so that Phainon could get a view of the battlefield before the scheduled fight. He didn’t want to give Krateros any advantage, after all. However, because there were Kremnoan guards clearing the Colosseum for their battle, Phainon couldn’t try a fight for himself on the Colosseum grounds, so all he could do was scan the area from afar. He was only able to even step into the Colosseum thanks for Empousa–most of the guards were extremely wary of a mysterious visitor who was clearly not from Kremnos Kingdom, and because Krateros had already stopped all rumors of King Mydeimos’s lover from spreading, no one knew who Phainon was.

The Colosseum was huge, bigger than any training grounds Phainon would ever lay eyes on in Okhema. It was basically a giant circular amphitheater made of concrete that spanned into the sky. Arches made up the many entrances that circled the entire diameter, and the top floors consisted of many, many rows of seats that had a clear view of the completely empty bottom floor. Phainon heaved a worried sigh as he scanned the area up and

down. There was basically nothing to hide behind and nothing that could get in their way. It was just a vast empty space where two people could fight in an all-out brawl, depending on nothing except for their own strengths. No hills could give them an advantage, no dips or holes could give them an advantage; just a completely flat ground with the sun beating down on them.

“Thanks for bringing me here, Empousa.” Phainon glanced over at her and was surprised she was already staring at him.

“You’re going to be okay, Phainon.” She offered him a small, reassuring smile. “I really think you are over-worrying right now. Krateros may be strong, but you are also just as strong as our strongest leader.”

Phainon laughed lightly. “Do I really look that worried?”

“It’s all over your face,” Empousa deadpanned, earning another light chuckle from the other man.

“Thank you again.” He sighed once more, his eyes turning back to the circular bottom floor. “I guess there’s nothing I can do except warm up and wait for the time to arrive.”

“I’ll join you!” Empousa jumped in place when Phainon turned around. “I’ll bring you to an unused training ground, and we’ll be unbothered there.”

“You really want to join me?” Phainon raised a skeptical eyebrow as the woman hurried to his side.

“Where do you think you are?” Empousa scoffed proudly. “You’re standing in Kremnos, you know–the land of battle-hungry fighters. Even regular maids know how to fight here.”

She led him down the path toward the palace once more as Phainon took in as much of the city as he could. Empousa refused to explain any of the interesting sights that he saw, and he figured it was because Mydei wanted to take the reins in showing him around. Empousa only made an exception

for the Colosseum due to the battle he had scheduled against Krateros, but she only made small talk with Phainon on the way back to the palace.

Pushing open the doors to what Phainon assumed to be the training grounds, she immediately made a face. Phainon, who was standing behind her, couldn’t really see what she was seeing.

“What are *you* doing here?” Empousa frowned.

“What else would anyone be doing in the training grounds?”

Phainon instantly recognized that the other voice belonged to Herklas, one of the other Kremnoan attendants that had joined Mydei to his trip to Okhema. He was even the one that shared a room with Empousa during their stay in the palace.

With a sigh, Empousa stomped through the door, with Phainon following right behind her. He nodded in Herklas's direction, whose eyebrows shot up at the sight of him.

“Phainon.” Herklas returned the nod. “I see you heard about Krateros’s battle.”

“That I did.” Phainon sighed heavily. He was going to be heaving a lot more sighs until the scheduled fight was over.

“And he's going to do great!” Empousa interjected, shooting a look at Herklas, who immediately understood her silent message.

He stared back at Phainon with a small smile. “I don't think there's a chance you will lose.”

“Seriously?” Phainon's eyes grazed over Herklas's expression, but, from what Phainon had learned over his few days in Okhema, the man was never one to jest.

“Just don't underestimate him.” Herklas pushed himself off the floor, standing where he was previously sitting. “I assume you're here to warm up before the fight. Let me join.”

“And why would we do that?!” Empousa gawked.

“It wouldn't hurt to let him join,” Phainon agreed. “The more people who know about Krateros, the more helpful it'll be for me, anyway.”

Mumbling under her breath, Empousa begrudgingly agreed, and Phainon spent the rest of Lucid Hour and the beginning of Action Hour fitting in a last-minute training session with Empousa and Herklas. They went over who Krateros was as a person, his fighting style, his weapon, everything that they possibly knew about the man both on and off the battlefield. As Phainon’s only encounter with Krateros was last night, when Mydei had an argument with him, Phainon did his hardest to retain everything that they were telling and showing him. He wasn’t sure how much Phainon could have possibly accomplished without these two helping him, and the time finally arrived faster than they had all realized.

Rolling his shoulders, Phainon stowed away the wooden sword that he was using as Empousa informed them of the time. His heart pounded against his chest at the realization that the time had arrived, and he was sure he would not be facing a happy Krateros, especially after the conversation he witnessed last night. Herklas wished him good luck and said he would clean up in the training grounds for them before heading to the Colosseum, so Empousa and Phainon went ahead without him.

He patted Dawnmaker at his side as they strolled over to the Colosseum. His palms felt clammy under the bright sun, and he had to wipe his hands along his clothes, which didn’t really help because he was wearing leather gauntlets. He balled his hands into fists over and over, feeling the blood pumping through his veins from when he was training with Empousa and Herklas.

After these few days of escorting the Kremnoans in Okhema, he had no need to swing Dawnmaker around within Okhema’s peaceful borders. He had previously done some test swings with Dawnmaker in the training grounds, and the weight of the greatsword still fit so naturally in his hand. Phainon didn’t think the next time Dawnmaker would be seeing action would be against a great Kremnoan general within their borders, yet here he was, approaching the Colosseum with a battle scheduled. One thing he was

slightly worried about was that he had never fought with this armor that Aglaea gifted him. He was used to the soldier's uniform, and he spent a good quint with Empousa and Herklas trying to become accustomed to the newfound weight on his shoulders.

He had originally thought it would be a spar with wooden weapons, which Empousa and Herklas quickly shot down and explained that it was a real battle. The battle would only stop once the opponent could physically not move or if they voluntarily surrendered, and Phainon swore he felt his heart dropping into his stomach at the news. They were proud Kremnoans, after all, and there was not a chance Krateros was going to voluntarily surrender. They explained the rules of the battle that severing limbs, permanently injuring the opponent such as blinding them, and actually killing their opponent was off the table, but everything else was fair game. Phainon's mind swirled at the simple yet drastic rules; he knew Krateros was going to do anything and everything in his power to win against Phainon, and he had to get in the same mindset as well if he wanted to win against Krateros.

Once they were face-to-face with the grand amphitheater once more, Phainon inhaled sharply as Empousa patted his back and led him to a guard standing in front of the entrance. Citizens of all ages were crowding into the stands. How did everyone know of this battle even before Phainon himself knew of this battle? He felt his hands become sweaty again at how many people filled the audience; he couldn't believe they were all hear just to witness this fight. Well, it *was* against a great Kremnoan general. Phainon was sure he would be watching in the stands too if he was not actually the opposing side.

"This him?" The guard posted out front scanned Phainon up and down.

Empousa nodded as she slapped Phainon's back. Turning to Phainon, she muttered, "Good luck. I'll be in the stands."

He was sad to see her go as he was left with the guard, and it felt like the pressure really was on now that Empousa was gone. The weight of the upcoming battle weighed heavily on his shoulders as the guard gestured roughly in a direction off to the side, telling him to wait in that room. Nodding, Phainon obliged, and he waited off to the side as he continued to

watch more Kremnoans filing into the amphitheater. The Colosseum was filled with bustling activity and the sounds of numerous conversations all happening at once, but all Phainon could hear was his heart pounding in his chest. He stared down at his hands, wondering what Mydei was doing.

A horn sounded from the bottom floor of the Colosseum, and Phainon jumped to his feet at the sound. There was some sort of announcer who was explaining the fight, but Phainon swore he could not register a single thing they were saying. He was way too nervous to understand a single word, and he flinched when the announcer's hand beckoned him forward.

With wide eyes, Phainon hesitantly stepped under the sunlight with hollers and cheers resounding through the stands. He wasn't sure what kind of introduction the announcer had given him, as he was even surprised the audience was cheering for some mysterious guest from afar. His blue eyes quickly scanned the crowd, but it was much too bright to see higher than the third floor.

His eyes shot back down when he spotted movement in the corner of his eyes, and he saw that older man from last night approaching the other end of the grounds. Adorned in that same armor Phainon had met him in, Krateros actually appeared much calmer than Phainon had originally expected. He would have thought the man would be seething with rage at seeing the boy he had raised announcing his love for some random man from some random kingdom, declaring that the royal bloodline would end with him.

Phainon withdrew Dawnmaker as he narrowed his eyes across the grounds at his opponent, while Krateros spun the spear within his hand. He was at a slight disadvantage in terms of reach, as the spear could reach much farther than Dawnmaker, but his greatsword was heavy enough to overpower the weight of Krateros's weapon. Breathing deeply through his nose to calm his nerves, the announcer departed from the bottom floor, leaving Krateros and Phainon to their battle.

He grasped tightly at the hilt of Dawnmaker, assuming a defensive stance as Krateros darted over from across the field. Phainon was shocked at how fast the man was, and sparks flew as their blades collided. Slashing his sword to

the right, he threw Krateros off balance and attempted another swing, but Krateros quickly regained his footing and dodged to Phainon's left.

Blue eyes shifted to the left as he sidestepped backwards, swinging his greatsword to the left as his foot swiped in an arc along the dirt underneath his feet. Krateros parried it with ease with his armored gauntlets, sliding his forearm down the blade that was too heavy to fully stop and ducking when he had the chance. Phainon barely managed to stumble backwards, pulling Dawnmaker back to his side when a spear jabbed forward at his abdomen.

With a deep breath, Phainon created distance between them and barely dodged the attack. Krateros was a lot faster than Phainon was expecting, and he would have to catch up to his speed if he wanted to even land a hit. Empousa and Herklas had already informed him that his fighting style was very abrupt but calculating, and Phainon was experiencing it firsthand. His movements were swift, confident, and quick, and he always managed to aim for Phainon's weak points even though they had never fought before. Krateros knew Dawnmaker was heavy, and he knew that Phainon was uncomfortable in the armor he wore. It truly proved just how much battle experience Krateros held that he could read his opponents so well, and he admired him for that. But right now, there was no time for admiration. It was Phainon's turn to take advantage of Krateros's weaknesses.

Krateros dashed up to him once again, closing the distance between them. Even though his spear had more reach, Phainon realized Krateros already knew he would lose going against Dawnmaker if their weapons truly went against each other. He was trying to fit himself into the space between Phainon and Dawnmaker's swing, and because Dawnmaker was so heavy, Krateros was trying to take advantage of the time Phainon needed to pull the greatsword back to his side. He was trying to injure him in the time before Dawnmaker could be pulled back. Phainon was well aware of this, but he needed some way to combat this. It wasn't as if he could just pull in Dawnmaker faster, but he needed to shorten the arcs of his swings, giving Krateros less space and less time to fit in.

Keeping his elbow close to his side to shorten his swings, Phainon swung downwards to push the man back, and Krateros jumped back just in time for the blade to barely brush against his body. Phainon swore he saw a

smirk across Krateros’s face, but he didn’t have time to think about it as Krateros was on the move once again.

Phainon couldn’t take advantage of knocking the spear out of his hand, as Krateros wasn’t going to swing his weapon until he was in that sweet spot between Phainon and Dawnmaker, so he opted for his second weakness: His left eye. Phainon noticed Krateros was blind in one eye, and he would have to position himself perfectly in his blind spot to gain an advantage. He knew an experienced fighter such as Krateros most likely already had defense strategies in place to accomodate his lack of sight, but it was the only chance Phainon had. The only problem was that Phainon couldn’t make it too obvious he was trying to hit Krateros from his left, and he would have to distract him until he could put himself into his blind spot.

With his new strategy in place, Phainon would have to pretend he was fighting against Krateros while discreetly moving to Krateros's left. He brought Dawnmaker up to his chest as another jab was sent his way, and Phainon swiped the blade away. Krateros spun the spear in his hand before Phainon could knock it from his grasp, and Krateros tried again, thrusting his blade toward Phainon’s right arm. Phainon could already tell Krateros was trying to block him from ever approaching his left side, and the obvious move would be to sidestep to the left to avoid the slash against his right. However, that would move Phainon farther from Krateros’s weak side, so, instead, Phainon would have to solidify his position on Krateros’s left.

Phainon pivoted his right foot behind him, turning his body and throwing his left arm forward. Raising his right arm above his head, he grasped at the shaft right behind the spear itself. It was an awkward angle, now that Phainon had turned his body to be perpendicular to Krateros’s straight thrust, but he pulled the spear to his right. Krateros, who still had his hands wrapped around his weapon, was pulled forward. Before Krateros could jump back in time, Phainon used the weight of Dawnmaker to slam the hilt against the back of Krateros’s head, knocking him face-first into the floor.

Dust flew up into Phainon’s eyes, and he coughed, squinting through the haze to make sure Krateros had not escaped. He still kept his left hand tightly grasping the spear so that Krateros could not withdraw, unless he

wanted to leave without a weapon in hand. He had planned for Krateros to pull him into the ground using the spear in Phainon's hand, and he had already bent his knees and rooted his feet into the floor so it would be harder for him to budge. But, nothing happened, and when the dust cleared, Krateros was lying on the floor, facing the vast blue sky above them with a huge grin on his face.

Phainon was too taken aback to do anything and just stared silently down at him. The older man glanced over at him once the dust had settled, and he breathlessly laughed.

"I surrender."

The crowd erupted in the amphitheater–Phainon had forgotten he had an audience the entire time. It was so loud that he couldn't tell if the crowd was excited or angry that the fight had ended early. He even had a momentary thought that Krateros was just pretending to surrender to get the jump on him, but Krateros released the spear from his grip and pushed himself off the floor. Phainon was left holding two weapons in his hand, gawking at the older man who was dusting himself off.

"You look surprised." Krateros smirked in his direction, and Phainon quickly straightened himself.

"I just thought it wasn't the Kremnoan way to surrender."

"I already lost." Krateros belted out a heart laugh, but Phainon was still confused.

"I don't understand." Phainon furrowed his eyebrows with a frown. He still felt like he wasn't a true victor. "I didn't hit you hard enough to render you immobile."

"The deal was that whoever landed a hit first would win," Krateros explained. "You're good, kid. I didn't believe Mydeimos when he said I wouldn't land a single hit on you."

“Huh?” Phainon froze when he heard the familiar name, and he blinked blankly at the older Kremnoan general.

“Mydeimos bet that I wouldn’t be able to land a hit on you, and I thought the idea was preposterous,” Krateros grunted, crossing his arms. “How could he think that I, Krateros, the man who practically raised him and taught him how to fight, wouldn’t be able to land a single hit before you? I took on his bet that I would accept you into Kremnos if you managed to land a hit before I could, thinking that it would be an easy victory. I only needed to hit you once before you could hit me, and I didn’t take the fight lightly at all. But who knew you would fight with such gusto.”

Phainon’s mind was swirling as his shoulder slumped. It was way too hot under the sun to think about this, and there was no shade he could hide under in the entirety of the bottom floor. The announcer returned to announce Phainon’s victory, and he wasn’t pulled from his stupor until the crowd began to disperse. Krateros roughly patted his shoulder, shaking Phainon from his thoughts.

“Welcome to Kremnos Kingdom. I apologize you had to see me in that emotional state last night.” Krateros patted him on the shoulder once more before taking the spear from Phainon’s hand and departing from the Colosseum.

Slowly turning on his feet, Phainon watched Krateros disappear in the distance outside the Colosseum. He still felt like he was missing something even though his opponent had already disappeared, and he stayed rooted to his spot in the Colosseum until more familiar faces approached him.

“Phainon!” Empousa practically leaped onto Phainon, and he barely had time to catch her, making sure he didn’t hit her with Dawnmaker still in his hand.

“Did everyone know the battle would just be a one-hit wonder except for me?” Phainon noticed that neither her or Herklas behind her were the least surprised at Krateros’s surrender.

“Huh?” Empousa held Phainon back at an arm’s length, staring him up and down. “They announced it at the beginning. Weren’t you listening to the announcer?”

Phainon didn’t know whether to laugh or cry. Of course it would be the *one* time he neglected to listen to instructions.

“No wonder you looked so lost,” Herklas commented with an amused smile.

Phainon didn’t know what to say; he was actually rendered speechless, and it even came to a point that Empousa had to basically drag him out of the Colosseum. It was getting late into Action Hour now, and Empousa wanted to celebrate his victory out at a restaurant before most of the city closed during Parting Hour.

Herklas had to recount everything the announcer said while they made their way into the city, and now everything suddenly made sense to Phainon. The announcer had introduced Phainon as King Mydeimos’s lover brought back from Okhema Kingdom, and it was why he had received so much applause when he stepped into the stadium. The announcer even explained the whole premise of the battle, that Phainon would be accepted into the kingdom as the King’s lover if he won. And because everyone except for Phainon was listening to the announcer, everyone cheered at Krateros’s surrender because they already knew it was the end of the battle with that one hit from Phainon.

Herklas had also explained that, because Krateros was such a famous figure in Kremnos, all the citizens were eager to watch a battle with him involved. Thus, because everyone went to the Colosseum during the battle, now everyone in Castrum Kremnos knew of him. Phainon slumped into his chair once they were finally seated at a table at a diner. He couldn’t believe he missed so much important information from the announcer. Suddenly, Phainon went from some mysterious visitor from afar to the King’s lover, and everyone recognized him wherever he went.

He was exhausted after so much information was poured into his brain, and he trusted Empousa to order his food for him while he reflected on his

battle with Krateros. It wasn't until the restaurant they were seated in erupted into chaos that Phainon glanced up and was met with very familiar golden eyes.

"Nice work, Deliverer." Mydei stood over their table with a smirk across his lips.

"Mydei!" Phainon's eyes sparkled with excitement, and he had to stop himself from jumping from his seat. Empousa and Herklas, who were seated across from Phainon, nodded at their King as he took the empty seat next to Phainon.

"Phainon truly is amazing." Empousa grinned once Mydei had settled into his seat.

"Indeed," Mydei agreed. "He perfectly met my expectations."

"Were you watching, Mydei?" Phainon eagerly hounded Mydei. He hadn't seen the man all day, and he was starving for his attention.

"Of course I was," Mydei huffed, crossing his arms and narrowing his eyes at the silver-haired man. "I'm offended you didn't see me."

"Where… were you?" Phainon furrowed his eyebrows as he thought back to the Colosseum, and then it hit him. It was so bright that he physically could not see above the third floor. Because the first floor was where Phainon and Krateros fought, Phainon could only see two rows of the audience before being blinded by the sunlight.

"The King's seat is at the very top floor of the Colosseum," Herklas explained. "It's quite the grand throne."

Phainon's eyes widened as he was scrutinized under Mydei's sharp gaze. Herklas was obviously implying that Mydei would be extremely hard to miss in the crowd.

"It was too bright to see!" He pleaded his case at Mydei, who raised an eyebrow. "I swear! I tried to look past the third floor, but the sun was in my

eyes!”

Sighing, Mydei let him off the hook, much to Phainon’s relief. “As long as you didn’t make me lose my bet with Krateros.”

“Was the battle entirely your idea?” Phainon stared at Mydei, who nodded.

“I told you that Krateros would accept you if he saw you battle. So, I set one up.”

“Without telling me?!”

“Did Empousa not tell you?”

“Well, yeah, but it was kind of sudden!” Phainon whirled his attention over to Empousa, who straightened at suddenly being dragged into this lover’s quarrel. “Didn’t you say Krateros declared the battle last night?”

“He did.” Mydei’s deep voice answered beside him before Empousa opened her mouth, and Phainon’s attention snapped back to Mydei.

“But, how did you set up a battle last night if–” Phainon interrupted himself with a heavy sigh as the realization hit him. “You didn’t fall asleep like I thought you did.”

“That’s the third time you thought I had fallen asleep.” Mydei smirked in amusement. “You’re right. After you fell asleep, I went to speak with Krateros again.”

Phainon heaved another sigh, propping his chin in the palm of his hand. “I feel set up.”

Mydei scoffed and leaned back in his chair. “You should, because you were.”

Scowling at his words, Phainon spent the rest of their meal bickering back and forth with Mydei, with Empousa and Herklas observing the couple with sheer amusement.

His body landed with a soft *thump* into the bedsheets that were now clean, and Phainon breathed a deep sigh of relief now that the day was finally over. After their meal, Phainon and Mydei parted from the two guards, and they spent the rest of Parting Hour together. Mydei had shown him around Castrum Kremnos and the palace as he promised, giving him a tour of his new home. He introduced Phainon to the throne room that they previously passed, Mydei's office, the vast kitchen, the dining halls, the numerous training grounds, and even a giant library that scaled from floor to ceiling and consisted of multiple floors. It was a grand library unlike anything Phainon had ever seen, even in Okhema and Janusopolis, where he occasionally visited under Aglaea's orders. Once they returned to their bedroom during Curtain-Fall Hour, Phainon washed up before collapsing into the bed out of absolute exhaustion, burying his face into the sheets.

He heard Mydei's deep voice chuckling beside him, and he felt the bed dip next to him as Mydei settled into the bed. Phainon's eyes fluttered shut when he felt a warm hand running through the back of his hair and massaging his scalp.

"You did good today, Phainon." Mydei murmured, playing with the silver strands upon his head.

Phainon hummed, his face still buried in the sheets. "Praise me more."

"If I praised you anymore, I'd have to prepare myself for another long night."

Phainon reached out and swatted in Mydei's direction, and the golden-haired man laughed as he caught his hand with ease. Pulling his face from the bed, he stared up at Mydei who was sitting right beside him.

"Did Krateros ever come around with you wanting to end the bloodline?"

Mydei scoffed, resuming to stroke Phainon's hair. "Of course not. But, my first priority was you."

"I'm sure you have better things to worry about than my livelihood in Kremnos," Phainon mumbled, his eyes half-closed from Mydei's

ministrations.

“How could I have you move to Kremnos without anyone knowing who you were?” Mydei remarked. “I want you to be comfortable in my kingdom, and you wouldn't be able to learn anything from anyone without first being accepted into the kingdom.”

Humming, Phainon lost himself to Mydei's touches and fully closed his eyes. He had to admit that Mydei was right; the Okhema assembly against the Council of Elders was only a few months away, and Phainon had to use that time to gain the trust of the Kremnoans to garner their support.

“How was Castrum Kremnos?” Mydei broke their brief, but comfortable, silence. “It was your first day here.”

“Tiring.” Phainon let out a breathless laugh. “But beautiful. I want to be able to explore Castrum Kremnos more while I have more energy tomorrow.”

“You deserve it.” A pair of lips pressed against Phainon's forehead, and he sighed with content as he felt the sheets shifting beside him. Wearily opening his eyes, Phainon saw that Mydei had tucked himself into bed and was in the process of covering Phainon with the sheets.

“Good night, Mydei,” Phainon mumbled with a smile as he was wrapped in the blankets, shutting his eyes and immediately letting the sleep overtake him.

With a small smile, Mydei brushed the bangs from Phainon's face, admiring his peaceful expression as the silver-haired man quickly fell into a deep slumber.

“I love you, Phainon.”

Epilogue 2: The Debate

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The carriage door opened, and Mydei and Phainon stepped out into the cool night air. It was Curtain-Fall Hour, and they had just arrived in Okhema Kingdom after a long journey. The carriage dropped them off in front of the palace in the depths of the night, and only a few guards were alerted that they would be arriving. On the other hand, Mydei had only brought two guards with him: Empousa and Herklas.

For this to succeed, it was imperative they moved in secrecy. They were trying to catch the Council of Elders off guard, so it was essential that as few people knew they were arriving as possible. It was also crucial for Mydei to bring as few people as possible to avoid detection. As far as the entire kingdom was aware, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae was still in Kremnos Kingdom.

It had been nine months since Phainon departed from Okhema Kingdom, and it was now the second month of the new year: the Month of Balance. This was when the review of legislation took place annually, after the celebrations marking the end of the previous year had concluded. The time seemed to pass by both slowly and quickly, as Phainon stared up at the familiar, yet unfamiliar, palace in front of him.

During his nine months in Kremnos Kingdom, Phainon did exactly as he was asked: to gain the trust of the Kremnoans. It wasn't very difficult, in Phainon's opinion, mostly because so many Kremnoans had built respect for him just from his battle with Krateros on his first day in Castrum Kremnos. Because of that day, everyone recognized Phainon's strength, and he further solidified his role and position in Kremnos, the more missions and quests he took upon himself to complete.

Mydei didn't grant him a special title, promotion, or any sort of high position within the Kremnos government. He didn't want it to seem as if he

were playing favorites, which Phainon agreed with as well. Instead, Mydei let Phainon do whatever he pleased in the kingdom, and Phainon decided to join the ranks of the Kremnoans vanguard alongside Empousa, Herklas, and Georgious, assuming the same role of a soldier that he had held in Okhema. It was during his nine months with the Kremnoan vanguard that they all built trust with Phainon, fought on the battlefield with Phainon, and completed missions with Phainon. It didn't take long for the Kremnoans to forget that there was even a time he did not reside in Kremnos at all. It seemed almost natural for Phainon to be with them, and they welcomed him with open arms.

There was some debate over his position, though, as many Kremnoans favored Phainon so much that they cried for him to have a position in government, similar to Krateros who earned his through strength. They believed that if anyone in this day and age was worthy of earning a title for their strength, it would be Phainon. However, Phainon had other ideas for what he would do in the government, and he had already discussed it with Mydei many months prior to their journey back to Okhema:

“You want to *what?!*”

Phainon's shoulders wilted at Mydei's exclamation. “Is that not possible?”

Mydei sighed exasperately, running his hands through golden hair. It had been about four months of Phainon living in Castrum Kremnos, and he had adjusted quite well to his new life. Considering that he was a vanguard, his daily life wasn't too different from when he was a soldier in Okhema. The only real difficulties he had was trying to remember where everything was located, and trying to remember that he didn't have to treat everyone so formally. In fact, people were treating Phainon with formalities, and it was something that he could never get used to.

“That's…” Mydei narrowed his eyes as he mulled over the idea.

“I know I'm an outsider, but–”

“That's not the problem. Do you know how hard it is to run a kingdom?”

“I'm with you every day, Mydei, of course I know.” Phainon steeled himself with determination. He was prepared for Mydei to lash out at him over his proposal, but he was determined to help Mydei wherever he could. “You said you would rely on me.”

“I didn't mean run my kingdom for me,” Mydei snapped.

“But–”

“I already told you that I have come to terms with my disposition. You do not have to worry about me, and it is not something that I am worrying about.” Mydei pushed himself up from his office desk, and Phainon scrambled to continue the conversation before Mydei could end it.

“Think about it, Mydei. You'll be living in a world where everyone you ever loved will be gone. You will have to watch them breathe their last breath every single time. You will have to watch them age without you, while your body remains unchanging. Every person that you will ever meet will eventually leave you behind, and it may even come to a point where you forget about all those you have ever loved. Is that really a life you want to live?”

Mydei wavered at his desk, standing in place. Unbeknownst to Phainon, Mydei was only thinking about Phainon as he spoke those words. He would have to watch Phainon age without him. He would have to watch Phainon breathe his last breath and leave without him. He would have to live a life without Phainon. And then, after all of that, Mydei would forget about Phainon and all the time they spent together.

“Let me help you, Mydei. Learn how to control your magic so that you do not live forever with your disposition any longer. And while you are away, I will run the kingdom in your place until your return.” Phainon stared at Mydei, who was still turning the idea in his head. He knew with Mydei's hesitancy that he had a chance to turn the conversation around in his favor before Mydei had a chance to end it.

Mydei had previously explained that he could not spare the time to control his magic like Castorice because he had to run a kingdom, while Castorice

did not have to do that. Phainon asked him at a later time why he didn't rely on Krateros to run the kingdom in his place, but Mydei said that they had very different views on the monarchy and leading the kingdom. Unless Mydei had to physically leave the kingdom for whatever reason, he would trust the kingdom into Krateros's hands. But Mydei's leaving for magic reasons was not a necessity, according to him. In addition, Krateros still had his own duties to handle within the kingdom as a general of the Kremnoan vanguard, and he wouldn't be able to play King at the same time. Which was why Phainon had a somewhat different idea.

“Teach me about the monarchy, and I will run the kingdom exactly as you wish. Then, we can set up a new Kremnos Kingdom together once you return, so that you do not have to live as its ruler for hundreds of years.” Phainon urged. “If we get married, then I'll–”

“*Married?!*” Mydei's face flushed red.

“W–Well…” Phainon couldn't help his own face from flushing in embarrassment after Mydei's reaction. “I would become your… Queen, basically, right? Then, I would be able to run the kingdom in your place while the King is gone.”

Mydei's throat bobbed at the idea, and he cleared his throat in an attempt to suppress his blush. “You wish to become Queen of Kremnos?”

Embarrassment continued to wash over Phainon, and his blush crept down to his neck. “It's…Well, I just–I'm trying to help you!” He cried, covering the lower half of his face with his hand and averting his gaze. “Look, if you don't want to get married–”

“I didn't say that at all.” Despite Mydei's crimson face, his words were completely serious.

“So you… want to get married?”

“Was it not your idea?”

“I was just thinking from a government perspective!” It was getting hot in Mydei's office, and Phainon began fanning his neck using the collar of his black undershirt.

“So, you only wish to get married to me so you can run the kingdom in my place?”

Phainon stayed silent, continuing to avert his eyes with an obvious blush. “Of course… not…” He finally mumbled, frowning at his heart that pounded in his chest.

Mydei scoffed in amusement, a smirk creeping onto his face, and his blush continued to grow. “So, you want to get married?”

“Do *you* want to get married?” Phainon hesitantly met Mydei's golden eyes that were smiling at him. “I mean… I know it's only been four months, but we can have the ceremony before you leave for the Grove and after I learn about this kingdom.”

Mydei hummed. “That's quite a way away. I don't think I can wait that long.”

“You want to get married right *now?!”* Embarrassment washed over Phainon once more.

Chuckling, Mydei swung his strong arms around Phainon's shoulders, pulling him close. Phainon didn't even realize when Mydei had approached him.

“I was only joking.” Mydei laughed lightly. “Fine. Let us get married later. And in the meantime, I will teach you all there is to know about our kingdom.”

“Our…” Phainon's face grew hot at his words.

“If you are to be my Queen, that would make this *our* kingdom, no?” Mydei smirked and pecked a kiss upon his lips, but Phainon was in too much of a daze to even react.

Thus, starting from that day, Phainon accompanied Mydei as his personal vanguard, learning all there was to learn about the kingdom and the monarchy. He alternated between accompanying Mydei while also taking on missions to sever the black tide monsters brewing outside their borders. In this way, Phainon learned about the monarchy while also gaining the trust of the Kremnoan citizens. And he did that for the next nine months in Kremnos up until his return to Okhema.

The carriages departed behind Phainon and Mydei, and to his right, Phainon could see Empousa and Herklas approaching them. They rode in a separate carriage that followed closely behind Phainon and Mydei.

An Okheman maid led them to their accommodations for their stay, and it was the same rooms that they had stayed in many months ago for the ball. They will be staying in Okhema for a week. The debate would occur tomorrow, and it would occur for the entirety of the day. Mydei, Phainon, Empousa, and Herklas would only appear when needed, which would be when Aglaea's plan was enacted. The rest of the week would be spent solidifying the alliance with Aglaea and ironing out the details for what was to become of this new age of Okheman government. That is, if their plan tomorrow was to succeed.

Phainon collapsed into the bed, exhausted from the long journey from Kremnos. Mydei proceeded to undress for the night, while Empousa and Herklas resided in the room adjacent to theirs. Heaving a sigh, Phainon stared up at the chandelier that he was familiar with all those months ago from when he would share this room with Mydei during the week of the royal ball.

“Nervous?” Mydei's deep voice rang clearly in the guest room.

Phainon turned to him wearily, blinking the sleep out of his eyes. “I'm more exhausted than anything. Although I am a little nervous, as I don't know what to expect tomorrow.” He only had a general gist of the plans and the role he would have to play, but he wasn't exactly sure if he had to specifically do anything other than show up as the Deliverer.

The other man slipped into his familiar silk robe, strolling over to Phainon and kneeling on the floor between his legs, which currently hung off the edge of the bed. “I am sure Aglaea already accounted for you in her plans. If she wanted you to do anything specific, she would have communicated that to us.”

Sighing, Phainon couldn't help but agree. Aglaea was like that, after all. He forced himself to sit up in the bed, observing Mydei as he stripped Phainon of his outside clothes. He pulled off his leather boots, undid the belt around his thigh, but before he could move on to his pants, Phainon held out his hand. “I can handle it from here.”

His blush didn't go unnoticed by Mydei, who smirked, lowering his hands, but he didn't move from his spot on the ground between Phainon’s legs. Phainon could only helplessly strip under Mydei's darkening gaze while ignoring the fluttering in his stomach.

“We have a big day tomorrow, Mydei,” Phainon mumbled, cheeks burning hot when the sound of his pants unzipping echoed in the room.

Mydei's eyes were glued to Phainon's hands that fiddled with his zipper. “I know.”

“Then…”

“It doesn't hurt just to look.” Mydei lifted his eyes at Phainon, his hands balling into fists at how delectable Phainon looked above him. The silver-haired man sat with his legs spread before him, a bulge already evident in his pants, with the most adorable blush across his cheeks as his blue eyes trembled under Mydei's gaze. Mydei still found it amazing how Phainon would get hard even without Mydei touching him.

“How are you not tired?” Phainon continued fiddling with the zipper even though he had already pulled it down. He just didn't want to do the next step of removing his pants right under Mydei's gaze, especially because he felt the heat between his legs stirring.

At those words, Mydei pushed himself off the floor, grabbing Phainon's waistband himself and dropping his pants to the floor. “I don't have all night to wait for you, Phainon. Didn't you say we had a big day tomorrow?”

Phainon gulped, eyes flitting between Mydei’s tempting lips that were nearing his and his golden eyes that were almost black from how much they had dilated. His breath hitched in his throat when a weight settled into his lap, and his hands automatically flew to grasp a handful of Mydei's behind as he settled on top of him. He continued shifting in his seat, teasing Phainon over the edge as he continued purposefully grinding into Phainon's already hard erection.

This was going to be a long night.

It was Action Hour when they all departed from their rooms and headed to the Demigod Council. It was a part of Okhema where the Council of Elders resided, and the debate was currently occurring there. As they were not needed until the question of Aglaea's power came into the discussion, they didn't depart until much later in the day. And because no one knew Phainon and the others were here, they couldn't leave their rooms until the time was right to ensure no one else saw them.

It was Phainon's job to lead the rest of his party over to the Demigod Council, and the Okheman citizens were quite shocked to suddenly see Phainon again after a couple of months of his departure with no prior warning at all, especially with the Kremnoan King in tow. Many of them would run up to Phainon in utter excitement but would immediately back away upon seeing the high-profile noble right next to him. Phainon would only wave to them from afar, explaining to all he passed that he and Mydei were going to the Demigod Council.

Because of that, more Okheman citizens decided to join the assembly with Phainon, and it soon felt like a crowd was gathering behind them as they all made their way to the Demigod Council. Citizens who wanted to participate and vote in the debate could only join at the very start, which was in Lucid Hour, so Phainon was not exactly sure why everyone was following them.

It was quite a far trek through Okhema, but they eventually made it to the outdoor amphitheater where the debate was taking place. From afar, Phainon could spot Caenis, the leader of the Council of Elders, in the center of the amphitheater, grandly discussing something, but he was too far to see what she was harping about. Off to the side was the rest of the Council of Elders, Castorice, and Anaxa. On the other side of Caenis was Aglaea, and in the stands were the participating citizens of Okhema. Phainon whirled his head toward Mydei with wide eyes, silently wondering how they were supposed to catch the Council of Elders off guard if there was a crowd of Okhemans following behind him.

He wasn't exactly sure if Mydei understood what he was trying to wordlessly convey because the man only nodded and proceeded to the amphitheater. Phainon, panicking, could only run after Mydei while he strolled straight up to Aglaea. There was nothing barring them from entering the amphitheater, and Mydei soon joined Aglaea's side with ease. Though, the look on Caenis's face was priceless.

“You–!” Her burning eyes whipped toward Aglaea, who appeared as nonchalant as ever with Mydei at her side. “What is he doing here?!”

“I would prefer it if you spoke to me directly.” Mydei's voice boomed in the amphitheater, and murmurs resounded throughout the stands at this new appearance. “It's nice to make your acquaintance. My name is Mydeimos, from Castrum Kremnos.”

Caenis's face boiled with rage, and she pointed a finger at Aglaea. “Why did you bring this outsider?!”

“Going by that logic, I believe we should remove the Grove and Styxia Kingdom, no?” Aglaea cocked her head to the side, her smile never dissipating. “I do believe a welcome is in order for the King. It's nice to finally have you join us, King Mydeimos.”

“The pleasure is all mine,” Mydei responded.

“That's because Okhema has an alliance with the Grove and Styxia,” Caenis retorted, continuing to ignore the King's presence. “There is no reason why

an outside kingdom should be present during discussions of Okheman legislation.”

“I believe there is a reason.”

As if on cue, Phainon finally met Mydei's side. He took a deep breath after finally settling next to the King, and the citizens in the stands erupted into an uproar.

“How did you get so far ahead of me?” Phainon muttered quietly enough that only Mydei could hear over the roaring crowd. The Council of Elders was taking this time to try to silence the Okheman citizens.

“Right on time, Deliverer.” Mydei smirked while crossing his arms.

“Huh?” Phainon furrowed his eyebrows, but before he could say anything more, Caenis's voice overpowered the crowd.

“Silence!” Caenis's voice boomed, and the citizens all settled down. With a deep exhale, she turned to Phainon with narrowed eyes. “Welcome back, Phainon of Aedes Elysiae.”

“It's a pleasure seeing you again, Miss Caenis.” Phainon never knew such an outright lie could ever leave his mouth.

“How kind of you to make it to this assembly, but I believe we no need for any more guards on duty for today.” Caenis shot him a wry smile.

“Phainon is here to join me today,” Mydei cut in, and Caenis's eyes finally fell upon the Kremnoan King.

“To join you?” Caenis raised an eyebrow, mirroring Mydei in crossing her arms across her chest. “Pardon me, but I still don't see why the Kremnoan King has decided to join us today.”

“King Mydeimos has agreed to work with Okhema.” Aglaea gracefully stepped forward after flashing a smile in Phainon's direction. “I sent Phainon over to Kremnos to work out arrangements for an alliance.”

Caenis didn't seem the least bit impressed. “So, Okhema will be joining hands with Kremnos Kingdom. That doesn't explain why that man was in Kremnos for more than a month.”

“Phainon and I are getting married.”

The entire amphitheater froze in time; even Phainon felt the air grow cold under the afternoon sun, and even Aglaea faltered in her footsteps just slightly. Across the amphitheater, Castorice's eyes widened, and Anaxa had buried his face in his hand. Phainon couldn't tell if Anaxa was flabbergasted or exhausted from hearing the news.

“Ex–Excuse me?” Caenis was also flabbergasted, and Phainon couldn't blame her at all. Even he was flabbergasted.

“Phainon is to become the new Queen of Kremnos,” Mydei leisurely continued. “Kremnos will not be joining hands with Okhema; they will be joining hands with the Deliverer.”

The crowd erupted into a frenzy of murmurs and whispers, with Phainon faintly hearing recounts of him being Mydei's guard a couple of months ago. Caenis’s eyes widened at the King's words. “You can't just pick and choose who you want to work with–”

“The Deliverer will be joining hands with Kremnos Kingdom. I don't see what is confusing about this.” Mydei tilted his head to the side.

“If you're working with that man, that means you are joining arms with the Okhema–”

“I don't recall the Deliverer having an official position within the Okheman government,” Mydei interjected Caenis's words. “Even the title ‘Deliverer’ is an unofficial title granted by the common people. Kremnos will be working with the Deliverer, who is currently under Aglaea's command.”

Caenis fell silent at his words, her eyes trembling with fury. The other Elders continued their silence, their gazes glued to Caenis in the middle of the amphitheater.

“Well, I believe we should have a vote now.” Aglaea nonchalantly waved her hand in the air, attracting the attention of the crowd. It was then that Caenis noticed that the crowd had somehow grown in size compared to this morning, but, in a fit of rage, she could not differentiate who had been there since the beginning and who had not. However, she wasn't very concerned since the newcomers could not vote.

“You–”

“Shall we start with the citizens' vote?” Aglaea gestured toward the stands. “Or shall we start with the government vote?” She stepped forward as her golden heels resounded against the concrete under her feet, meeting Caenis in the middle. “The legislation in question is: Aglaea's role in the Okheman government. To abolish their leader and become an oligarchy–a government in which only the Council of Elders will rule. Or, shall I propose a new form of government–a government without the Council of Elders at all.”

The citizens erupted once more at Aglaea's proposal, with Caenis's attention whipping back over to Aglaea.

“And where are your grounds for proposing such legislation?” Caenis barked.

“My grounds being that my own rule is being questioned by the Council,” Aglaea promptly answered. “How are the citizens supposed to believe in a government where its Council questioned the motives of their leader?”

“It is only a mere proposal,” Caenis scoffed back. “A proposal that does not yet have a ruling.”

“To question is to lose trust.” Anaxa's voice suddenly resounded through the amphitheater. “The moment you question is the moment trust falters.”

“Would you say, when a student questions you during a lecture, that they are losing trust in you?” Caenis turned toward Anaxa, who was still standing among the Council of Elders.

Much to everyone’s surprise, Anaxa readily agreed. “I would say so.”

“So, you would agree that you have lost the trust of every single student that has ever asked you a question?”

“You misunderstand.” Anaxa shook his head in annoyance. “Asking a question does not equate to questioning. You may ask a question out of sheer curiosity or a need for clarification. But questioning would mean doubt–doubt in what an individual says, does, or believes in. Conversely, I would regain their trust after answering or explaining correctly.”

Caenis scoffed. “A professor and Grand Sage who so readily admits to having his authority questioned by his own students. Were you not of the same mind to unite under an oligarchy? Similar to how the Grove is run, Okhema can venture toward that same path.”

“An individual can never learn if they can never doubt,” Anaxa said. “And an oligarchy would only be the correct path if run by the correct people.”

With the professor’s final words, the crowd murmured amongst each other once more. His answer was vague enough that it could be taken both ways: Either he believed the Council of Elders to be the correct people, or he did not believe they were the correct people.

“Let us start with the government vote.” Caenis, who had regained her composure, glared at Aglaea. “As we always do.”

Aglaea only smiled and returned to Phainon and Mydei's side of the amphitheater. In the center of the amphitheater was placed a large jar, and each member of the assembly was given a metal disk with a different color on each side. By dropping the metal disk either up or down that corresponded with their vote into the jar, it would record the number of responses for each side and emit a color of smoke for the winning vote.

As per usual, the government officials and allies would vote first, then the citizens would vote after. After finalizing the winning side for each group of voters is when the color of smoke is released from the opening of the jar. It was why the citizens who just joined the crowd could not vote; the metal disk was only distributed at the very beginning of the debate.

However, a metal disk was each given to Phainon and Mydei now that they had joined the assembly. Caenis couldn't kick Mydei out now that he had announced his allegiance to Phainon and Aglaea. Kremnos was now seen as an ally who could partake in the assembly, and Phainon was given a metal disk now that he was connected to the monarch of Kremnos and no longer an average citizen.

Each representative went up, one by one, to drop their metal disk into the jar. With their back turned to the assembly, it would be impossible to see who voted for which side. The Council of Elders voted, Castorice voted, and Anaxa voted. Aglaea voted, Mydei voted, and finally, Phainon voted. Following them, the citizens began to cast their vote. One by one, each citizen in the stands who possessed a metal disk would rise, dropping their disk in the jar.

Phainon watched the crowd whispering amongst each other in the stands, and it was then that he realized. All of the citizens who followed Phainon up to the amphitheater were in support of him, and now that they were sitting amongst the crowd, they could influence the decision-making of those citizens in possession of a metal disk. Phainon, Mydei, Empousa, and Herklas approaching the Demigod Council was all a show. It was a wordless show of Kremnos's alliance with Phainon, and now that the citizens knew they were even getting married, Phainon was being seen in a new light of holding his own government power in a different kingdom. They were not voting for a titleless man anymore; they were voting for a queen. Everything somehow followed the exact plan that Aglaea had articulated, even without any specific instruction from Aglaea herself.

With the last citizen returning to their seat in the stand, every single metal disk was now accounted for. With Phainon, Mydei, Aglaea, Castorice, and Anaxa all voting for the same side, they should outnumber the votes of the Council of Elders. And, if all went according to plan, they would have to win two-thirds of the citizen votes to win the citizen assembly vote.

Everyone watched silently with anticipation as the jar sat in the middle of the amphitheater. Whispers and murmurs echoed amongst the stands as they urged the jar to reveal the outcome of the votes. Gold smoke would mean more metal disks with the gold side facing up were cast into the jar, which

was in favor of Aglaea keeping her position. Whereas, white smoke would mean more metal disks with the white side facing up were cast into the jar, which was the side for the oligarchy.

And everyone saw the jar puff up a smoke glittering with gold.

“I believe a congratulations is in order.”

Phainon, who was watching the assembly disperse, glanced over to the voice speaking to him. With smiling eyes, he nodded in her direction. “Congratulations, Miss Aglaea. Everything proceeded according to your plan.”

Her eyebrows shot up as she stopped in front of Phainon. “I didn't mean for me. I meant for you.”

“For me?”

“I heard you were getting married. Thus, a congratulations would be in order.”

Phainon choked. “Thank you… Miss Aglaea.”

“Oh, don't be so formal with me.” She tilted her head with a smile. “I am only but a leader; nothing in comparison to a queen.”

At her jest, Phainon burned brightly. “I am not married yet.”

“Still, I didn't realize your relationship had blossomed like so.” She laughed lightly at how dark Phainon’s cheeks became. “Had I known, I would have sent you to Kremnos much earlier. I didn't realize you had talks of marriage during those couple of months on leave.”

“Miss Aglaea…”

“I'll be awaiting my invitation to the ceremony.” With another chuckle, Aglaea departed from the Demigod Council. Most likely, she had a lot of work to return to as the new sole leader of Okhema.

With Phainon left in the amphitheater, he proceeded to make his way to Mydei, who was speaking to Empousa and Herklas off to the side. They were watching the debate on the sidelines, since they could not participate in the vote. As he was making his way over, however, he noticed someone else staring in his direction.

Laughing, Phainon turned toward their peering eyes. “Castorice, I don't bite.”

Castorice's cheeks grew red as she scurried over. “I didn't mean to stare.”

“I don't mind, Castorice.” He was already quite used to Castorice’s somewhat odd behavior. “How have you been? It has surely been quite a while.”

She nodded, her eyes darting between Phainon and something behind him. “Business has been the same in Okhema. I am glad to see you in such good health, Lord Phainon.”

“The same goes to you.”

“Has… Kremnos been treating you well?” For some reason, Castorice's cheeks grew red once more. Phainon wasn't sure why; it was quite a typical question.

It was Phainon's turn to nod. “Kremnos has been very good to me. Although it took some time to become accustomed to the new environment, life has treated me well over there.”

“I'm glad.” The blush across her face did not fade. “I… would like to express my congratulations to you as well… again. Should I refer to you as Queen Phainon?”

Phainon frowned as his own face mirrored the color of Castorice's. “Thank you, Castorice. And…” He cleared his throat. “Just ‘Phainon’ is fine.”

Castorice nodded once more. “Has King Mydeimos been treating you well? I heard a little from writing to Miss Empousa.”

“You exchange letters with Empousa?” This was the first Phainon had ever heard of it. Empousa never mentioned such a thing. Since when had the two become close enough to even exchange letters?

“*Err*, yes.” It seemed the color of Castorice's face darkened.

“What do you write to her about?”

“...Stories.”

“Stories?”

“And… writings.”

Phainon vaguely remembered when he had first seen Empousa and Castorice together, and they had said they were talking about inspiration for Castorice's writings. “That's right. How have your stories been coming along?”

Smiling softly, it was almost as if Castorice's eyes sparkled. “Very, very well.”

“You get a lot of inspiration from Empousa?”

Her eyes seemed to sparkle even more brightly. “Very much so.”

Castorice and Phainon talked with each other for quite some time, catching up with each other and what each person had been doing. Castorice talked about what had happened in Okhema while Phainon was gone, and Phainon would explain what he had been up to while in Kremnos. It was refreshing being able to speak with Castorice again after not having seen her for a number of months. It wasn't until a strong arm wrapped around his neck did he realize just how long he had been standing in the now-empty amphitheater conversing with her.

“Phainon.” Mydei narrowed his eyes at him with his arm wrapped around his neck. “Will you be staying here for the remainder of the day?”

Phainon chuckled, turning his head toward him. “Sorry, I didn't realize how long it's been.”

“I don't mind you staying here,” Mydei clarified. “I can go ahead if you'd like more time.”

“No!”

Phainon and Mydei paused momentarily before turning toward the third person present who had shouted.

Castorice's face was bright red as she stammered, “Don't worry about me! We… We have spoken long enough. Please go ahead.” She cleared her throat in an attempt to regain her composure.

“Are you sure, Castorice?” Phainon tilted his head to the side as she nodded enthusiastically.

“Please, I insist,” she squeaked. Nodding toward Mydei, she quickly added, “It is a pleasure to see you again, King Mydeimos. Congratulations on your union.”

Mydei, with wide eyes, quickly cleared his throat to contain his blush. “Thank you.”

She scurried off, leaving Phainon and Mydei in quite a daze. They both stared at each other, exchanging a laugh before reuniting with Empousa and Herklas. They spent the rest of their day at the pub, thanks to Empousa, celebrating their victory and the news of their soon-to-be marriage. They now had the rest of the week to enjoy their time in Okhema, which Phainon was looking forward to. Mydei and Phainon would have to meet with Aglaea quite frequently during this week to solidify their alliance, Phainon's new regiment consisting of both Okheman and Kremnoan soldiers, and other plans for this new Okhema that Aglaea had in mind, but Phainon was more than happy to resume his role of assisting Aglaea once more.

It was now the depths of Curtain-Fall Hour when they returned to their temporary quarters and parted from Empousa and Herklas. Empousa, who

was thoroughly knocked out from all the drinking, was slumped in Herklas’s arms, and Phainon and Mydei bid him good night as he stumbled into their shared room.

Phainon and Mydei returned to their own room, with the bedsheets freshly washed after their previous night’s activities. A tub of warm water sat in the corner, awaiting their arrival, and Phainon wanted nothing more than to relax in a bath at this moment. He began to unravel each belt, but before he could get very far, Mydei cleared his throat from behind him.

Still fiddling with the belt that held his pauldrons upon his shoulders, Phainon pivoted on his feet, assuming that Mydei needed him for something. “Did you need me, Myd–”

When Phainon had glanced up from the belt, his voice faltered when he saw how red Mydei's face was. It was so red that it was the same color as the cape that hung off his shoulder and his red tattoos. Mydei was nervously shifting on his feet, holding a small box in his hand.

“Give me your hand,” Mydei murmured. It was so quiet that Phainon had barely caught his voice.

Quickly releasing the belt from his grasp, Phainon held out his fighting hand for him; although Phainon was ambidextrous, he often used his right hand for fighting. He wasn't sure what exactly Mydei needed him for, but it must have been important with how nervous Mydei was. Usually, out of the two of them, Phainon was the one who was always more nervous.

“Other hand.”

Phainon immediately switched hands, holding it in front of them with his palm facing upwards.

Mydei, who had removed his gold gauntlets at some point already, gently grasped Phainon’s hand and flipped it over. The warmth from his hand spread up Phainon’s arm as Mydei tenderly rubbed his fingers. Mydei still had his eyes cast downwards at Phainon’s fingers before bringing the small

box closer to his hand. Curiously, Phainon watched as Mydei slowly opened the box.

“Don't say anything,” Mydei mumbled, refusing to look up at Phainon, who could see how adorably red his ears were through his blonde hair.

With a smile, Phainon stayed quiet, but when Mydei unveiled what had been hiding in the box, it suddenly became hard for Phainon to keep his voice down.

Trembling hands slipped a golden ring on Phainon’s finger. With widened eyes, Phainon saw the crest of the Kremnos royal family engraved upon the head of the thick, gold band. It was the ring that Phainon brought back to Mydei before they returned to Kremnos all those months ago; however, the only differences were that the ring was in completely new condition now and that the ring perfectly fit his finger. Phainon's shoddy job of trying to clean the ring had been perfected, and it stood glowing upon Phainon's hand.

“This is…” Phainon was frozen in place, unable to do anything except mutter these words.

Mydei hesitantly lifted his gaze up from the ring, frowning at how much his face burned. “It is my mother's ring.”

“I… know. But, why are you giving me this?” Phainon's throat burned as he asked this question, his heart racing in his chest.

“It's a symbol of the Queen,” Mydei explained. His eyes dropped toward Phainon's hand, but he quickly caught himself and locked eyes with Phainon's once more. “This ring is supposed to belong to the current Queen of Kremnos.”

“But, I'm not–”

“But you will be.” Mydei cut him off, struggling to take a deep breath. “So this ring is yours.”

“Mine…” Phainon slipped his hand from Mydei's warm grasp, holding his hand out in the air and watching the ring twinkle under the chandelier light.

“Will you marry me, Phainon?”

Phainon's eyes, now wide again, quickly shot up from the raised ring to Mydei's shaking gaze. The blood pumped through Phainon's veins as his pounding heart filled his ears. Phainon needed to hear those words again–at least confirm that he wasn't just dreaming.

“...What… What did you say?”

“You heard me.” Tears twinkled in Mydei's glaring eyes, and Phainon immediately wrapped his arms around Mydei, almost knocking the breath out of his lungs and causing the man to stumble backwards.

“Yes! Yes! Mydei, of course I will!” Phainon, who was grinning from ear to ear and with his own tears brimming in his eyes, squeezed Mydei in his arms like his life depended on it. He was even holding back from jumping into Mydei's arms, but he was afraid of catching the man off guard and making them both crumple to the floor. Phainon opted to squeeze the life out of Mydei and nuzzle his face into golden hair instead.

Mydei smiled, half from relief and half from how adorably Phainon had reacted as the man continued to shove his face into Mydei. Although they had already talked about marriage, that conversation occurred a few months ago, and neither of the two men ever officially asked for the other man's hand in marriage. As the date of their return to Okhema quickly approached, Mydei had planned to officially ask for Phainon's hand in marriage with the ring that he had found, and took it to a shop in Kremnos to have the ring cleaned, polished, and fixed to be in pristine condition for when he presented it to Phainon again. He had been nervous ever since the debate ended, for he knew he was going to ask for Phainon's hand today. He was only thankful that Phainon did not notice his nervousness until they returned to their room.

“You're… really asking me to marry you?” Phainon had his forehead pressed against Mydei's shoulder as he clung to his red cape.

“Did you think I gave you the ring and asked you just as a joke?”

“No!” Phainon's head shot up, and his face flushed red at Mydei's narrowed eyes. “I just… I just feel like I'm… dreaming.”

Mydei scoffed, throwing his hands to Phainon's cheeks and pulling him in for a deep kiss. But before Phainon could react, Mydei had already pulled away.

“Does this still feel like a dream?” Mydei muttered against Phainon's lips, his eyes boring into his blue ones.

“Um… Yes…” Phainon's gaze darted left and right, unsure of where to look on Mydei’s beautiful face that was still close to his.

Rolling his eyes, Mydei muttered, “HKS,” before pressing yet another kiss onto Phainon once more.

Phainon groaned, his eyes fluttering shut and cheeks ablaze as he pulled Mydei's waist toward him, hungrily returning the kiss. He leaned his head toward Mydei, who equally reciprocated with the same fervor, and they parted breathlessly, their hot breaths fanning upon their lips as they panted for breath.

“Phainon.”

“Yes?”

“I love you, Phainon.”

“I love you too, Mydei.”

Chapter End Notes

> After this, they go and visit Phainon's parents in Aedes Elysiae. Mydei meets Phainon's parents, and they announce their happy marriage to each other and invite them to their wedding in Kremnos Kingdom.

Thank you so much for reading, and I hope you guys enjoyed! I still cannot believe this became 100k+ words idk how that happened.....

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